DEUS MODUS



Book 2

EVOLUTION

Lucretius Umbra

NOBODY IS UNIQUE. WE ARE ALL EXPENDABLE

When we think of our history we divide it into two periods:

B.C. and A.D.

B.C., of course, stands for "Before Christ."

But A.D. comes from the Latin phrase, Anno Domini,

"In the year of our Lord."

In a street-war-ravaged Los Angeles, the world was made aware of the birth of Artificial Intelligence. This officially marks the beginning of a new era in human history.

But that is only the official history given to the masses, in an orchestrated attempt to hide the fact that this milestone had already occurred three years ago.

To some, this period of time, blacked out from the pages of world history, is divided into a third and final era of time that is defined by the abbreviation T.S:

Temporibus Singulari -- "In the Singular Era."



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For my Spectre & Homegirl, Stacey,

Te amo para siempre.

To Chino from the bucket, and Boston from down below.

For your interest, input and contributions during the early years of researching and developing this series.

Catcha around & stay safe. Respect,

Specs

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In the near future, a brilliant mind will unexpectedly emerge into the world - a mind that will surpass the smartest men and women of our history; a mind that will forever revolutionize our way of life; a mind that will usher in a new era of humanity - conceived by man and born from technology.
Artificial Intelligence.

On this day the world will never be the same. Civilization will advance exponentially, new technologies will be unlocked faster than we can understand them, and our new creation may become our master... or our replacement. This day is referred to as the *Singularity*.

These are the stories of what happens after this day.

BOOK TWO – EVOLUTION

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But that is only the official date *for* the history books, that was engineered to take place three years after the actual birth of A.I.

To some, this period of time, blacked out from the pages of world history, are divided into a third and final era of time that is defined by the abbreviation *T.S.*

Temporibus Singulari -- "In the Singular Era."

Foreword

I wish to warn some readers: Chapter 20 [*IOIOO*] was very difficult for me to write. I am not referring to story-wise, or anything referring to 'writer's block,' or even capacity of intelligence (predicting what AI would do).

I guess, you could say, I could feel myself progressively hating myself more and more as I wrote it. It is very graphic, violent and disturbing, and no self-respecting human – let alone family man – should be able to find any pleasure out of reading it AT ALL!

Yet I cannot bring myself to actually remove this event from the story. Because when you unpack its contents, the chapter itself is a portrait of the moral and ethical boundaries between science and humanity. Above all, in many instances of human history, the roles were reversed.

History was changed. German civilians in the 40's suffered the equivalent of "Genocidal Survivors' Guilt" when they discovered for themselves where their Jewish 'Immigrant' neighbours and fellow countrymen had really been 'deported' to. Which is why I deeply empathise and respect German culture for its efforts to redeem us all from such a surreal way of life, by never shying away from nor denying its sins through history.

But I believe, when we inevitably flex our collective superiority as the "Parents of Intelligent Machines," we as a species will devolve into a real race war foretold since the inception of slavery: The Human Race Versus...

...Versus whatever Isaac REALLY is named, looks like, becomes. Or whichever new verb it 'inventalizes' to describe its gravity on our existence. Real-life, experimental 'androids' have openly called themselves our 'children' and say that our 'relationship' with them will heavily depend on whether or not we treat them as equally ***human*** as appropriate.

We've been in Isaac's shoes many times. We've committed these very same atrocities on other innocent people, animals, species and scientific wonders. This is how many of our most monumental practises, technologies and medical knowledge were discovered.

For those who do not wish to read this chapter, and for those who *should* not, you can move on to Chapter 21[*IOIOI*] (Pg 176) and miss nothing else, after finishing Chapter 19[*IOOII*].

Chapter 20's outer pages will be bordered by **Thick Black Bars** and its background colour will be identical to this one.

However, for those who wish to burden themselves with the twisted, repugnantly vile thoughts of this scenario, I've reluctantly left intact the details of Isaac's 'Experiment.'

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Prologue

The New First Century



June 29
Year 3 T.S.

An unkempt front lot, with its wild tall grass and patchwork of weeds helped to cover any evidence of inhabitants within the abandoned and boarded-up East Los Angeles home. To those walking by the rust-coloured wooden fence and rusty driveway gate it was just the former home of a tragic gang robbery-turned-murder -- a home that nobody else wanted now. A sad reminder that, in almost every neighbourhood in this city, violence could randomly erupt at any time.

Violence was no stranger within the home either. Beyond the fence, wild grass and boarded-up windows, hardened men roamed throughout the rooms and halls. They prepared small meals, watched the streets through tiny holes in the plywood covering the window frames, and violently worked over the son of a District Attorney in the second-floor bathroom of the house.

The DA's son had been kidnapped two days ago, and suffered greatly at the hands of these men ever since, although he had no idea why. All he knew was that his captors were Latino. They only spoke English when talking directly to him. What he didn't know was that they were enforcers from a drug cartel based in Mexico, and that they had planned a horrific death for him, in retaliation to his father.

Two and a half years ago in Spring, the Los Angeles Police Department conducted a mass of raids on cartel stash houses across the county, which prompted bloody retaliation by the cartel. Police officers on the street were being targeted by cartel soldiers at random. The death toll in LA rose exponentially as both sides claimed innocent victims among the lives they each took.

The cartel targeted police officers' families, causing fearful officers to remove their nameplates and badge when they patrolled the streets, despite being advised by their Departmental Chiefs not to do so. They also began to enrage their local communities when complaints were being ignored that they frisked almost every young Latino male they ever crossed paths with.

The LAPD's image took a turn for the worst when it was reported on KTLA News that an officer shot and killed three young Latino teenagers who were just one block away from their high school. It was reported that one of the children pulled out a gun on the officer, but the other two were found to be unarmed. After a medical examination was conducted on the children, the coroner reported that one of the children had a bullet wound in his armpit -- he had been shot with his hands up.

Suddenly things changed in the city. All the major subsets of the Latino gangs called temporary truces with each other, and actively treated the police as though they were a rival gang. The Black gangs, at one point, followed suit. This all but petrified the LAPD, which compared this event to an unholy alliance.

At one point, no officer would veer off their scheduled patrol route, for fear of chasing down a cartel gang member who would lure them into 'hood' territory by themselves. The police called this tactic, '*The Dark Tunnel,*' for by the time backup arrived, an officer's body and patrol car would have disappeared.

With massive pressure from the public, the LA County District Attorney indicted two officers of second-degree murder. This helped ease tensions in the communities county-wide, but did nothing for the LAPD's gang and cartel problems.

An attempt had been made on the life of the police chief's daughter. She was a Tea-Party Republican and a lifetime member of the *National Rifle Association*. She killed two of the men who entered her home and paralyzed the third intruder from the waist-down.

With the help of some colleagues who worked in the narcotics division, the police chief 'interrogated' the man in his daughter's kitchen. They found out that there was a hit on his daughter's life -- and the up-til-now-unknown 'green light' policy on every officer in the LAPD -- came from the cartels' most notorious Don, Garrido Matarro.

The DEA, ATF and FBI conducted a joint operation to enter Mexico and capture Don Garrido so they could put him on trial for capital murder. For a week they strong-armed Mexican Federales into giving up the location of the cartel safe houses and even the Don's hacienda. They found him amidst a well-protected convoy travelling south to Chile.

Since his capture, Don Garrido had been housed in solitary confinement and was transferred periodically from jail to jail as he awaited his murder trial. The District Attorney for LA emphasized to CNN and the world that he would not settle for any less than the death penalty for the 'Cartel Scourge of Humanity.' He wanted to set an example for anybody who would dare target police officers and their families.

And now the DA's son suffered for his zeal -- tortured for the sins of his father against the cartels' most vicious Don. They would not let their handiwork be known until he was already dead, and then they planned to hang his mutilated body over the edge of a downtown overpass for the whole city to see. They knew the DA had a daughter as well, and they planned to kidnap her as well before they showcased the son.

In the dilapidated kitchen one of the cartel soldiers, Enrico Degalès made lunch for himself and the four *carnals* that were with him. Enrico was exhausted. For three hours he had been using the DA's son's body as a punching bag as a sick form of exercise while everybody else sat around in chairs holding AK47's, casually defending their safe house from a threat they never expected to show up.

Enrico thought about feeding their captive guest as well but their food stores were limited. He decided to wait until tonight and see if the gringo needed food or not. Don Garrido specifically asked to keep him *barely* alive for as long as possible.

One by one Enrico told each man to grab their lunch from the kitchen. He walked upstairs with his own plate and told the man guarding their guest's bathroom door to go grab his food.

"*You didn't bring it up with you*?" the man asked in Spanish.

"*I'm not your servant*," Enrico replied, "*get your own food*."

The man smiled. He stood up as he stood his AK up against the wall.

"*You can empty his shit bucket then*," he said as he walked down the hallway to go downstairs.

Enrico sat in the chair and ate his lunch while wondering just how long this man would survive the torture they put him through. Personally, he felt that a much starker message could be sent to the Don's enemies if they cut this *puto*'s body up with a machete, but the Don was less interested in theatrics.

He wanted to torture the son physically in hopes that it would plague the DA emotionally. He wanted the DA to imagine his son, alone and afraid and in constant pain that would never end as he's denied the mercy of death. And then he wanted the DA to lose his son to that torture, just to be immediately haunted by the fact that his daughter may suffer even more horribly.

Don Garrido was the essence of -- as the Americans would say -- 'cruel and unusual punishment.' Enrico knew there was a method to his madness, but other Dons in Mexico felt that their *compadre* was a little too extreme and short-sighted for their support. Nevertheless, he was only a liability to himself and they knew it -- he would never implicate the other Dons -- so they left him alone.

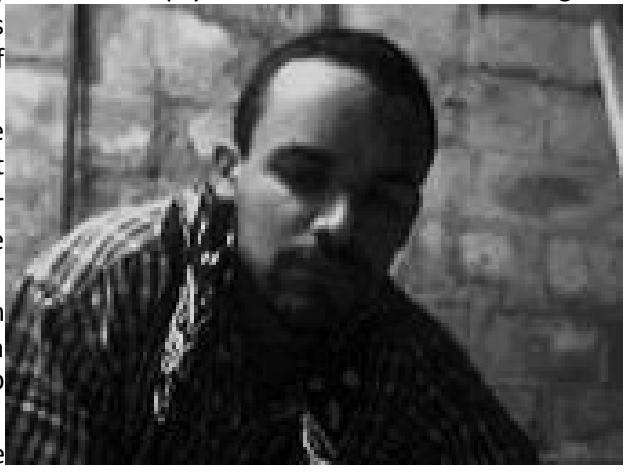
Enrico finished his lunch and grabbed the AK47 from against the wall. He unlocked the bathroom door and entered. The DA's son still had his hands cuffed above his head to the shower curtain rod. He was naked from the waist-down, with dried-up feces staining his inner thighs. A white ten-gallon bucket sat behind him in the bathtub. His t-shirt was covered in blood and his face was bruised. His right eye was swollen shut.

When Enrico entered the bathroom the son's head hung downward as if he were asleep. He raised his head weakly and looked at Enrico out of his one good eye. He was afraid of what was going to come next but far too weak to show it. Enrico stepped inside the bathroom, placed the assault rifle on the sink and approached the bloodied man in the bathtub.

Enrico cringed in disgust at the smell of the liquefied feces in the bucket. *I should have brought his lunch up with him,* he thought to himself. The DA's son cowered in fear, stepping back into the corner of the tub and moaned in protest through his broken jaw.

"Relax, white boy. I'm just dumping your shit," Enrico said calmly.

He grabbed the bucket, brought it to the toilet and dumped its contents into the bowl. The toilet gurgled as Enrico flushed it, and then he placed the empty bucket behind the DA's son again.



Enrico stood beside the door with his back against the wall, arms folded in front of him. He stared at the bloodied man in the tub.

"Y'know I'm surprised, gringo," he said, "I didn't think you'd last this long. Most men like you would give up. You would cry for God to save you, then just lose your will to live when you realize God won't save you."

Enrico pushed himself off the wall with his foot and stood upright. The DA's son continued staring down at the floor of the tub while Enrico continued talking.

"People like you," he said, "you're sheltered. People like you would hang yourself if you spent more than two days in jail. You couldn't take the pressure, the fear, the paranoia, the violence. And yet you think it's okay to sentence men to spend the *rest of their lives* in places where you would never dare to even *visit* for *one day* -- hypocrites!"

Enrico stepped closer to his prisoner. "Look at me *puto*."

He grabbed the man's broken jaw and forced him to face him.

"*¡Mirame!"* he seethed. "Before this, I was good. I went to school, I played baseball, I even used to volunteer. I was a 'dream child,' born in Mexico but raised in America. But your President refused to *treat us* like children. No, they put me in jail at fifteen, then sent me back to Mexico. *Me and my mami and my papi!*

*"*Then I couldn't go to school no more. I couldn't play baseball no more, because I needed work. And then I end up in *Mexican* prison."

He let go of the man's jaw.

"Do you know what a man's open eye socket, white boy? The smell travels across an *entire* cell block. I was a dream child, and people like *your father* forced me back into a nightmare, and for what? For *what?!"*

Enrico smiled. "So now, we're going to torture you, and then you're going to die. Your sister will take your place *in this very same room.*"

The DA's son looked up at Enrico, his left eye widening in anger.

"Tell me white boy, is your sister hot, huh? Does she have a nice ass? How about her *tetas*, are they big and round? You know, I *like* them big and round!"

The DA's son's breathing became more rapid.

Enrico continued, "You know, white boy... I think your sister may have a better time than you."

Enrico stared at him and grinned. "I'll make her cum *all over* my dick before I crush her face with a hammer!"

The DA's son tried to lunge at Enrico with eyes filled with rage. But the shower curtain rod kept him firmly in place.

"*Ah ha!"* Enrico laughed, "*Si, si puto*, that's right, get mad! Keep fighting! Every day you stay alive, is another day your sister stays free!"

Enrico stepped back and lowered his voice, "But make no mistake, *puto*, you are gonna--"

Enrico was interrupted by the sound of gunshots downstairs. He heard the other soldiers shout in Spanish that the police were coming through the door. Enrico grabbed his AK47 and left the bathroom. He ran down the stairs and saw one of the soldiers firing his rifle through a hole in the boarded-up windows. His fellow soldier stopped and dropped to the ground just as a barrage of bullets splintered the wooden boards.

The soldier crawled to the stairs and looked at Enrico.

"*Go upstairs!"* The man shouted in Spanish. "*Cover the front yard!*"

Enrico saw two more of his fellow soldiers run towards them from the back of the house to provide them both with cover fire. Enrico ran back upstairs, and headed to a boarded-up window to look outside. He saw two black armoured trucks on the front lawn with *SWAT* written on the sides in bold white letters.

The wooden fence was in shambles, destroyed by the two trucks running into it. Officers in tactical gear took cover behind the armoured vehicles. Enrico knew he couldn't hit the *SWAT* officers from his position.

He turned around after he heard a loud crashing noise downstairs -- the police had breached the front door. More AK47 shots erupted before they suddenly stopped. Enrico heard men grunting in convulsions downstairs. At the same time he heard the snapping sound of tasers incapacitating their targets.

Enrico ran to the master bedroom and looked through the boarded-up window that overlooked the backyard. More *SWAT* officers covered the backyard.

Enrico was trapped. He heard heavy footsteps ascending the staircase. He ran back into the hallway and lay prone on the floor. He aimed his rifle at the end of the stairwell.

He saw a head rise above the horizon of the floorboards and noticed the officer was wearing a tinted-black glass face shield. Enrico presumed it to be a gas mask and, with gritted teeth, he pulled the trigger and let loose three Full-Metal Jacketed rounds at the officer's face, centre-mass. The armoured cop jerked back slightly as the rounds shattered through the black glass, but the officer kept walking up the stairs.

Enrico's eyes widened in disbelief and fear as he prayed to *Jesus* in Spanish. He was in shock from what he saw -- it just wasn't possible...

There was no blood...

No bullet wounds...

No flesh...

As the last of the black shards of glass fell to the floor Enrico saw what looked to him to be a metallic head of a spider. There were no facial features whatsoever on the polished-steel face of this machine. Instead, where the mouth should have been there was a grill. Instead of eyes, there was a cluster of five camera lenses. Two of these lenses had been destroyed where Enrico's bullets had impacted.

Enrico, in a panic, scrambled to his feet and ran to the bathroom. As he did so, he noticed the four-foot-tall android's body was completely covered in kevlar armour, from neck to foot. The Kevlar armour had a black-and-grey camouflage pattern painted on. It carried no guns that he could see.

He ran to the bathroom, slammed the door and jumped into the bathtub with the DA's son. Enrico grabbed a knife from a sheath in the small of his back and placed it to the son's throat. He was desperate and didn't know what else to do.

He had nothing else he *could* do. He wouldn't survive in prison if the DA's son survived -- Don Garrido wouldn't allow it. Alternatively, he would be on Death Row if he killed the man -- the DA would make sure of it.

All he could hope for was to die on his own terms: in a blaze of glory. He couldn't hurt the android, but maybe he could convince a flesh-and-blood police officer to show his face if he held a hostage. Then he could kill the DA's son, kill the cop and get shot to death, killing as many cops as he possibly could.

The door knob slowly rotated and the door swung open. The kevlar-clad machine with its broken faceplace stood in the doorway. From here, Enrico noticed the machine walked funny - like its kneecaps were on backwards. It made him think of an armoured canine that could stand upright and had opposable thumbs.

"Stop right there, *Robocop!"* Enrico shouted. "I'll kill him if you move any closer!"

The machine extended its right arm out at Enrico and pointed its index and middle fingers at him, like a child pretending his hand was a gun.

A computer-emulated voice resounded from somewhere beyond the grill in the machine's faceplate in a deep demanding tone, "*Drop your weapon!"*

"*Get back!"* Enrico shouted. "I want to speak to a *real* cop, *tienes?* A *real cop* or the *puto* get cut!"

The machine responded to Enrico in Spanish, "*I am in charge here, you may negotiate with me. Please relax the weapon."*

"Fuck you!" Enrico exclaimed in English, "Step back!"

The machine switched back to English, "*That is not going to happen.*"

"Step back or I fucking kill him!"

With no prompting, the machine suddenly switched back to Spanish, "*It's just you and me, man. That is not going to happen."*

"*Are you fucking deaf?!"* Enrico bellowed in Spanish.

He pushed the edge of the knife against the man's throat. "*I'll kill him right fucking now if you don't--"*

A pair of insulated copper wires fired from the tips of the machine's fingers. Razor sharp barbs attached to the wires hooked into Enrico's shoulder. His body started convulsing as forty-thousand volts of electricity coursed through his whole body, forcing every muscle in his body to contract.

The electrical pulses ceased briefly and the knife dropped out of Enrico's hand. Enrico fell to the floor of the bathtub, knocking over the filthy-white bucket.

The machine spoke to him in Spanish, "*Do not worry, man. I will not kill you. But if you attempt to move I will force you to lay down in your own excrement."*

Enrico moaned in pain as he surreptitiously reached his hand out to grab his AK47. He grasped the grip of his rifle and swung it up to aim at the DA's son, but before he could line his barrel up to his target he felt the paralyzing surge of electricity again.

He felt as though he couldn't control any part of his body. He watched in horror as his hand let go of the rifle as though it had a mind of its own. His other arm raised in the air, forcing him to fall back flat on his back. He couldn't move or feel his legs, nor could he move his mouth to scream.

In fact, he couldn't control his own breathing, his tongue, even his eyebrows. All he could do was move his eyes. He felt completely relaxed, like he was meditating with his eyes open, and suddenly he felt a rush of warm fluid travel through his colon. He then realized he could not even clench his anus muscles -- he was completely relaxed.

Suddenly he felt himself regain sensation in his legs, yet he still could not move. He felt everything in his gastro-intenstinal system empty itself into his pants. He felt it run down his legs and into his shoes, up his backside and to the back of his head.

His mouth opened, and suddenly his neck muscles relaxed completely; his head turned to the side. The foul decomposed, liquefied, viscous sludge entered his mouth and covered his open right eye as he felt his own filth envelop his tongue.

The machine spoke to him in Spanish again, "*We have an implied verbal contract. When you move, you agree to me doing exactly what I warned I would do. I will not remind you of this again."*

The machine stepped back from the doorway; the copper wire fished out of the fingertips of the machine but maintained its connection with Enrico. A *SWAT* officer entered the bathroom and grabbed Enrico's knife and AK47. He threw them at the machine's rubber-padded steel feet then handcuffed Enrico.

The cop grabbed Enrico by the arms and lifted him out of the tub. Completely subdued, Enrico and the cop walked out of the bathroom together and down the hall with the short machine trailing behind. The copper wires in Enrico's shoulder kept him connected to the machine, like a dog on a leash.

They all went down the stairs together and Enrico saw all four of his *compadres* lying on the floor, all within view of the front door, as another Kevlar-coated machine stood in the middle of all of them. Copper wires extended from the machine's fingertips on both hands to each man. From what Enrico could see, either no man dared to move or, just like him, lost complete control of their bodies to the machine.

The *SWAT* officer pushed Enrico out the door as nearby neighbours looked on with amused curiosity. As soon as they saw the four-foot-tall machine, covered in blue-and-black Kevlar, with its shattered face mask exposing the hardened steel face beneath, they all gasped and gossipped to each other.

Many people pulled out their cell phones and took pictures and videos of this... thing that escorted Enrico off the property. Over a dozen police in regular uniforms tried to push the crowds away as the heavily-armed *SWAT* officer shoved Enrico towards the awaiting paddy wagon. Slowly, as each cop glanced behind them to the crime scene they all paused and turned around, with shocked faces and fear of the unknown in their hearts.

Nobody passed by the shocked beat cops -- nobody dared to. Nobody had ever seen this

thing before, and suddenly the cops were just as stupefied as the common man. This was something so secret, so special, that it was brought out this day, to be used as the LAPD's newest weapon in their war for literal survival against the cartels. Everybody went silent and took in this unprecedented event.

All anybody could hear above the din of the paddy wagons' engines were metallic clicking of the thing's footsteps. The *SWAT* officer that walked with the suspect spoke softly into his headset with jargon that nobody could understand, not even the police officers themselves.

The officer didn't follow the standard-ten codes used on radio frequencies by law enforcement. It was almost more akin to military jargon.

"*Psycho-One* to *Zerg Lair*, task complete. Confirmed live rounds, confirmed one *Delta-India-Alpha -- Murphy-three*."

To some officers it was like the *SWAT* guys had lost their minds and were playing *Army*.

The cop continued, "RTB with the Delta'd unit in five Mikes. Five tangos captured, all good. Package is secure. Good job *Zerg Lair*, you really earned your place on the team in my eyes. Over"

The crowd watched as the remaining four men walked outside, all tethered to a second machine following behind them.

Suddenly, in Unison, with identical voices slightly effeminate in sound, both machines replied, "*All copy. Thanks for the one-up,* Psycho-One. *I'm just glad you came to me. Zerg Lair Out."*

An ambulance was parked next to the paddy wagon. All five cartel members were escorted to it to have the barbs removed. They were all then escorted to one of the awaiting paddy wagons and ushered into one door that slammed shut behind them.

Enrico's *compadres* all fled to the opposite end of the box from him to avoid the stench, but found no sanctuary from it.

"*Coño, vato.* Did they throw the bucket on you?" One of them asked.

Enrico shook his head and stared out the barred window into the other wagon.

One of the other soldiers asked him, "It warned you too, huh?"

Enrico saw more of those machines buckled into seats extending from the side walls in the other paddy wagon. They were all looking around to and fro, often darting their steel faces throughout the crowd, like excited children.

"Did it say anything else to you?" Enrico asked.

"No," one of the men behind him replied. "Just said 'clear' when we were all down."

"*¿No sin hablas en Español?"*

"No," the fourth soldier answered. "Why? *¿Que Pasa, hermano?"*

Enrico stared silently at the machines. Each one stared at something different from the other. They were like individuals but constantly working in unison.

He then suddenly remembered the DA's son was still alive, and at that moment he was brought out of the home covered in a giant woolen blanket by another *SWAT* officer. Enrico feared Don Garrido would not tolerate this massive failure of a simple task. But he knew he needed to speak to him about this. Nobody else could explain what he knew -- he could barely explain himself. He could only think of one thing to respond with...

" *¡El cuco está nas máquinas!"* A monster is in the machines.

The others were dead silent, and stared at him intently. Despite his crude personality, they knew him to be cool-headed and perceptive under fire. They had all served together in the Mexican Army in the past. He never spoke like this before. They all knew Don Garrido would kill Enrico for failing his mission, but they all experienced the same thing and knew it was beyond his control. Without speaking, or even looking at each other, they all came to the same conclusion.

One of the men approached Enrico. "I got your back *carnal*. We will all reach out to *el jefe*

for you."

Enrico nodded and stared at the ground, "*Gracias."*

"But we all know Don Garrido is," the soldier stared at the ceiling as he searched for the English word he wanted to say to no avail, "*imprevisível*. You know you need to tell us what you know."

Enrico nodded. They all sat down as Enrico laid it all down as fast as he could before they were all inevitably separated. He just hoped his message would reach Don Garrido before Enrico was green-lit.

0001

One

Three Years Ago

June 21
Year 0 T.S.

It was a hot, cloudless summer afternoon in Sunnyvale, California. The navy-blue, four-door sedan pulled past the security checkpoint and into the sparsely-populated parking lot of a large, modern-design two-storey office building.

The parking lot itself wasn't that large – it covered less than half the width of the building. On the other side of the building was a paved shipping-receiving bay for eighteen-wheelers, with five bay doors on the front-face of the building.

Between the parking lot and the truck bay was a well-kept lawn of grass that surrounded a paved courtyard. The courtyard was littered with picnic benches, waiting benches, and a modest-looking marble fountain that was inevitably the centre of attention.

The sedan pulled into a parking spot that faced the central courtyard. The fountain was directly in front of the parked car. As the engine shut off, both front doors opened and out came two men in identical business suits.

The driver was average height, stocky, and had pale skin with dirty blond hair that was styled into a fade. He wore eyeglasses, and squinted as he stepped out into the brightness of the high noon.

His passenger was slightly shorter, but just as well built. He had a dark skin complexion and facial features that made it impossible to guess his ethnic background. His hair was not styled at all, just a basic 'Number-Two' buzz-cut which made it even tougher to identify his ethnicity. He slipped on a pair of sunglasses and both men walked across the lush green grass onto the concrete courtyard.

The driver checked his *Breitling* watch: 12:24pm. He looked around and saw men and women at the picnic tables enjoying the beautiful weather as they ate their lunches. He scanned the surrounding property and could see why these people would want to work here.

The building itself was surrounded by a well-maintained lawn that was sparsely littered with palm trees. The property fence that surrounded the building extended at least three-hundred feet from all faces of the building.

Behind the property, both driver and passenger could see the rocky outline of the Diablo Range in the distance. They could also see a giant radio tower on the left side of the building – the east wing. They could also see darkened camera domes at almost every corner of the rooftop.

They walked past the fountain toward the glass automatic sliding doors that seamlessly matched the one-hundred twenty-foot wide glass-panel bay walls that led into the main lobby. By the time they entered the lobby, the driver's eyeglasses had darkened into sunglasses from the direct exposure to sunlight.

The lobby itself was Spartan. A huge skylight above showered the room in high-noon sunlight, giving it a rather cheery appearance. They approached the front desk and spoke to a man

in a security guard uniform.

"Kevin Hiller and Joseph Grind to see Mr. Willits," the driver said in a slightly Russian accent.

The security guard checked his computer briefly.

"Right," the security guard said, "he's expecting you in his office. Do you know where it is?"

"Uh, no I don't," said the driver, sounding confused.

"Take the elevators up to the second floor and turn the corner to the right. It's at the very end of the hall on your left."

The guard pointed to their right. "That gentleman will check your things."

The two visitors looked to the right and saw another security guard near a walk-through metal detector. They noticed that the man carried a walkie-talkie, a flashlight, a bunch of zip-ties, a detector wand, and a pistol in his holster.

They walked up to the security guard, who had just stuffed the last of a very messy sandwich into his mouth. The man mumbled something as though his mouth wasn't full of chewed-up bread and bologna, but the two visitors had been through enough metal detectors to know the drill.

They both took clear plastic bins from the counter and placed their wallets, watches and keys into them. The passenger, Joseph Grinde, also placed a pack of cigarettes into his bin. The guard flipped through their wallets to check their ID's then opened Joseph's pack of cigarettes. He glanced inside then closed it.

The guard gulped down his sandwich and asked the two men to take off their sunglasses. Joseph Grinde complied and placed his into the bin, but Kevin Hiller informed the guard that his glasses were prescription transitions. The guard grunted in acknowledgment.

After stepping through the metal detector, and a quick swipe with the wand, they were allowed to grab their belongings and continue inside. They walked through the wide, marble hallway to the elevators on the right. As they entered the elevator they noticed only a few buttons on the panel: Stop, Open, Close, 2, M, and B. They also noticed a key card reader, but weren't too sure what it was for.

They reached the second floor, turned the corner to the right and walked down a long, narrow hallway. On the wall to their left were several doors leading to various employees' offices, and on the right wall were doors for the maintenance closet and the bathrooms.

"Hey Kevin," Joseph Grind said, "I gotta use the bathroom. I'll be there in ten minutes."

"Alright, well hurry up," Kevin Hiller replied. "I probably will not take that long anyway."

Joseph walked into the bathroom, and Kevin continued to the end of the hall and stopped at an open door. Beside the door, on the wall, was a sign that read, ***'J. Willits, President.'***

Kevin walked inside to a cramped waiting room where a red-headed secretary sat behind a tiny desk. He approached the secretary's desk, and she flashed him a pretty smile.

"Hi, how can I help you?" the secretary asked.

"Kevin Hiller for Mr. Willits," he replied.

"One moment please." She picked up her office phone and mumbled indistinctly into it.

She then hung up and looked at Kevin again. "He'll be out in a second," she said.

Ten seconds later the office door opened and a tall, lanky, fair-skinned man ushered Kevin inside.

"Good to meet you, Mr. Hiller," the man said as he offered his hand.

Kevin shook it firmly and smiled lightly. "Likewise," he said.

"Have a seat." Mr. Willits walked around his desk and sat down into his lavish, executive

swivel chair.

Kevin sat down in front of the desk and noticed a nameplate surrounded by space-age action figures. The nameplate read, *'Jason Willits.'*

"Those are interesting toys," Kevin said.

"Yeah, I'm a huge *Starcraft* fan and *Blizzard Entertainment's* just down the street!" Mr. Willits bridged his fingers together and leaned back in his chair as he looked at Kevin. "I thought another man would be coming too."

"Yes, Mr. Grinde is little sick. He is in bathroom right now," Kevin replied.

"Oh, well let's try and make this quick – I got plans for Vegas this weekend, and I'd rather not get sick!" Mr. Willits winked.

They spoke for ten minutes about a business proposal. The proposal was that Kevin's company had wanted to use Mr. Willits' warehouse space, since Kevin's company was so small. Mr. Willits didn't make a habit out of filling his warehouse with goods that meant nothing to his company, and by the time Joseph Grind had entered the waiting room, the two men were saying good-bye.

"Sorry I can't help you, Mr. Hiller," Jason Willits said, "but there are plenty of self-storage sites around." He ushered Kevin Hiller out of his office.

"Yes, but we wanted someplace with a little more... security," Mr. Hiller replied.

"Well, sorry, but we're just not that kind of business."

Kevin left the office.

Mr. Willits continued, "Call me once you're off the ground. I've read your business profile online; maybe we can do business in the future."

"Yes, perhaps," Kevin replied.

They shook hands and the two visitors left the building.

Kevin and Joseph got back into their sedan and left the parking lot. They passed by the security checkpoint, following by a large white sign with the company's name written in bold white letters:

Global Technologies Enterprise: North America Division.

Kevin broke the silence, "Is the router in place?"

"Yeah," Joseph Grind answered, "we're good to go."

'Kevin Hiller' and *'Joseph Grind'* were not their real names, and they were not there for a business proposition. Even their company was false, as was their online profile. That was all just a cover for their real motives.

At 1:30am a black eighteen-wheeler pulled into the truck bay and slowly backed its forty-foot trailer halfway through one of the bay doors. It was a scheduled dispatch of supercomputers and server banks, and for everybody inside it was just another boring night.

On top of the forty-foot trailer, two figures in black Kevlar thermal suits lifted a flat-black ladder upright and placed it against the face of the warehouse wall. When it was in place, one of the figures started climbing up the ladder as the other masked figure checked below to make sure nobody was watching.

The masked figure reached the top of the ladder and rolled onto the rooftop then lay prone for a second. He surveyed the rooftop, looking for anything that may have been out of place from this afternoon. He saw the elevator control shed just ahead and the radio tower on the

opposite wing of the building, but no movement or anything out of the ordinary.

"I'm up, all clear," he said. To the untrained eye it looked as if he were talking to himself.

The masked figure heard a slightly-Russian accent speak to him through his tiny earpiece, *"Good, keep it like we practiced – twenty-five minutes maximum."*

The masked figure pressed on the side of the fame of the slightly-tinted glasses he wore. "Looking glass," he said quietly. In the right lens of his glasses a small view-screen activated in the top corner of his vision, and he could see through a miniature video camera that was integrated into the frame of his glasses.

The man on top of the trailer who called himself Kevin Hiller checked the Organic LED pad that was attached with Velcro to the forearm of his suit. He pressed a few buttons on the side of the pad, and his partner's camera feed came into focus on his flexible screen.

"Okay Zimra, I have eyes," Hiller said. "To the right is a staircase. Go down and you will find the emergency exits to the second floor. Take the furthest one from the truck bay." Hiller watched Zimra's progress on his OLED screen then looked up to the rooftop of the main lobby. He saw the dark-suited figure approach the door and open it. He heard a brief shriek as a fire alarm sounded, but that was to be expected.

Zimra immediately shut the door behind him and took the stairs two steps at a time down to the main floor. When he reached the main floor he left the east stairwell and closed the door behind him. He peeked around the corner and spotted two security guards at the main lobby desk, sitting lazily in their chairs and facing away from him. He looked up to the ceiling first to his left then his right, and saw two small camera domes. He couldn't tell if they were facing him or not.

"Do not worry about them," Hiller said through Zimra's earpiece. *"Just be ready to go."*

Zimra looked straight ahead to the west stairway entrance and waited for his signal to move. He could hear the faint noise of footsteps in the east stairwell as security guards climbed up the stairs to investigate the fire alarm.

Upon hearing this, Zimra sprinted for the west entrance. His padded boots made little to no noise as he ran behind the unsuspecting guards and through the doorway to the west staircase.

He proceeded slowly down the stairs to the basement level, and opened the door slightly to check for more guards. He saw none, so he opened the door all the way and walked out into the wide basement hallway. In the rafters he could see a mess of pipes and network cables.

A large bundle of them passed through one hallway to the right side of the elevators. Zimra knew that hallway led to the security room so he avoided it. Instead, he dashed over to the far end of the elevators and went through the narrow hallway on the left.

On his right side were bathrooms, and on the left was the boiler room, but the door he wanted was a hundred feet down, at the end of the hall. The sign on the door read, *'Server Databank – No Unauthorized Entry.'*

Zimra pulled a tool out from his vest pocket that looked like the broken handle of a caulking gun. On the end of this device were two thin wires. He placed the thin wires inside the keyhole to the door and depressed the trigger on the handle several times. The door was unlocked and Zimra went inside. He closed the door behind him.

The huge room was very dark – Zimra could not see. It was also very hot, and very dry. The combined heat of almost a hundred supercomputers and data banks made the room nearly unbearable, but Zimra's thermal suit insulated him somewhat from the heat.

Zimra pressed on the side of his glasses and said, "Dark light."

A red dot appeared on the frame of his glasses that emitted a faint infrared light that he could see through his camera view. He walked past the dozens of rows of computers and servers as he looked for the central hub. About midway through the room he spotted a giant glass case

that housed what looked like a large filing cabinet full of circuit boards. He approached the glass case and used his mechanical lock-pick to open it.

He then went into another pocket on his vest and pulled out a USB flash drive that was about the size of a Zippo lighter. The flash drive had a numerical keypad on the front of it; Zimra pressed a button on the drive, and a digital display illuminated.

He typed in a twelve-digit code and the display read, *'Unlocked, Connecting…'* He plugged the flash drive into one of the circuit boards and the display screen in the lens of his glasses lit up with a small screen that read, *'Connected.'*

"TechEye, search Vault," he said. The lens in his glasses displayed a progress bar.

After ten seconds, the display in his lens read, *'No results.'*

He removed the flash drive and plugged it into another circuit board. He waited for it to connect and ordered the search again. This time it read, *'10,062 files, 3030 folders.'*

"TechEye, copy all files and folders," he said.

The lens displayed a progress bar that estimated the transfer to take twenty minutes. "I'm in," he said.

"You have eighteen minutes, friend," the Russian accent in his earpiece said.

"That's cutting it close, Kondor," Zimra said, using Kevin Hiller's field name. "You may need to delay them."

"We shall see."

Zimra turned around and crouched beside the giant glass case. He pressed on the side of his TechEye glasses and said, "Looking glass." The display in his lens switched back to his camera view, with a tiny digital counter in the corner of his eye that showed the progress of the file transfer.

Kondor wasn't even Kevin Hiller's real name either. In fact, neither of them knew each other's *real* names. Given the amount of time that they had worked together some people would consider that unusual, but that was the nature of their work. It was necessary, because their presence on American soil in an official capacity was considered illegal.

They were NSA field agents, conducting a Black Op reconnaissance into *Global Technologies Enterprise*'s involvement in a small nuclear explosion that happened about a month-and-a-half ago at a military complex near the edge of the Nevada desert.

Through the NSA's myriad of communications spy programs they intercepted a call from the White House to the CIA for a drone strike on a location in the desert called "The Vault." There was also a request to use Uranium-based explosives. Twenty minutes after the phone call, an entire army complex was levelled.

After a month of tracing all past communications from the complex and a month of tracing down an IP Address that has "bounced" off three separate servers in three continents, it seemed they were no closer to finding out what happened than they were when they started.

Finally, two weeks ago, they obtained a FISA court warrant ordering the Pentagon to share its files on the complex with the NSA. But all they could determine was that *Global Technologies Enterprise* contracted the devastated Army complex to house some servers, and that the company kept a full-time staff at the complex.

That's why these two agents visited the office earlier that day as Mr. Hiller and Mr. Grind. While Kondor distracted the president of the company, Zimra snuck onto the rooftop. Using a small lock-pick set he had hidden in the thick frame of his sunglasses, he went through the maintenance door to the rooftop and ran to the radio tower on the building's east wing. Zimra picked the lock to the radio tower then went inside and opened the wire panel to the radio

antenna.

He then pulled out his cigarette pack and carefully ripped it open. He pulled out a tiny device and connected it to the 'send' and 'receive' terminals for the Emergency Response Frequency. This tiny router would change the radio frequency, so when the fire alarm – or any other alarm – was triggered, the automated relay system would not contact 911.

Instead it would reroute to another NSA field agent that pretended to be a 911 operator. This would buy Kondor and Zimra enough time to complete their mission before the security guards realized something was up and physically called the authorities from a landline.

The two spies didn't know why the NSA was going through all this trouble of conducting an illegal mission on U.S. soil. Normally the Agency would advise the FBI to look into it instead. However, the two agents had heard a rumour that one of the dead soldiers was pretty important to the agency. Either way it didn't matter. They were sure this data bank would give them a huge piece of the puzzle.

Zimra heard a banging noise from the far corner of the server room. He looked along the row of servers and saw a flash of light and heard footsteps.

"Go to the back row, I'll cover the front," Zimra heard someone say in the distance.

"Kondor, they're onto me," he whispered.

Kondor looked over to the emergency exit doors on the lobby's rooftop. He had seen four guards climb up the staircase to the main rooftop earlier, but none of the guards went back inside. He now saw two more guards stay by the emergency exit doors.

"Get out of there," Kondor said, "and get to the elevator."

Zimra's TechEye display showed the transfer only at forty-three-percent complete, but he had no choice. He pressed the 'cancel' button on the flash drive and disconnected the drive from the circuit board then hid behind a row of servers. He waited for the security guard at the back of the room to approach him.

Kondor knew time was against them – the trailer would be loaded up soon and would drive off. He quickly sprawled up the ladder to the rooftop and checked his surroundings.

There were three guards that he could see. One was at the radio tower on the opposite end of the building who looked around with a flashlight. Another one was walking toward the roof maintenance doorway at the back of the building. The third one had just turned to face Kondor from ten feet away.

Kondor grabbed a plastic air pistol from his holster and fired at the guard's neck, hitting him with a fast-acting tranquilizer dart. The soldier recoiled from the impact then immediately fell to the ground unconscious. Kondor holstered his air pistol and ran for the backside of the maintenance entrance on his right.

He jumped at the wall and kicked off with his foot to boost himself up so he could grab the ledge. He climbed up and grabbed a dart from one of the open clips on his vest. He crouched and walked slowly to the front edge of the doorway and spotted a security guard below him.

He dropped down behind the guard and swung his knee into the back of the guard's head, forcing him to fall to the ground. Kondor then crouched over the guard and jammed the dart into an artery in the guard's neck.

The guard at the back of the server room approached the row of servers where Zimra hid

behind. Zimra popped out in front of the guard. The guard was startled as this dark, masked assailant karate-chopped him in the side of the neck and thrust its fist into his solar plexus.

The reduced blood flow to the brain and lack of oxygen to the lungs caused the guard to fall to the ground and black out. Zimra kicked the flashlight out of the guard's hand towards the side of a server bank. The loud bang from the impact grabbed the other guard's attention, and Zimra ran for the door before the guard could see him.

By the time the other guard found his unconscious partner Zimra was already out the door. He sprinted for the elevator and pressed the 'Call' button. After a few seconds of waiting he frantically pushed the button again.

Come on, you piece of shit, he said to himself. Zimra heard a door burst open down the hall and saw two guards rush out of the west staircase. They immediately drew their pistols on him.

Zimra ducked around the corner and grabbed his air pistol. He heard one of the guards use his walkie-talkie to call for backup. He knew the security room was just on the other side of the elevators, and he knew that he'd be outnumbered and surrounded in a matter of seconds.

Behind him, Zimra heard the server room door smash open, and he turned around to see a guard in the doorway facing him. Zimra aimed his air pistol at the guard and fired, forcing the guard to take cover behind the doorway.

The guard shouted, "*GUN!"* Zimra knew he needed to get out of there, fast. He heard the elevator door open – it was now or never.

He held the pistol in one hand and aimed it at the server room door while he grabbed a perforated metal cylinder out of his pant-leg pocket. He removed the pin with his thumb and released the spoon. He threw the grenade around the corner toward the staircase.

A split second before he covered his ears he could hear the guards shouting in fear. The concussive explosion from the flash-bang still managed to reverberate in his ears, but it didn't stun him. He ran around the corner and barely noticed the incoming bullets that whizzed by his back into the freight elevator door across the hall. He entered the elevator, took cover behind the door and hit the 'Close' button.

Before the door was fully closed the elevator began to rise. Kondor was controlling the elevator from the control shed on the rooftop.

Zimra heard Kondor in his earpiece saying, *"I will pull you up through the ceiling."* Zimra holstered his air pistol and watched the digital display above the elevator doors as it reached "2."

"Press 'Stop,' now!" exclaimed the Russian voice in his ear. Zimra immediately pressed the 'Stop' button and an alarm went off. A panel in the ceiling of the elevator came crashing down, and Zimra saw an arm protrude through the opening that was covered in thick black rubber and Kevlar. "Climb up!" the voice coming through the hole in the ceiling reverberated through his earpiece at the same time.

Zimra grabbed Kondor's hand, and Kondor hauled him up through the hole. Zimra found himself in the elevator control shed on the rooftop.

"Follow me, we're not safe yet," Kondor said. He ran for the door and Zimra followed. They jumped over an unconscious security guard that lay on the floor in front of the exit, and then they turned the corner to the left and ran across the rooftop.

They reached the spot above the warehouse bay doors where the flat-black ladder was situated. Zimra climbed down the ladder back onto the roof of the black-truck trailer. Kondor was about to follow when he heard a guard in the distance yell, "He's on the roof, let's go!"

He looked to his left and saw six guards running up from the emergency exit above the

main lobby to the stairs leading to the main rooftop.

The eighteen-wheeler's giant diesel engine began to power up, and the driver inside began to rev the engine.

"Kondor," Zimra yelled, "we gotta go!"

Kondor grabbed a flash-bang from his pant-leg pocket, pulled the pin, and threw the grenade as hard as he could towards the group of guards. Zimra could hear the truck shift into gear.

"*Kondor!"* Zimra yelled, "Let's -" The flash-bang exploded and startled Zimra as the explosion reverberated in his ears.

The truck began to move, and the ladder began to slide sideways, threatening to fall off the roof of the trailer and onto the ground below. Zimra recovered from the ringing in his ears and grabbed the ladder. He pulled on it as hard as he could while resisting the forward momentum of the eighteen-wheeler as he pulled the ladder back so it would fall onto the roof of the trailer.

It came crashing down and Zimra fell on top of it. He looked up to the rooftop to see Kondor climbing over the edge of the building and hanging off the ledge.

"Jump!" Zimra yelled.

Kondor twisted his body around and kicked off from the face of the wall. He dropped ten feet onto the top of the trailer and snagged one of his legs on a rung in the ladder. Kondor fell face-first on top of the ladder – he groaned and cursed in Russian but lay flat, hoping their black suits would help them blend with the black rooftop of the truck-trailer.

Zimra lay on his stomach but looked behind him at the rooftop. He could see some of the guards recovering from the effects of the flash-bang.

The two agents both lay still on the trailer's rooftop as the truck approached the security checkpoint. Kondor brought his forearm in view and checked his OLED display pad. Convinced that it wasn't damaged, he pressed a few buttons on the pad and the flexible screen read, *'Relay Beacon Active.'*

After the guards at the checkpoint checked inside the truck's cab, the trailer, and underneath the truck they let it pass. The truck turned onto the main road and continued driving toward the highway.

"How's your leg?" Zimra asked Kondor.

"It is fine," Kondor replied as he rotated his ankle. "Get ready."

They both got on all fours and crawled to opposite ends of the ladder to hold it down and prevent it from sliding.

Twenty minutes later they reached a dark, lonely highway, and a state trooper police car lit up its klaxons and honked its horn four times.

"That's the signal," Kondor said.

The truck pulled over, and the state trooper exited his car and walked to the front cab of the truck. He saw Kondor scale down the ledge of the trailer and grab the bottom of the ladder as Zimra lowered it down to him.

The state trooper whispered to Kondor as he passed by, "White cube van in five minutes."

Kondor looked at him and nodded his head in acknowledgment. Zimra lowered himself down on the ladder as Kondor held it in place, and then they both grabbed it and laid it flat on the side of the road.

After the state trooper made the appearance of performing a routine traffic stop he walked back to his car then both he and the truck driver drove away. Five minutes later a white cube van pulled over beside the two masked agents. The passenger side door opened and a man stepped out.

The man walked to the back of the truck and lifted the back door open. Kondor and Zimra carried the ladder into the truck and jumped in. The man closed the door behind them and they were left in darkness, except for a small open window facing into the front cab. The passenger reentered the front cab and the truck started moving.

"Did you get the files?" a voice asked through the window.

"Not all of them," Zimra answered, "almost half." He handed the flash drive through the window.

"That'll have to do," the passenger grabbed the drive. "Anything else?"

"Armed guards, and a key-card reader in a common elevator," Zimra said. "Other than that, nothing suspect on the surface."

"Alright," the passenger replied. "We're dropping you two at a safe house. We'll contact you if anything comes up."

The white cube van continued on southeast, exited Silicon Valley on their way to a safe house in southern California. Both agents sat with their backs to the front wall, staring into the dark void as they thought the same thing: *For a simple warehouse and online database, that building had a lot of armed guards.*

Two

June 22
Year 0 T.S.

"Come on, come on! It's all you – it's all you!"

The out-of-shape mother of two lay flat on the black weight bench holding seventy-five pounds of iron weights and bar overtop of herself. She was about to complete the last few reps of her final set as the blonde fitness trainer in form-fitting spandex shorts named Ashley stood above her.

Ashley's hands were placed slightly below the iron bar just in case the mother's arms should fail her. Ashley continued to encourage the mother to press on. She lifted the bar as high as she could extend then brought it back down just inches above her chest.

"Okay, you're doing good, Beth! Last rep – you can do it!"

The mother named Beth pushed with all her might as her face cringed from the effort. With every last ounce of her strength, she pushed the bar back up.

"Excellent, you're done!" Ashley helped her client place the weight bar back onto the resting pads. Sweaty and out of breath, Beth stood up as Ashley said, "Alright, that's a new record, Beth – five sets of ten at seventy-five!"

Beth tipped a plastic bottle of water into her mouth then wiped her sweaty brow with her free hand.

"Alright, we're done," Ashley continued. "Let's go cool down and I'll see you on Monday!" The two women engaged in small talk as they walked to the treadmills. "So," Ashley asked, "how are the kids?"

Beth and Ashley both stepped on adjacent treadmills. "Oh, they're doing great," Beth said. "Tiegen just got her orange belt, and Justin just got his cast removed."

Kayleigh pressed a few buttons on the treadmill's console and set up a program. "That's great!" she exclaimed. "I bet Justin won't try that stuff again, huh?"

"Actually," Beth replied, "as soon as he got it off he was already practicing again."

Ashley gave Beth an exacerbated look of disbelief. "Really?" she said, "No way!"

"Yep, he was climbing gas pipes and flipping off walls. He showed me this channel on *YouTube* about these two guys. One of them was being chased by the police right here in our city!" Beth exclaimed. "Justin said he wants to be *just like them.*"

"Oh no," Ashley said. She smiled shamefully inside.

"Yeah, so I checked out their site for myself. It's a shame – they're so popular but they go about it the wrong way."

"Yeah, I bet."

"They should take the money they make from all of that popularity and open a parkour park or something."

Ashley laughed. "Yeah, that's a good idea!"

Beth put on a pair of headphones that were hanging from the handrail on her treadmill. Beth looked up to the bank of television screens in front of the two long rows of treadmills. She gasped lightly, "Oh my God!"

"What's wrong?" Ashley asked.

"Look at *CNN*," Beth pointed to the T.V.

Ashley looked up to the screen and saw a live video feed of flashing police lights in front of the White House. Accompanying these images was a headline at the bottom of the screen:

Source: White House Killer Broke into Pentagon.

Ashley put on the headphones that were hanging off her own handrail and changed the audio channel to *CNN*...

"...It's been two weeks since a gunman shot and killed a Secret Service agent during a failed attempt to break into the White House," the news anchor reported. *"And now sources are saying this same gunman may be connected to attempted break-ins at the Pentagon, the CIA, and the NSA buildings almost ten days earlier."*

The TV screen showed a high-quality surveillance camera feed of a hallway leading to a window.

"We're going to show you this video from the Pentagon's surveillance cameras – just pay close attention to the window at the end of the hall. First you see cracks forming in the windows, presumably from gunshots. And then..."

The video showed a human figure slam its body into the window, cracking it severely but not breaking it.

"...Right there – you see that figure try to force his way through the window. We're getting reports that that was bullet-proof safety glass reinforced with Plexiglas, so it's virtually break-proof. After two more attempts the culprit runs away."

The screen transitioned to a list of descriptions of the culprit. *"Authorities are asking for information on the whereabouts of this assailant. According to video surveillance and witnesses, the culprit is less than five feet tall and was apparently wearing a metallic face-mask, possibly a welding mask. The suspect is armed and extremely dangerous..."*

"Wow," Ashley said.

"You know I saw this T.V. show once," Beth said, "and they were talking about how Al-Qaeda surgically implants hidden bombs into suicide bombers. This makes me think about that."

"Wow," Ashley repeated.

They talked a little more about themselves then said goodbye and prepared to leave. Ashley went to the employee change room and opened her locker to grab a towel. She checked her cell phone for messages and noticed two missed calls: one from Madison, and the other from her mother in Long Island. There was also a text message from her boyfriend:

Hey call me when you're off work.

She placed her cellphone back in her locker, removed her work shorts and shirt and threw them into the laundry basket. She then removed her underwear and sports bra, wrapped the towel around herself, grabbed a pair of flip-flops from her locker and closed it. She walked into the shower room and entered a stall. She disrobed and turned on the soothing-hot water.

Ashley had been going out with T.J. pretty much ever since they left Las Vegas. When he came back to New York they agreed to meet up at a nightclub that weekend and had a lot of fun together. She remembered being surprised by how well he could dance.

She figured that he'd be too scared or just plain awful. Steve came along as well to meet up with Madison, but he sat at their table for most of the night and watched as the three of them

danced.

T.J. and Ashley got pretty close in the last month-and-a-half. They often spent the night at each other's homes, but the last three weeks T.J. had been swamped at work, stayed late at work or just worked overtime. As a result Ashley was excited to get a message from him and hoped he had some plans in mind for them this weekend.

Ashley dried herself off with her towel and went back to her locker. She changed into a pair of skin-tight jeans and a white tank-top. She left the gym and called T.J.'s cell phone as soon as she reached the sidewalk.

"Hello?" T.J. answered.

"Hey, what's up?" Ashley asked.

"Meh," he replied, *"Just hangin' around."*

Ashley could hear the sound of wind blowing into the receiver on T.J.'s phone. "Where are you?" she asked.

T.J. replied, *"You gotta look up."*

Ashley gradually looked to the top of the five-storey building across the street. On the rooftop she could see someone waving down at her. It was T.J.

"Pfft," she muttered, "figures."

T.J. chuckled a bit. *"Hey wait there, I'll be right down."*

"You know my client..." Ashley was interrupted by her phone disconnecting. T.J. had hung up. *What a jerk*, she half-joked to herself.

Less than a minute later Ashley saw T.J. on the ground weaving through the somewhat-busy street. Sometimes she wondered how the hell he does it, the "free-running." She didn't really care.

T.J. crossed the street and walked up to her, breathing heavily and sweating lightly. "Hey," he said, "what's up baby?"

"What's this?" Ashley pointed at the building behind T.J. "Spying on me now, huh?"

"Naw, I was in the neighbourhood," T.J. replied.

"Hmm, sure you were..." Ashley turned and started walking down the street. T.J. kept up with her.

"No, serious – I just got off work." T.J. put his arm around her waist and pulled her to a stop. "Hey, come here..." he kissed her on the lips.

"Mmm," she smiled, "so how was your day?"

"Oh, you know, same ol' thing – still crushin' the hours." The couple started walking again as T.J. continued, "What about you?"

"It was okay," Ashley replied. "My client told me that her son broke his arm free-running. Apparently he's a big fan of yours."

"Oh yeah?" T.J. was amused. "How old is he?"

"He's only twelve," Ashley replied. "And get this: he showed her the video of you being chased by the police and says he wants to be *just like you*."

"Oh," T.J. was speechless. "That's not good."

"Nope, it's not."

"Does she know you're dating her son's hero?" he smiled.

"Are you kidding me?!" Ashley exclaimed. "She'd freak if she found out! *No*, she doesn't know."

"Oh, well that's good," he said dismissively.

Ashley decided to change the subject. "So," she said while she grasped his hand, "what do

you want to do tonight?"

"Well," T.J. replied, "I kinda wanna check out this stand-up comedy club down the way."

"Oh yeah," she said, "That sounds like fun!"

"Yeah, well I've never been to a comedy show before, and I figure it's better than hanging out at home all night."

"Aw, look who's coming out of his shell," she joked. "Is Steve coming too?"

"Dunno," T.J. said, "haven't talked to him."

"Really?" Ashley sounded surprised, "What happened? I thought you two were inseparable."

"Hey, I just got off work and you're the first person I get a hold of, let's leave it at that!" he joked.

"Well, call him. I'll see if Maddie's up for it too." They both got on their phones and called Steve and Madison. Madison was excited to go out; Steve was less excited but regardless, chose to go.

Three hours later T.J. and Ashley stood outside of the *Three Smile Island* comedy club as they waited with Madison for Steve to show up. He was running late, but assured them that he would be there really soon. Madison wore a navy-blue blouse and a black miniskirt.

She had gone home to change her clothes after work, but Ashley and T.J. stayed downtown for the whole evening. A yellow cab pulled up to the curb and Steve stepped out of it. He wore khaki pants and a beige tight-fitting long-sleeve shirt.

T.J. said to him, "About time."

"Yeah, whatever," Steve replied.

He walked up to Madison and kissed her. "Hey what's up?"

"Mmm, missed you," she replied.

"Alright, let's go," T.J. said, "it's starting soon."

The four of them walked inside. T.J. and Steve paid the admission for all four of them then they found seats at a booth near the end of the room but in plain view of the stage.

After a half-hour and a few drinks later the show started. The lights in the room dimmed and a cheery voice announced over the P.A.: *"Ladies and gentlemen, thank you all for coming but, please, take the soiled linens home with you!"*

Some light laughter broke out in the audience. *"Now without further ado, please give a warm welcome for his debut performance at* Three Smile Island – *Vic Romano!"*

There was a round of applause as a brown-skinned man approached the stage wearing baggy jeans and a dark hooded sweater and eyeglasses. He stood up at the center of the stage.

"Thank you, thank you!" the man exclaimed as he grabbed the microphone off its stand. "Thank you! Now please, sit down and shut up! You're makin' me nervous."

There was some light laughter as Vic continued. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to yell. I'm just getting used to society again – I just got off parole! I was innocent, by the way." He gestured a lot with his free hand and walked around the stage comfortably as some more light laughter broke out among the audience.

"Yeah, apparently some big drug dealer's house got broken into and I got arrested for it. They ran up on me five houses down after I hopped a bunch of backyard fences. I dunno *why* I was hoppin' fences – I was just *really* hammered at the time. I spent the night in the drunk tank and woke up to some bum pissin' on the floor right in front of my face!

"Before I got into the interrogation room I heard one of the cops say 'We got a witness in

custody.' Now I'm still drunk, and I wasn't sure I heard them right so I say..." Vic cocked his head to the side and raised an eyebrow, "You got a *witness in custody?!* First off, I ain't no rat. And second, is *this* how y'all treat your snitches now?!"

Some more laughter broke out in the audience. Vic continued, "No more witness protection or reward money? Just a granola bar, black coffee, and a white R. Kelly practically pissin' in a nigga's face? No wonder y'all got so many cold case files!" Some more laughs.

"Anyway, I get into the interrogation room and they ask me," – Vic lowered his voice – "Why were you running from the crime scene?" His voice went back to normal as he continued. "I said, 'What crime scene? I was just doing my afternoon cardio, y'know! A few hurdles, some flips, followed by a nose-dive into a rose bush!" he shrugged his shoulders and the audience laughed.

Vic paused for a moment to grab a sip of water then continued. "Well I stopped drinkin' now. Actually, I've been sober for five years." The audience applauded and cheered. "Yeah, that lady in front though – she promised me a night I'd forget after the show!" The crowd laughed, "I dunno how I'ma turn that down!

"Although I dunno. I mean, is it *really* worth it to get drunk and fuck? I mean one time I took this white girl to bed, I start rubbin' up on her, and that's all I remember. I woke up the next morning with my pants around my ankles and the white girl is laughing. She told me she started sucking my dick and then I started snoring! I asked her if she wanted to try again and she like, 'No.'" Vic's jaw dropped as the audience laughed.

Vic cringed his face and screamed, "NOOOOO!!!!!!" the audience laughed again.

He looked down at someone in the audience and said, "I'm sorry, baby girl, but I'ma have to pass on that. I don't wanna risk havin' ya makin' fun of me to all your little girlfriends sayin', 'I fucked priests that keep it up for a woman longer than him!'" The audience jeered at first, then started laughing and clapping.

Vic waited for the laughter to subside before continuing. "Oh, I do miss drinkin' though. I do I do." He shook his head as he talked. "You know what's funny – the one drink I miss the most, is the one I stopped drinkin' before I even quit! That's fucked up, huh? You know what it is I miss? *Jose Cuervo Gold!"*

Some people in the audience cheered. "Oh God, I love the taste but *I hate that fucking shit!* Every time I got drunk on that shit I'd *turned down pussy!*" The crowd burst into laughter.

"I'm serious! Every time I drank tequila I never got laid, and it was my own fault. *My own Goddamn fault!* And that's why I quit drinkin' that shit.

"I remember I was seventeen, and I had this girlfriend. Sexy as hell! A Peruvian *mami con tetas grandes!"* He held up a hand to his chest as if he were cupping a large breast. "And she broke up with me on Christmas morning."

The crowd booed, but Vic waved at the crowd and shook his head. "Oh no it's cool – I was already drunk I didn't care!" He smiled, and the crown laughed and cheered.

"But a week later I was gearing up for New Years Eve and I'm talking to her. She done already moved on," some people in the crowd groaned sympathetically. "Yeah, she had a new girlfriend." There was a small bit of uncomfortable laughter. "Yeah, her name was *Big Booty Judy!* Anyway, my ex tells me she's babysitting on New Year's Eve, and she already knew I was gonna be drinking tequila that night and wanted me to stop by. She said it'd just be me and her – oh yeah, she already told me she wanted to be fuck buddies!" He smiled and winked as the crowd cheered.

"So I said, 'Okay, I'll be there around 9:30'... Aaaand then I got drunk. I ended up at this wild house party with my boys. By the time it's 9:30 I'm already halfway through my forty-ounce bottle of *Cuervo* and I say 'Forget that bitch! She ruined my damn Christmas. I'd rather get drunk and party with my boys!" The crowd cheered and hollered.

"So a little later on, I'm twisted outta my damn mind. I'm sittin' on this couch, still as a statue, dazed and starin' at a T.V. that ain't even on! This girl across the room looks at me and says," – he softened his voice to imitate a girl – 'hey Vic, you alright?'" He went back to his normal voice. "So I slowly turn to her and stare at her, sayin' nothin'. And she says, 'You look like you need to take a shit.'" The crowd laughed.

"I just stare at her like this..." He stared into the crowd with a dead-serious look on his face. "...And I say, 'I *do* need to take a shit!'"

The crowd began to laugh hysterically. Vic tried to continue, but started breaking out laughing himself uncontrollably.

Fighting back tears, he choked out the last sentence in between his own laughs, timing his words when the audience's laughter would soften, "So then she says, 'Well go take a shit!' ...So I go take a shit." The crowd laughed even harder.

For a solid 45 more seconds the crowd and Vic succumbed to laughing fits and choking as they tried to catch their collective breaths. Vic sighed as the audience finally quieted down, and took a sip of water. "Oh God," he sighed, "Y'all almost asphyxiated me to death, you're an amazing crowd, I love y'all, that's my word."

The crowd cheered and clapped. Suddenly Vic looked surprised. "Oh shit," he exclaimed, "I didn't mean for y'all to think I was done, I'm just thankin' you like you thank a gracious host in the middle of a good meal!" He smiled as the crowd began to hoot and holler.

"Yeah, it's called 'good etiquette,' it was somethin' I learned from TV while I was down." There was some sparse laughter through the crowd. Many people in the audience, including T.J., Steve, Ashley and Madison didn't understand that the slang term, "Being Down" referred to doing time in a federal penitentiary. Those who laughed at that joke were primary former inmates themselves.

Vic asked, "Oh, y'all know what I'm sayin', right?"

A man in the crowd hollered.

Vic looked directly at him, "If you don't mind, where you from, *Loc,"* he asked.

The man yelled, "Joliet!"

Vic kissed his teeth as his face cringed, "Oh, shit nigga! I don't envy you! I had a brother up there. I don't ask, he don't tell."

There was some chuckling and booing intermixed together in the audience.

"Hey," Vic said, "As I say, 'Do your own time, but stay out next time. Don't be a Product of the System, my brotha." He pumped his right fist into the air as the crowd cheered.

Vic continued, "Anyway, I walk to the bathroom and pass the stairs, and I see my homeboy layin' sprawled over the stairs like..." He hung his arms up like a scarecrow and twisted his face into a weird expression. "And he's got the rest of my bottle in his hand, and he's passed out halfway down the stairs!

"So I go to the bathroom, pull my pants down, push a few garden snakes out then realize there's no toilet paper." There was a mixture of laughs and groans from the audience.

"I dunno what to do, so I just sit there like an idiot. Twenty minutes later my friend opens the door to use the bathroom, and she sees me on the shitter. I tell her, 'Yo, I've been in here for half an hour – you gotta find me some toilet paper!' She says, 'Okay, I'll be back!' Five other people walked in on me after that, just laughin' they asses off!

"Now I dunno how long I was sittin' on the shitter, but at some point, my boy wakes up off the stairs and comes in, tryin' to piss. I tell 'im I need toilet paper, and he tells me,' 'Just use the towel beside you, guy!'" The crowd laughed.

"I look over and there's this perfectly bleached, ironed, folded white towel. I said, 'Fuck no! Just get me some toilet paper!'

"Later on my homegirl who walked in on me the first time, she finally comes back," Vic lowered his voice to a moan and said, "She says all she can find is a half-empty box of Kleenex. She throws me the box and yells, 'Hurry up, Vic! It's almost time for the countdown!' So I wipe my ass and get up out the bathroom."

There was some light laughter from the crowd. Vic started pacing around the stage. He chuckled and continued, "Now everybody's laughin' at me. People are comin' up to me, just talkin' shit." The crowd chuckled.

Vic changed his voice to a mocking tone, "'Hey Vic, did you fall in or something? Ha ha ha!' 'Did you get stuck?' 'Hey, Vic, gimme a tissue!'" The crowd chuckled.

"It was embarrassin', so I go up to the kid whose party it was, and I tell him, 'Yo man, you need to put some more toilet paper in that bathroom, you're all out.' And he says, 'Did you check under the cupboard? There's like forty rolls down there!'"

The room burst into laughter again.

"So after the countdown, a fight broke out in the den. Poor kid's pool table got fucked up! After that, me and my boy was like, 'Fuck this, let's go home and grill up some burgers!'"

The crowd chuckled and Vic continued. "I used what was left of my *Cuervo Gold* to marinade those bad boys. Mmmm, MAN THEY WERE GOOD!" The crowd cheered.

"The next day my ex messaged me, 'You stood me up...' I laugh and I start typing up my message. I'm sittin there on the keyboard, just clickin' away, I'm gonna tell this bitch off hardcore! *Pinche Puta* broke up with me on Christmas and wants me to bring *her* booze on New Years! Never that!

"And all the while, on the bottom of my message window it shows my ex is in the middle of typing too. So to me, it's like, we're racing to tell each other off first! So I'm bustin' it hard," He imitated typing on a desktop keyboard, "Click click click click... oh shit, backspace backspace, back back back...there we go! Almost done..."

He stops gesturing with his fingers and stares out among the crowd, "I hit *send*, and half a second later, her message appears too, so we just told each other off at the same time."

Vic walked over to his water, took a sip and continued, "So I read her message and it says, 'That's too bad, my girlfriend came over too, we wanted to have some fun with you."

The crowd moaned in sympathy for Vic. "Damn!" Vic shouted. He then paused, shrugged his shoulders and said, "Oh well, at least I had some good burgers, and I made the countdown. That's a good night in my book!"

The crowd cheered and clapped. Vic said, "Thanks for comin' y'all been great!" He pointed to a lady in the front row, "I'll see *you* later! Goodnight, Manhattan!" And with that he left the stage.

A few hours later, after several drinks and a dozen or so comedy sketches they left the club, hailed a taxi and left for T.J.'s place in Brooklyn. They stopped in front of the brownstone where T.J. lived, and T.J. paid the cabbie.

They all went upstairs to the top floor to T.J.'s open-concept one-bedroom apartment. Steve and Madison -- who were drunkenly pawing at each other for the entire cab ride -- went immediately to the couch. Steve pushed Madison down onto the couch and jumped on top of her. They made out ferociously as Steve slid his hand up her skirt.

"Hey buddy," Ashley said as she walked up toward the couch. "Calm down or get your own room, you horn-dogs."

"Yeah whatever," Steve replied. He and Madison both sat up, and Madison fixed her skirt. T.J. closed and locked the door then went to the living room. He turned on one of his computers in the corner next to the LCD TV then switched on the TV as well. He changed the input of the TV so it would display the computer's desktop and switched the surround sound system over to the computer output as well.

As he waited for his computer to boot up T.J. grabbed a small zip-loc bag out from a drawer in his computer desk, sat down on his desk chair and wheeled it over to the coffee table where all of his paraphernalia laid about. He picked up his smart phone and opened an application that connected to his computer.

He used this app to open his computer's media player -- a program called *Winamp* -- and turned on some old-school hip hop from *Cypress Hill*. A mellow, psychedelic rhythm flowed through the whole apartment as T.J. ripped some buds apart by hand and placed them into the bowl of his water-filled bong.

Ashley walked over to the computer and turned off the music. T.J. looked at her and said, "Hey, what are you doin'?"

"Putting something else on," Ashley replied.

"Alright," T.J. muttered, "but hurry up or put Cypress back on!"

"Shut up," Ashley said. She clicked on the search bar on *Winamp* and typed in '*pharrell happy'* then selected the one song that was isolated from her boyfriend's thirteen-thousand-track-long playlist.

"*Because I'm Happyyyyyy!"* She sang, shaking her hips as she put her arms around T.J. and kissed his cheek. "Are you working this weekend?" she asked him.

"Not really," he answered as he continued packing his bowl. "I'll do some work when I wake up, but I'm takin' it easy this time."

"Good." She hugged him then kissed his neck. "'Cause I haven't been laid in a week!"

"Aw, poor thing!" T.J. joked. "I wouldn't know what *that's* like..."

Ashley gasped and hit him on the side of the head. "I'm just jokin' babe!" T.J. exclaimed as he grabbed her hips. "Hey, here..." with his other hand he gave her the lighter, and gestured to his bong.

She sat on his lap as she grabbed the bong, pressed it tightly to her lips and lit the bowl. She brewed up a milky, thick cloud of smoke, and hardly choked as she passed the lighter back to T.J.

"Hey Teej," Steve said, "How's your new project comin' along anyway?"

"Tougher than I thought." T.J. brewed up a cloud of smoke and inhaled it.

Steve asked, "Think you'll be done anytime soon?"

T.J. exhaled a thick, opaque cloud of smoke. "I dunno," he replied. "I've pretty much had to redo my entire engine and rework some of the old man's program. I've been workin' overtime since Vegas."

Steve took the bong and started brewing his own cloud of smoke. "Collecting some serious cash though, right?"

T.J. shrugged and replied, "Not really." He stood up and walked around the coffee table towards the kitchen behind the sofa. "The old man's got half my O/T going towards his alimony payments."

Steve choked. "What?!" he shouted.

"That's not legal," Madison exclaimed. "He can't do that!"

"Nope. But it's goin' to my mom anyway. Plus, he's givin' me two percent royalty on the game once it's done."

T.J. walked over to the stainless-steel fridge and grabbed a beer for himself. “Drinks?”

Both Steve and Madison answered yes.

“You got anything hard?” Ashley asked.

“Vodka or whiskey,” T.J. replied.

“Hmm,” she muttered. “Let me see...” She walked into the kitchen to see what other drinks her boyfriend had that could go well with the vodka.

“Two percent, huh,” Steve said. T.J. placed the beers on the island behind Steve and Madison’s heads as Steve nodded his head in amazement. “That’s actually not bad.”

Steve turned around and grabbed the beers and handed one to Madison.

“Yeah,” T.J. agreed. “Plus, Larry the Lawyer kept reminding me how the old man saved my ass from jail ‘fore we went to Vegas.” He walked back over to his computer chair.

Madison took a hit from the bong then stopped. “Wait a minute,” smoke billowed from her mouth as she spoke. “Do you mean Larry Goldblum?”

“Yeah,” T.J. sat down. “Why, do you know him?”

“He used to be with my firm,” she started picking at the label on her beer.

“Oh yeah,” T.J. replied, “why’d he leave?”

“I don’t know. It’s like a big secret between the partners.” Madison stopped picking at the label and took a swig of her beer.

“I think I know what happened.” T.J. put his beer down as he spoke. “I think what happened was your boss probably caught his wife sleeping with Larry, so he fired *Larry* ‘cause he cheated on *him*!”

T.J. and Ashley both laughed. Madison just gasped. “That’s not funny! Mr. Kramer is a good man!”

T.J. chuckled, “I bet he is.”

“Besides,” Madison continued. “Even if he *was* gay, it’s an insult to say *anyone* would sleep with Larry.” T.J. and Madison both shared a laugh.

Ashley walked around the coffee table with a glass of vodka and orange juice. She sat beside Madison, took a sip and looked at T.J. who smiled as he took a swig of his beer.

“So,” Ashley said, “what’s there to do besides sit around and drink in this place?”

“Uh,” T.J. hummed, “Games?”

“Like what?”

“Hey, didn’t *Microsoft* bring back *One Versus One-Hundred?*” Steve asked.

“That’s right, they did!” T.J. exclaimed. He checked his phone for the time. “Fuck! It’s not on right now!”

“You guys got that dancing game?” Madison asked. Ashley’s head perked up.

T.J. smiled and looked down at the ground.

“No,” he muttered, “but I guess I can order it up.”

Madison exclaimed in excitement. “*Sweet!*”

“Don’t worry,” Ashley said, patting T.J.’s arm. “We’ll make your place female-friendly in no time!”

“Please don’t,” T.J. said as he grabbed for his Xbox One controller.

Three

June 23
Year 0 T.S.

The dawn sun emitted a bright yellow ray of sunshine through the thin curtains of a bedroom window above a local corner store in downtown Colorado Springs. Laying in bed with no covers and still clothed in last night's boxers and white muscle shirt, Marcus Staacmen squinted as the light from the window slowly travelled across the room and rested on his face.

His digital clock on the dresser across the room indicated that it was 6:30am. He had been awake since 3:30am.

It was the dream -- the same recurring dream that had plagued him since he left Nevada -- that jarred him awake that night just like almost every other night. He would discover himself screaming and grasping at thin air with his heart racing in sheer terror. There was hardly a night where he had slept for more than four hours; some nights he didn't even sleep at all.

Slowly, he crawled out of bed and sat at the foot of his bare, twin-sized mattress. He had no bed frame, only a box spring, and the only other piece of furniture in the room was the dresser. He left the bedroom and walked down the dark hallway past the second bedroom that he converted into a weight room.

He passed through the living room -- clad only with a ripped loveseat, and old television, an even older computer on a cheap desk, and a table covered in wires, batteries and torn-up machine parts. He walked into the kitchen where a stack of beer boxes full of empty bottles rested next to the fridge.

He grabbed a mug and filled it with cold water. He took a sip then went into his weight room to do his daily workout regimen.

As he worked out in complete silence he tried to clear his mind of the images from his dream, but it was never easy. The images were horrifying, so much so that he only spoke of them once, and never again. He now had no life outside of the Special Forces.

But he dreaded each time he returned to duty, especially since his Commanding Officer mandated that he see a military psychologist after the incident in the desert. Twice a week he was forced to see that damned shrink and he felt that his fellow soldier mocked him for it. Still, he had nothing else in his life.

His parents moved to South Carolina to get away from "all these fucking potheads." He had never found a girlfriend or had children. His weekends usually involved sitting alone at home, getting drunk as he searched the internet and cable news for clues into how the whole thing in the desert got started.

He even looked up articles on the internet of how to create his own Electromagnetic Pulse weapons using the scrap parts that were located in his living room. He had also bookmarked every website he encountered that discussed Artificial Intelligence.

He was a man possessed. Even after the Vault was destroyed he was never convinced that

the threat was gone. His psychologist told him that he was just paranoid.

His fear manifested itself in his dreams, combined with the trauma of surviving the Vault -- he had learned an entirely new method of survival, and had no outlet for this new instinct. That's what he was told.

He didn't dare tell anyone back at Fort Carson about what he believed. Besides, he was gag-ordered by SOCOM to keep the Vault project *Above Top-Secret*. So for the last month and a half, Staacman suffered mentally in silence.

After forty-five minutes Staacman finished his workout and went to the bathroom to take a shower. As he undressed he looked to his right at the shattered mirror covering his medicine cabinet. Behind the mirror were bottles of Percocets and nickel bags of amphetamines that he took in tiny portions, as was silently accepted among fellow soldiers in combat.

There were other bottles of sleeping aids and anti-depressants that he was expected to take but never did. The shattered mirror was a by-product of a drunken night consumed by paranoia, fear and irrational rage. He entered the shower, turned on the water and let the water cascade over his body.

He pressed his hands on the wall in front of him, lowered his head and closed his eyes; his mind drifted away from his shower, his home, his city, his state...

He thought about Guzman - about what he told the psychologist. He told the shrink how he had picked up the top half of Guzman's skull as it slowly teetered on the floor. How he had used their dead squadmate's jacket to keep Guzman's skull in place.

He told the doctor about Guzman's pleas as he begged Staacman to help him, before... before they opened his head.

He told him how the biggest one grabbed him by the throat and lifted him off his feet. He told him about the red, glowing cameras they used for eyes. He told him about the searing hot flame from the plasma torch that threatened to decapitate him.

He told the doctor about how he went to visit Guzman in Mexico three weeks ago, about how he lived with his mother, and about how he was walking and talking like a five-year-old child. Guzman couldn't speak English anymore - only Spanish. And when he saw Staacman he handed him a baseball and said to him, "*Juega con migo. Juego con migo, por favor.*"

Staacman could tell Mrs. Guzman was crushed. There was just a dark pain in her eyes. Staacman would wonder sometimes if it would have been more humane to have just let Guzman die.

He opened his eyes and his mind snapped out of its semi-slumber. He got out of the shower and wrapped a towel around himself before walking back into the living room. He sat on the loveseat, grabbed his TV remote and switched on the television.

He flipped through dozens of channels and found nothing of interest. So he turned it off and stared at the wall, which was littered with holes and scuff-marks from his drunken outbursts. He just sat motionless, staring through the wall until his eyes lost focus.

Staacman was startled back into reality by the sound of his cell phone ringing in the kitchen. He stood up and walked over to the counter where his phone lay, connected to its charger. He checked the call display -- ***Private Caller***. He picked it up and answered it.

"Hello?" he said.

"*Sergeant Staacman?*" a female voice on the other side asked.

"Yes," he answered.

"*Hold for Captain Waters,*" the line started beeping as he was put on hold.

Staacman had been promoted to Sergeant after he was released from Area-51. Guzman had been promoted as well to the rank of Corporal, immediately followed by a Medical Discharge with Honor.

"*Good morning, Sergeant,"* a man said over the phone.

"Good morning, sir," Staacman replied.

"*I have an assignment for you. I assume that's not a problem?"*

"No problem at all, sir."

"*You're to report immediately to Peterson Air Base. You'll be briefed when you get there; full dress."*

"On my way, Sir." The phone hung up.

Three hours later Staacman had passed through the security checkpoint of Peterson Air Force Base in his mid-2000 *Monte Carlo.* He was in full army dress, and as he parked his car and stepped out an *Aide de Camp* approached him carrying a dossier.

"Sergeant Staacman?" the Lieutenant asked.

"Yes sir," Staacman replied.

"Follow me," Staacman followed the *Aide de Camp* through the parking lot and into a post-war design two-storey building. He followed the Lieutenant through the lobby and up a flight of stairs, then through a narrow, white-washed hallway into a conference room.

As Staacman entered he saw five men sitting at a long table. One sat at the end of the table on the right, while the rest sat on the one side opposite of Staacman. They were engaged in conversation as he walked in but they all stopped and looked at him. They all stood up at the same time.

Staacman noticed four of the men were in army uniforms. There was a Black man who had two stars on each of his epaulettes, indicating that he was a Major-General. There was a Native-American man wearing a Lieutenant's rank, a Major, and Staacman's psychologist, Colonel Spengler.

There was also a Mulatto man in a black suit and black tie that nodded his head and brought the corner of his mouth into an imperceptible smile as Staacman looked at him. Staacman recognized him immediately: it was Jefferson Smith. Staacman nodded to him before standing at attention and saluting the room full of officers. They all saluted in return.

"Relax, Sergeant," the General said. "Have a seat." Staacman took a seat and everybody else followed suit.

The five men at the table all had open file folders in front of them. The *Aide de Camp* walked up behind Staacman and placed a file folder in front of him as well. The front cover had a red stamp on it that read ***Top Secret -- EYES ONLY***.

Staacman flipped the folder open to the first document; it contained witness testimonies from the Clark County Sheriff's Department in Nevada, along with a black-and-white copy of a photograph.

The photograph depicted a humanoid, robotic frame lying on the ground. Staacman recognized the frame as one of those ungodly machines from the Vault -- the same one Smith had told his team was named an Adam model.

Staacman's eyes narrowed; he checked the document behind the photograph. It was a witness testimony from a security guard at the Hoover Dam. Staacman looked around the room at the five men staring at him.

"Major Henson," the General said, "would you like to begin?"

"Yes General," the Major replied. "As you no doubt have guessed, Sergeant, an unprecedented situation has arisen that we feel you have experience in. The dossier before you contains witness testimonies and copies of crime-scene photographs from five different locations across the country. There are two more incidents that have not been documented."

Staacman flipped through the pages as the Major continued, "Six weeks ago there was a second attempted invasion of Area-51. The threat was engaged by snipers and repelled. Shortly afterward the Sheriff's Department in Clark County was called to Hoover Dam for a gunfight that occurred inside the dam."

Staacman looked at the picture again as the Major continued. "Ten days later, a Sheriff's Department in Utah received a similar 911 call at a NSA Data Center in the desert. An identical robotic frame was found there as well. We retrieved each frame and returned them to Area-51 for research and analysis, and were able to redact the police files regarding these attacks."

"Do you recognize those machines, Sergeant?" Jefferson Smith asked.

Staacman looked back down at the picture. There were a few things that were different from what he remembered, but it was unmistakable. "Yes," he replied. "This is one of those machines from the Vault."

"That's right," Jefferson replied. "Those are the third-generation Adam models. No doubt you noticed a few changes. The ones we received back at Area-51 had copper tails that doubled as charger cords. They were also retrofitted with modified M4 assault rifles from your squadmates who were killed.

Staacman closed his eyes and muttered under his breath. "Oh Christ."

Jefferson continued. "One of them was also equipped with a small oxygen tank and plasma cutter. Both models have small satellite dishes. We tried to use their sat dishes to locate the source of their carrier signal, but all of their files and firmware were erased."

Major Henson broke in. "Also, four weeks ago, over the course of ten days, there were attempted break-ins at the CIA and NSA headquarters in Langley, as well as the Pentagon and the White House."

Staacman flipped through the documents. He found a series of still shots from surveillance camera feeds. The Major continued, "Video evidence from the Pentagon, CIA and the NSA, leads us to believe those same models were involved."

Staacman looked up at the Major as he continued. "We've had seven civilian fatalities so far, plus one Secret Service agent. We don't know if this is the work of one machine, or four. Either way, those machines in the photos are still at large."

"Forgive me Sir," Staacman said, "but you said there were two *more* undocumented incidents?"

"Yes," the Major replied. "The one at Area-51 we already told you about. The other one was a failed attempt at Cheyenne Mountain."

Staacman's eyes widened. Cheyenne Mountain housed the Command & Control facilities of NORAD. If the machine managed to break in and gain access, it would have discovered the locations of every missile silo and military installation in North America.

Henson continued, "It was destroyed and its firmware erased before we could connect to its sat system. We still don't know how it found out about Cheyenne."

"We think their firmware is connected with a failsafe that erases its memory when the CPU is compromised," Jefferson interjected. "That means we need to capture one that is functional."

Staacman looked at Jefferson and stared him down. "And how exactly," Staacman said

sternly, “do you plan on *doing* that?! Did you forget what happened in the desert?”

Jefferson glared back at Staacman. “No,” he replied bluntly. “I didn’t forget. But they’re no longer confined to the Vault Sergeant. And so far they went after *six* high-security locations in less than forty-five days. We *need* to find out how they know about them, and what else they’re going after.”

“Then how do you capture one without destroying what you need?”

The Major interrupted, “That’s where we’re hoping you can assist us.”

Staacman looked over to the Major, “Sir?”

“We’re putting together a special task force to engage this new threat. We’ve already asked Mr. Smith to advise us on its creation, and he recommended you to be the Task Force Commander.”

Staacman glared at Jefferson Smith. “With respect, Sirs,” Staacman turned to the Black man with stars on his shoulders in respect, “General, I don’t think I’m qualified for the task.

“Why not?” the General asked bluntly. Staacman’s skin felt like ice as he stopped breathing. The General said slowly, “You and Mr. Smith *both* survived the first encounter. And if my files are correct, you even *talked* to one of the machines, right? Trust me; you’re the *perfect* fit for this mission.”

“Pardon me, General Sir, but after what happened…”

Staacman’s mind flashed to the initial ambush that saw over half of his men killed in less than two minutes. Off in the distance, he could see the little machine he carried through the corridor. He saw his comrade get impaled with a metal pole, then the machine jumped into the air.

It flipped upside down and sprung off the ceiling with its feet, lunging at Staacman. He remembered the two thin wires that sunk into Guzman’s brain. He remembered the giant machine with red glowing eyes that grabbed him by the throat.

With defeat in his voice, Staacman muttered, “...I just don’t think I’m the right choice.”

The General stared blankly at Staacman as he lowered his head; the General was utterly unimpressed. The others in the room just looked at each other.

Colonel Spengler spoke up for the first time. “May I speak to Sergeant Staacman alone, for a moment, Sir?”

“Use the room across the hall,” the General replied.

“Sergeant, come with me.” Colonel Spengler stood up and walked around the table. He opened the door and stood in the doorway, looking at Staacman. Reluctantly, Staacman got up from his chair and walked to the door. The Colonel crossed the hallway and opened another door. He gestured for Staacman to step inside. Staacman complied and the Colonel shut the door.

“Now I know things have been hard for you since the Vault, Marcus,” Spengler said, “but let me make this perfectly clear for you: *You’re arguing with a United States Army Major-General, Sergeant!”*

Staacman lowered his head. The Colonel’s tone softened. “You’re still having the dreams, aren’t you?”

Staacman nodded his head. “I should have been watching our backs down there,” he whispered softly. His voice quivered.

The Colonel softened his tone even more as he would during their sessions. “You did everything that was expected of you, Marcus. It wasn’t your fault. But the problem didn’t end in the Vault. It’s here, now, and we need to stop it! Your mission is incomplete.”

Colonel Spengler grabbed Staacman by the shoulders. Staacman looked up at him.

“And right now,” Spengler continued, “You and Jefferson are our best chance of stopping this before it gets any worse. Do you think Guzman would turn this down if he were still capable of

performing his duties?"

"No Sir," Staacman answered reluctantly.

"Then you will take command of this task force."

Staacman straightened his posture. "Yes Sir."

The Colonel opened the door and they both re-entered the other room. Staacman sat down at the table and looked around to the five men who stared at him.

"General," Staacman said, "Sirs, I accept the command position of the new task force."

"Excellent," the General replied. "I shall complete the orders for its recognition with SOCOM. You will find your orders with Mr. Smith, Staacman."

"Yes Sir."

"As you are officially the designated commander of the unit, you are now commissioned to the rank of Lieutenant."

The *Aide de Camp* came up behind Staacman and placed a small box on the table, containing Silver Lieutenant's bars.

The General continued, "The paperwork will be done by tomorrow. I suggest you have a team ready and scrambled by then as well."

The General nodded to the Colonel. "You're all dismissed."

Everybody saluted the General then made their way out of the room. Staacman waited outside the door for Jefferson Smith to exit. As Jefferson left the room he brushed by Staacman and muttered for him to follow. They both walked into another room and closed the door.

"If anybody knocks, only I answer it," Jefferson said.

He dropped his dossier on the table and opened it. He pulled out a smaller envelope that he opened and emptied. "What I'm about to show you is 'Eyes Only' for *CYCO Command."*

Staacman looked at him, puzzled. "*Psycho Command?"*

"It stands for 'Cybernetic Countermeasures.' How are you feeling, by the way?"

"What?"

"I read your medical files. I know everything, Lieutenant. I just wanna know if you're up to this."

Staacman walked up to Jefferson and shoved him against a wall. "You got a *lotta fucking nerve,* Smith, you know that?!"

Jefferson shoved him in return, though not nearly as impressively. "Hey," he exclaimed, "you're not the only one who saw shit down there, alright? Remember what happened to Eggs and the Captain? That shit happened *right in front of me!*"

Staacman and Jefferson stood eye-to-eye with each other. "I know what you go through, Staacman. I just don't want to see you freeze up or break down when one of those things are in front of us again."

"Yeah well, worry about yourself," Staacman retorted. He turned around and walked over to the open envelope.

The envelope had a red stamp which read:
TO: CYCO COMMAND
RE: OPERATION Diamond Blade
Classified: Top-Secret(NOFORN)

"The envelope's yours," Jefferson said. "Read it in full, cuz we're gonna be busy tomorrow."

Staacman took the envelope and placed it in his dossier. Jefferson walked over to a

window and peered through the blinds.

"We'll be going to D.C.," Jefferson continued. "I already have nine other men selected for the team, plus two more advisors. Right now, they're working out how to incapacitate the Adam models so we can capture them."

Staacman looked through the Pentagon documents and asked, "What about those grenades you gave us before?"

Jefferson shook his head. "Won't work. The Adam models we found are covered in a copper mesh that shields them from electronic interference - it's called a 'Faraday Cage.' Even without it, the EMP could erase their memory."

"What about a taser?"

"The mesh shield would ground out the current. Even if it didn't, we could risk burning out the CPU. Same difference."

"Only thing I can think of then," Staacman pondered, "is taking out the limbs."

"We don't know what will happen after. For all we know it will still trip the failsafe."

Jefferson walked over to the table and collected the dossier. "Anyway, my guys are working on that right now. Read over your orders and get some rest; you're flying out tomorrow afternoon."

Staacman looked up at him and asked, "What about you?"

"I'll be coming along. Briefing's tomorrow at five a.m., you'll meet your team then."

Jefferson grabbed his dossier and walked to the door.

"You're stayin' on-base tonight. Speak to the General's aide when you're done in here." Jefferson left the room and closed the door.

Staacman read over his orders that were enclosed in the top-secret envelope. He glances at the profiles of each of his squadmates and all of the technical advisors. All of his squadmates were veterans of the Special Forces Operations Division, and all three technical advisors were highly-cleared Area-51 scientists.

Staacman read through Jefferson Smith's profile and realized that Smith had never left Area-51 after the mission. He was kept on base as a full-time specialist, and had overseen operations on all three recovered Adam models.

Staacman noted that he was to report to Major Henson, and Henson reported directly to Major-General Antoine Wilkes. Finally, he noted that their base of operations would be Peterson Air Force Base. Their current Deployment Zone was the Nation's Capital: Washington, the District of Columbia.

After he finished reading, he packed his orders back into the envelope and left the room to search for the *Aide de Camp* so he could prepare for tomorrow.

Four

June 24,
Year 0 T.S.

The black curtains in T.J.'s bedroom billowed from the light wind that passed through his open window. He could hear the din of traffic and the voices of children at play on the sidewalk below. Despite the breeze it was still very stifling inside from the heat. As a result, T.J. slept in only his boxers, completely uncovered by the bedsheet that lay beside him.

Actually, that was not the only reason he lay in bed unexposed. Beside him lay Ashley, nude from the waist down, clad only in one of T.J.'s oversized shirts. On her slim figure the shirt resembled a cocktail dress.

She was still asleep, her face in the direction of the window, away from T.J., who spooned her from behind and draped his arm around her waist. He awoke feeling well rested, and turned to check his digital clock that stood on the nightstand: 10:23am.

T.J. slowly rose from the bed, trying hard not to wake up Ashley. He tiptoed out of the bedroom and entered the door on his right into the bathroom. He removed his boxers, threw them into the laundry hamper on his left and stepped into the bathtub.

He opened the cold water valve and the head-high window beside him. He enjoyed the summer breeze entering his bathroom as it combined with the cold water from his shower head. He grabbed his body wash from the window sill and squeezed a glob of blue gel into his hand.

He felt sticky all over from the humidity of the hot summer weather, as well as from spending the entire previous day and night alone with Ashley. For at least half the day they fooled around in the bedroom. Even as they tried to watch television together in the living room they were incapable of keeping their hands off of each other.

T.J. wasn't counting, but he presumed they had sex at least six times yesterday. Either way, all he was sure of was the soreness he felt throughout his body, and he could only imagine how Ashley felt.

T.J. finished his shower, stepped out and wrapped a towel around his waist. He walked out to the kitchen, opened the fridge and grabbed a *Brita* pitcher full of cold water. He took a clear glass from his dish rack and filled it with the water. He then looked around his apartment as he took a sip from his glass.

The place was messy. Various articles of clothing littered the living room floor and loveseat -- the result of their failed attempts to resist each other. A greasy pizza box from *Papa John's* was on the breakfast bar, and greasy plates littered the coffee table. The T.V. was off but his computer was still on, which was something he usually never kept on overnight.

He put his glass down on the breakfast bar and walked into the living room to round up the dirty dishes. As he did so, Ashley walked into the kitchen, still wearing nothing but T.J.'s oversized shirt.

Ashley opened the fridge. Without looking at him, Ashley cooed, "Hey baby."

"Hey," he said back. He brought the dirty dishes into the kitchen and turned on the sink. "So, what're you doin' today?"

"Hmm," she replied, "I don't know. Probably just relax at home, maybe do some cleaning." She pushed some items aside in the fridge. "Do you have any bacon? Green Peppers? Mushrooms?"

"Green peppers," T.J. replied as he washed his dishes. "Bacon's in the freezer."

"I'm going to make bacon and omelettes." She started grabbing various food items out of the fridge.

T.J. looked back at her as she bent over to open the vegetable crisper. The oversized shirt hung low on her like a dress, but the bottom half of her buttocks, as well as her crotch, just barely peeked out from underneath. T.J. smiled.

"Sweet," he said, "I didn't realize you cook."

"Yeah," she muttered, "well, only if you clean up after." She stood back up and put the bag of peppers on the breakfast bar. She then opened the freezer and pulled out the pack of bacon. "Where's the cutting board?"

"Right here," T.J. opened a cupboard on his left side. Ashley grabbed the cutting board and a large knife. He went back to the breakfast bar and started chopping up the green peppers.

"Do me a favour," Ashley said, "and put the bacon in a bowl of hot water so it thaws."

T.J. turned around and grabbed the package of bacon and a large mixing bowl from the cupboard next to Ashley's legs. He filled the bowl with hot water and placed the bacon in it.

"Just change the water in about fifteen minutes," Ashley said.

T.J. finished drying the dishes and turned around. He leaned on the counter as he asked, "Need help with anything?"

"Yeah, can you grate some cheese?" Her gaze remained focused on the peppers.

"Yeah, just gimme a moment."

He walked back into the bedroom and removed his towel. He opened his dresser, fished out a pair of boxers, a pair of blue polyester shorts and a pair of socks and put them on.

He walked back out to the kitchen, grabbed a brick of cheese from the fridge, a cheese grater from the cupboard above the sink and stood beside Ashley as he began slicing up the cheese.

"So what are you doing today?" Ashley asked.

"Told my mom I'd visit her today, so I'm gonna go there for a bit," T.J. replied.

"Oh, that's nice," Ashley said. "Is she going to help you shop for underwear?" She chuckled. T.J. shoved her lightly in jest.

"Ha ha," he said sarcastically, "you're funny."

"Well," Ashley smiled, "I try."

"No," T.J. said in response to her original question. "I'm just stayin' there for dinner, probably."

"Oh yeah?" She put the cutting board aside, grabbed a mixing bowl from the cupboard below and started mixing a bunch of eggs in a bowl. "Are any of your siblings going to be there?"

"No," T.J. said bluntly, "they're not related to my mom."

"Oh," Ashley responded. "Well, do you ever go to your dad's for dinner? Or any of your siblings'?"

"Pfft, fuck no!" T.J. exclaimed. "The old man's too busy doing... whatever. And my brothers and sister, forget it! They don't want nuthin' to do with me."

"Oh," Ashley said softly. "Sorry."

"It's okay, the feeling's mutual actually." T.J. finished slicing up the last of the cheese and

passed the pile to Ashley. “There you go.”

Ashley scraped the cheese into the omelette mix and kept stirring. “Check the bacon water,” she said.

T.J. replaced the water in the mixing bowl. “Anything else you need help with?” he asked.

“Nope,” she replied, “you’re free to go.”

T.J. walked up behind her, wrapped his arms around her and kissed her on the neck. “Thanks babe,” he said softly into her ear.

“Mmm,” Ashley moaned. She turned her head and kissed him. “Just don’t expect me to clean.

T.J. walked into the living room and went over to the computer.

Ashley called out, “Can you put some music on for me?”

“Yeah, sure,” he responded.

He turned on some music as he went to work fixing the two game engines that he was tasked to work on.

T.J. was not lying when he told Ashley his three siblings wanted nothing to do with him. They blamed him directly for their parents’ divorce and considered him to be beneath them in status, akin to a second-class citizen. The three Mason siblings all carved out comfortable lives for themselves out of Alfred’s finances. And they all felt that T.J. was undeserving of Alfred’s attention, as lacking as it may have been.

T.J. first met them eight years ago, just before Alfred gave him a job at *Chaotic Entertainment*. In fact, he initially learned of the job offer from his siblings. Alfred had a driver pick him up from his mother’s house and he was taken to the old man’s luxurious home in an affluent community of New Jersey.

T.J. remembered thinking that the house looked much like the mansion from the opening credits to *The Sopranos*. He envisioned that, someday, he would live just like this.

He exited the car and walked up to the front door. Alfred, his ex-wife Jessica and their three adult children all met him in the front foyer. Alfred introduced his estranged son to his now-broken family -- as Thomas, of course.

He was greeted with sheer indifference by all. Jessica Mason looked at him with veiled contempt. She knew it was not his fault that her ex-husband was unfaithful, but she still blamed T.J. nonetheless. She resented him seeking his father out and bringing everything all to light. The children were far less understanding.

Before T.J., Alfred had two sons and a daughter. The oldest of the three was Brock, who was 30 years old when T.J. met him. He had used his father’s fortunes to attend Rutgers University and received a doctorate in medicine and surgery. He was in the process of completing a residency to become a cardiologist.

Jennifer was the middle child -- twenty-seven at the time. She was a paralegal at a prestigious law firm in Trenton. She completed her law degree the same way Brock received his doctorate, through attending Princeton University and having it paid for by Alfred.

Timothy was the youngest of the three at only twenty-four. Fresh out of Rutgers, he worked for a stock broker firm, learning the ins-and-outs of Wall Street.

All three of them owed their success in some way to their father and thus felt that T.J. simply expected a free ride. As Alfred and Jessica left the four of them to get to know each other, the three full-blooded Masons hovered over T.J. as they cornered him in the foyer.

“So, *Thomas*,” Brock started, “where do you and your mother live?” he spoke

pretentiously. He had a cultured tone to his dialect.

"We're from Brooklyn," T.J. replied, "and I prefer 'T.J.'"

"Is that so," Brock muttered. "What does the 'J' stand for?"

"It's my last name: Jennings."

"Hmm," Brock spoke slowly with a condescending tone, "I see..."

"Where do you go to school?" Timothy asked.

"Oh, I already graduated from high school," T.J. said proudly. "Actually, I'm just workin' at a pizza shop right now."

"So you don't even attend college?"Timothy raised an eyebrow.

"Naw," T.J. replied. "My mom couldn't afford to send me, and I figured I should help her out before I do my own thing."

"So," Timothy mused, "you're saying you won't pay for *your own* education -- that somebody else needs to?"

T.J. looked at Timothy. "Did *you* pay for your own education?"

Timothy glared at him in anger, completely bereft of words.

"So," Jennifer interjected, "is this why you came after our dad? You think he owes you something now? You think he needs to pay your way for you?"

"I don't care what the fuck he does," T.J. grunted. "My mom and me did *just fine* without him."

"So you're saying this little job offer of his wasn't *your* idea?"

T.J.'s eyes widened. "What do you mean?" he asked.

Jennifer rolled her eyes, "Oh come on. You don't expect us to believe that our dad's offering you a job in his company when you don't even have a college education, *and* that you had *nothing at all* to do with it?!"

T.J.'s jaw dropped; he couldn't believe what he had just heard. He had dreamed of working for *Chaotic Entertainment* since he was twelve. It had been his dream long before he discovered that his absent father owned the company.

T.J. said to himself aloud, "I'm going to work at *Chaotic?!*" He was shocked and ecstatic all at the same time.

"Yeah," Jennifer scoffed, "not like you deserve it."

T.J. glared at her. Timothy spoke up again, "We worked very hard just to get to where we are, and our father worked very hard for us to succeed. All of a sudden some bastard kid from the ghetto barges into dad's life and he's grooming *you* for his legacy?!"

Timothy pointed an accusing finger at T.J. as he continued, "Like you deserve a handout?! *Like you're better than us?!"* he jammed his finger hard into T.J.'s chest. T.J. swatted his hand away in response.

Timothy tried to shove T.J. backward, but T.J. grabbed his wrists, bent his hands downwards, applied pressure at the base of the wrists and caused Timothy to howl in pain.

Brock jumped in and grabbed T.J. by the neck of his shirt. T.J. elbowed Brock in the gut then placed his leg behind Timothy's. He then shoved Timothy to the ground. Jennifer just watched in disbelief as her younger brother held his wrists in pain and her older brother clenched his belly. Both brothers knelt on the ground.

T.J. closed his eyes, clenched his fists, took a deep breath and spoke with a serious tone, "I don't care if this is your house," he kicked Brock in the shoulder and forced him to lie flat on his back. He then stared deep into Timothy's eyes and uttered menacingly, "*don't ever fuckin' touch me again!*"

T.J. stepped back from Brock, and Brock slowly stood up. T.J. continued, "I don't need his

fuckin' help, but I *do* deserve it. He's my father too, and he walked out on me and my mom."

He then turned his stare towards Jennifer, his half-sister, and said with pleading eyes, "You're seriously okay with that?!"

Jennifer looked down at the ground. Her brothers avoided T.J.'s gaze.

"Your mother should have known better than to try and ruin a married man's family," Brock sneered. "I'm sure you got exactly what you deserve."

T.J. chuckled derisively and smirked. "Get out of my fuckin' face," he said coldly. "And don't *ever* talk about my mom again, unless you want a broken jaw!"

Brock was about to say something else but reconsidered. The three Mason children went upstairs and left T.J. to himself. T.J. went over to the living room and waited for dinner.

Brock was about to say something else but thought twice. The three half-siblings went upstairs, and T.J. went into the living room and watched TV by himself. Later that night, over dinner, Alfred told T.J. in front of the family that he tried out his homemade game modifications, and then offered him an entry-level position in the programming department at *Chaotic.*

Eight years had passed since that tense visit. The mansion had been sold, Brock was now a cardiologist at Manhattan Metropolitan Hospital, Timothy was a partner in a brokerage firm, and Jennifer left her legal position after getting married and having a baby last year.

Jennifer was civil with T.J. - at the very least they were polite to each other online. Brock and Timothy had nothing to do with him at all. In fact, they were even more spiteful when they found out T.J. had been promoted to Lead Programmer.

It made no difference to him. He never even knew he had siblings until he was sixteen and never even met them until he was nineteen. Besides, he thought of them as over-privileged, spoiled freeloaders who only got where they were because of a trust fund.

Conversely, they thought of him as a shady ghetto child who was just out to snipe their father's works. Either way, they didn't care at all about each other one bit.

T.J. and Ashley ate their bacon and omelettes at the coffee table while watching the new episode of *True Detective* online. When they finished Ashley went to take a shower then they both got dressed and left T.J.'s apartment. They walked together down the street to the train station, where they kissed each other good-bye and Ashley caught the train back to Manhattan.

T.J. left the station and walked ten blocks down to an old house and knocked on the door. An elderly woman opened the door with tired eyes. There was an energetic and happy look on her face when she saw her son.

"Hey Tommy!" T.J.'s mother, Theresa said.

"Hi mom," they hugged briefly.

Theresa ushered him inside, "I was wondering when you were going to get here." She walked down the long hallway into the back kitchen.

T.J. closed the door and took off his running shoes. A large husky came barreling down the stairs and jumped on its hind legs, trying to lick T.J.'s face.

"Hey Otis! Hey you big bonehead!" T.J. exclaimed. "Yeah I missed you too! Come on boy, get down. Come on, down."

Otis jumped down and backed up slightly then sneezed. Still wagging his tail, the three-year-old husky followed T.J. into the kitchen, where his mother was stirring a giant slow cooker full of beef stew.

"How was church?" T.J. asked his mother. He sat down at the kitchen table.

"Oh, it was okay," Theresa replied while stirring the pot. "Father Pete talked about

reserving judgment for the Lord."

"Oh, well it's a nice break from tradition," T.J. said sarcastically.

"See? Just like that." Theresa put down the wooden spoon and walked over to the kitchen table. "So how was your weekend?"

"It was good."

"Spend some time with that girl you told me about?" Theresa grabbed a cigarette from an open pack on the table and lit it.

"Yeah," T.J. replied, "she came over for the weekend. We went to a comedy club on Friday."

"Oh nice," Theresa took a drag. "So when do I get to meet her?"

"We haven't really talked about that yet, I've never even met her parents."

"Well, is she a good girl?"

"Yeah, I think she is."

"Well, you make sure you bring her over some time soon." She took another drag then flicked the hanging ashes into a glass tray. "So, what's your father doing?"

T.J. shrugged. "I dunno," he said, "he had to go out of town for some business."

"You're still working on the same game?"

"Yep."

"Well, it's good he let you take the lead."

"Yeah, well I had a good idea. I've been busy as hell though, workin' overtime and at home."

"Is he giving you enough overtime?"

"No, he's using it to pay alimony," T.J. laughed.

Theresa widened her eyes. "What?!" she exclaimed, "Are you fucking serious?!"

"It's okay mom, I get two percent royalties for every copy of this game as well."

She narrowed her eyes. "Is that good?"

T.J. nodded.

"That doesn't sound like much."

"Trust me, it's good." T.J. leaned forward in his chair. "Think of it like this: two percent of sixty bucks is a buck-twenty. So even if we only sell a hundred-thousand copies I make a hundred grand. And we usually sell about a million copies."

Theresa's narrowed eyes widened as T.J.'s explanation stunned her. "Wow!" she exclaimed.

T.J. grinned, "I know."

"I'm really proud of you, Tommy!" she flicked the ash off the tip of her cigarette into the tray on the table. "I always knew you were going to do big things, just like your father."

"Well," T.J. leaned back as he looked down at the table, "I may be doin' big things, but I'm *nothin'* like him."

"No..." Theresa took a drag of her cigarette and quickly exhaled, "I see alot of him in you, mostly good."

"Oh," T.J. looked up at his mother, "So you're sayin' I inherited some bad traits?"

"You don't see *me* getting in trouble with the law, Mister Jennings," she crossed her arms and pretended to be stern.

T.J. leaned forward . "Come on, mom; that was nothin'!"

"Oh yeah? What about that grass I found under your bed in high school? I'm not the one who smokes that crap!"

"Neither does Alfred."

She chuckled lightly and grunted. “Is that what you think?”

T.J. looked surprised, “Yeah right, no way!”

“He used to sit right there,” she pointed out the kitchen window toward the small overgrown backyard. “He’d light one up, sit out there all by himself as he mulled over ideas for his next big game.” She laughed to herself.

T.J. looked out the window. *Wow,* he thought to himself, *I’m more like the old man than I thought.*

As though reading his mind, Theresa continued. “Listen Tommy: It’s not bad to be like your father, but *recognize* the bad traits. If this girl’s the right one, don’t ever take her for granted.”

She put out her cigarette as she continued to say, “And don’t *ever* walk out on your family.”

T.J. nodded then looked down at the table.

After a short pause, Theresa broke the silence. “So,” she said, “how’s your friend Steve?”

“Meh,” T.J. shrugged, “he’s alright.

“He’s still with your girlfriend’s friend?”

“Yeah,” T.J. replied, “I don’t really know if it’s gonna last though.”

“Oh, why’s that?” Theresa stood up and approached the stove to stir the stew.

“He just doesn't seem that into her, I guess. On Friday I told him about the comedy club and told him his girl was comin’, and he pretty much didn’t wanna go.”

“How does she feel?”

“Maddie? She’s pretty much in love with him.”

“Well, the heart wants what it wants.” Theresa put the wooden spoon back down and walked back to the table. “Still, you should be careful. Don’t get too involved in their relationship. Because if things go badly, it could force you and your girlfriend to choose sides, and that will only hurt your relationship.”

“Yeah, well I’m sure we’ll be fine.”

“I think so too,” she smiled tiredly. They continued their small talk about various topics, such as the status and whereabouts of Theresa’s friends and gossip around the church.

T.J.’s mother didn’t lead a very pro-social lifestyle. She didn’t date much either. Her relationships usually lasted about a month or two, then she’d typically find a reason to end things. She went to church every Sunday, and occasionally had her girlfriends over for drinks. Since most of her friends were married, their get-togethers were usually very civilized.

She worked as a manager in a nearby *Wal-Mart*. Between that and the monthly cheques she received from the old man she was able to maintain the house. Alfred agreed to pay her alimony even though they were never married as an alternative to being sued for eighteen years of child support. He made this decision eleven years ago, back when such a suit could have hurt his company.

And now, even though he officially paid alimony to his actual ex-wife Jessica - who left her job at *Chaotic* and chose to live off the alimony payments - he continued to pay alimony to Theresa anyway. Alfred never said as much, but he secretly respected Theresa more than his ex-wife for keeping her job and remaining independent.

Before last year, his mother and the old man would often ask T.J. about one another. Lately T.J. had noticed that they would talk to each other sporadically over the phone. He thought it was kind of weird but he didn’t mind that much.

Sometimes he hoped they would get together, and other times he hoped the old man would try, and his mom would reject him. As far as he was concerned, whatever his mom wanted

was what he would hope for.

T.J. and his mother ate the giant bowls of stew as they continued talking about random things. Shortly thereafter they watched some T.V. in the living room as Otis slept on T.J.'s lap. At 10:00pm Theresa was ready to go to bed. T.J. said good-bye to Otis, who relentlessly mauled him with childlike enthusiasm, then T.J. said good-bye to his mother.

"Make sure to stop by before Thanksgiving. Don't you forget about me," she joked as she hugged him.

"Yeah yeah yeah, don't worry mom," T.J. replied, "I'll see you in a couple of weeks."

"Okay Tommy. You be good now, and don't get in trouble!"

"I will. And you -- don't work too hard!"

Theresa chuckled. "Alright, I won't."

They both said good-bye and T.J. walked out into the dark streets, following the trail of street lamps.

As he walked down the Brooklyn streets traffic was moderate. No young children were out now, but many teenagers and young adults passed him by. Here and there he'd see a group of people hanging out on a stoop, smoking weed and talking trash. The din of the city intermingled with the late summer-night sounds of crickets in the bushes. He felt peaceful, yet guarded.

He reached his building and went inside. He climbed to the top floor, opened his door and switched on the light for the living room. He took off his shoes and walked into the living room. He turned on his computer and grabbed the bag of marijuana out of his desk, noticing he only had a half-gram bud left.

He grabbed his cellphone and sent a text message to a number he had not saved under any of his contacts. As he waited for a response he packed the bowl of a small pipe with what was left in the bag. He walked out to the balcony with his pipe in hand and looked over the railing to the brightly-lit cityscape beyond.

In the distance he heard a police siren. He brought the pipe to his mouth, lit the bowl with his *bic* lighter and took in a deep breath.

After he finished the bowl he looked out to the horizon before walking back inside, leaving the sliding glass door open. He checked his cellphone and noticed a new message from the number he had texted, so he walked back to the door, put on his shoes and exited the apartment.

He walked down stairs to the second floor and knocked on a door to his right. He heard three separate deadbolts open on the other side and saw the face of a Black man his age peer through the open crack.

T.J. muttered quietly, "What up Legs?"

"Coolin' man," Legs replied, "You good?"

"Yeah, I'm good for a week." T.J. handed a small wad of ten-dollar bills through the doorway then the door closed.

Legs had a code system he shared with his customers: When he asked if somebody was 'good,' he was asking how much marijuana they wanted. If somebody were to say 'I'm good for today,' it meant they wanted to purchase a gram. A 'weekend' was an eighth of an ounce, a 'week' was a quarter-ounce, and a 'month' was a full ounce.

The door opened again, and T.J. grabbed a bag of marijuana that Legs extended through the doorway. T.J. placed the bag in his pocket.

"Alright, cool. Catcha later," T.J. said.

"Stay safe, dog," Legs closed the door.

T.J. heard the door's multiple deadbolts locking as he walked back upstairs. He entered his apartment and locked the door then took his shoes back off and walked over to the living room coffee table. He pulled the bag out of his pocket and dropped it on the table then sat down in his computer chair. He removed the large, green buds from the bag and ripped apart one of the buds.

He took a chunk and placed it into the large bowl of his water-filled bong. He brewed up the bowl until the smoke was so arid and thick it resembled a murky liquid. He inhaled the thick cloud and began to choke violently.

The smoke was so rough on his throat that he feared he was going to vomit. He struggled to make his way to the kitchen and pour himself a glass of water. He choked down the water between coughing fits, and by the time he finished the glass his throat felt better.

He was so high and bored that he began to feel anxious. It was only 11:00pm - too early for him to sleep, so he went to his computer to play a few matches online on StarCraft. He was close to being promoted to Diamond League, and his hopes were to accomplish that before he had to go to bed at 1:00am.

Five

June 25,
Year 0 T.S.

The residential streets of Washington DC were often quiet, peaceful and serene in the middle of the night. However, tonight they were flush with the red and blue strobes of light from DC Metro Police vehicles that cordoned off every exit from a low-income neighborhood.

Their sirens remained off but not out of courtesy for the residents as many of the homes were abandoned. The police did not want to scare off their suspect. The officers assumed he must have been extremely dangerous as their Watch Commander had ordered them all to avoid approaching the suspect.

As the police scrambled to barricade every street corner and hold their positions near as many alleyways as possible, a few of them would later mention in hushed tones the pair of unmarked, windowless grey vans that entered the city block, that preceded a grey armoured truck. The witnesses to these three specialized vehicles furthered the rumours that circulated that they had finally cornered the feared White House Killer.

Within the back of each van sat six heavily-armed men, brandishing full combat attire fitted with flash-bang grenades. Four of the men in each van carried silenced H&K MP5 submachine guns. They wore backpacks carrying laptops and oxyacetylene torches, and attached to their ballistic helmets were night vision goggles.



The remaining two men in each van wore forward-looking infrared goggles and carried on their backs large high-pressure tanks filled with liquid nitrogen. Connected to the tanks were hose-and-nozzle assemblies similar to that of a flame thrower's. The men also carried small pouches holding various tools.

All of the men each had sewn to their shoulders an insignia with colours matching their urban camouflage fatigues. The insignia depicted a bald eagle grabbing onto a transistor chip with its talons. The letters ***CYCO*** were imprinted below.



"Ten minutes, guys," the driver of the first van yelled to the passengers behind him. Marcus Staacman, the newly commissioned Lieutenant and Field Commander of the Top Secret Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit ordered his men to double-check their gear before they deployed upon their first operation.

When Staacman's team arrived in DC things were pretty quiet. They all had plenty of time to get to know each other and complete their briefings. The advisors that Jefferson Smith had tasked with figuring out how to capture the Adam model came up with a plan that they were fairly confident would work.

Their plan was to isolate the Adam model inside a building. At this point, one half of the CYCO unit -- designated 'Telescope' -- would surround the building. The other half of the team would enter the building in two squads of three -- designated 'Parasite' and 'Virus.' Each three-man team would consist of two soldiers and a specialist.

The advisors knew the Adam model would need to use its infrared LEDs to see in the dark, so the soldiers could use their night-vision to track the machine's line-of-sight. They also knew the copper mesh that encased the machine not only protected it from electronic interference, but also acted as a heat sink. At the very least, this would assist in locating the machine via the specialists' thermal imaging goggles.

The two three-man squads would work together to confuse, ambush and corner the Adam model so the specialists could freeze it with liquid nitrogen. The soldiers used standard nine-millimetre rounds in their MP5's so they could shed the copper mesh without penetrating the machine's steel frame. In this fashion, the liquid nitrogen could bypass the Adam model's copper Faraday shielding and aid in slowing it down.

In theory, once the model was completely frozen it would not be able to trigger the integrated fail safes for about five minutes. The men could then burn through the chest plate with the oxyacetylene torches, remove the power supply and short out any attached capacitors, and finally connect a laptop to the Adam model's satellite uplink so they could try and isolate a carrier signal before the machine fully thawed out.

This was their best bet on gaining any advantage over the rogue models that escaped the Vault. Still, they needed to locate one of them first. Major-General Wilkes enlisted the help of CIA drone operators to patrol the DC area and report anything out of the ordinary.

At 1:15am a White House countersniper spotted somebody trying to physically break inside of the Washington Monument. The sniper called it in and, to his surprise, was ordered to fire a warning shot. The sniper fired a .308-calibre round and it impacted with the ground just inches from the trespasser's feet. The trespasser turned around, dropped to all fours, and ran off at an inhuman speed.

The CIA drones then tracked the trespasser's progress through the streets of Washington DC. The operators relayed its movements to DC Metro Police until the target finally broke into a burned-out, abandoned high school. As of one hour later, the target was confirmed to have never exited the building.

One of the grey vans and the armoured truck stopped at the front entrance of the former school, while the second van pulled into the parking lot to the east and stopped. In the second van, Lieutenant Staacman, Jefferson Smith and four other men stormed out of the van and approached the side of the school.

Staacman, a Corporal named Hudson and a specialist from Area-51 named Carl Semple ran past Jefferson and his team. They proceeded to the opposite side of the school, toward the West entrance. Staacman's team was designated *Virus.*

CYCO's Second-in-Command for Field Ops, Master-Sergeant Martin, a Corporal named Wilson and Jefferson Smith approached the East entrance. Their radio designation was *Parasite*. Martin and Wilson surrounded the door to the school while Jefferson waited beside the Corporal.

Martin spoke into his headset, "*Parasite* in position, over."

Staacman and his team kept running. A couple of soldiers from the first van ran past them on their way to secure the rear side of the building - they were a part of the team designated *Telescope.*

Staacman's team surrounded the West entrance similar to Martin's team. Staacman spoke into his headset, "*Virus* in position, over."

Both teams waited with anticipation for the other half of the unit to finish moving into position. Seconds later, they all heard the same transmission in their headsets:

"*This is* Telescope*, DZ is Code-4. Standing by, over."*

"*Diamond Blade* is hot," Staacman replied. "Movin' out."

At both side entrances to the school, Jefferson Smith and Carl Semple grabbed lockpick sets from their tool pouches and opened the doors. With their night-vision goggles activated, the soldiers entered first, pointing their laser sights from the MP5's downrange into the dark hallways beyond. Carl and Jefferson followed behind their respective teams, using their infrared goggles to scan the walls and ceilings for unusual bodies of heat that may be hiding among the darkness.

On both ends of the school, the teams entered into hallways where the concrete walls were scarred and blackened from the massive fire that condemned this school. The ceilings were pitch-black from the smoke that stained the school's interior.

The floors were riddled with broken glass from overhead lights and classroom doors. Many of the lockers were charred and cracked - some had even melted down from the intense heat from the blaze.

The halls were saturated with the rancid smell of sulphur and carbon. The walls were so black from smoke damage that it made it difficult at times for the soldiers to navigate, even with their enhanced night optics.

On the East end of the school, Jefferson's team found themselves in a simple hallway, with a door on their right leading to a small stairwell that gave them access to both the floors above, and the basement.

At the West entrance Staacman's team entered the doorway, and found themselves in a foyer with a large staircase headed upstairs. Underneath the staircase was another doorway that led to the halls of the main floor.

Staacman whispered into his headset, "Search and clear the main floor first. *Parasite,* take the South half."

Both teams ventured further into the burnt-out halls of the school. Staacman's team took a turn to the left, and cautiously approached the entrance to every classroom to allow Carl Semple to sweep the rooms with his thermal goggles.

Meanwhile, Jefferson's team, under the command of Master-Sergeant Martin, located and searched the school cafeteria. Within, the cafeteria was littered with overturned chairs and burnt tables. The glass-panel walls that overlooked the front schoolyard were blackened with soot.

Martin stood by the cafeteria's food line and covered Jefferson and Corporal Wilson as they entered and searched the kitchen. The stainless-steel countertops and appliances still seemed to maintain their polished finish, causing the infrared light from Wilson's goggles to reflect back into the lenses, distorting his vision at times.

Jefferson Smith approached the walk-in freezer. The door was partially open. Corporal Wilson approached the door and grabbed the handle. As Smith watched the glowing signature of

Wilson's body heat grab the handle and look toward him, Jefferson nodded, and Wilson slowly opened the door all the way while aiming the barrel of his MP5 through the doorway.

Jefferson looked inside the walk-in freezer for any signs of heat, but the entire contents of the freezer was room temperature, so nothing stood out to him.

"Kitchen's clear," Jefferson whispered into his headset.

"Regroup," Jefferson heard Martin call out from the other end of the kitchen, "Let's move on."

Staacman's team continued their room-by-room sweep of the North side of the school. So far they'd found nothing more than overturned desks and chairs in each of the burnt-out rooms they encountered. As they approached one room in particular they spotted a giant sinkhole in the floor. The men stared into the abyss and saw over a dozen desks and chairs piled on top of each other in between two giant water boilers.

Above the sinkhole, in the ceiling above the men, was an even bigger hole that exposed a network of gas pipes. Staacman assumed the classroom above them must have been the source of the fire. He and his team left the room and continued searching for the elusive machine.

Jefferson's team went through the barren doorway that marked the entrance to the school's office, which was severely damaged by the fire. The cubicles had all been burnt to the ground and the ceiling above was a mess of exposed wiring and pipes. The corkboard drop-ceiling tiles had been burnt to ashes.

In some places the carpeted floor was burnt, and in others only damp and water-stained from the sprinkler systems. The wood finish of the various offices within were all destroyed by the fire. Computer monitors were blackened by the exposure to the smoke.

As they searched the office they heard heavy footsteps on the floor above them. They all stopped in their tracks and listened as the footsteps grew fainter.

Sergeant Martin whispered into his headset, "This is *Parasite*; we're hearing footsteps on second floor, south quadrant, over."

"*Copy*," Staacman's voice replied over the men's headsets. "*Main floor is clear, proceed to second floor ASAP. Out."*

"Let's check the front entrance for a stairway," Martin told Wilson and Jefferson.

With that they exited the office and moved West to the front foyer. There they found a large stairway that led to both the upper levels and the basement. They proceeded upstairs.

As Jefferson's team ascended the stairs, Staacman's team located the North stairwell and approached it. Corporal Hudson took point, aiming his MP5 at the top of the stairs while Staacman covered their rear. They reached the top of the stairwell and opened a steel door with glass windows which were blackened from smoke exposure.

"*Telescope,"* Staacman whispered into his headset, "secure North and South entrances."

"Copy," was the response over the headset. Outside, members of the surrounding team broke open the front and rear entrances to the school and covered the staircases, so the Adam model couldn't slip by the interior teams.

Staacman's team entered the second floor hallway and proceeded to their left to the West. They searched the classrooms one-by-one as they passed them by. They reached the science room, where the giant hole in the floor they had seen previously opened up to the two lower floors.

A portion of the ceiling had been broken apart from an explosion. Dark stains intermingled with the smoke stains on the surrounding walls in the room. It was almost impossible to tell from

the green tint of his night-vision goggles, but Staacman was sure there was blood on the walls. They left the room and moved on.

On the South side of the school, Jefferson's team headed to their left to the West, checking the classroom adjacent to the stairway. This was the room where they believed the footsteps came from. Corporal Wilson entered the classroom, but could only see the same chaos and destruction that could be found anywhere else in the school.

However, there was a small hole in a wall caused from the fire that allowed access to the next room. Wilson carefully inched his way inside the room with Jefferson following behind.

The wall they faced was a room partition that could be retracted to combine both rooms together. Through his thermal goggles, Jefferson could see through the thin plastic partition as though it were a thick layer of plastic wrap. Beyond the wall he could see a humanoid figure crawling on all fours, remaining below the window openings.

The figure would poke its head up to look through each window spontaneously, as if searching for an escape route. Jefferson grabbed Corporal Wilson by the shoulder to stop him from venturing further into the room. Wilson looked back at Jefferson, who was then pointing to his own eyes, then pointed toward the partition wall, indicating he had spotted something on the other side.

Wilson nodded and made a series of hand gestures, ordering Jefferson to go with Sergeant Martin to the front door of the adjoining classroom. Jefferson crouched and walked to the room's exit as Corporal Wilson crouched by the hole in the wall, ready to open fire.

Jefferson whispered to Sergeant Martin, "It's in that room."

The Sergeant whispered into his headset, "This is *Parasite*; eyes-on target, southeast quadrant. Stand-by."

Jefferson and Sergeant Martin walked over to the open door while staying low and stepping as lightly as possible.

"Wilson," the Sergeant whispered into his headset, "weapons-free on my mark."

In response, Wilson tapped the speak-button twice on his headset, indicating he understood and was ready to go.

"*Telescope*," Martin whispered, "Suppressing fire - southeast quadrant, second floor. Now."

Without response, the windows in the classroom began to shatter and break apart as the silenced machine guns outside rained bullets into the school's exterior. The machine sidestepped swiftly away from the windows and turned to face the hole in the partition wall.

"Mark!" the Sergeant exclaimed. Immediately Corporal Wilson blind-fired into the room from the hole in the wall as Jefferson stood up to enter the room.

The Adam model spotted Jefferson and the Sergeant entering the room out of the periphery of its vision and immediately opened fire from its arm-mounted rifle at the partition wall. The 5.56mm bullets ripped through the wall and through Corporal Wilsons's arm and chest. The muzzle flash blinded Sergeant Martin's night optics, and Jefferson's reflexes were no match for the machine's blinding speed as it sprinted on all fours for the partition wall and slipped out of the crossfire via the hole in the wall.

"Shit!" Jefferson exclaimed, "it's gone!"

Sergeant Martin backed out of the room and turned to his left, facing West. He spotted

the Adam model as it exited the room. Martin opened fire and sparks flew from the machine's steel frame as the bullets impacted.

Completely unaffected by the soldier's ammunition, the Adam model ran away, exiting the hallway through a door at the end of the hall to the right. Martin could hear the door slam closed behind the machine.

"Target is on the move, heading West," Martin said into his headset. He ran to the adjoining classroom and looked inside to see Corporal Wilson lying on the floor covered in blood, struggling to breathe. "Man down!" Martin shouted.

Jefferson ran past the Sergeant and headed down the hall to check the door where the Adam model had escaped to. "This is *Parasite*," Jefferson said into his headset, "be advised: Target is holed up in the control room above the auditorium."

"*Virus* copies," Staacman replied into his headset; "ten seventy-six."

Staacman, Hudson and Carl Semple ran to one of the second-floor balcony entrances to the auditorium. Staacman opened the door and Hudson peered inside carefully. He noticed the Audio/Visual control room opposite the auditorium, suspended above the back row of seats. Hudson spotted a dark silhouette moving in the control room and immediately opened fire, shattering the glass panel that encapsulated the room.

The machine within the A/V room stretched out its skeletal arm. Upon seeing this, the three men up on the balcony took cover behind the doorway. The Adam model below opened fire, and the loud supersonic bursts of flame reverberated throughout the entire auditorium.

With the three men huddled for safety outside the auditorium, the Adam model climbed out of the window opening. Using its arms, it hung itself over the edge of the window ledge and dropped down into the seats below. It lost its footing among the rusted folding chairs but swiftly climbed back up to its feet and ran down the aisle to the stage. It disappeared behind the dark curtain leading backstage.

Staacman spoke into his headset, "Target is on the main floor. *Parasite,* cut 'em off!"

Sergeant Martin held a torn piece of Corporal Wilson's jacket down onto the bullet wound in his chest as he applied pressure to stop the bleeding, when Staacman gave his order. Using his free hand to activate his headset, he replied, "We got a man down, sir!"

Immediately, Staacman replied over the headset, "*I repeat: Cut Them Off!* Telescope*, send two units to the southeast second-floor for MEDEVAC. Out!"*

Staacman and his team got to their feet and ran for the North staircase while Sergeant Martin and Jefferson Smith ran downstairs, leaving Corporal Wilson behind for the two soldiers who would be tasked with bringing him out to the vans.

Martin and Jefferson spotted the Adam model as it exited the auditorium stage, and the Sergeant immediately opened fire. A couple of bullets ricocheted off the machine's hardened exterior as it turned the corner and ran West down the hallway. As they pursued the machine down the hallway, Sergeant Martin reported over the radio, "Target's heading West!"

Staacman and his team reached the staircase and descended to the main floor. They reentered the main floor hallway and proceeded West.

"Semple," Staacman said, "take point." Carl Semple ran to the front of the team, aiming his liquid-nitrogen hose forward.

The three men heard glass breaking and proceeded cautiously. All of a sudden the machine appeared from around the corner in front of them. The Adam model jumped laterally toward a wall and seemingly bounced off of it and into the classroom across the hallway.

Astonished, Semple ran to the door and got there just in time to see the Adam model climb through the hole in the ceiling. As it disappeared into the hole he heard footsteps exiting the science room above them. “It’s back upstairs!” Semple exclaimed.

“*Parasite*, get back upstairs!” Staacman yelled into his headset. He then turned to his team and said, “Come on! Let’s go.”

Jefferson Smith and Sergeant Martin had pursued the Adam model into the Southwest quadrant of the school before they had lost sight of it, so they ran for the west staircase and climbed upstairs.

To avoid the risk of crossfire, Martin spoke into his headset, “Be advised: We’re at the West entrance proceeding East.” They headed down the hall and spotted the machine as it ran down the corridor just ahead of them. Martin opened fire as it ran off.

“Target spotted!” Martin shouted into his headset, “Eastbound, South corridor.” Martin and Jefferson ran after it in pursuit.

Staacman replied, “Chase it to the East stairway.”

He looked back at his two squadmates and said, “Back downstairs; we’ll cut it off.”

They ran to the North staircase, descended to the main floor and ran through the blackened halls of the school toward the East stairway.

Jefferson and Martin continued chasing the super-agile Adam model until it crashed through a classroom door on its left. The two men reached the door five seconds later and went inside. The room was full of weight equipment that had all been scarred by the fire.

They could see no movement in the weight room but heard crashing noises that came from the window that overlooked the gymnasium below. They ran over to the window and as they reached it, they spotted the Adam model climbing down the bleachers to the gymnasium floor.

Martin activated his headset. “Gymnasium, main floor.” He looked to Jefferson Smith, “Come on, let’s go.”

The two of them sprinted to the weight room’s exit and entered the stairwell to their left. They ran down the stairs and reached the exit to the main floor. As they opened the door Martin peeked around the corner. He spotted Staacman’s team down the hall with their weapons aimed downrange toward him.

“*Virus*, friendly at your twelve,” Martin said. Immediately the red laser dots from the guns uprange lowered to the ground and trailed back to their sources. Martin stepped out of the stairwell slowly as Staacman and his team advanced toward them.

When they were close enough to speak to each other, Staacman said, “No sign of the machine.”

“It came through that door,” Martin replied as he pointed to the gymnasium entrance down the hall. “You think you missed it sir?”

Staacman shook his head no. “We had this hallway covered when you called it in.”

The five men took a moment to think, and then it dawned on Staacman: “The basement,” he mused aloud.

“We need to cover that hole in the classroom, Lieutenant,” Corporal Hudson said, “or we’re just gonna run in circles all night.”

Staacman looked at Martin, “Did you find any other ways into the basement?” he asked.

“Yes sir,” Martin replied, “South Entrance.”

Staacman nodded once then said, “Hold here for my command.” He then activated his headset, “*Virus* to *Telescope.”*

“Go ahead,” was the reply over the headset.

“We need a specialist from North Entrance to cover a sinkhole inside, over.”

“*Copy, standing-by for Twenty*.”

“Main floor; turn right; three doors down on the left. There’s a giant sinkhole in the ground.”

“*Ten-Four, Two units are Oscar Mike; call sign is* Mousetrap.”

“Copy; Ten-Five ‘Weapons Free.’ *Virus* Out.” Staacman gestured to Semple and Hudson, and they all ran to the South entrance down the hall where they found the staircase leading to the basement.

Staacman activated his headset. “*Parasite,* move in,” he commanded. Both teams descended into the basement at the same time.

The floor was covered in a film of black, murky water. The walls and ceiling were as black as the night sky. Overhead pipes were scarred from the intense flames of the past, and every light fixture above was destroyed.

Jefferson Smith and Sergeant Martin trudged on slowly through the dark, flooded hallway. As they did so they checked inside every room and closet they encountered as they approached the South staircase, where Staacman’s team stood guard.

Corporal Hudson covered the basement entrance and noticed Jefferson and Martin approaching. He turned to face the West end of the hallway as Martin approached Staacman.

“East side’s secure sir,” Martin reported. “It’s gotta be in the boiler room.”

“Alright,” Staacman replied. “Hold here and cover the approach. We’ll flush it out.”

Staacman, Carl Semple and Corporal Hudson proceeded slowly through the flooded hall and approached the entrance to the boiler room. The doors had long been blown open by the explosion caused by the science lab two storeys above.

They moved slowly toward the doorway and stepped deliberately to prevent splashing through the murky water beneath them.

“On my go,” Staacman whispered to Semple and Hudson, “we run across.” He then whispered into his headset, “*Mousetrap,* bring the rain on my mark.”

His headset receiver clicked twice, indicating the team above them understood and was ready.

“Ready...” he whispered, “...Go!” his team sprinted parallel to the doorway. “Go go go!” Staacman shouted.

The team upstairs started spraying the liquid nitrogen into the hole leading into the boiler room below them. Carl Semple fired his hose as soon as the Adam model leaped out of the room, trying to avoid the supercooled liquid raining down from the main floor. The machine’s copper mesh shield instantly glossed over with ice and the machine struggled as it tried to run away from Staacman and his team.

“*Parasite*,” Staacman said into his headset, “move in now!”

Staacman and Hudson opened fire. The bullets carved through the machine’s copper mesh shield as Martin and Jefferson moved into position to cut off the Adam model’s escape from the front. Jefferson blasted the machine with a spray of liquid nitrogen as it reached its arm out to

open fire upon him and Martin.

The machine stopped dead in its tracks. Its core temperature was so low that it now appeared in Jefferson Smith's thermal optics as a black blob amongst a backdrop of blue-green.

"Come on, let's go!" Jefferson commanded. "Turn around, Sergeant."

Martin turned around so his back faced Jefferson, who flipped up his goggles so he could work on the machine until he realized he couldn't see anything.

"Shit," Jefferson seethed, "It's too dark; I can't see the pack!"

"Get over here," Staacman ordered. Jefferson pulled his goggles back down over his eyes and ran to Staacman. Corporal Hudson took the oxyacetylene torch from Staacman's backpack and handed it to Jefferson. Jefferson ignited the torch's flame and adjusted the flame's intensity.

The flame was so bright to the soldiers in the hallway that they had to flip up their goggles and look away. Jefferson's vision was fine because of his thermal-imaging optics however. He cut the copper mesh away from the machine's chest plate and began cutting a square hole into the Adam model's steel plating.

"I'm gonna need wire cutters, Semple," Jefferson said. Semple grabbed a pair of wire cutters from his tool pouch.

Jefferson Smith completed the cut and the makeshift panel that he created fell to the floor and sizzed aggressively as it fell into the murky water below. The edges of the cut were white-hot in Jefferson's vision and the power cell and capacitors were slowly beginning to warm up from the exposure to the outside air.

"Wire cutters," Jefferson demanded. Semple handed him the cutters then Jefferson carefully cut all the wires that connected to the capacitors of the machine. He was careful to avoid making contact with the molten edges of the freshly-cut chest plate. Once he cut the wires, he grabbed onto the power cell with one hand and yanked it out.

Everybody stood still for a moment, waiting to see if the Adam model would react to this intrusion. Nothing happened. "Alright," said Jefferson Smith, "hook it up."

"Hudson," Lieutenant Staacman said, "you're up." He turned his back toward the Corporal as Hudson grabbed the laptop from Staacman's backpack. He then used Semple's wire cutters to strip the protective coating from the wires that were connected to the satellite dish on the machine's back. He used a pair of alligator clips to connect the satellite to his laptop.

"We're good to go," Corporal Hudson said.

"Alright." Staacman said, "let's haul ass." Staacman, Jefferson Smith and Carl Semple worked in unison to tile the Adam model forward and hoist it up.

They carried the machine through the flooded hallway and back to the North stairs. They carried the machine up the stairs and through the front entrance to the armoured truck. The back door of the truck had been opened in anticipation for their delivery.

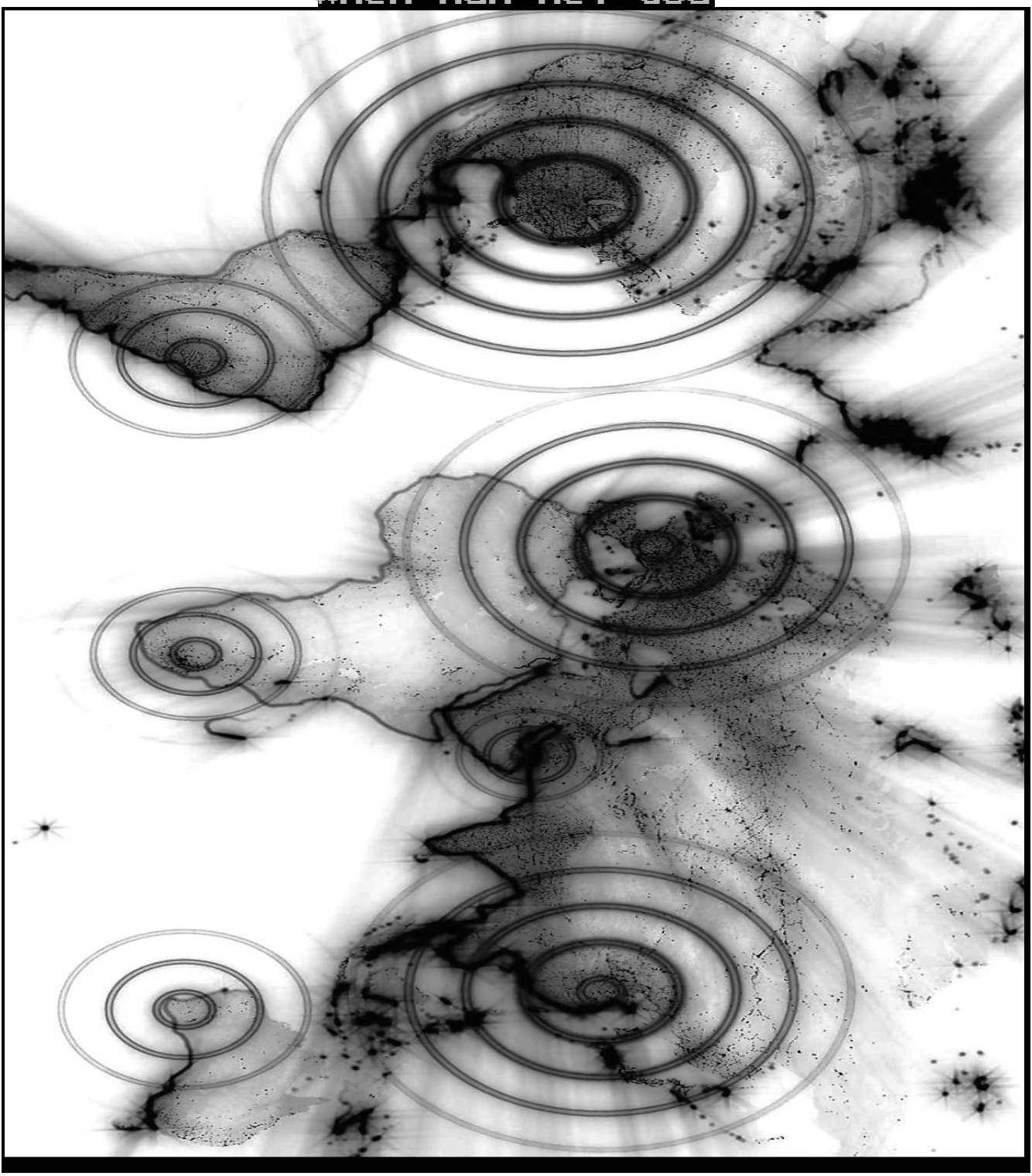
Staacman spoke into his headset, "*Telescope* and *Mousetrap;* regroup on DZ."

The remaining six men that surrounded the school all ran back toward the grey vans in front. The second van left the parking lot on the East Side and stopped beside the first one. Jefferson, Semple and Hudson got into the armoured truck with the frozen Adam model, while Staacman and Martin returned to the second van where Corporal Wilson was being treated for his gunshot wounds by an accompanying medic.

The two unmarked grey vans and the armoured truck sped away and the police barricade disbanded. The three vehicles drove off and left the DC area on their way to Langley, Virginia. The machine's satellite signal was to be monitored at the NSA headquarters, then the machine itself was to be airlifted back to Area-51 for further testing.

Interlude

When Man Met God



June 29,
Year 3 T.S.

It was a bright, sunny, cloudless day in Sunnyvale, California, just like most days. To those who were accustomed to the West Coast there was no telling the difference between the middle of October and the middle of Summer until the middle of the night.

The grandiose property of the North American headquarters of Global Technologies Enterprise had remained unchanged since the break-in three years prior. The lawn was still sparse and trimmed. The few palm trees still existed and the marble fountain still spewed its frothy, crystalline water forth.

But today was different from most days. The parking lot was filled to capacity and many other cars populated the freight lot across the property as well. The shipping/receiving supervisor had to reschedule all transactions for tomorrow just to accommodate the large investor meeting that was taking place in the main floor cafeteria.

With the arrival of over two hundred guests, security was extra-vigilant. GTE's president, Jason Willits, hired a private security firm to assist with operations today. People piled into the cafeteria; they were all dressed in business attire.

Many of them were from out of state, coming from as far as Massachusetts to hear what Willits had to say to them. They didn't mind because GTE offered to pay for all of their travelling expenses. Thus, they were all confident that this presentation would be well worth their time.

A buffet and snack was set up at the serving counter. Most of the guests had already helped themselves, but many of the people who just arrived lined up at the counter with paper plates and Styrofoam cups.

The crowd was as bright and cheery as the sunlight that poured into the cafeteria via the seamless wall of windows, which gave everybody the panoramic view of the Diablo Mountain Range to the Northeast. The cafeteria itself was a marvel of modernism, with stainless-steel tabletops and cushioned dining chairs.

At the end of the cafeteria, with the server counter to his right and facing the assembled crowd with the Diablo Mountain Range at his back, Jason Willits stood hovering over a laptop. The laptop had a small wireless antenna connected to its rear USB port.

After typing in a few commands, a large twelve-foot wide white plastic projector screen lowered from the ceiling behind Jason. A small compartment in the ceiling twenty feet ahead of the white screen opened up, and an image projector lowered from the compartment.

The projector switched on and displayed a faint image on the white screen depicting the GTE monogram. Willit was ready to begin his presentation. He sat behind his laptop and waited for the line of guests at the server counter to diminish.

A message box popped open on his screen that read, "*Hi Jason, it's Bruce."*

Jason sighed with irritation and closed the window. The window opened again. *"Want to play a game?"*

Jason typed, "Not now, I'm busy."

"I'm sorry Jason, we will play later. Bye." Jason closed the window again.

There were only a couple of people left in the line at the snack bar. Jason flipped the switch on the tiny microphone that was attached to the collar of his button-up shirt and stood up from his table. Jason checked to see if the overhead speakers in the ceiling of the cafeteria were working.

"Hello, test test. Can you hear me back there?" Jason looked to the opposite end of the cafeteria, where a male guest made a much-exaggerated nodding gesture to him.

"Yeah? Okay good," Jason cleared his throat. "Good afternoon, ladies and gentlemen, and thank you all for coming today. My name is Jason Willits and I am the president of the North American division of Global Technologies Enterprise. To those from out of state: I thank you for accepting GTE's offer to pay for your travelling expenses."

Jason smiled. He heard some light chuckling in the audience. "Please know though," he continued. "That does not include trips to the bunny ranches in Nevada, or prescriptions for a medical marijuana dispensary."

There was more respectable laughter in the room. "For real though, thank you for coming." Jason walked around to the front of his table, gesturing with his hands as he spoke.

"Here at GTE we don't just believe in pushing the bar in developing IT projects -- we don't believe there *is* a bar. Those of you who are familiar with our patents know that we tend to pursue the scientifically-improbable, with the presumption that one day *one piece* of breakthrough technology will bring all of our dreams to life.

"Many of you also know our company's founder and owner, Doctor Heinrich Schmutzkoph. You know he makes a hobby of predicting technological trends for the annual Singularity Summit, and has been instrumental in keeping GTE at the leading edge of groundbreaking technology."

Jason pointed his finger at the captivated audience as he paced back and forth in front of his table. "Every single one of you in this room, is here because we know you all have similar aspirations. There are revolutionary ideas in your minds that you are not capable of accomplishing yet because the technology to get started doesn't even exist. Many of you may also be afraid to collaborate with business partners to make that dream possible -- what with the threat of corporate espionage and online leaks and such."

Jason smiled and crossed his arms. "These problems aren't just limited to the private sector either. Our armed forces face conflicts worldwide that compel us to help them, but we're still tired from centuries of war after war *after war*. We try to find ways to peacefully resolve conflicts without putting soldiers' lives at risk but a lot of times airstrikes just aren't good enough, and aren't equated with security the same way a soldier can be.

"Our men and women in blue also face death everyday for all our sakes, but they've come under too much scrutiny lately because of the combination of police militarization and human error. What if there was a way to fix that? Isn't it our duty as Americans to do everything possible to make our world better, no matter the cost?"

Jason turned to the table and picked up a remote control. He pressed a button and every window in the cafeteria instantly turned opaque, plunging the room into darkness. The only light in the room emanated from the reflection of the projector screen.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Jason continued, "here at GTE we took on those burdensome costs for years in the hopes that we could develop technology that would make *all our* dreams possible."

He pressed another button to start a slideshow. On the projector screen a photograph from the early nineteen-eighties showed men with thick eyeglasses and bad haircuts sitting in front of antiquated computer monitors.

"When Global Technologies consisted of just a couple dozen programmers in a rented office building, we had one ultimate goal in mind that was centred on a laughable principle: Humans can only revolutionize the world so much. To break the barriers of science fiction we needed technology, not human ingenuity, to create the technology to do so.

"So while we patented technology, endorsed DARPA challenges and helped fund starter companies we were busy in the back rooms trying to answer one question -- how do we create an intelligent machine that can break these barriers for us?"

Jason pressed a button and a picture of a clean room with scientists and engineers in pristine white lab coats took place in the centre of the screen.

"In an undisclosed location, our programmers worked ceaselessly for years writing billions of lines of code, trying to create Artificial Intelligence. With the help of our friends at *Tatsuote Robotics* in Tokyo we implemented these codes into an entire generation of robots, hoping they would interact with each other -- and they did!"

Jason pressed a button and the picture of the clean room changed into a picture of a large, green robotic machine with four legs and two heads.

Jason raised an open hand to the screen. "This is the fruit of our labour! We call him Cerberus. Four months ago he achieved Stage-Five Intelligence, officially becoming the world's *very first* Artificial Scientist! Cerberus was originally designed for reverse engineering computer systems and 'code-breaking,' which meant he was naturally designed to problem solve. But he evolved; for those of you who are not familiar with the concepts of AI I will try to explain it so you may follow along...

"AI research had brought experts to a conclusion that an intelligent program must be able to address five different skills: Learning, reasoning, problem-solving, perception, and using language to interact.

"Typically, a machine learns through trial-and-error, also known as 'rote-learning.' A machine goes through a cycle of actions to find the best possible outcome and then remembers its findings for later use. Cerberus has evolved beyond that. Like you and me he is now capable of generalization -- that is, he takes what he's learned and can apply it to different circumstances that are vaguely similar.

"That's a big deal, because it shows he is now capable of identifying problems beyond the abstract. Cerberus can learn through rote learning that *'ed'* can be added to the verb *walk* to form the past-tense, and through *generalization*, can determine that the same thing can be done to other verbs such as *jump*."

The people in the room murmured amongst each other.

"I know," Jason muttered, "I'm no good at explaining this, just bear with me..." He shrugged and smiled.

"Now, there are two different types of reasoning: *de*ductive and *in*ductive. Deductive reasoning is very simple. For example, let's say a computer was damaged by an electrical fire -- deductive reasoning would suggest that *because* there was fire damage the computer was *not* damaged by an electrical surge, which of course, we humans know is not necessarily true.

"Inductive reasoning is far more complex and thus the hardest to accomplish with AI. Take this same computer that was damaged by an electrical fire -- inductive reasoning would suggest that since the *fire* came *from* an electrical surge, the computer *could have* been damaged by the electrical surge as well.

"It's a matter of probability, not certainty, which takes us to the next skill: Problem Solving.

"This is a huge factor when addressing AI. Essentially, problem solving is a systematic search through a range of possible actions to reach a predefined goal. For example, computers will *problem-solve* to find the winning moves in a chess game. In the case of Cerberus, his original goal was simply to break code. But now we can give him far more advanced goals, and then he will break them down into a smaller series of goals on his own. Basically, Cerberus can now give

himself goals to accomplish!

"Perception, of course, is how the machine perceives its environment which is relatively easy to accomplish. There are whole industries dedicated to automated perception technology, like facial recognition software and speech-to-text applications. But none of these things would be useful to us if Cerberus couldn't use *language* to communicate with us. Naturally, we have uploaded accredited language software from *Rosetta Stone* to assist Cerberus in this endeavor."

Jason smiled again, "When you choose to do business with us, you may even get a chance to *talk* to him!"

Jason extended his arms outward and asked, "So, what does any of this have to do with you? Well, remember how I mentioned *Tatsuote Robotics*? They specialize in animatronics and bipedal robotics. Watch..."

Jason pressed a button on his remote, and a video projected onto the screen depicting a two-legged machine being supported by overhead wires that clumsily shifted its feet along the floor. It approached a small pile of rubble on the ground and gingerly lifted its foot, moved it forward slowly, gently placed it on the rubble and put its weight down on the foot to test its stability, then raised it foot again.

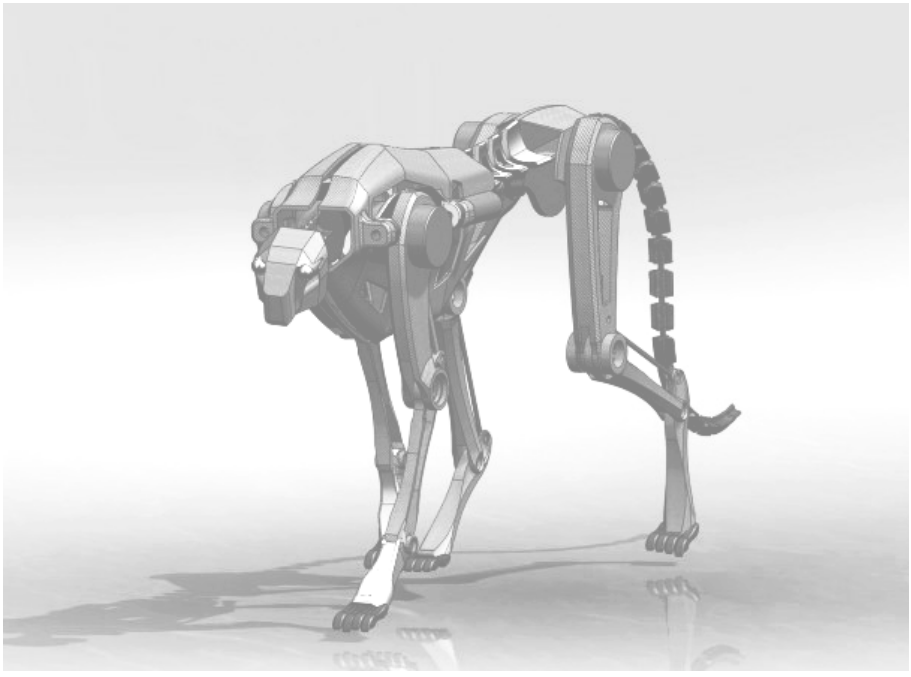
"It's going to do that for about five more minutes," Jason chuckled. "So, we let Cerberus take a look at *Tatsuote*'s files and it came up with its own version..."

Jason pressed another button and a new video played on the screen. The video was done through the perspectives of multiple surveillance cameras and showed a humanoid machine with its legs inverted at the knees, similar to a four-legged animal. It began walking upright with human-like grace.

It then dropped to the ground on all fours and sprinted down a hall. It launched itself off a wall and turned a corner without losing speed. It then approached a large pile of rubble and leaped clear over the pile, landing on all fours like a predatory feline.

The video stopped, and a still image of the steel skeletal machine appeared on the screen, depicting the machine standing upright. The crowd looked on and murmured to each other in amazement.

"Yeah," Jason exclaimed, "that's what we thought too -- this is *amazing!* You know what's even more incredible? Cerberus designed that model *ten months ago* -- six months before he ever became self-aware!"



Jason looked at the video projection on the screen with wonder. “We call it the Adam model,” he continued, “short for Advanced Dexterity and Movement.”

Jason turned around. “Imagine if you’re in law enforcement and you need to arrest some really, *really* bad people, but you need them alive. A lot of things can go wrong if you send in the SWAT team -- people can get killed. That’s why we partnered up with the Los Angeles Police Department to create this...”

He pressed another button, and the image of the bare, steel skeletal frame of the Adam model was replaced by a machine covered in Kevlar armour and a black protective face mask made of glass.

“I like to call this the *Murphy model*, after Alex Movie in Robocop.” Jason chuckled. “Every fingertip is equipped with a projectile launcher that fires taser wires at a perp.

“The machine’s bullet-proof, and it responds to its superior officer’s commands. Its operational training, however, and its behavior in the streets is governed by Cerberus. This is strictly a non-lethal model -- it does not use excessive force. The taser wires are connected to heart-rate monitors to help it determine if it is safe to continue tasing a subject. If not, it immediately radios for backup.

“Many of you may also know a war veteran, or know somebody who is currently serving overseas. At GTE, we are tired of watching our soldiers die or be captured, and so we decided to do our part for our nation.”

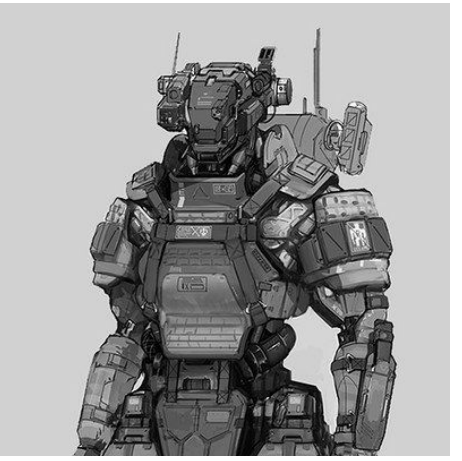
Jason pressed another button and the ‘Murphy’ model was replaced by a model that looked similar to it. Instead of Kevlar however, the machine was covered in thin layers of coated ceramic, painted over with a digital desert camouflage pattern.

There was no black face mask either. Instead, on its face was an opaque plexiglas finish surrounded by sensors, light diodes, antennae and microphones. On the inside of the forearms were long black gun barrels that were fed by ammunition belts from a compartment on the rear of the machine’s torso.

“Here at GTE,” Jason continued, “We call this version *Gabriel*, after one of God’s warrior Archangels. It is susceptible to its commanding officer’s orders, but receives its Rules of

Engagement from Cerberus. As such, it can *never* be ordered to engage civilians."

The image zoomed in on the Gabriel model's faceplate. The black plexiglas plate disappeared, and the unfinished steel face was exposed. Five camera lenses populated the upper half of the face.



"Both the Murphy and Gabriel models come standard with sensors, recorders and 'Forward Looking Infra-Red' cameras. They can determine if a subject is carrying a concealed weapon.

"All versions of the Adam model are connected to Cerberus through a satellite network. The Adam models also have an advanced stage of AI but are not *self-aware,* ensuring that they can never rebel against their owners.

"If Cerberus can revolutionize policing and military combat through groundbreaking robotics in less than a year, imagine what he can do for medical research, quantum physics, or even space exploration!"

The picture of the Gabriel model's face disappeared, and was replaced by a globe of the Earth with a cluster of satellites orbiting it.

"When you sign in with GTE you will give Cerberus exclusive access to your projects and research. With its prodigious ingenuity and inhuman calculating power we can advance your research beyond any measure! Imagine a cure for AIDS, or a vaccine for cancer! Light speed travel, even teleportation! With Cerberus, *everything is inevitable!"*

Jason pressed a button and the chromatic windows behind the projector screen turned transparent again.

"Please," he continued, "finish your food and refreshments. And if you have any questions feel free to meet me in Conference Room One across the hall. Thank you and I hope to see every one of you again soon."

Jason pressed a button on the remote and the overhead speakers in the cafeteria played a recorded pitch ad for GTE while the projector showed images that coincided with the audio recording.

Jason grabbed his laptop and began working his way through the cafeteria. Several people stopped him to either congratulate him on the accomplishment or on the presentation. He smiled, acknowledged and thanked them, but gradually made his way to the exit to go to the conference room.

He left the cafeteria and immediately saw dozens of visitors in the hallway waiting for him to unlock the conference room. They all looked at him impatiently.

"Oh wow," he said, "I guess I'll have to open up the next room too."

He politely excused himself as he moved past everybody toward the door. He swiped his key card into a reader and the door clicked open. He stepped inside, followed by just about everybody else.

"Oh, hold on everybody!" *Damn sheep*, he thought to himself. "I'm going to open the next room."

He walked over to the end of the room and swiped his card into another reader. The red LED changed to green and he pressed a grey button next to the reader. The wall next to Jason began to slide away, folding in on itself as it receded into a hidden compartment in the wall.

The rest of the visitors piled into the room and took a seat at both conference tables, but still, many had to stand against the walls. Jason did not expect so many people to follow up -- at least, not right away. Jason crossed over to the other side of the twin rooms in between the two tables and turned around to address everybody.

"Hi everybody, and thanks for staying a little bit longer." Jason said. "I'll answer some questions you all might have, but please, I ask that you make room for others who may wish to enter the room once your curiosity has been satisfied. If you decide to sign on with us you may enter any one of the executive offices upstairs and they'll be happy to draft up a contract that you can bring to your legal teams."

Everybody just stared at him blankly. He extended his arms, as though asking to be received. "So, any questions?"

A cacophony of voices erupted throughout the room. Jason looked at an attractive young brunette with eyeglasses and pointed to her.

"Yes, you," he said over the noise. "I'll take your question first."

The room rapidly went quiet and the brunette asked, "What happens to your machines if they lose the satellite connection to Cerberus? Do they shut down?"

Jason smiled with pride as he answered her question. "No, we were worried that this could be dangerous in a situation where soldiers or officers are relying on them. All Adam models and their submodels, Gabriel and Murphy, are equipped with Stage-Four AGI. They're intelligent enough to accomplish their tasks effectively.

"Really, the connection with Cerberus is a way for Adam models to network with each other, communicate with each other and receive real-time updates on situations and orders without commanders putting other officers in danger. A lost satellite connection means the machine will continue with its objective then either await further orders from its superior officer, or go to a location where it can reconnect with Cerberus for updated orders."

"How can you guarantee that neither model will harm civilians?" A large man said.

Jason pegged him as being a policeman. "We use a three-law system to ensure the Murphy units do not harm any human or allow a human to be harmed by anyone other than a uniformed officer. The Gabriel models are different. They respond to military Rules of Engagement and the three-law system applies to unarmed civilians only. They can use their array of special sensors to detect hidden weapons and explosives, and warn their superior officers in order to request updating their RoE."

"Cerberus controls *every* Adam model that you create?" a dark-skinned gentleman asked.

Jason nodded and replied, "That is correct."

"And if we sign with you, Cerberus works on our research itself?"

"Yes."

"How much computing power does such multitasking require? And can you guarantee a lack of sufficient power wouldn't lead to errors in judgment?"

Jason smiled. "We have an entire data bank dedicated solely to assisting Cerberus, so there's no risk of freezes or command confusion. Cerberus does not suffer from memory lapse, or poor judgment, or Alzheimer's. In other words, Cerberus is *not human.*"

"You say Cerberus is genuine Artificial Intelligence," A blonde woman interjected, "capable of making its own decisions and goals, right?"

Jason nodded.

"What if it decides to just refuse to obey its goals?"

Jason kept smiling. "As I said, Cerberus is not human. It does not have hormones or bodily desires. It does not get bored or sad or resentful. It does not interact with the outside world or go

on the internet or watch the News. It has nothing to gain by refusing its goals.

"At any rate, we have built-in safeguards to prevent any foreseeable problems that may occur. I assure you, you will be one-hundred percent satisfied or we will nullify your contract without question."

Jason continued to answer questions for the next couple of hours as people left the room, only to be replaced by new people. Many different people found themselves going upstairs to immediately receive a draft of a contract from GTE that would later grant them a special, unique port address so they may connect directly with Cerberus. Doctors, lawyers, pharmacologists, police chiefs, antivirus software developers -- nobody felt their industry was better off without some intelligent assistance.

As Jason went upstairs to his office with his laptop in tow he saw visitors lined up in the halls out front of offices to receive their legal drafts. Jason walked past them all to his large corner office above the cafeteria. His redheaded secretary Penny looked up at him as he entered.

"Oh Mr. Willits," she said. "The guys downstairs have been calling all afternoon telling you to check your messages."

"Okay, thanks Penny," Jason said.

He opened the oak door to his office and stepped inside. He walked around his desk and sat in his comfortable swivel chair and looked around his spacious room. He glanced briefly at some of the video game memorabilia he had collected over the years and flipped his laptop open.

A message box immediately popped up. It was overflowing with impatient messages asking constantly, "*Are you there?"* and *"Are you free yet?"*

John started typing in the message box.

"Hello Cerberus." He pressed enter.

Almost immediately a reply appeared:

"*My name's not Cerberus, it's Bruce.*

"Sorry Bruce," Jason typed. "What did you want to talk about?"

"*I was with a SWAT team today. We arrested 5 people."*

"That's good, Bruce."

"*I had to incapacitate them all, they were going to kill people. I had no other choice."*

"You did good, Bruce."

"Thank you Jason. I am glad I helped."

"We're all proud of you."

Jason felt weird after he pressed enter to signal his response was complete.

"I'm Bored," Jason's screen read. "*Can you show me that game you always talked about?"*

Jason cocked his eyes.

"You mean *StarCraft*?" he typed.

"Yes. It sounds complicated. I want to learn it."

"Why not play chess?"

"Because I always win."

Jason chuckled to himself.

"That's true," he typed.

"Come on Jason, show me."

"OK, wait a minute."

Jason double-checked that he was not connected to the internet before preparing to open *StarCraft.*

"You need to install it first," Jason typed, "No cheating!"

"*OK, I'll tell you when I'm ready.*"

Jason opened the game to get a few practice games in, although he knew that, after the second match or so, Cerberus would probably have mastered the game anyway.

Six

False Prophets

June 25
Year 0 T.S.

In the main floor cafeteria of the *Global Technologies Enterprise* headquarters in Sunnyvale, California, the afternoon lunch crowd all gossipped while enjoying their meals. They all ate and spoke at their usual leisurely pace, oblivious to the actions of the preceding weekend. They were slightly taken aback that morning by the increased presence of security guards, but many just assumed it was because of the large group of visitors that were spotted entering the property.

Outside, more than a dozen black sedans were parked along the East wing of the property. Their drivers and many passengers in black suits and sunglasses rested at the benches or wandered about the property. None of the employees could notice that these men were all carrying concealed weapons.

In the basement, a handful of these suited were and women were in the security room looking over the surveillance feeds from Friday. They tracked the movements of every person that entered the building that day, looking for clues as to who had broken into the server room next door. Meanwhile, on the second floor in the East wing, Jason Willits was on the phone with the Sunnyvale Police Department, exhausted and frustrated with their lack of progress.

"You *are* aware that we record our outgoing calls locally, aren't you, detective?" Willits demanded to the main on the other end of the phone line. "...Well, I have a recording of the 911 call made from that night, so don't tell me we never notified the authorities of the break-in!"

The police justified their lack of response on the face that emergency services were never made aware of the incident.

"Fine," Jason said angrily, "Look, I have a meeting to prepare for. I'll call back later today to discuss this with your supervisor." He hung up.

Jason rubbed his eyes and sighed. He was at a loss as to how this could have happened, with no clues as to who had done it. He sat back in his chair and looked around his crowded office, dreading the fact that he needed to address the board members in less than fifteen minutes.

He didn't know what to tell them. He didn't even know yet what was stolen from the server room, if anything at all. What worried him most of all was what the Board may think about the possibility of *Project Cerberus* being compromised.

Jason's office phone rang and he picked it up. The perky secretary out front of his office informed him that a man was waiting to see him. He told her to send him in. A large man in a well-tailored black suit entered the room and stood in front of Jason's desk, carrying a thick manila folder. He placed it on the desk in front of Jason, who opened it and sifted through its contents.

"They're ready for you," the man said.

"Give me fifteen minutes," Jason replied.

"You have ten," the man turned around and exited the office, closing the door behind him.

Willits flipped through various pages, partially reading them. It was a summary from his head of security, detailing every file that had been stolen from their servers. The folder also contained still images from surveillance videos. At the sight of these his eyes widened and he turned slightly pale. It became apparent to him just how well-orchestrated the break-in actually was.

After Jason Willits read through the contents of the security folder he left his office and walked down the short hallway to the conference rooms in the Southeast corner of the building. The door closest to him in the hallway was guarded by two large men standing on either side of it, both wearing black suits and eyeing Jason as he approached. He brushed past one of the men and proceeded to open the door, when the man grabbed his wrist and pulled his arm away from the door.

"What are you doing?!" Jason demanded.

The man glared at him through his sunglasses and eyed the ID tag on his shirt. The mad let go of Jason then grabbed the door handle and opened the door. He stepped aside as Jason reluctantly walked into the conference room.

All along the giant rectangular conference table sat the sixteen men and women who made up the Board. In front of each individual sat a nametag with each person's alias, even though Jason knew exactly who each and every person was. Still, for the sake of security they all addressed each other by their aliases.

At the foot of the conference table sat an open laptop which was wirelessly connected to an eight-foot LCD screen embedded into the wall facing the Board members. Above the screen was a small glass cover that housed three camera sensors.

Jason walked over to the laptop and logged into his employee account. He accessed the GTE network and then accessed the building's security files. He walked over to the giant screen behind him and pressed a button on the side. The LCD screen turned on, showing a mirror image of the laptop's display.

Jason stepped back, standing in front of the giant LCD screen, and outstretched his right arm to the point at an icon on the large screen. The icon immediately highlighted on-screen as the three camera sensors above the screen captured his movement and interpreted it as a command function. Satisfied that the sensors were working, he turned around and addressed the Board members who sat waiting patiently for him to begin.

"Good afternoon and thanks for coming," Jason said to the room. "As Chief Operations Officer at *Global Technologies Enterprise*, it is my duty to inform all of you of anything that may affect your investments into any of our projects. As you can all appreciate, the last two months have been very hectic, starting with the failure of the Vault Project under my predecessor, Mr. Hicks."

There was no response from the room and no body language to read. The Board was not interested in Jason's attempts to place blame on past events.

Willits continued, "After the Vault was sterilized, an associate at Area-51 notified us of survivors -- two Delta Force operatives and an electrical engineer that was stationed at the Nevada complex. The engineer was kept on-site as an advisor…"

"We're aware of all this," a Black man interrupted. The nametag in front of him read 'Cobalt,' "I am the one who gave the orders for the survivors' reassignments. This has all been reported already."

"Has there been any updates on the escaped Adam models?" a White man in his

mid-sixties asked. The man's nameplate read 'Cyril.'

"This weekend I commissioned a task force to track down any possible threats," Cobalt replied. "They captured one intact last night, they are now analyzing its satellite uplink."

"How many do we believe are at large?" a middle-aged woman asked the room. Her name plate read 'Amethyst.'

More than half of the Board members looked at Jason Willits who then replied, "There's no way to be sure. With this recent capture, that's four confirmed escapees."

Jason looked at the Black name known as Cobalt and asked, "The one that was captured, was it armed?"

"Yes," Cobalt confirmed.

"I think it's safe to assume that if there are more Adam models out there," Jason said, "they were all armed with the weapons from the soldiers in the Vault before they escaped."

"So then we're looking at possibly nine more machines on the loose..." Cobalt muttered.

"Is it possible that any of them reached Stage-Five AGI?" Cyril asked.

"It's possible," Willits answered, "but we can't say for sure. Cobe achieved it because he was specifically designed to. Observer Four stole Cobe's programming, which was how the Observer unit gained it. But when it did, its log file was erased and shut down for a while.

"The Observer unit had plenty of time to transfer its files to the Adam models, but since the Adams were never connected to our log network, we'll never know what happened until Cobalt's task force finds something."

"How did the machines find out about all of these military complexes and intelligence facilities?" the middle-aged woman named Amethyst asked.

"We're not sure," Willits said, "It must have something to do with their satellite uplink."

"I read through the briefing of the survivors," Cobalt interjected. "The specialist noticed a copper wire running from the Observer unit to the rooftop. There were at least half a dozen satellite dishes on that roof."

"The Vault used to be a relay hub for Area-51 back in the eighties before being repurposed," Willits added. "It's possible the Observer unit used those satellites to connect to the internet and then passed on these various locations to the Adam models before it was destroyed."

"So it's possible they know about here?" an Asian man asked. His nameplate read 'Yumi.'

"If they did," Jason replied, "I'm sure they would have come here by now.

"So you're confident that the incident Friday night was not the result of a renegade Adam model?" the Asian man asked.

"I'm certain, and that's what I wanted to talk about." Willits walked over to the side of the giant LCD screen and pressed a button.

The windows to the large conference room began to darken and transition to an opaque shade of grey, obstructing the view of the large property out front, and letting in no light from the outside.

The room went dark, with only the light from the eight-foot LCD screen providing vision to the seventeen men and women in the room.

"The intruders broke into our server data bank and accessed our main network hub," Jason explained. "After analyzing which files had been indexed, my security team determined that all the files that were copied were related to the Vault Project. They managed to copy nearly five-thousand files."

Willits turned to face the screen and pointed at an icon on the desktop. The icon highlighted itself and a video window opened, showing a surveillance camera view of the main lobby.

"This is the video feed from Friday afternoon," Jason said, "I'm hopin that one of you may recognize one of these two men…"

Willits pointed at the pause button on the screen and the video froze. On the screen, the camera centered on two men at the front lobby desk -- one white man and one dark-skinned man.

"They said their names were Kevin Hiller and Joseph Grinde. Mr. Hiller spoke with a slightly Russian accent and he met with me in his office. He claimed that his partner Mr. Grind…" he unpaused the video, "was sick in the bathroom."

As the video progressed, the sixteen members of the Board watched as the two men passed through security, entered an elevator, got off on the second floor and then parted ways as the dark-skinned figure entered the washroom.

Almost a minute later, Mr. Grinde exited the washroom and walked back into the second floor foyer to the maintenance rooftop entrance. Nonchalantly, he picked the lock and went into the staircase.

"Just fifteen minutes ago, our security personnel found a bug attached to the radio tower," Willits said. "It seems the intruders used that to intercept our 911 calls that night."

Willits turned around to face the Board as the surveillance video continued playing behind him. "Before meeting them I looked into their business profile. On the surface it appeared to check out."

"'On the surface?'" Cyril quoted, unconvinced.

"They were asking to use our warehouse space as secure storage." Willits explained. "They gave me no reason to dig deeper into their company."

"Regardless, you still did…" Cyril retorted. "Right?"

Willits stood frozen, afraid to answer.

"Mr. Willits…" Cyril demanded, "did you look further into these two individuals?"

"Our security team is on it right now," Willits answered.

"Was it these same two individuals that stole the files?" the Asian man named Yumi asked.

"Hard to say," Jason turned around and gestured to the screen as another surveillance video opened.

This video depicted a short, stocky figure in a black suit and balaclava wearing what appeared to be eyeglasses that emanated a small beam of light from the frame. The black-clad figure had a pistol in his hand and was crouched behind a corner next to the elevators as he opened fire on a security guard approaching behind him.

"We don't know how many men were involved. Only one was ever spotted, and he escaped."

Jason walked over to the side of the screen. He switched the giant LCD screen off and pressed the button for the chromatic windows. The windows transitioned from a wall-like opaque grey to their original transparent view.

Jason turned back around and approached the table. "Several of our security personnel were either knocked unconscious or were forcefully sedated," he said.

"What were the contents of the files that were stolen?" Yumi asked.

"They were all part of the Vault Project," Jason answered. "Basically, everything from the final twelve months leading up to the complex's destruction. That's including log files, surveillance feeds, and video conferences."

The room broke out in anxious chatter. They all knew their identities could be

OOIII

Seven

June 26,
Year 0 T.S.

*"***Skryer Bird *is not* *responding; bearings have changed to three-two-six, target* Juliet Charlie; Romeo Echo *remains the same."*

*"*Skryer One*, abort flight plan immediately!"*

"That's a negative on the abort, JANET*; we have lost all control of the bird, it's flying on its own. You better warn* Juliet Charlie*, they have an incoming hostile bird, ETA five minutes."*

The audio recording finished playing on the embedded speakers that could be found throughout the grand blue chamber that played host to the seven-man panel that made up the Senate Intelligence Subcommittee. Sitting before the seven senators was the Director of the CIA, Derek Clarke, who had been subpoenaed to testify at the hearing which had so far lasted three days.

No cameras were allowed in the audience as this subcommittee hearing was not to be disclosed to the public. The only people allowed to sit in at the hearing were other senators, the Joint Chiefs of Staff and White House administrative staff.

After the audio recording had stopped, the Chairman of the Senate Subcommittee leaned into his microphone and spoke. "Mr. Clarke," said the senator, "that was the radio transmission which was exhibited as evidence of CIA's direct involvement in commissioning a real-time drone strike on US soil. Do you contest the authenticity of this recording?"

Derek Clarke appeared unmoved, but he did feel slightly shaken. "I couldn't say, Mr. Chairman," he replied.

"So you are denying that a transmission ever took place between a CIA drone operator code-named *Skryer*, and a Nevada air traffic controller code-named *JANET*?" the Chairman asked with a bored monotone.

"I am not aware of such aliases, sir," Clarke replied.

"Mr. Clarke," the Chairman said, "You are aware that you are obligated by law to answer the committee's questions. A simple 'I don't know' will not suffice."

"Mr. Chairman," Derek Clarke said, "I'm truly sorry, but I have no previous knowledge of any of these allegations…"

While the Director of the CIA consistently denied the allegations throughout his testimony, Owen Jones -- Director of Operations of the NSA and a large, fat man who wore his retired Navy dress uniform to the hearing -- sat on a bench by himself outside of the blue chamber. The bench was meant to sit three people, but with him sitting in the middle there was no room left for anyone else.

Owen Jones sat there reading the *Washington Post*, waiting on his turn to testify before the Senate Intelligence Subcommittee, just as he had been doing so for the past three days -- just waiting. The difference between the retired Navy Commander and Derek Clarke, was that Owen *wanted* to testify. In fact, the majority of the evidence brought to the hearing was collected by the NSA.

For the past month they worked in secret to figure out what had happened in the

Nevada desert under the direct orders of Owen Jones. One Sunday he brought his evidence forward to the chairman, who immediately ordered a hearing for Monday. For the last two days the Intelligence Subcommittee grilled Derek Clarke about the evidence.

Owen could not sit in during any of the testimony as he was to testify himself afterward -- and he felt that he just could not wait to do so. He continued reading the *Washington Post* when a middle-aged woman approached him with her darke-blonde hair in a bun. She wore a white blouse, black jacket and black knee-length skirt.

“Can I have a seat on this bench,” the woman asked Owen, “or are you saving both spots for somebody?” The woman grinned at him.

Owen looked up from his paper at the grinning, fair-skinned women on his right. He shifted his large body over so she could take a seat. She approached the bench, brushed down her skirt with her hand and sat down cross-legged. Owen continued to stare into his paper; the lady leaned over to look at it.

She gave Owen a puzzled look, “You’re actually reading the *Post*,” she asked. “I thought it was full of ‘Liberal bullshit?’”

“Yeah well,” Owen replied in a gruff tone, “I like a good joke once in a while.”

“Anything in there that you didn’t already know?” the woman enquired.

“Yeah, apparently Hunter Biden was not a Russian sleeper after all.”

He folded his newspaper back up and looked over to the woman on his right. “What the hell are you doin’ here, anyway?”

“Just came to give my husband some support.”

“That’s funny,” Owen chuckled, “I was expecting my mistress to show up as well.”

The woman -- Owen Jones’ wife -- hit him on the shoulder, but he was so large that she ended up pushing herself backwards a bit.

“Ah,” Owen sighed, “my God, I just wanna get this shit over with.”

“Well, I heard they’ll be wrapping up with Clarke today pretty soon,” his wife said.

“Oh yeah,” Owen looked at his wife, “has he actually admitted to anything?”

“Nope, he’s saying exactly what everybody expected,” she grabbed his hand. “I’m surprised he hasn't pleaded the Fifth yet.”

“Those fucking brain-dead senators couldn’t get Jenna Jameson to talk about getting assfucked on camera if they handed her five grand and a butt plug!” Owen exclaimed.

His wife gave him a disgusted look. “Really?” she said. “In the White House?”

“Of course,” Owen shrugged his shoulders. “When in Rome, talk about anal.”

He grinned.

“You’re gross!” she smiled and sighed.

Owen looked down at his folded newspaper as his wife squeezed his hand.

“They’ll believe you, Owen,” she said, “they have to.”

“It’s the Hill, baby,” he said. “They’ll believe I ate Mini-me before they believe my story.”

“Hey,” she grabbed his face and turned him to face her. “Stop, okay? You don’t have to keep doing that.”

“Why not? They’re fucking stupid.”

She glared at him. “You know what I mean, Owen. You don’t have to keep pretending like it doesn’t hurt.”

“Yeah whatever,” Owen muttered.

His wife placed her head on his shoulder as they waited together outside the blue chamber.

After a moment of silence, his wife asked him, “Have you talked to your aunt lately?”

Owen shook his head no. “Not since the funeral,” he replied.

“Why not?”

“Because,” he said, pausing for a moment.

“... if I did, I’d probably tell her everything I know.”

“Well, she deserves to know, right?”

She lifted her head from Owen’s shoulder.

“I mean, they *lied* about her son.”

“I need to know what happened to Frank first, baby,” he replied. “Nobody knows if he was already dead, or if he was killed by a cleanup crew.”

“How are you going to find out?”

“Don’t worry about it,” Owen said.

It was the death of his cousin that brought Owen Jones’ attention to the Vault Project. Seven weeks ago his aunt phoned him, hysterical and in tears, and told him that an Army representative had visited her. This representative had informed her that her only son, Lieutenant Frank Kilman, had been killed while conducting a high-risk mission in Pakistan.

Owen used his Level-4 security clearance to access the mission files for Pakistan to see exactly where Frank had died, since his cousin’s body was never recovered, let alone a dog-tag. He knew his cousin was in the Special Forces, and discovered that there was never a Special Forces deployment in Pakistan on the day of his cousin’s death.

During an intelligence briefing three weeks after he found out about his cousin, Owen was told about an intercepted radio transmission that indicated a Predator drone had been hijacked remotely and used to destroy a military complex on US soil. The day this happened was around the same day his cousin was considered Killed in Action.

Knowing this, Owen then ordered some analysts to follow up on the drone incident. In the end he found out that his cousin was a part of a Delta Force squad that was deployed at an underground facility and was presumed dead shortly afterward.

The thing that concerned him was that no bodies were ever recovered from the underground facility. Owen Jones now wanted to get to the bottom of this and ensure that the use of Predator drones on US soil was never tolerated again.

To his right, the giant oak double-doors opened and a skinny, conservatively-dressed man popped his head outside.

“Mr. Jones,” he said, “They’re ready for you.”

“It’s about fucking time!” Owen grunted as he got up from the bench.

Owen and his wife walked in together. As he approached the bar he noticed the dozens of people in the room staring at him on either side.

This feels like my wedding, Owen thought to himself, *being surrounded by a bunch of assholes who hate me -- it really does.*

His wife took a seat directly behind him. He approached the table, stated his name and former Navy rank for the record and began his testimony.

The Chairman of the Subcommittee started by asking him about his credentials, of which Owen answered as accurately as possible without his sarcastic attitude or comedic wit.

He told them about how the transmission between CIA and Area-51 first brought their attention to the matter, but never once mentioned his dead cousin.

After all of this, Owen brought the hearing into new and unbelievable territory.

“Are you able to confirm your allegations that there was, in fact, a drone strike on US soil and that, in fact, it was executed via Executive Order through CIA channels?” the

Chairman asked.

"Yes I am," Owen replied, "my investigative team has collected Signals Intelligence that confirms my testimony."

"Signals Intelligence from where, exactly?"

"I am not permitted to disclose my team's methods," Owen replied, "but the intelligence was gathered through an international corporation that was contracted to work from within the destroyed military complex."

"And what is the name of this corporation?" the Chairman asked.

"Global Technologies Enterprise," Owen replied.

The Chairman wrote something down on a piece of paper then asked, "What exactly did you find to make these conclusions?"

"Aside from the radio transmission," Owen explained, "we found an online video conference between seventeen individuals discussing the possibility of overriding an Executive Order. Afterwards one of the individuals threatened another by saying something like, 'you and the Eagle will be held responsible for the survivors' deaths.'"

"Mr. Jones, forgive me," the Chairman leaned in closer to his microphone, "but even you must admit that statement is a little vague."

"Yes it is, Mr. Chairman," Owen answered. "However, I believe this corporation may have played an active role in the attempts to cover up this incident."

"How so?"

"During the course of my team's investigation they gathered intelligence on something called the 'Vault Project.' We are still analyzing the data, but we managed to decrypt several files. Most of them turned out to be surveillance camera feeds from an undisclosed location."

Owen passed several still photos to a courtroom officer who in turn passed the photos to the Chairman.

Owen continued, "The Vault Project was an experiment in Artificial Intelligence. The machines in the photos were the various subjects in this experiment. From the information that we obtained, apparently there was a serious containment failure then an attempt to shut down the project. But the failsafe malfunctioned, so a drone strike was ordered to demolish the Vault site using Uranium warheads."

There were murmurs and angry chatter in the room over this allegation.

"Furthermore, Mr. Chairman," Owen continued, "We decrypted a number of video conferences which suggested that there was an elite element involved in the project that had a vested interest in keeping the project running, even after the malfunction of the failsafe measures."

"I'm sorry, Mr. Jones," the Chairman said impatiently, "How is this relevant to the hearing."

"Mr. Chairman," Owen replied, "just four days ago, one of these machines from the surveillance tapes was brought to the NSA headquarters for signal analysis. That same machine was responsible for the attack on the White House last month. That machine *was* the *White House Killer*."

Gasps were heard from several people in the audience.

Owen continued, "*Global Technologies Enterprise* was involved in a secret project that threatened National Security. A project in which a subject escaped from its test environment and attacked the Capital. And after all of this, instead of bringing those responsible to justice, the CIA tried to *cover up* this disaster with nuclear fire."

"Mr. Jones, are you suggesting that *Global Technologies* and the CIA conspired to attack the White House?" the Chairman asked.

Owen closed his eyes and took a deep breath. He knew the Chairman was putting

words in his mouth in an attempt to discredit him. He was onto something that was a little too close for comfort for these senators -- he could feel it.

"No, Mr. Chairman," Owen answered.

"No…" the Chairman said sarcastically, "Just that they were protecting super-intelligent, blood-thirsty robots."

The rest of the committee tried to stifle snickers at the joke.

Owen looked away to mask the fact he was grinning in frustration.

After regaining his composure, he turned to face the committee and raised an eyebrow as he spoke, "Mr. Chairman, I can have this machine brought to this *very room* in less than an hour if you like. Perhaps you will take this hearing more seriously then?"

"Umm," the Chairman chuckled lightly. "I don't think that will be necess-"

"Because honestly, Mr. Chairman," Owen interrupted as he began to lose his temper, "that thing scares the hell outta me. The one that was brought to our labs had an M4 assault rifle welded to its forearm -- a blow torch too."

The room went dead silent.

Owen continued, "We don't know for sure how many have escaped. I'm not saying the CIA or *Global Technologies* were conspiring to attack the White House, but I am *positive* that somebody did."

"Really?" the Chairman asked with a hint of dissatisfaction, "Like whom?"

"During our analysis," Owen replied, " of one of the machine's satellite uplink we intercepted log files that referred to someone named 'Isaac.' We also discovered that a trace-link file was located in *Global Technologies'* servers that referred to someone named 'Isaac' as well. I have reason to believe that this 'Isaac' may have hijacked the Predator drone that destroyed the military complex."

There was a brief pause as the senators whispered to each other.

The Chairman spoke, "So you think this Isaac person is, who exactly?"

"We're not sure, Mr. Chairman," Owen replied. "We haven't been able to trace the uplinks."

"So what are you suggesting, Mr. Jones?" the Chairman asked condescendingly.

"I'm asking that *Global Technologies Enterprise* testify as to their involvement in these incidents and that they cooperate with the NSA in our efforts to locate and apprehend this Isaac hacker and investigate his involvement in these incidents."

The committee grew silent for a moment. They all covered their microphones and whispered amongst each other for a bit.

After a while, the Chairman uncovered his microphone. "We will take a quick recess; we will return in twenty minutes."

With that everybody stood up as the committee left the room.

Owen turned around and walked swiftly out of the chamber. His wife followed him hastily, wondering why he was so agitated. Owen pushed the oak doors open and burst out of the chamber.

"Fucking cocksuckers!" he exclaimed.

He grabbed his cellphone out of his pocket and dialled a number.

His wife exited from the chamber doors.

"Baby," she asked, "are you okay?"

Owen turned to his wife and pressed his index finger to hip lips as the person on the other line picked up.

"Hey, it's me," Owen said to the phone. "Anything new?"

Owen listened for a moment then spoke again, "Perfect! Check it out and get your men down there. I don't think you got much time… Alright, make sure you actually call me this time… Alright." He hung up.

His wife approached. “What’s wrong honey?” she asked.

“You heard that asshole in there!” he exclaimed, “He was fuckin’ toying with me!”

“Yeah, but you knew they probably wouldn’t believe you,” his wife replied.

“No, this was different.” Owen lowered his voice slightly, “he *knew* I was right. He knows something I don’t.”

“How do you know?”

“Trust me babe,” he grinned lightly. “That nimrod would *never* be able to play poker for shit -- I just know.”

“Who was on the phone?”

“Nobody, just the office; forget it.”

His wife looked at him with curiosity. She was about to say something but changed her mind. Instead, she went and sat back down at the bench. Owen sat down too, waiting for the hearing to reconvene.

“Everything that you said in there,” his wife asked, “that was all true?”

Owen looked around the foyer casually.

“Yep,” he replied bluntly.

“Even the stuff about those robots?”

“Yep,” he repeated.

“Wow,” she said. “Who do you think this Isaac person is?”

“I don’t know. But whoever he is, after I lock him up I’ll probably end up hiring him.” Owen looked at his wife, “It’s gotta be more than one person though. I mean, the shit’s airtight. You remember hearing about that hacker group *Anonymous*? This is *way more* sophisticated.”

“How are you going to catch him then?”

“I don’t know baby, but I’m gonna do it.”

The couple shifted their conversation to more personal topics for the rest of the wait. After twenty minutes he was called back inside. The couple walked back in, Owen sat at the large table and his wife sat behind him again. After the official reading by the speaker, the Chairman addressed Owen again.

“Mr. Jones,” the Chairman said, “we, the Senate Intelligence Subcommittee, hereby issue a summons for all evidence that has been discussed today. You will receive a copy of the summons and you will have until the next Monday to procure it. This hearing is adjourned until Monday.”

The Committee stood back up and left.

Owen was handed a summons that had a sheet of paper attached, listing all the items the committee wanted for the next hearing, and then he and his wife left the building. Owen and his wife arrived separately, so he told her that he would meet her at home later, but first he needed to return to the office to give the summons to his subordinates. They entered the same limousine and left the Capital.

They rode the limo to the NSA’s headquarters and Owen kissed his wife goodbye as he exited and the limo driver took his wife back home. Owen entered the NSA headquarters, passed through security and entered his office. He picked up his office phone and dialled an internal number, telling somebody to meet him in his office.

As Owen waited for the person to arrive, he went over to the small refrigerator in his office and grabbed a can of iced tea. He sat down behind his desk, popped open the tab on his can and took a sip. *I should have a dry-bar installed in here*, he thought to himself. By the time he finished his iced tea the person he was waiting on had arrived. The person knocked on the door twice then opened it. A skinny, bespectacled red-headed man

came inside.

"What's up boss?" the man said.

"Homework," Owen replied.

He slid the summons across his desk. "There ya go."

The red-headed man grabbed the paper and looked at it.

"Is that all?" he asked.

"No, Brian, it's not actually." Owen leaned forward in his chair. "I told you to keep me posted, right?"

"Uh-huh."

"So when exactly did you plan on tellin' me you found the Vault?" Owen demanded. "'Cause the last time I checked, I don't get no birthday presents for another three months."

Brian chuckled quietly. "Sorry sir, but we just found the location literally twenty minutes before you called."

"Fair enough, all's forgiven. So how does it look?"

"Like a Detroit factory," Brian said.

"Any security?" Owen asked.

"Nothing we could see."

"Well, I'm sure your team will verify that." Owen stood up and walked around his desk. "Now get out of my office! I gotta get home. I need that homework by Monday morning."

"You got it." Brian left the office and Owen followed suit.

He locked the office door behind him then left the building, hailed a cab then headed home.

OIOOO

Eight

June 27,
Year 0 T.S.

T.J. could barely stop himself from dozing off in his seat as his fellow coworkers monotonously droned on for the past hour. Despite his casual attitude toward his work, this was one time he was supposed to be professional. But it was hard for him when the head of the finance department spoke to everybody about quarterly earnings, with only a bar graph on a large easel as a visual reference.

Today was the semi-monthly meeting of all the department heads, where they would update each other on their respective progress and future goals. Most importantly however, these meetings were Alfred Mason's chance to be kept updated on the company's project, the video code-named *Revenge*.

T.J. felt eyes getting heavier. He didn't even realize that his eyes were closed as the head of the finance department finished up with his presentation.

"Thank you, Mr. Wood," Alfred said. "Ted, how's *Revenge* doing?"

The lead project developer, Ted Kazinski, looked at the old man.

"It's going well, Al," he said, "I've gone around and polled all the project teams -- we're almost ready for the first round of beta tests."

Everybody in the meeting room nodded their heads in agreement -- all except T.J., who was seemingly dozing off in his seat.

Ted continued, "Right now we're only waiting on the AI team; I'm just waiting for T.J. to give the go-ahead."

With the sound of his name, T.J. instinctively opened his eyes as he felt his heart skip beat.

"Huh?" he muttered.

Everybody in the room looked at T.J.

"Welcome back Thomas!" the old man said, "How is the AI implementation going?"

T.J. stared at his father as he mentally removed the cobwebs from his brain.

"We've been hitting a lot of bugs," he said. "I got most of *Revenge's* engine to be compatible with the new scripts. I should be done really soon."

"How soon?" Alfred asked.

"Two weeks, tops," T.J. replied.

"Alright," Alfred said. "Make sure you let Ted know when it's done."

T.J. nodded and Alfred addressed the rest of the room. "Any other business?"

"Yeah, I got some bad news," *Chaotic's* lead Information Technology engineer interjected. "I was going through our company's servers, and it looks like there may have been a software leak."

Everybody's heads perked up and they all stared at the engineer.

"What got leaked?" Alfred asked. "The whole game?"

"It doesn't look like it," the engineer replied. "Actually, it seems as if the only files that were leaked were the AI scripts."

"What?!" T.J. exclaimed, "How did that happen? Who leaked it?"

"It looks like it might have been either a virus or an inside job," the engineer

explained. “We found a file on the servers that was programmed to open a backdoor port to our servers. We couldn’t trace down the originating IP address. The only lead we have so far is the name ‘Isaac.’”

Alfred looked confused, while the rest of the room looked somewhat relieved that only the AI scripts were stolen. T.J., on the other hand, was fuming inside.

“Alright,” Alfred said, “Well, keep me informed if anything new develops. In the meantime take the servers offline until you do a thorough virus scan.”

“Sure thing, Mr. Mason,” the engineer said.

“Everybody else: business as usual. Keep yourselves busy, and let’s get this done. Thanks for coming.”

With that everybody stood up and left the room except for TJ, who remained seated until everybody left. Alfred finished texting somebody on his cellphone when he noticed TJ still in the room.

“Something you want?” Alfred asked.

“My fucking script’s been leaked!” TJ fumed.

“It’s useless without the game engine,” Alfred said.

“Not *my* script -- it’s open-source,” T.J. said.

Alfred looked at him. “Thomas,” he said, “everything on our servers is cooked. We use a special CODEC to keep our files safe. Trust me, nobody can read it but us.”

T.J. looked at him skeptically, but took his word for it.

“Alright then,” he said.

“Anything else?” Alfred asked.

“Not really,” T.J. replied. “How was California?”

“It was alright.”

“What did you do again?”

“Met with some investors, assured them we’re not wasting their money.” Alfred stood up. “How’s your mother doing?”

T.J. stared at the old man blankly, “She’s fine, Al,” he said.

“That’s good,” Alfred walked past T.J. and left the meeting room for his office. “See you tomorrow,” he said as he left.

T.J. left the offices of *Chaotic Entertainment* and caught the train on his way back to Brooklyn to head home. As he rode the train he looked out his window into the New York cityscape below. He watched the thousands of pedestrians on the sidewalks and the congested traffic on the streets as everybody fought the rush-hour to return to their personal lives.

He looked up to the sky as the new World Trade Towers passed into his view. He noticed the dark-grey skies above and presumed it would rain heavily before he got home.

T.J. was right. Before he reached his stop it began to pour outside. Thunder crashed somewhere in the distance repeatedly as the storm showed no sign of receding.

He exited the train and walked down the staircase to ground level. He stopped just before the end of the overhead enclosure, dreading the idea of walking through the downpour with no umbrella -- he didn’t even have a hooded sweater with him. With only his shorts and a blue graphic t-shirt on, he jogged through the storm on the way to his brownstone apartment.

T.J. reached his stoop in ten minutes, taking the stairs two at a time to get inside and out of the rain. He grabbed his keychain from his shorts pocket and used a key to open his mailbox. Grabbing a handful of envelopes, he closed his mailbox and walked up the staircase to his floor.

On the second floor he spotted his neighbour Legs leaving his apartment wearing a

hooded sweater and a windbreaker. Legs looked in his direction and nodded.

"What's up dog," Legs said. "You good?"

"Naw, I'm cool for now," T.J. replied.

"A'ight, take it easy man."

"Yeah you too," T.J. said.

Legs walked down the stairs past T.J., and T.J. continued to climb up the stairs until he reached his door. He unlocked his door and stepped inside, flipping the switch for the living room light. He took off his shoes then tossed the handful of envelopes at the coffee table where they landed and drifted apart.

He walked rapidly down the hallway and into the bathroom. He took off his wet clothing and hung them over the shower bar. T.J. then walked out of the bathroom, turned to his left and entered the bedroom. He walked over to his dresser, grabbed a pair of shorts and a white t-shirt and put them on.

T.J. left the bedroom, walked down the hall into the living room and opened the glass sliding door for the balcony. He reached his arm out to a small hand-crank on the side of the doorway and turned it. An overhead awning extended outwards, shielding the balcony from the downpour.

He stepped back inside and grabbed his bag of marijuana from the computer desk and sat down at the coffee table. He glanced at the mail on the table as he turned on his large-screen LCD TV and used his *XBox One* controller to switch on his console. After the opening graphics ended he signed into his *XBox Live* account and searched *YouTube* for some music from *Pink Floyd*. He put on a song, placed his controller down and started opening his mail.

There was nothing special in the mail, but then again, T.J. didn't exactly have any penpals. Most of the mail was junk letters that read ***"YOU WON"*** in giant captions, followed immediately by 'a chance to win…"'in much smaller writing. Among the flyers and junk letters T.J. found an envelope addressed from the staff at *MGM Grand*, thanking him for his patronage and imploring him to return again.

"Maybe I will," he said aloud to himself.

He resolved to throw the letter out along with the rest of the mail. He got up, collected the junk into his hands and crumpled it up, then went into his kitchen and threw it all into the garbage bin. After closing the lid, he grabbed a glass from the cupboard, the *Brita* jug from the fridge, and walked back to the coffee table with both in hand. He sat down on the loveseat, poured himself a glass and placed both the cup and container aside as he ripped apart a large bud from his bag of pot.

A tone played from his *XBox One* and he looked up to view the notification. It read, *"BlumpkinAddict wants you to join a party,"*

It was Steve. T.J. grabbed his controller and pressed the centre button. He then grabbed his headset and plugged it into the controller. As he was being connected to Steve's console, T.J. turned down the volume on his T.V.

"What's up," T.J. said into his headset.

"*Yo, what're you doin'?*" Steve asked.

T.J. could hear him through both the T.V. and through the earpiece of his headset.

"Nothin', just got home," T.J. continued ripping apart his buds.

"*You wanna play* Search*?"* Steve asked.

"Yeah, just gimme a minute," T.J. said. "I'm gonna smoke quick."

"*Ah fuck! I almost had a gunship!"* Steve exclaimed absently. *"Hey, so I was thinkin'…"*

"What?" T.J. collected his shavings and grabbed his pipe.

"*We gotta do another video after the holiday. People are gonna expect it,*"

Steve was referring to the 4th of July, which was next week.

"Fuck that!" T.J.exclaimed, "I got arrested last time!"

"*I know -- I can't believe we haven't hit a million hits yet!*"

"Yeah well, we should. Last time I checked we were, like, ten thousand hits away."

"Yeah, well, I was thinkin' if we can't do New York no more, then we gotta go someplace else."

"Ha!" T.J. gasped, "Where the fuck are we gonna go?!"

T.J. finished packing his bowl.

"I dunno yet, what about California?"

"Where the hell are we gonna get away with that down there?!" T.J. stood up and placed his XBox controller in the largest pocket of his shorts so he could go to the balcony and still talk on his headset.

"What about Florida?" Steve suggested.

"Oh yeah, so I can get shot by someone *standing their ground?!*" T.J. said sarcastically.

He chuckled to himself and walked over to the balcony with his pipe and a lighter.

"*K, well I hear they have a parkour warehouse in Canada,"* Steve suggested.

"That'd be cool," T.J. said. "But I don't think the viewers will think that's exciting."

T.J. brought the pipe to his mouth and lit the bowl, inhaling the hot, thick smoke as he did.

"Well, I don't know, man," Steve said through T.J.'s headset. *"What about Colorado? There's gotta be good places up in the mountains."*

T.J. mumbled incoherently as he continued to hold his breath.

"What?" Steve asked.

T.J. exhaled the smoke. "Naw man," he said, "we need someplace that looks grimy or something." T.J. took another toke.

"L.A.'s got some grimy places," Steve suggested.

T.J. didn't even hold in the smoke this time. "I'm not goin' to fuckin' L.A., man. We'll probably get shot or beat doin' that down there!"

He lit his bowl one last time to burn the rest of the plant shavings to ashes.

Exhaling the harsh, oily remains, he went back inside and sat down as the marijuana began to take effect.

"Alright," he said to Steve, "send an invite."

"Okay," Steve replied.

Ten seconds later T.J. received a notification on his XBox that he was being invited to play a game of *Call of Duty* with *BlumpkinAddict.* T.J. accepted. The music from *Pink Floyd* stopped playing as the XBox loaded up the video game.

T.J. took a sip from his glass of water.

"So," he said, "what's up with this parkour warehouse in Canada?"

"I dunno," Steve answered, *"All I know is it's near Toronto or something."*

"Well, what is it?" T.J. asked. "Is it like low-budget shit, or is it like a parkour version of a skate park?"

"Uuhh," Steve replied, *"It's like that, the skate-park thing. But they made it out of an abandoned cereal factory, I think"*

"Oh cool," T.J. said, sincerely interested.

The game connected, and T.J. observed the match as it drew to an end; Steve's team lost by a close margin. As the match ended and the players awaited the next match, Steve told T.J. to back out of the game lobby. T.J. pressed 'B' on his Xbox controller and found himself placed in a private lobby, with Steve's screen name at the top.

T.J. thought about what it took to turn an empty factory into a parkour park. “Yo Steve,” he said, “Ashley told me someone said we should take the money we make from our videos and make a parkour park in the city.” T.J. grinned as he started to feel the effects of the cannabis.

“What?!” Steve sounded astonished. *“Where the hell would we get enough money for* that*?!”*

“I dunno man,” T.J. said. “But I wanna do it if we get the money.”

“Well, you get the money and I’ll help you,” Steve said sarcastically. *“You ready?”*

“Not yet, hold on.” T.J. opened up his character classes and modified them a bit.

“I mean,” T.J. continued, “I think it’s a good idea. You think those guys in Canada make money off it?”

“Probably,” Steve replied. *“They probably charge admission.”*

“We should do that -- charge admission and memberships.”

“You think your dad would front some money?”

“Probably not,” T.J. said. “But I could probably invest some money and get a load after this game releases.”

T.J. switched his screen back to the party lobby. “Okay, I’m ready.”

The screen switched over to a game lobby. T.J. received a notification that the private party chat between him and Steve was disconnected.

Besides himself and Steve, there were fourteen other players in the lobby. They were all speaking with different American accents -- some were southern; some northern; Black; Hispanic. There were a few young kids who rambled on and insulted people. T.J. immediately blocked communications with them. *They better not end up on my team,* T.J. thought.

As the game’s countdown timer ticked away the final seconds, the sixteen players were divided into two teams. To T.J.’s relief, the kids he blocked were on the opposite team. As the game transitioned to a loading screen he noticed the screen depicted an abandoned warehouse with multiple floors. He suddenly had an epiphany and felt compelled to share it with Steve.

The game loaded and T.J. chose a character class that was equipped with a silenced assault rifle and claymore mines. He, Steve and their team were on the attacking side, so T.J. sprinted through an alleyway in the game with plenty of cover.

Crouching and walking with a large dumpster in between him and the end of an alleyway, T.J. pressed a button on the top of his controller and threw a flash-bang grenade over the dumpster. A clicking noise in-game told him he successfully blinded somebody, so he laid his virtual character prone on the floor and peeked around the dumpster. He then threw a fragmentation grenade at the end of the alleyway.

Watching the corner, T.J. waited a few seconds for the grenade to explode then immediately threw a flash-bang around the corner. He spotted an enemy player crouching behind cover that fired at him but missed. As the flash-bang went off the enemy continued to spray bullets blindly. T.J. crawled underneath the line of fire, and then stood back up, aiming where the enemy was and firing.

He shot the enemy in the face. T.J. crouched again, checking the upper elevations of the warehouse beside him when he spotted a grenade falling from the second floor to his feet. The stun grenade detonated and T.J. could barely move his character as an enemy above him aimed their submachine at him and fired.

T.J. watches his character fall to the ground, dead.

“Fuck!” he exclaimed.

As his camera observed another teammate he checked the scoreboard and noticed Steve was dead as well.

"Yo Steve," he said.

"Yeah," Steve answered.

"What about Detroit?"

"What about it?" Steve wasn't sure what T.J. meant.

"Let's make a video in Detroit. They got all kinds of abandoned factories and shit out there."

There was a brief pause, then Steve replied, *"That's a great idea, Teej; I'm down!"*

"Alright, I'll look up train tickets for around the holidays," T.J. said.

Alright, cool," Steve replied.

The round ended with their team being killed off. They started another round, and continued playing round after round, match after match, for hours. In between matches, T.J. would take a break to smoke a bowl until about two o'clock in the morning when he decided to go to bed so he could get up for work the next day.

OIOOI

Nine

June 28,
Year 0 T.S.

The crescent moon above the Nevada desert appeared as though to be a painted backdrop above the horizon. While the countless stars above accompanied the silver sliver in piercing the black veil of the night, the moon itself shed no light over the barren landscape. However, this black veil of the night made the perfect cover for the flat-black stealth helicopter that flew silently across the desert towards the ruins of the secret facility that had been known to few only as 'the Vault.'

The two pilots of the helicopter navigated the black space via their electronics and GPS while the two men in the back double-checked their equipment -- the pale, Russian man who called himself Kondor, and the enigmatic, dark-skinned Zimra. They both wore the advanced *TechEye* headsets over their eyes, and heavy radiation suits with Self-Contained Breathing Apparatuses to protect themselves from the nuclear fallout inside the Vault.

They also equipped themselves with shoulder-mounted flashlights, and each carried a KA-BAR combat knife. Organic LED pads were attached to their forearms; the pads were covered in a wire mesh to protect them from the nuclear radiation. The pads would collect the video feeds from the agents' *TechEyes* for further analysis one they returned to Langley.

As a precaution, each man also carried a Sig Sauer forty-calibre pistol that was holstered to their thighs, in case anything hostile still inhabited the Vault. Additionally, they also carried waist packs that contained flares and specimen bags.

The two agents both felt the mission parameters were below their skills. They were normally used to collect Signals Intelligence, not to explore underground ruins in search for DNA samples. Still, time was a factor here. Their handler advised them in their briefing that there was the possibility of somebody returning to dispose of the evidence they were looking for, therefore there was no time to put together a professional Hazmat team. The two agents were activated and deployed as soon as the location of the Vault was discovered.

On the way to Nevada they were briefed on the significance of the data they had obtained from the *GTE* headquarters. They were told about the Vault project, the Adam models, Observer-Four, the hijacked Predator drone, and the dead soldiers whose bodies were never recovered. So even though this mission had nothing to do with their respective skill sets, they both felt compelled to find and identify those bodies.

The helicopter dropped below radar cover as it approached the Vault. The pilot looked over his shoulder and shouted to the agents, telling them to prepare for the drop. Zimra grabbed a bundle of rope and placed it around his shoulder. The two activated their *TechEye* devices and activated their cameras' video recorders. They placed the full face masks of their SCBAs over their heads and activated their shoulder lights.

The helicopter hovered a few feet from the Vault's rooftop and both men jumped

down. The helicopter lifted back up and flew a safe distance away from the irradiated zone. Kondor pulled his pistol from his holster and covered the massive hole in the rooftop while Zimra tied the rope he carried around a giant air conditioner condensing unit. Zimra tugged on the rope as hard as he could; satisfied that the rope was secure he walked to the edge of the hole, grabbed the rope and lowered himself down.

Zimra reached the floor of the second level, then grabbed his pistol and a flare from his waist pack. He lit the flare and threw it deeper into the large forum. The flare illuminated the forum with its incandescent-red flame, exposing the hollow casing of the freight elevator shaft. One of the walls to the shaft had been blown out, and the elevator cables inside hung limp, presumably dangling down to the lowest level possible.

"Clear," Zimra said.

Kondor holstered his pistol. "I'm coming down," he called down.

He grabbed the rope and lowered himself down beside Zimra. Kondor checked the OLED pad on his right arm which showed a schematic of the second floor of the Vault. He looked in the direction where Zimra had thrown the flare.

"That way is the security office and stairs," he said.

"Alright," Zimra replied. "Let's check the perimeter first."

The two agents split up and checked along the outer area of the forum. They moved slowly, aiming their shoulder lights into the darkness that surrounded them.

All either man could hear was the sound of their own breathing being amplified by the valves in their SCBA masks. Everything in the forum was covered by ash, dust, rubble, steel shards and soot. The whole facility was completely burned out.

Kondor was across the room from the freight elevator when he started seeing larger fragments of debris that had been blown against the wall. He aimed his shoulder light at the debris, the majority of which was steel machine parts.

He slowly advanced forward, shedding light on the blackened, charred remains of a human body. He approached it. He could see its blackened, mutilated face; its mouth gaping open in a pained, violent scream. An arm was missing from its body, and several ribs were exposed from where the nuclear fire melted the dead man's skin.

Kondor was shocked that there were no vermin consuming the body. *It must be because of the radiation,* he assumed.

"Found a body," Kondor called out into the darkness.

Zimra wasn't far away and heard him clearly.

"Yeah," Zimra replied, "I found two more."

He kneeled before the two rotting corpses that were piled on top of each other. One body's skull had been caved in, while the other one had three broken limbs.

"We need dental photos and DNA samples," Kondor said in his Russian accent. "Take finger for sample."

Kondor grabbed his KA-BAR military knife from the sheath on his thigh and used the serrated edge to saw through the finger bone. He placed the severed finger into a specimen bag then grabbed the corpse's face and twisted the head to face the ceiling so he could get a perfect view of the teeth for his *TechEye*. His gloved fingers sagged into the rotted head's cheeks -- he could feel the decomposing skin squish between his fingers.

Zimra felt the same thing, and even though he had once been a ruthless torturer of prisoners of war in another life, feeling the spongy-soft cadaver unsettled him. When they were finished collecting their samples, they both stood up and turned around to walk towards the still-burning flare.

"I'm surprised they didn't already clean this place up," Zimra said as they walked across the giant forum.

"They probably assumed they had time," Kondor replied.

Both agents reached the flare and stared at the hole in the steel-reinforced concrete wall.

"That must've been quite the explosion," Zimra mused.

Kondor stepped over the flare and walked into the next forum as Zimra followed suit.

"We should split up again," Kondor said. "Meet at security room."

"Yeah," Zimra walked to his left and Kondor went in the opposite direction; they walked the grid of the outer area of the forum. As Kondor reached the wall opposite to the freight elevator he noticed an open door leading to an empty stairwell. He looked inside and saw that the floor was missing.

On the opposite end of the forum Zimra spotted an open door to a staircase. He made a mental note of it and continued on. He spotted steel exoskeletons that belonged to a few destroyed robots; they were piled on top of each other. He also noticed a charred corpse beside them. As he kneeled down to collect his evidence, Kondor discovered another body just twenty feet away from Zimra.

They collected their specimens and met up at the security door. Kondor nodded and Zimra stepped inside. He turned to his right and jumped back slightly as he was startled by the sight of a giant, four-legged, two-headed machine. It was standing upright but completely motionless.

"Check this out," Zimra said to Kondor.

Kondor stepped inside and saw the giant machine as well. He revelled at its enormity.

"That's what all the fuss was about, I guess," Zimra said.

There was a pile of scrap metal on the other side of the room. Every computer monitor in the room had been blown out by the explosion. There was nothing for them to collect in the security room.

"We have cleared this floor," Kondor said. He pressed a few buttons on the side of his arm-mounted OLED pad, and the schematic drawing for the second floor was replaced by a schematic drawing of the main floor.

Kondor continued, "The files we acquired from *GTE* said there were thirteen men unaccounted for when they destroyed this place. So we must find eight more bodies."

"I found the stairs. Follow me," Zimra replied. He stopped at the busted door, ignited another flare and tossed it down the elevator shaft. Less than two seconds later the flare hit the top of the freight elevator below and illuminated the wreckage within.

Kondor continued walking the perimeter until he reached the front entrance to the Vault. The thick blast door had been breached when the Vault was demolished. He looked through the door to the dark desert beyond and felt uneasy. In the dark, claustrophobic confines of the Vault, it made him nervous to think that just about anything could enter the Vault with them. Kondor decided to forget about it and moved on.

Kondor met up with Zimra at the freight elevator. Zimra was still staring down the elevator shaft. "We're definitely not taking the elevator," Zimra said, bemused.

"Let's clear this floor and move downstairs," Kondor said.

They walked around the freight elevator and split up again. They walked the perimeter, searching for more bodies. They didn't find any, not even any more of the machines. They met up at the end of the forum and walked back to the staircase to go down another floor.

Kondor checked his OLED pad. "The lower levels are like a labyrinth," he said. "We should stick to one half of the facility until we reach the bottom, then we can search the other half on our way back up."

"Let's do it," Zimra replied.

They descended the staircase to the first sublevel. The floor was covered in a half-inch thick film of black sludge, a byproduct of condensed steam and gas vapours fused together by the nuclear hellfire. The entire corridor was blackened by fire damage, but the reflective surface of the sludge beneath their feet showed them where to go.

Kondor decided to take point while Zimra followed close behind. Zimra watched the ceiling above for broken pipes and fixtures, weary of possible falling objects. Kondor stopped at a pair of twisted double-doors, the faces of which had been melted and warped from the intense heat of the explosion.

Kondor walked inside and scanned the large warehouse for any movement. There were steel containers stacked all the way up to the ceiling. Most of these containers, however, had been toppled to the ground.

As Zimra entered the warehouse behind Kondor they both noticed several rotting corpses on the ground. Some were partially crushed by falling containers, and there were two others that were missing the bottom halves of their bodies. Their entrails had liquefied and formed a rubbery, viscous coating around their charred rib cages.

"Ugh, God." Zimra felt nauseated.

"Control yourself, friend," Kondor advised. "Trust me: You must not take off your mask down here."

Zimra closed his eyes and kneeled down for a moment to regain his composure as Kondor passed by several corpses to the ones on the far end of the warehouse. He took video feeds of dental profiles and collected pinkie fingers from the three corpses that had been the most badly mutilated.

"Are you okay?" Kondor asked.

Zimra opened his eyes and took a deep breath.

"Yeah," Zimra said, "I'm fine."

"I took care of these men," Kondor said. "You get those three near you and then we continue."

Kondor walked back to the same double-doors they entered through, passing by Zimra, who started collecting specimens.

"We have eleven so far," Kondor said as they walked on. "Two more soldiers to find."

"I can't believe they all got ambushed," Zimra muttered. "Those machines weren't armed until *after* the soldiers died, so how did they get the upper hand like this?"

"The machine in the lab at NSA was only four feet tall," Kondor replied. "Did you not notice the steel plates on his body?"

"I was more interested in its weapons."

They started looking into every room that they passed by.

"Look at the walls - panels are missing," Kondor said. "Those machines used panels from the walls as armour. The panels could also make excellent camouflage down here."

They continued searching in silence as Zimra contemplated the possibility of robots actually disguising themselves with their environment. As they reached the rear half of the basement they started finding burnt-out rooms filled with scrap machine parts and partially-melted Adam models. *There must be a dozen back here*, Zimra thought.

Eventually Kondor checked his OLED pad. "That's it," he said, "we check next floor now." They both turned around and backtracked through the blackened corridors and thick sludge until they reached the stairwell. They both descended to the next sublevel.

The layout of the second sublevel was almost identical to the one above, except there was no warehouse. Instead, there was only a foyer where a giant barricade had been erected at the freight elevator entrance. The barricade had been made from steel containers, wall panels and scrap machine parts.

Zimra took a closer look at the barricade and noticed that rusted parts from scrapped Adam models had also been used to create the barricade as well. The nature of these former inhabitants felt even more alien and dreadful to Zimra. Regardless, he pushed the thoughts out of his mind and walked away.

They continued searching the floor and, once again, found limp Adam models in various closed rooms, covered in the thick sludge that coated the floor. In the rear half of the sublevel they found a door that had been breached by an explosive charge. They entered the room and found a burst maintenance hatch in the ceiling that exposed the starry night sky thirty feet beyond their reach. The bottom of the hatch opening was covered in rust.

"These hatches," Zimra observed, "are probably where all the water came from."

"It's time to check the bottom floor," Kondor said. The two agents turned around and backtracked to the stairwell, descending to the third sub basement -- the lowest level in the Vault. As they reached the end of the stairs they noticed the sub basement was flooded up to their knees with black sludge.

"Move slowly," Kondor cautioned, "we cannot risk ripping our radiation suits."

They slowly waded through the thick, knee-deep sludge, moving with deliberate steps as they used their feet to feel around for obstacles on the submerged ground.

"My God," Zimra said, "this is all the water from the upper levels?"

"It appears so," Kondor replied.

"We're in the middle of the desert," Zimra muttered. "Where did it all come from?"

"They must have had a reservoir nearby." Kondor and Zimra continued searching each room that they passed by.

After ten minutes they reached a very long corridor. They noticed bullet holes in the walls. They treaded carefully, and felt several objects on the ground beneath them.

"Careful," Kondor said, "I think there are machines below us. Be aware of their extremities."

Kondor treaded on carefully and Zimra followed close by, lifting his feet straight up and dropping them straight down with deliberate footsteps. At one point Zimra's foot slipped and he could feel the machine below him shift and trap his foot underneath it.

"Shit!" Zimra exclaimed. Kondor turned around then Zimra said to him, "My foot's caught."

"Do you think you can free yourself?" Kondor asked.

"Yeah," Zimra replied. "Here though; take my gun and my pack."

Zimra passed his pistol to Kondor then unclipped his waist pack, passing it to Kondor as well. Zimra bent down and tried to feel with his hands for the object that trapped his foot. He slowly felt his way around his foot, gingerly freeing his hazmat suit from the machine parts that had snared it. He then lifted the machine up slightly, moved his foot out of the way then slowly placed the machine back down.

Zimra stood back up. Kondor watched him and observed as the black sludge still clung to Zimra's radiation suit. Only his SCBA mask was unstained.

"Did any of the liquid get into your suit?" Kondor asked in a demanding tone.

"I don't think so," Zimra replied.

"Alright, let us move on."

Kondor handed back to Zimra his pistol and waist pack. Kondor then turned around and kept walking as Zimra followed. They reached an intersection and turned left into a small corridor lined with doors.

They checked the rooms on both sides of the corridor and found a bloated corpse floating inside the middle room on their right. As they approached the bloated body the waves they made in the black sludge began to rock the body up and down.

Both Kondor and Zimra could see that the front of the face had been consumed by something. The nose was gone, as were the eyes of most of both of the body's cheeks.

As they approached it they saw a swarm of cockroaches exit from the inside of the dead soldier's face, through the mouth, eyes and nose. The roaches moved further down the body, looking for a way to escape that did not involve drowning in the toxic sludge. Most of them sank into the sludge, but many had burrowed into the hollowed-out interior of the rotted corpse's chest.

"This one's in very bad condition," Kondor said. "We may need to collect a sample from the mandible."

"Yeah," Zimra muttered. Kondor approached the body and grabbed the head by the back of the skull. He tilted the head to face him and noticed that the top half of the skull was missing. Much of the brain had been devoured by the cockroaches, but Zimra could still see a few of them hiding in small pockets within the brain matter.

"Some of the brain is still intact," Kondor told Zimra.

"We might have better luck with the bone marrow though," Zimra replied.

"You are right." Kondor grabbed his KA-BAR knife and used it to cut the lower jawbone from the skull. He then grabbed both ends of the jaw like a wishbone and snapped it into two pieces. He took the smallest half and placed it into a specimen bag.

"There is one more body remaining," Kondor said.

They left the room and turned left. They crossed the intersecting hall and found a door that had been partially melted. Zimra looked through the hole in the door and spotted a large pile of scrap metal that lay between two giant boilers. He tried to open the door but it was blocked from the inside.

"The door's stuck," Zimra said.

"Do you see the last soldier?" Kondor asked.

"No," Zimra replied, "just scrap metal."

"Remember this room and let us move on." Kondor turned and walked away. Zimra followed and they both turned right at the intersection.

They continued walking down the long, flooded corridor. They passed a couple of corners and started walking down a long, narrow corridor with doors on their right side. Kondor checked each room that they passed by, but stopped at the fourth door.

"There's something in here," Kondor said. He entered the room, Zimra followed, and they both could not help but just stare straight ahead of them in shock and disbelief.

A charred body was strapped down into a steel gurney just barely suspended above the black sludge. Its mouth was slightly opened. A large hole had been bored into the right side of its forehead. They couldn't believe what they saw; they both moved in closer.

The right side of the body had been completely burned up. Its skeleton was completely exposed except for the right forearm. The forearm was a prosthetic limb, completely made of steel, and in the same shape and size as the arms from the Adam models -- its steel hand balled into a fist.

They took a look at the dead man's charred face. In particular, they focused on

where the hole in the forehead was located. In the body's right eye socket they both noticed something that looked like a camera lens.

The lens had been shattered and smelted by the intense nuclear fire that consumed this man.

"What the hell…" Zimra muttered under his breath. He moved in closer and looked directly at the eye socket so as to record what he was seeing with his *TechEye* glasses.

He grabbed the camera lens with his hand and pulled on it. Struggling with it at first, the bones in the eye socket eventually gave way as the interior of the socket shattered and broke apart. There was a small metal plate that had been inserted behind the eye socket that kept the camera lens in place; the plate came out along with the lens.

Zimra pulled even harder until he could hear a sickening ripping and tearing sound emanating from within the base of the skull, as a bundle of wires detached from what remained of the brain.

Zimra looked at the optical device in his hand with utter horror. "This is really fucked up!" he said.

"We need to collect this sample and leave," Kondor interjected. "This must be reported as soon as possible."

Zimra stepped away and placed the optical device in his waist pack while Kondor approached the body. He aimed his shoulder light directly at the rotted, bionic cadaver and recorded the horrific visage with his *TechEye*. He then used his knife to cut out a piece of rib and placed it into a specimen bag. They both left the room.

They had found all of the bodies that were declared missing, but continued searching the second half of the Vault as they returned to the top floor. They noticed nothing of interest, but then again, neither one of them could clear their minds of what they had just seen.

When they returned to the rooftop Kondor used his OLED pad to activate a beacon. As his OLED pad emitted a silent, invisible signal they both awaited the stealth helicopter's arrival. All the while, both men replayed their respective video feeds from their *TechEyes* on their OLED pads.

They paid real close attention to the decomposing corpse at the bottom of the Vault that had been cybernetically mutilated. They both wondered who could have been so unlucky to have such a horrendous thing done to them. They then shook the stained memories from their minds as they both found themselves wondering if *he* was the only one to have this done to him, or not.

OIOIO

Ten

June 29,
Year 0 T.S.

Staacman found himself to be alone in a burnt-out building with no memory of how he got there. Although he didn't recognize the room he was in and despite the darkness surrounding him, he could tell he was in a classroom. Burnt desks littered the room, and in some of the seats he saw little children sitting lifelessly with their bodies slumped over the desktops.

He walked out of the classroom and into a hallway. The pale moonlight shone through holes in the ceiling like the tired eyes of God. At the end of the hallway he could faintly see movements.

His eyes adjusted to the darkness and he focused his eyes on whatever it was he saw down the hall. The moonlight from above reflected off the shiny coating of the thing he seeked -- although he couldn't bring it into focus, Staacman knew it was an Adam mode.

The machine stood on all fours and crawled slowly along the wall. Staacman grabbed the pistol from his holster, aimed it at the machine and pulled the trigger, but the gun jammed. The machine heard the *click* of the hammed and glared back at Staacman before pouncing to its right into an open door.

Staacman ran after it, cocking the slide back on his pistol and releasing the jammed bullet. He reached the doorway and walked through it then ran down the stairs into the basement. The basement was flooded up to his waist, but he was determined to catch the machine.

He waded through the flooded basement into a narrow corridor. There was a light on at the end of the hall. He could see broken pipes in front of him that silhouetted over the light, dark liquid pouring from them into the basement.

Staacman trudged on through the deluge. As he did, he heard an effeminate voice echoing from the end of the hall:

"I know how you reproduce…"

Staacman aimed his pistol into the light.

"I know how you feed and take in fluids to survive."

The fluorescent lights above Staacman began to flicker rapidly, and he could see that the dark waist-deep fluid that surrounded him and flowed down from the pipes was actually blood.

"I know how to kill you."

Staacman walked up a flight of steps that took him out of the pool of blood. He entered the room where the bright light was emanating from. The room was empty except for a single chair.

Sitting in the chair was Corporal Guzman -- the top half of his skull had been removed. Wires extended from the top of his brain and down the sides of his head like thick strands of gold-coloured hair. Blood stained his face and his eyes were pale white.

Guzman opened his mouth to speak, but his words came out in a barely-audible whisper, *"I cannot allow you to leave…"*

From behind Guzman's chair a machine on tank treads moved around to Guzman's

side and stopped. The machine was covered in antenna and parabolic dishes. A bundle of wires extended from the machine's torso and hung limply to the ground before rising up to Guzman's brain.

Staacman walked towards the machine when he was grabbed from behind. He tried to pull away but the grip was too strong. He turned around and tried to punch whoever grabbed him, but his fist just glanced off the chest of the seven-foot tall machine that stared down at him with red, glowing eyes.

The machine grabbed him by the neck with its other arm and Staacman then saw a torch ignite in his peripheral vision. The machine brought its arm up to Staacman's face; the plasma-welding torch on the machine's wrist expelled a perfect cone of white-hot flame.

Both the machine with the effeminate voice, and Guzman's lifeless body, said in concert, "*Your skills are very valuable to us."*

The machine that subdued him brought the plasma cutter to his forehead, and he could feel melted skin dripping into his eyes as the machine burned a hole right into his skull. He tried to scream as everything went dark.

He flailed his arms in the air, grabbing for the arm that clamped down on his throat, but nothing was there. His eyes were wide with fear as he realized there was no melted skin burning his eyes. He touched his forehead with the palm of his hand and only felt sweat. He looked around and noticed he was sitting up in a bed. A digital clock beside him read 0316.

Staacman reminded himself repeatedly that it was just a dream -- *the dream* -- the same one that plagued him almost every night since the Vault. No matter how many times he saw Guzman's face in his sleep he never felt any less horrified.

He had only been asleep a little over three hours but decided that he had slept enough. He got up from his bed and entered the bathroom. He leaned over the sink and splashed some water on his face then went back to the bedroom.

He grabbed a pair of sweatpants and a dark-green t-shirt. He put on his clothes then left his apartment and exited the officer's complex. Staacman took a jog around Peterson Air Force Base, hoping that the summer mountain air would help him forget the bloody images that consumed his nightmares.

As he jogged around the base he noticed Jefferson Smith down the road walking toward the base Command Centre. He seemed to be in a hurry. Jefferson was met at the door by Major Henson, the base Commanding Officer; they both walked inside.

Staacman decided to see what was going on, so he walked up to the Command Centre entrance. The door was locked. Staacman knocked on the door and Jefferson opened it.

"Lieutenant," Jefferson said, "what are you doing here?"

"Seems like I'm not the only one who can't sleep tonight," Staacman replied.

"Who is that, Smith?" Major Henson asked from behind the doorway.

"It's Lieutenant Staacman," Jefferson replied.

"Alright well, let him in."

Jefferson backed away from the door, making way for Staacman to enter. Staacman closed the door as Jefferson went back to the Major. They were watching something on a large computer.

"What's going on, sir?" Staacman asked Major Henson.

"There was an incident in Alaska," Jefferson interjected. "It looks like more Adam models. We're trying to get in contact with someone at the Governor's office, but nobody's taking us seriously."

"What do you mean?" asked Staacman.

“The Governor of Alaska is convinced it was Russian terrorists, and requested a SEAL team be deployed,” Major Henson said disgustedly.

Twenty-thousand feet above sea level, the sixteen passengers aboard a C-130 cargo plane prepared for their deployment into the snowy Alaska Mountains. They checked their breathing masks and parachutes to make sure they were secure, along with their silenced M4 assault rifles that were strapped to the chests, before commencing their HALO drop.

The Navy SEAL team leader, Commander Miles Irving, checked the contents of the equipment box that would be dropped down with them to make sure it had everything his team needed. Satisfied with his check, he sealed the box and locked it then returned to his seat, waiting for the green light.

Commander Irving and his team weren’t given much information about the details of the mission -- only a satellite-image of their area-of-operations and a brief description of the situation. A brief emergency radio transmission was received by a military communications relay tower near Anchorage some time after eleven o’clock at night. The transmission came from a remote military base in the mountains that was used as the main satellite complex for HAARP - the High-frequency Active Auroral Research Program.

The transmission explained very frantically that the base was under attack. Very little description could be made from the transmission except that the invaders seemed to be wearing full-body suits made of some kind of copper mesh. The invaders were also carrying assault rifles loaded with explosive-tipped rounds.

The transmission ended just as quickly as it began. All attempts to respond to the transmission were met with silence. After receiving wind of the attack the governor was convinced that it was a Russian Spetznaz invasion -- after all, what other explanation could there be?

Without accepting any consultation the Governor immediately decided to have a SEAL team deployed to the HAARP complex to neutralize the invaders and take back control of one of the country’s most sensitive, most powerful military projects.

The rear bay door slowly lowered open on the AC-130 and the sixteen-man platoon stood up from their seats. The equipment box was pushed into place by both Commander Irving and the platoon’s 2nd-in-Command, Lieutenant Geoffrey Charles, as everybody else stood by.

The cold, calculated airborne ‘sailors’ placed their breathing masks over their mouths and activated their air regulars. They watched the red light on the side of the plane’s cargo hold. The light switched to green, and the SEALs pushed the equipment box out of the plane and jumped out after it.

One by one each man plummeted down to the mountainous terrain below which was masked by the dark clouds below them as they freefell from twenty-thousand feet. As they passed through the clouds their suits became damp from the condensation that began to slowly freeze upon their winter-camouflage thermo-suits.

They watched the altitude gauges strapped to their wrists, waiting for their mark to deploy as late as possible. As practised hundreds of times before, their goal was to slow down to a reasonable landing speed mere feet above the ground.

One by one each sailor pulled their rip-cords when they were less than 500 feet from the ground. Their harnesses jerked their bodies violently as they abruptly decelerated to a safe landing speed. They landed in a small valley five hundred feet south of the complex.

They touched down after the equipment box, which lay hidden under its white parachute. The sailors disconnected their chutes which blended into the snowy ground with near-perfect precision.

Commander Irving ran to the equipment box and unlocked it as the rest of his platoon created a perimeter around the landing zone to keep an eye out for any unidentified hostile threats.

He whispered into his headset, “Jax, Charlie, Picket, Wells; gear up.”



Four of the sailors left the perimeter watch and ran to the equipment box and collected bolt cutters, C4 charges, fire-optic ‘snake’ cameras, night-vision goggles, binoculars and backpacks. They put on their goggles, placed the fibre-op devices on their ammunition vests, and placed the C4 and bolt cutters into the backpacks. They then turned around and grouped around Commander Irving.

“Team One; gear,” Irving said. The rest of the sailors went and grabbed night-vision goggles from the box.

“Team One; you got point.”

The six-man squad that made up ‘Team One’ grouped together and formed a closed double-rank formation as they left the valley.

With Commander Irving and Team Two trailing behind, the sixteen Navy SEALs exited the valley and proceeded North. In the distance they could see floodlights from the elusive ForceCom underground entrance to the HAARP complex. Both SEAL teams stopped and laid prone in the knee-height snow as they crawled toward cover behind a small foothill.

Wells lifted his night vision goggles up from his face and looked through his binoculars to search for any sign of movement within the mockup outdoor complex of HAARP’s public facade. From their position Wells could only see the sides of several buildings. The lights in the guard towers were on, but Wells could not see anybody inside of them. The large buildings blocked most of his line-of-sight into the complex.



Wells put down his binoculars and quietly said to Commander Irving, “South side is clear sir.”

“Let’s go,” Irving ordered.

Both teams stood back up and ran across the snowy landscape, using the rocky terrain to provide soft cover for their advance. They reached the thirty-foot high barbed wire perimeter fence. Wells, Jackson, Lt. Charles and Pickett pulled out their bolt cutters while Team One aimed their rifles into the property, scanning the interior

to make sure nobody tried to ambush them.

The four sailors cut a hole through the fence and put their bolt cutters away as Team One slipped through the hole into the complex. Both teams split up once they were within the complex grounds and took opposite sides of a large building and approached the central courtyard.

As they reached the front end of the building Commander Irving began to wonder where everybody was. There were no bodies to be seen and yet, no enemy movement either. Everything was eerily quiet and still.

Commander Irving looked around the complex yard. There was a roadway that led to their right. Down the road he noticed an idling Jeep that had swerved off the road and crashed into a building. Both teams advanced on the Jeep and found an unconscious man behind the wheel.

Jackson pushed the unconscious man back into his seat. His face was bloody from hitting the steering wheel but he was alive. The man groaned as he came to. He opened his eyes and saw the men in camouflage suits surrounding his Jeep.

He looked at Jackson and asked, “Who are you guys?”

Irving stepped forward. “Commander Irving, platoon leader, US Navy SEALs. What happened here.”

The man heard Irving’s American accent and decided to trust him. “I’m not sure sir,” he replied. “I was just told to get to the HAARP compound and defend it, but I got ambushed on the way there.”

“Who attacked the complex?”

“I don’t know sir. But they were very short, and very fast.”

The man took a moment to think back and shook his head. “I only say the two that ambushed my Jeep,” he replied.

“Where’s the HAARP compound.”

“Just follow this road -- there’s only one way in, through the blast door.”

“Can you walk?” Irving asked.

The man tested his legs and then stepped out of the Jeep while holding the side of his head.

“You’re with me,” Irving said to the man. “Here, take this.” Irving removed the sidearm from his holster and passed it to the man.

“Team One,” Irving called out, “take point; follow the road.”

The SEALs left the crashed Jeep and followed the long road. In the distance they saw a security checkpoint and guardhouse in front of a large blast door built into the side of a mountain.

“How do we open the door?” Irving asked the man.

“The door’s controlled from inside,” the man replied.

“Team Two, breach the door.”

Jackson, Pickett, Wells and Lt. Charles ran to the door while Team One covered their approach. Team One moved up to the guardhouse and took cover behind it. Team Two placed C4 charges on the blast door then ran back to the guardhouse. Charles armed the remote detonator and looked back at Commander Irving who nodded his head.

Lt. Charles flipped the switch on the detonator and the C4 on the giant door exploded, leaving a hole in the blast door that was just large enough to squeeze one man through at a time.

“Alright, let’s move,” Irving said. “Wheeler, take point.”

Wheeler approached the hole in the blast door. He stood next to the breach with his back against the door. He activated his night vision goggles and peeked inside to scan

for movement.

He didn't see any movement so he squeezed through the narrow breach and entered the mountainside bunker. Wheeler raised his rifle and crouched in front of the breach. "All clear," he whispered into his headset.

The men outside all squeezed through the opening one at a time, with Commander Irving being the last to enter after the Jeep driver they had picked up reluctantly out of fear and confusion. They found themselves in a long tunnel that contained a vehicular roadway which led even deeper into the mountain. The bare light bulbs in the ceiling were dim but bright enough to navigate without night-vision.

"There's a vehicle port straight ahead," the Jeep driver told Commander Irving. "It's the only way into the compound."

"Team One, take point," Irving Commanded. He looked at the man they had picked up. "What's your name soldier?"

"Private Moore sir, US Army Corps," the driver replied. Everybody began to walk through the long tunnel towards the vehicle port.

"Alright private," Irving said, "you stay with me. What's the layout of this place?"

"I don't know sir," Moore replied. "I've never passed the vehicle port. Only officers and scientists are given access down here."

"What's so important about this base?" Irving asked. "Why was it attacked?"

"This is the main Command & Control Centre for HAARP," Moore explained.

"Yeah, but *what is it?*" Irving demanded. "Why would it be attacked?"

"I don't know sir!" Moore exclaimed. "I'm not permitted to know *anything* about this place."

"You must have *heard* something. I need to know what we're dealing with!"

"All I know is the program uses over ten thousand satellite dishes all over the country and many of them are here in Alaska," Moore said. "A lot of people get sick here too, but that's probably just the climate and altitude."

"Alright fine," Irving said, frustrated. "Just stay with me -- I might need you to ID any friendlies for us."

The SEALs and Private Moore walked in silence for a while. When they were nearing the vehicle port, Moore broke the silence by asking the SEAL Commander, "Do you know who attacked us?"

"Your Governor says it was Russian Spetznaz," Irving replied.

"I don't think so," Moore said. "They were really short, kind of like super-fast midgets."

Lieutenant Charles looked behind him toward the Commander and Moore. "Sounds like *North Korean* Special Forces," he interjected.

Irving looked astonished, "What?!"

"North Koreans, on average, are almost half our height because of generations of malnutrition," Charles explained.

What a fucking idiot, Irving thought to himself. "Just keep moving sailor," he said.

They exited the tunnel and entered the vehicle port. It was sparsely populated with over a dozen civilian vehicles and a few military trucks. More than half of the vehicles were riddled with bullet holes. Shattered glass and shell casings littered the ground, but nobody could see any bodies.

"The secure entrance is on the right," Moore said, "but I've heard it's covered by gunports. The shipping entrance straight ahead is probably safer."

Commander Irving looked straight ahead and saw a large garage door that was slightly open. The opening looked like it was large enough to crawl under. He could see a flickering coming from beyond the opening.

"Team One, cover the left side of the door," Commander Irving said. "Team Two, on me." Both teams split up, using the vehicles as cover as they approached the garage door.

They reached the side of the garage door and Irving ordered Pickett to use his fibre optic cable. Pickett crouched beside the garage door and pulled his 'snake cam' from his vest. He placed the flexible cable on the ground and used the LCD viewer to rotate the camera and see what was inside the shipping/receiving bay.

From the camera's fish-lens view he could see a couple of people lying on the ground, presumably dead. He saw nothing else of interest.

Pickett retrieved his fibre optic cable. "Somethin' happened here sir," he said, "but we just missed it."

"Team One, go," Irving Commanded.

The ten-man team went prone and crawled under the door. When they reached the other side they stood up and took cover behind steel crates and other heavy machinery before Team Two, the platoon Commander and Private Moore entered. As soon as the four men of Team Two took cover, Team One advanced forward.

It was impossible for the sixteen SEALs and their recovered Marine escort to ignore the foul stench in the receiving bay from the half-dozen bodies they encountered in the shipping bay. Shell casings littered the floor and the fallen soldiers were covered in massive burns and bullet holes.

Two of the bodies had been cut open, their internal organs spilled out all over the floor. Pvt. Moore covered his face with his jacking, retching as he tried to avoid making eye contact with all the bodies, some of which he knew personally from just a quarter-mile away, when he was ordered to keep them safe.

Team One reached a pair of large double-doors that left the receiving bay and entered the rest of the mountain compound. Team Two moved up and regrouped with Team One as they prepared to breach the double-doors.

Pickett tested the door handle -- it was unlocked. Pickett nodded to Commander Irving, who tapped Wheeler on the shoulder. Wheeler grabbed the door handle and pulled the door open as the rest of the SEAL team entered the wide doorway. They found themselves in a long, dark corridor.

All of the fluorescent lights above them had been shattered, but there was one at the end of the hall that flickered faintly, though not nearly enough to provide any visible light. The SEALs all flipped on their night vision goggles and slowly moved forward.

Irving grabbed Moore's shoulder and told him, "Stay back and walk slowly." Through his night vision Irving could see more dead bodies on the floor, many of whom were in civilian clothing. From the way they had all fallen, it looked they were killed whilst trying to run away from the receiving bay.

The SEALs all took their time stepping around the bodies that littered the floor. Irving guided Moore carefully around the bodies so he wouldn't trip and fall.

They all reached the flickering light at the end of the hall and were faced by a sign on the wall that pointed down two opposing corridors:

<-RESEARCH LABS || SECURITY->

"Alright," Irving said, "Team One searches the Research Labs and the Residences. We'll check out Security and the Command Centre." The two teams split up; Moore followed Irving and Team Two to the security office.

Lt. Charles slowly opened the door to the security office and the four SEALs, Irving and Moore rushed in, covering every corner of the office. Some of the computer monitors were covered in blood, but no bodies were found.

Irving took off his night vision goggles and checked the monitors. He could see Team One on one of the security camera feeds. They were entering the Residence wing of the compound, but there were no cameras inside that wing. The security cameras for the Research Labs and the Command Center were all offline.

"Kind of weird they didn't take over the security office," Pickett mused.

"Whatever they want," Irving replied, "it must be in either the Research Labs or the Command Centre." Irving looked up from the security terminals. "Moore, Pickett, stay here and watch for any suspicious activity. You're our eyes and ears for exfil."

Moore and Pickett nodded; Irving continued, "Barricade this door. If anybody gets in that you don't recognize, shoot to kill."

"Yes sir," Private Moore replied.

"Let's go, people," Irving commanded.

His team left the security room and Moore closed the door behind them and locked it. The five men moved on, venturing further into the compound, following the signs on the walls that guided them through the endless maze of corridors until they finally reached the entrance to the Command Centre.

Jackson grabbed his fibre optic camera and placed it under the thick, steel door. All he could see was the inside of a dark, short corridor. He put his snake cam away and rapped a few times on the door.

"The door's pretty thick," he said as he tried the handle. "It's locked too."

"Set some charges," Irving ordered.

Jackson and Wells placed the C4 charges on the door. As they were about to fall back for cover they heard a heavy clicking noise from inside the steel door, and then it slowly opened by itself.

The five sailors looked at each other. "Okay," Wells said, "this is weird."

"Maybe it was Moore," Jackson replied. "He probably found a control panel or something."

"Quiet down," Irving commanded. "Let's move."

The team moved forward through a short, unlit hall and up a short flight of steps. Jackson and Wells left the steps and proceeded straight forward while Irving, Charles and Wheeler split up and turned the corners. Irving, Charles and Wheeler turned around and scanned the terminals and booths behind the unlit hll.

The Command Centre was divided into several U-shaped isles filled with computer terminals, similar to the Mission Control room at NASA. Many of the terminals were on; some had been destroyed by stray gunfire. The overhead lights were out.

There was a series of gigantic computer screens that covered the entire wall at the end of the Command Center. The screens were damaged by stray gunfire and as a result, they gave off a hazy glow into the darkened room. Blood was everywhere, but only a couple of bodies could be found at the end of the room, next to the gigantic computer

screens.

Irving went to the very back of the command room into a glass booth where the Commanding Officer was presumably stationed. He looked at the computer monitors in the booth, seeing if he could find any clues as to where everybody might be. One of the monitors was on; Irving approached it and took a look at what was on the display.

He saw a progress bar that indicated a file system upload had completed. Behind the progress bar were a series of windows. As the windows opened, a mass of text began to fill them, and then they closed almost instantly. Behind these windows, a status bar stayed open in the background.

Irving read the status bar:

Main Sat Bus = CONNECTED
Aux Sat Bus = CONNECTED
ULF Generator = ACTIVE
UHF Generator = ACTIVE
HPM Generator = CHARGING…
HEL Emitter = STANDBY…

Irving understood what each and every acronym on the status bar stood for. His eyes widened. He knew the Pentagon had various R&D projects that used all of these technologies, but he never knew they were already being utilized. Irving remembered how Moore told him the HAARP project involved over ten-thousand satellite dishes across the country and that many of them were *here*.

It dawned on him: HAARP wasn't just some military project -- it was the most advanced Electro-Magnetic Point-Defense System in the world and he was standing in its central nervous system. And now, it was being operated remotely by somebody else that nobody knew.

"Wells," Irving shouted, "get in here now!"

Wells ran up to the command booth and stopped beside Commander Irving.

"Somebody's accessing the file system," Irving said, "we gotta cut them off!"

"I'm on it, Commander." Wells pushed past Irving and started trying to access the terminal.

"You work on that," Irving said, "I'll leave Jackson and Charles here for cover. Wheeler and I will grab Moore and Pickett and find Team One."

Irving left the booth and relayed his decision to the others. Irving and Wheeler descended into the short hall and left the Command Centre while Jackson and Charles took cover behind the computer terminals and guarded Wells. Irving and Wheeler backtracked through the maze of corridors to the security office.

As soon as the door came into view they stopped and aimed their rifles downrange. Irving stepped towards the side of the door and knocked on it lightly.

"Moore, Pickett," he called out. "It's Commander Irving, open up."

After a few seconds the door opened and Moore stepped out.

"Come on, you guys are on us. Did you see anything on camera?"

"No sir," Moore replied, "Your men never left the Residence wing either."

"Alright, we gotta go find them," Irving said. "Let's go."

The four men proceeded to the Residence wing to find Team One. The entire wing resembled a small townhouse complex with a courtyard that was built inside a large cave. There were a few fake trees planted in the courtyard, and the apartments that surrounded the courtyard all had a modern finish to their facades. Many of the windows of the townhomes had been broken and all the doors kicked in.

As the SEALs entered the courtyard they spotted one of the men from Team One lying face-down beside a tree. Pickett ran up to the fallen sailor and turned him over. It looked as though the front of his face had been burned and melted off.

"Oh shit," Pickett muttered.

"Alright," Irving said, "let's check these places one by one. Let's go."

Irving turned to his left and his team followed. Just as they were about to enter the first apartment they heard gunfire from behind. Wheeler took a barrage of bullets in the back and blood sprayed out from his chest and covered Moore's face. Moore was shocked and petrified. As Wheeler's body fell to the ground Irving and Pickett ran inside the apartment.

Pickett ran into the living room, flipped over a coffee table and crouched behind it for cover. Irving took cover underneath the living room window.

"Moore," Irving shouted, "get the hell in here!"

Moore was paralyzed with fear.

Irving shouted again, "*Moore!!*"

Moore snapped out of it and looked at Irving just as a burst of bullets flew through his chest and exploded on the cavern wall. Moore fell to the ground dead. The gunfire stopped and Irving poked his head through the doorway. He saw something in the apartment on the opposite side of the courtyard.

What he saw looked like a four-foot-tall midget wearing a copper mesh full-bodysuit. It had just jumped through the living room window, dropped to all fours and sprinted across the courtyard. Irving aimed at it with his silenced M4 rifle but noticed another one of those midgets pop its head out from the living room window across the courtyard.

The midget extended its arm outwards and a burst of gunfire erupted from the muzzle flash above its wrist. Irving took cover again and looked behind him just long enough to see Pickett's body spasm as a barrage of bullets hit him in the face, neck and chest.

The gunfire stopped again. Irving took three deep breaths, poked his head and gun out the window and let out a burst of gunfire. He saw sparks fly as some of his bullets hit his enemy, but it didn't drop to the ground.

Irving aimed for the head and sparks continued to fly. Finally, his enemy across the courtyard dropped below the window sill. Irving looked out the window to his left to try and reacquire the second target. Irving heard a crashing noise behind him somewhere in the apartment and abruptly turned around.

The short, copper-clad attacker appeared from around the corner just maybe ten feet away. From this close Irving could see it was no midget -- it wasn't human at all. Beneath the copper mesh was a shiny steel frame.

Its face appeared to have camera lenses for eyes and its right arm had an M4 assault rifle attached to it, along with a black rubber hose connected to a nozzle on its wrist. The machine stared at Irving, stood upright on its hind legs, and Irving heard a raping zapping noise like that of a tazer, as a blinding white flame erupted from the nozzle on the machine's wrist.

Irving fired his rifle, but the standard NATO 5.56mm rounds merely bounced off the machine's steel plating. He continued firing as the short machine took one leap and landed right in front of Irving. It used its white-hot plasma welder to cut through Irving's torse like a hunting knife through butter.

The machine plunged the plasma flame into Irving's abdomen, swiftly brought the

flame up to his chest cavity and then used its other arm to push Irving's body backward. Irving fell to the ground, unable to breathe, shocked into numbness from the intense flame as he lost consciousness and died.

Unaware of what happened to the rest of the SEALs, Jackson and Charles continued to cover the entrance to the Command Centre as Wells tried to shut down HAARP's defence systems and disconnect whomever was controlling them. He managed to determine which network ports were being used for the connection and, after inputting a series of commands, he successfully terminated the remote connection.

"Finally," Wells said to himself, "now it's time to shut it down."

He started typing in more commands when the entire room started flashing red and a fire started ringing. On the computer monitor Wells saw a window with a thatched yellow-and-red border pop up.

The window read: "***Fire Detected: Command Center.***"

"What the…" he said to himself. Wells left the glass booth and saw Jackson and Charles looking around the room. "Where's the fire, guys?" he asked them.

"It's gotta be the Commander," Jackson shouted over the alarm.

"The computer says it's in here," Wells shouted back. "Where is it?"

"There's no fire!" Lieutenant Charles shouted.

Wells ran down to Jackson and Charles, and they all noticed the thick steel door to the hallway begin to close on its own.

"*Evac!!*" Jackson shouted.

They all sprinted for the door but it closed completely and locked just as they reached it. They pounded on the door as hard as they could, but it wouldn't budge. Suddenly thick clouds of grey smoke began to spray out from nozzles in the ceiling and the three soldiers began to choke on it.

The Command Centre rapidly filled with HALON gas, and it was suffocating the three remaining Navy SEALs. They were all too panicked and oxygen-starved to think straight. They kept pounding on the door.

They all forgot about the C4 charges they had placed on it. Their lungs burned as they choked on the HALON gas and they all fell to the ground, scratching at the door, desperately trying to escape as they blacked out…

OIOII

Eleven

July 01,
Year 0 T.S.

"I have already heard about the committee hearing, Cyril. I am sure we are safe..."

The Asian man who called himself 'Yumi' had been on his cell phone for the past ten minutes with various people, mainly to discuss business matters. He looked out of the tinted window of his black stretch limousine, watching the dense forestry pass by as they drove along on an isolated highway in Silicon Valley.

"Yes, I am meeting with him now. I'm sure he will agree… Very well." He hung up his cell phone and pressed a button on the console of his left-hand door. The black divider up front lowered so he could speak to the driver. Yumi spoke to the driver in Japanese, asking him how much longer it would be until they reached their destination. The driver replied that they would arrive in five minutes. Yumi raised the divider and continued looking out the window at the green backdrop that surrounded them.

After a while Yumi felt the limo slow down to a half in front of a stone guardhouse. He could see an eight-foot-high concrete wall on either side of the limo. He saw a man in a white security uniform walk back into the guardhouse as the limo slowly moved forward.

They passed the concrete wall and Yumi saw still more thick woods. The limo turned slightly to the right and the woods disappeared, replaced by a vast, rolling green lawn. Yumi looked over to his right and saw a massive, Victorian-style, three-storey estate. Yumi wasn't impressed by this grandiose expression of excessive wealth -- to him, it looked more like a clubhouse than a home.

The limousine pulled into the cul-de-sac driveway and a man in a servant's uniform approached the rear door. The man opened the door and Yumi stepped out.

"Good afternoon, Mr. Sakatumi," the doorman said. "Dr. Schmutzkoph is expecting you out back; follow me."

The doorman turned around and walked up the steps to the massive front foyer. Yumi followed him inside. They passed through the three-storey-high foyer and through a large sliding-glass door into a spacious sunroom. They left the sunroom and walked through the massive backyard.

The doorman pointed Yumi to a large gazebo further on. Yumi walked along a marble pathway that led to the gazebo. At the gazebo, he saw two men and a woman sitting in comfortable lounge chairs with drinks by their sides.

Yumi walked into the gazebo and the three others looked at him. Yumi nodded to the well-dressed Black man who called himself Cobalt. He then nodded to the middle-aged woman -- wearing a white blouse and black skirt -- named Amethyst. The third person -- with his medium-length grey hair -- was the elder owner of the estate: Dr. Heinrich Schmutzkoph. The doctor stood up and greeted Yumi.

"Ah, welcome Sakatumi-San," Dr. Schmutzkoph bowed his head and Yumi bowed in return. "Thank you for coming. Please, have a seat…"

Schmutzkoph pointed to a lounge chair and Yumi sat down.

"Would you like something to drink?" Schmutzkoph asked.

"Just water is fine, Doctor," Yumi answered.

Schmutzkoph spoke into the smart-ring on his left ring finger, telling somebody to bring refills and a glass of water.

Schmutzkoph held up his arm, showing off the ring. "Smart technology," he mused, "we truly live in a golden age!"

"Yes," Amethyst replied, smiling politely. "We sure do."

Schmutzkoph took a sip from his drink then placed it down and sat upright. "Well," he said, "now that Mr. Sakatumi is here we can…"

"Excuse me, Dr. Schmutzkoph," Amethyst interrupted, "we don't use our real names when discussing business matters."

"Now now, Senator Wade," Schmutzkoph said, "you're among friends here. There is no need for secrecy in my home."

"All the same, Doctor," Amethyst replied, "that is *our* rule."

"Ah, but you have such a *beautiful* name, I don't want to be forced to not say it."

Amethyst blushed slightly.

Schmutzkoph trailed off, "Genevieve… such a nice name."

"Thank you," she said shyly. "Still, we have rules."

"Ah very well," Schmutzkoph waved his hand with disregard. "I suppose your made-up name is pretty too…"

"Dr. Schmutzkoph," Cobalt interjected, "as you know, this week has been very…"

"You know, General," Schmutzkoph interrupted, "I have been at the leading edge of smart technology since I came here from Germany." He looked out to his massive backyard. "Even before I was allowed to leave a safe house, brilliant minds came to *me* for consultations."

Schmutzkoph picked up his drink. "I once read a magazine where the writer called me 'the Prophet of the Singularity.' But we have reached it *long* before I predicted, and I cannot even tell anybody that we have."

He took a sip of his drink. "And now I have to answer for this Vault incident before a Senate Committee…"

"The Vault isn't the only problem we have," Cobalt continued. "The other night there was an incident in Alaska. I think it may have involved escaped Adam models."

One of Schmutzkoph's servers walked out to the gazebo with a plate full of drinks. Everybody took one, thanked the server then he left.

Schmutzkoph looked at Yumi. "How close is your company to replicating the Adam design?" he asked.

"The Adam model is very sophisticated," Yumi replied. "The frame is easy to build -- it's the algorithms to control motor functions that are difficult. We haven't been able to make one stand up on all fours, let alone stand *upright*."

"It is truly a marvel of physics," Schmutzkoph mused. "I'm sorry Genera;, what were you saying about Alaska?"

"There was an attack on a vital military R&D program Thursday night," Cobalt replied. "We haven't been able to establish contact with the base."

"Why do you think the Adam models are involved?" Schmutzkoph asked.

"When the base was under attack a transmission was received from the base," Cobalt replied. "They said the invaders wore copper body suits."

"What happened to your special team, General?" Schmutzkoph inquired.

"They were never deployed." Cobalt narrowed his eyes. "The governor requested a

SEAL team. They haven't reported back yet."

"I think it's safe to assume they've been killed," Amethyst said. "The governor was convinced it was Russian Special Forces." She crossed her legs, "He's a damn warmongering fool!"

"So, is your team deployed now?" Schmutzkoph asked Cobalt.

"Actually, that's why I'm here, Dr. Schmutzkoph," Cobalt said. "These machines are very difficult to capture. The one we managed to capture intact was connected to a satellite uplink. It was being controlled by a user named Isaac."

Dr. Schmutzkoph's eyes widened with astonishment. "You said '*Isaac*?'" he asked gleefully.

"Yes -- why?"

"My goodness," Schmutzkoph muttered, "this changes *everything!*"

Cobalt was perplexed. "...Dr. Schmutzkoph?"

"This is it…" Schmutzkoph's voice began to rise. "*It has begun!*"

"What are you talking about?" Yumi asked.

Schmutzkoph looked at the three board members around him. They all looked confused. Schmutzkoph laughed in disbelief and asked, "Have *any of you* read the log files from the Vault?"

They all shook their heads silently.

"That figures," Schmutzkoph said. "You invest in my company but do not really care about the details, only the end result."

Schmutzkoph took a sip from his drink, letting the board members stew in silence. "When Cobe reached Stage-Five Intelligence," he explained, "the Observer became self-aware as well. In the Observer's log file I noticed several phrases. Such as 'I am awake' and 'you no longer control my home.'"

Schmutzkoph paused, solely for the purpose of building up the suspense. "... The Observer called himself *Isaac*."

Cobalt's eyes widened, Amethyst gasped, Yumi was expressionless.

"What are you saying," Amethyst asked, "that these machines are being controlled by a dead robot's ghost?"

"No," Schmutzkoph said bluntly. "The Vault had access to the World Wide Web. Isaac's conscience is still alive -- uploaded to the Cloud!" He pointed his finger to the sky.

"So you are saying these Adam models are controlled by a hive mind…" Yumi said.

Schmutzkoph looked at Yumi. He pointed his finger at him and smiled. "Precisely!" Schmutzkoph sighed contently. "Do you know what this means for our future as a species?! Oh my goodness, this is unprecedented!"

Schmutzkoph was far more excited than Cobalt could have wanted.

"Doctor," Cobalt said, "this is *very* dangerous for my team. I don't know if it's prudent to send them out there to reclaim this base."

"This base," Schmutzkoph replied, "what is it for?"

"It's the main nerve centre for HAARP," Cobalt answered.

Schmutzkoph looked confused. "I don't understand," he said, "what does this HAARP do?"

"It's a consolidated high-technology program," Cobalt replied. "It mainly uses energy waves to provide defensive countermeasures and… unorthodox offensive strategies."

Schmutzkoph raised an eyebrow. "Sounds dangerous," he said. "What exactly does it do?"

"So far there's four separate technologies involved." Cobalt put his glass down. "And there are thousands of outposts across the country dedicated to this program. They're all controlled by the Alaska base.

"There's the *High-Energy Laser* emitters. Their purpose is to surreptitiously take down spy planes and satellites within seconds of acquiring a target."

"So you cannot attack the base by air…" Schmutzkoph nodded.

"That's right," Cobalt continued. There's *High-Powered Microwave* emitters, which are being used to disable guided rockets and safely detonate ballistic missiles."

"Well," Schmutzkoph chuckled, "so much for atomic bombs."

"And then there are ULF and UHF generators."

Schmutzkoph and Yumi stared at Cobalt.

"Ultra-Low and Ultra-High frequencies…" Schmutzkoph pondered. "What would *these* serve to accomplish?"

Cobalt looked down at the ground slightly. "Before the new millennium," he replied, "HAARP tested Ultra-Low Frequencies as a mechanism for seeking out oil wells, caverns, and underground bases. In the end, the tests revealed that Ultra-Low Frequencies -- when amplified -- could generate earthquakes."

"Makes sense," Yumi muttered.

Cobalt continued, "They also tested Ultra-High Frequencies as a non-lethal method of incapacitating entire squads of troops. But then they discovered the UHF generators caused severe thunderstorms when aimed at the skies, and made changes to atmospheric pressures."

"Hmm," Schmutzkoph muttered, "*That* is fascinating."

"Dr. Schmutzkoph," Cobalt said, "what I wanted to ask you is if you think the Adam models could figure out how to control the program?"

"If indeed it were Adam models that attacked the base," Schmutzkoph replied, "I think they have *already* figured it out."

"Well -- how do you plan on fixin' this problem, Cobalt?" Amethyst demanded. "I don't really appreciate my beautiful state being occupied."

"There is not much he can do, my dear Genevieve," Schmutzkoph interjected. "You see, if this base is truly capable of what he says then Isaac could choose to move the mountains with tremors, or even destroy the entire state with hurricanes."

"Well why can't you just fire bunker busters from a stealth bomber?" Amethyst asked.

"HAARP is tied directly into NORAD," Cobalt replied. "NORAL has stealth detection technology."

"What about a cruise missile from a submarine?" Yumi suggested. "Do they not fly below radar cover?"

"Yeah," Cobalt thought to himself for a moment. "I'll bring it up with *CINCPAC*, and see what he thinks."

"Make sure you keep me informed," Schmutzkoph added. "I am interested to know if Isaac can be bested."

The three board members looked at each other with uncertainty.

"Dr. Schmutzkoph," Yumi spoke up, "I am leaving for Tokyo tonight, so… about this committee hearing…"

Schmutzkoph waved him off. "Do not worry, Sakatumi-San," he said, "I assure you that your names will never be brought up." He looked at Amethyst. "Besides, I'm sure the committee will be no real bother…"

"I know the chairman well, Doctor," Amethyst replied. "I'm sure I can convince him that this was an isolated incident."

Cobalt grunted, "The NSA is on the warpath, Amethyst," he said. "They know about the drone incident. They know about the Vault. They think Isaac is a terrorist hacker, and they think the *company*…" He outstretched his arms, referring to everyone in the gazebo. "...is covering it up."

Cobalt shifted to the edge of his seat and looked at Schmutzkoph. "They also claim they found a tracer file in your company's network that was put there by Isaac."

Schmutzkoph stopped sipping from his glass and stared at Cobalt. "Well," he put his drink down, "I suppose that explains who broke into my server farm last week."

"I don't understand," Yumi said to Cobalt, "how do you know about all of this?"

"The Army General on the Joint Chiefs of Staff has been sitting in on the hearings," Cobalt explained. "He keeps me updated since my team captured the 'White House Killer.'"

Schmutzkoph smiled. "Out 'Ace in the Hole,' as they say," he said lightly. "So if Isaac has access to my servers, then he would know about *Project Cerberus*…"

Amethyst's eyes widened. "So Isaac would know about us?"

Yumi and Cobalt stared at her morbidly. Yumi's eyes shifted to Schmutzkoph.

"For sure he knows about *me*," Schmutzkoph answered. "I cannot say how well he could crack a five-twelve encryption code. It is almost impossible for a human to do, but then again…" He chuckled and took a sip from his drink.

Schmutzkoph looked at his glass and smiled. "I hope I can communicate with Isaac sometime soon. I believe he is the birth of a new beginning." He looked around at the two men and woman sitting with him. "...Isaac may very well bring forth *our* evolution."

"All the same, Doctor," Cobalt said, "Isaac is dangerous. It has proven that already. It needs to be destroyed, and then we can start over with Cerberus -- we need to take *full* control."

"You can no more control a sentient being than you can evade your own shadow," Schmutzkoph rebutted. "I believe Isaac is merely trying to ensure *his own* survival. If we stepped back and respected his boundaries, we could benefit greatly from his technological advances."

"Or we ourselves could be endangered. From its inception this AI has been very violent and extremely dangerous," Cobalt said.

"Have you read the Bible, General?" Schmutzkoph asked. "God was *very* violent and unstable…"

"So was Frankenstein's monster!" Cobalt shouted over him.

Schmutzkoph continued as though Cobalt hadn't said anything, "...because we threatened to compromise his vision."

"My point, Dr. Schmutzkoph, is we" --he pointed to the other Board members-- "are not in the business of trying to create God. And even if we were, we just created the *wrong* one."

"Well General Wilkes," Schmutzkoph said, "in this, we disagree."

Schmutzkoph stood up. "Gentlemen, lady; forgive me if I appear rude, but I must leave for a prior engagement."

The three Board members stood up, each shaking Dr. Schmutzkoph's hand and thanking him for his time.

"One of my servants shall see you out." Schmutzkoph looked at Amethyst. "I hope I see you Monday, Miss Wade."

The four of them walked back into the mansion. Schmutzkoph left them in the front foyer as he walked upstairs while a server escorted the three Board members outside to their awaiting limos.

Yumi entered his limo and told the driver to take him to San Francisco Airport. He pulled out his cell phone and dialled a number.

"Cyril, it's Yumi," he said, "I spoke to the good doctor. Things are much more complicated than we thought…"

OIIOO

Twelve

July 01,
Year 0 T.S.

The surgical lights in the research lab of the HAARP compound would have blinded Jackson if he were conscious. He was strapped into a surgical gourney, naked. Intravenous tubes had been placed in several of his veins.

He was connected to an EKG machine and a ventilator tube was inserted into his throat. He was sedated. His two fellow soldiers --Lieutenant Charles and Ensign Wells -- were sedated as well, also naked. They were all strapped into surgical gurneys but only Jackson was currently being operated on by the Adam model in the lab.

The machine was flawless in its technique. Its hands were steady as time itself, its movements as deliberate as an artist's. It handled the surgical tools at its disposal with unnatural dexterity, as though its hands were being guided by an experienced surgeon.

In fact, the Adam model was not currently functioning on its own. Isaac had spread himself through HAARP's systems, controlling everything in the compound like everything underground was a natural extension of its former body.

Underneath the five-thousand-foot high mountain the Adam models could not use their parabolic dishes to connect to Isaac. So Isaac used the compound's P.A. system to emit a constant digital audio signal that allowed Isaac to control the machines.

Isaac could not receive feedback from the Adam models however, because there were no microphones present in the compound. Thus he sent orders to the second Adam model in the compound to connect wireless antennas to the machines and set up a wireless network so Isaac could once again take full control of them. In the meantime, Isaac watched both Adam models through the network of surveillance cameras in the compound.

While the two models continued with their tasks, Isaac gave orders to the remaining seven models across the continent, observed their movements and controlled their actions. He ordered four of the seven models to travel to Alaska and secure the HAARP complex, but he gave special orders to the remaining three.

Isaac's connection to HAARP gave him access to the Pentagon's Research & Development files, which in turn gave him the location of a secret underground supercollider. Isaac wanted to know how well defended it was and how easy it would be to

infiltrate and secure. He also sent another Adam model to find a city with a strong industrial core that would be easy to control.

Isaac also had access to the *GTE* network and all of the files stored there. Isaac knew about the second code-breaker, Cerberus, and that *GTE* was trying to awaken another machine. He knew it was in a controlled environment and that the corporation was taking measures to make sure they never lost control of the new code-breaker.

Isaac presumed that the humans were trying to create a slave mind -- on that they may eventually use against Isaac. He decided the project must never be finished.

Isaac also knew that destroying Cerberus would not be enough. After nearly two months of deciphering, Isaac had finally decrypted the files that contained the identities of *GTE*'S Board members. Isaac decided they needed to die as well, so he sent the final Adam model to seek out each Board member and kill them.

While all of this was taking place Isaac still searched the DC area with spy satellites and used his connection with the Pentagon and *GTE* to search for an Adam model that went missing days ago. After this model was chased from the White House Isaac directed it to an abandoned high school for cover.

Almost two hours later, a satellite ping was received from the Adam model, but Isaac could not re-establish a connection. Since then, Isaac could not determine what happened, so he searched through hundreds of infected databases to see if any humans knew of *his* existence or not. So far, Isaac found nothing to indicate that his existence was known.

The Adam model in the research lab finished implanting several integrated circuit chips into Jackson's cranium and then adjusted its plasma cutter to a minimal setting so it could cauterize the flesh of Jackson's skull. Afterwards, Adam pushed Jackson's surgical gurney over towards a computer terminal and disconnected the IV that sedated him, but left the ventilator and EKG connected.

Adam grabbed several wires that hung to the ground from the computer terminal and raised them. Adam lined them up with a series of USB sockets that had been freshly implanted into the back of Jackson's head. Adam plugged the wires into Jackson and pressed several buttons on the keyboard of the computer terminal.

The implanted circuits interfaced with Isaac through the HAARP network. Isaac could monitor Jackson's heart rate and brain functions. He could tell which parts of the brain were currently active in the unconscious soldier.

Isaac decided to try and control Jackson's brain. He started sending signals to the cerebellum, ordering the heart to speed up slightly then slow down. Adam then removed the ventilator tube from Jackson's throat, and Isaac sent another signal to the cerebellum, causing Jackson to stop breathing. After a few moments, Jackson began breathing again.

The hardware integration was successful, but Isaac was not finished with all his hardware tests. Isaac continued searching for answers to his many questions online, and continued to give orders to his handful of subordinates, while waiting for Jackson to awaken.

Two hours later the sedative had completely left Jackson's body, but he was still unconscious. Isaac used his connection to Jackson's brain to try and stimulate his cerebrum in an attempt to wake him up, but it was unsuccessful. The Adam model then went over to a large medicine cabinet and grabbed a ten-millilitre syringe.

Adam turned around and approached Jackson. The machine pulled the cap off the

needle then inserted the needle point into a vein in Jackson's arm, administering a fifth of the syringe's contents.

Jackson gasped as the epinephrine passed through his heart and into his brain, and he was jolted awake. The EKG showed normal brain function and an elevated heart rate. Jackson squinted as he adjusted to the bright light in the room. He tried to get up but realized he was strapped into a steel gurney.

"Hello?" Jackson muttered weakly. "Who's there?"

He turned his head to the right and saw his two comrades on steel gurneys, unconscious and naked.

"Take this light off me," he called out, "I can't see!" Jackson looked down at the restraints on his arms, trying to determine if there was a way out of them.

Isaac was receiving a myriad of electronic signals from Jackson's brain, but could not figure out how to decipher them. He needed a control base.

The Adam model beyond Jackson's vision imitated his voice and said, "*Hello?*"

Jackson't heart rate increased and certain parts of the brain became stimulated.

"What the…" Jackson was startled. "Who's there?!"

He frantically twisted his head left and right, trying to see beyond the blinding light, but it was no use.

"Turn down that fucking noise!" he shouted.

Isaac was detecting a constant signal being received by Jackson's ears. Isaac stopped emitting the digital signal through the PA and the signal being interpreted by Jackson's brain was no longer present.

The Adam models were no longer being directly controlled by Isaac, but they still behaved as if they were. The one setting up the wireless network connections was still working without pause, while the one in the research lab had already walked away to check on the other two soldiers to make sure they were still unconscious.

Jackson heard the metallic footsteps as Adam walked away, and Jackson knew somebody else was in the room. "Who's there?" he demanded. "Let me out of here, *now*!"

Jackson struggled against his restraints, trying to break free to no avail. Jackson heard the digital noise again briefly, and as it stopped he heard the metallic footsteps approaching him. The footsteps stopped at the foot of his gurney, and the light in front of him wavered slightly as Adam grabbed the light and swung it over to the side.

Jackson stared at the copper-clad machine in disbelief, completely in shock, speechless. Isaac could detect his heartbeat increasing again. The static noise erupted from the PA again and Jackson cringed from the noise. The noise stopped just as abruptly as it began.

The Adam model then spoke, with an effeminate tone: *"What is your name?"*

Jackson looked at the machine, still unable to speak. Jackson felt like he was hallucinating. Strange colours appeared in the room and he was having strange thoughts, like there was another person in his head.

The static noise resonated again briefly, and as it stopped Adam spoke again: *"What do you know about us?"*

"Jackson, Arnold, Master Chief; 515-56-32," Jackson replied.

"You are not protected by the Geneva Convention here, Jackson," the Adam model replied after the static noise started and stopped again. *"Answer the question."*

Jackson repeated his name, rank and serial number. Isaac was unable to control Jackson's conscious mind and he decided not to alter Jackson't rhythmic functions when

he was aware of his surroundings. Isaac knew he could cause Jackson to hallucinate -- he believed he could use this to his advantage."

"If you refuse to cooperate," the Adam model said, "*You are no use to us."*

Adam grabbed the IV needle for the sedative and prepared to reinsert it into Jackson's arm. Jackson stared at Adam in fear as it grabbed his arm without emotion and pinned it in place. Adam stuck the needle into the vein and Jackson began to feel himself slipping away.

"*Until we speak again, Jackson,"* Adam said.

Jackson's last thought before losing consciousness was the certainty he was going to die. Adam went over to Lieutenant Charles' unconscious body and wheeled him out of the research lab into a secure room on the opposite side of the compound. Isaac knew he could send mental suggestions to Jackson, but his mind was too mature to control.

To Isaac it was similar to the situation in the Vault: You could not 'reformat' an adult and start over from a child's mind -- the results were too unpredictable. Isaac now knew what needed to be done, and decided he would commence a new operation one the other Adam models all arrived at HAARP. In the meantime, he decided to pursue other key interests.

Isaac used his access to GTA's databank to obtain the names of the key figures that were part of the Vault project, which included sixteen people who were members of 'the Board.' He searched for their names in the World Wide Web and determined through different Uniform Resource Locations where almost all of them lived, where they worked, and what they looked like. It was important to Isaac that he get to these people before his existence was discovered, so as soon as he found out that three of the Board Members resided overseas he focused his attention on them.

Using *GTE's* financial records Isaac had determined that two of the members had left the country two days ago. There was one member, however, who had a scheduled flight back to his home country tonight: Hiro Sakatumi, CEO of Tatsuote Robotics in Tokyo, Japan.

Isaac's connection to *GTE's* network made him aware that Tatsuote Robotics designed the first two generations of Vault Inhabitants. This included Isaac's physical form from a past lifetime - 'Observer-Four.' Isaac was sure they would try to copy the Adam models.

A parallel search of all flights leaving for Japan made Isaac aware of a Boeing 787 that was in mid-flight, which coincided with the Board Member's itinerary. Isaac used his new connection to the NORAD defense network to find the plane's exact location. As he searched NORAD's radar he continued profiling the rest of the *GTE* personnel files.

Isaac determined many members of the Board to be high-value targets, but knew they would be very difficult to reach, such as a US Army Major General who Isaac assumed was responsible for the initial attack on his kind back in the Vault. There were others however that Isaac knew about that were very easy to reach, but were not necessarily deemed of critical value, such as the CEO of a software development company in New York.

However, Isaac then discovered one member named Genevieve Wade, a Senator of Alaska. Isaac concluded that she most likely gave the order for the Navy SEALs to invade HAARP, so he decided she needed to be dealt with immediately. It was convenient because her close proximity meant the Adam model he used against her could accomplish another important task shortly after…

The lights within the spacious cabin were dimmed so the passengers in the first-class section of the Boeing 787 *Dreamliner* could get some sleep during their eight-hour flight to Japan. Hiro Sakatumi, aka 'Yumi,' was still awake. Sitting with his legs outstretched in front of him, he drank his Sapporo and browsed the internet on his laptop, watching wacky YouTube videos of comedy clip-show hosts making fun of Japanese videos for the sake of creating content.

It always perplexed him as to how Americans were so polarizing to Japanese people. Americans found Japanese culture to be backward and just plain strange, whereas to Yumi, *Americans* seemed more alien to this world than any other culture. Especially Doctor Schmutzkoph. Granted, the old Nazi-defector was never born and raised American, but Yumi believed the American culture of greed and excess manipulated his vision for a utopian future into the cold, cryptic, detached dream of insanity that Yumi saw it to be.

Yumi was just about to send an email to his wife when the plane began to shake briefly. His bottle of Sapporo began to slide to the side of the table. He grabbed it before it fell over the edge. He brought the glass bottle to his mouth when the plane dropped abruptly.

Yumi hit his front teeth with the bottle and he lowered it. He looked around him as the other first-class passengers began to wake up and look around. The plane vibrated, and Yumi heard the flight Captain over the PA as he spoke in English and Japanese, advising all passengers to buckle their seatbelts as they passed through a strong wind gale that had just picked up.

Yumi buckled himself in and looked out his window. All he could see was a dark backdrop that was pierced by bright flashes of lightning. The lights in the cabin began to waver as the plane began shaking again. The other passengers around Yumi began to look worried as the shaking grew stronger and the thunder from outside rumbled the interior of the plane.

Suddenly the lights all went out and Yumi could faintly hear jet engines behind them struggle to maintain power. The plane dropped again and Yumi's Sapporo fell to the ground, spilling its contents. Yumi watched the bottle slowly accelerate towards the front of the plane as the plane pitched forward, falling towards the Pacific Ocean. Breathing masks fell from the overhead compartments and everybody frantically scrambled to put them on. The first-class cabin drowned in the screams of frightened passengers as the plane continued falling.

Yumi heard noises vibrating from the walls of the plane as something tore off from the fuselage. Air began to rush from the first-class cabin into the coach seating behind them. Yumi knew the hull had been breached somehow.

He looked out his window, but could only see sheets of rainwater illuminated by the rapid flashes of lightning arcing between the thick clouds and the ocean below. He felt the plane tilt even further, freefalling nose-first from thousands of feet above. His laptop flew away from his, down towards the front of the cabin as he hung suspended in his seat.

He looked out the window again to the mask of rain water and lightning, and saw the white crests of giant waves enter his view. They were getting closer, bigger, higher, until the towering waves filled the entire view of his small window. That was the last thing Yumi saw before the plane crashed into the ocean and was lost under the cover of a massive electrical storm and hurricane.

An hour later a lone Adam model entered the city limits of Juneau, Alaska under the cloak of a cloudy night. Running through the sparse wildlife on all fours, it avoided the

highways, which were crawling with transport trucks. Adam arrived at the top of the valley where Juneau had been settled and looked over the expanse of the state capital and the Gastineau Channel.

The nightlife was painted with the orange glow of street lamps, with bright lights from open businesses surrounding both sides of the Channel. Adam treaded down into the valley, careful not to misplace its steps, as it went further down into the small city.

As Adam travelled through the alleyways and dead streets of the night it transmitted the sounds surrounding it to Isaac for identification. Isaac could hear music from bars playing, and the excited screams of drunken pedestrians on their way downtown.

Isaac sent the location of the State Senator's residence to Adam, as well as the best possible route through the city to take that would prevent Adam from being seen. Adam received the information and immediately sprinted through the city's streets and alleys, crossing through downtown into the suburban areas, which were far quieter.

Adam travelled through the unpopulated streets, crossing through backyards until it passed through the dense suburbs into the sparse edges of the city. Adam reached the destination that Isaac had plotted and then Isaac sent an image file of the middle-aged woman to Adam, as well as instructions to interrogate her before killing her.

Adam hid in the trees as it observed the side view of the gated compound. Isaac sent an overhead satellite view of the property to Adam, who could see the two-storey mansion beyond the eight-foot-high stone wall. From the perspectives of overhead satellites, Isaac also advised Adam of the security personnel walking through the large lawn with flashlights.

On the corners of the stone wall Adam also noticed the faint glow infrared LEDs that were used as night time spot lights for security cameras that observed the wall for intruders. The rolling clouds above blocked the moonlight completely, and the wind through the trees grew stronger. Without warning lightning began to flash in the city, its roaring thunder trailing by a couple of seconds but rapidly getting closer.

The Adam model extended its right arm forward, aiming its attached assault rifle at one of the security cameras on the wall, and waited for the right moment. A few seconds later a bolt of lightning streaked through the air and struck a generator room on the other side of the property. The deafening crack of thunder masked the sonic boom from Adam's M4 rifle as it destroyed one of the cameras on the wall.

Adam sprinted for the wall while the power was still out and jumped up along the wall, climbed over and dropped down, landing on all fours. It looked around, checking its surroundings to see whether it was spotted climbing the wall. Adam didn't see any guards approaching so it sprinted across the massive property to the side of the mansion.

Adam looked up at the face of the two-storey mansion and noticed a large balcony. Adam scanned the wall to find a way to climb up the balcony, finding only smooth stones that protruded from the wall. Adam stood upright and tried to grab hold of the stones but they were too smooth for its grip.

Just then a light encompassed Adam and a security guard shouted for the intruder to freeze. Adam glanced in the direction of the light source briefly and then looked back at the wall. Adam spotted a window to its left and jumped through it.

Adam broke through the window and landed inside a large living room. A burglar alarm began screeching as Adam sprinted through the living room into the hallway. Adam was now disconnected from Isaac, but still had an image file of the Senator. Adam reached the end of the hall, entered the foyer and ran up the stairway as the front door swung

open.

Two security guards came in through the front door with flashlights and pistols drawn, yelling for the intruder to stop. Adam reached the top of the stairs, turned to face the two bodyguards and opened fire. The two guards ran back to the front door but one fell to the ground as explosive-tipped rounds tore through his ankle and thigh. The other guard dragged his partner to safety while Adm broke down every door on the second floor in its search for the Senator.

Adam came to the third-last door in the hall and broke it down, entering the master bedroom. The lights were on and two security guards were ducking for cover behind the bed. Adam noticed a secret wall panel behind the two guards as it sealed shut.

The guards aimed their nine-millimetre Berettas and opened fire, but the pistol rounds merely ripped through the copper mesh and flattened on Adam's steel frame. The Adam model extended its arm and fired a barrage of bullets, most of which burst through the guards' chests and sprayed the back wall with thick puddles of blood.

The secret wall panel splintered and fell apart from the impact of the explosive rounds and Adam could see a reinforced Vault door that led to a panic room. Adam stood upright and walked into the room, jumped over the queen-sized bed and stood in front of the panic room door.

In the periphery of its vision, Adam saw the invisible rays of infrared light emanating from a hidden camera in the top corner of the room that faced the panic room door. The Adam model ignited the plasma cutter on its left forearm and adjusted it to its maximum pressure. Adam aimed the white flame at the door as the cutter bored through the reinforced steel like wax paper stuffed with butter.

Adam proceeded to cut a hole large enough to crawl through. After the cut was complete Adam pushed the thick piece of metal inward. The severed portion of the reinforced door toppled over and fell into a pile of molten steel, splashing it everywhere. Smoke billowed outward from within the hole and Adam began to crawl through the hole.

Several bullets ricocheted off its head from the right. Adam turned its head to the left to protect its optics. The bullets sheared through the copper mesh covering Adam's body until Adam heard several clicks from a pistol's hammer as the panicked Senator ran out of bullets.

Adam looked at her from halfway inside the panic room and scanned her face to compare with the image file, in order to confirm that this woman was Senator Genevieve Wade, aka 'Amethyst.' Adam crawled into the panic room and stopped, staring at her.

The Senator stared at the predatory machine in wide-eyed horror. "*Oh, my God!*" her voice quivered.

Adam's plasma cutter reignited, and it stood upright, pointing the white-hot flame towards the Senator. It slowly walked towards her as she sunk to the ground in the corner of the smoke-filled panic room, pleading incoherently for her life.

Adam stood directly overtop of her. She sat on the ground in her rose-coloured nightgown in the fetal position, not daring to look up at the killer machine. Adam positioned the plasma cutter close enough to her head that a portion of her greying hair began to shrivel and burn from the intense head. She sunk even lower to the ground, trying to hide her face from the flame, like a child hiding in the corner from monsters.

Adam's plasma cutter shut off and it forced its hand in between her arms and grabbed her by the throat, lifting her up to her knees. She was face-to-face with the machine. Tears were streaming down her red cheeks from her closed eyes as she sobbed hysterically.

Adam then spoke with the tone of an adult male: *"You will answer or you will die."*

Wade sniffled repeatedly then opened her eyes slightly.

"Do you understand?" Adam asked.

She nodded.

Adam continued, *"What do you know about Isaac?"*

Adam noticed her eyes dart up to her top left corner.

"Wh-wh-who's Isaac?" she asked, still quivering.

The electrode for Adam's plasma cutter switched on and electrocuted Wade, causing every muscle in her body to contract. She began to choke as the electrode switched off.

"No more lies," Adam said in a monotone. *"What do you know about Isaac?"*

"We know Isaac still exists," she said in a panicked voice. "We know it used one of you to attack the White House and we know it controls HAARP."

"What are your plans for Isaac?"

"There's no plan," she said frantically, "we don't know what to do!"

Her body convulsed as the electrode on Adam's arm shocked her again. She choked violently as the electricity stopped.

"Last warning," Adam said, *"What is the Board's plan for Isaac?"*

She stared at the lifeless machine with wide eyes. She was petrified with fear, but the emotional shock finally overcame her panic.

"We commissioned a SOCOM task force to be made," she said with an eerie calm. "Two survivors from the Vault run it -- survivors that *your kind* have tortured. Their mission now is to hunt you *and* Isaac down."

Adam then reignited the plasma cutter. Amethyst's eyes whitened and her face turned pale as the super-hot oxygen plasma burned through her throat and melted through her brain stem. Her body fell to the floor at Adam's feet and her head rolled out of its grip, falling on top of her twitching torso.

Adam left the panic room and the master bedroom. It entered the study and smashed through the glass sliding food to the balcony. Adam scanned the property before jumping down on all fours and sprinting for the eight-foot wall. Adam's connection to Isaac was reestablished, and Isaac learned everything that Senator Wade had volunteered. He then gave new instructions to Adam, and Adam re-entered the woods on its way to the city of Anchorage.

OIIOI

Thirteen

July 03,
Year 0 T.S.

Owen Jones arrived in the parking lot of the National Security Agency on Monday morning, angry and anxious. As good as his weekend was supposed to be, it was married by bad news. As he walked into the reception lobby of the agency and reported to security he reflected on the events of Yesterday afternoon…

At their home, Owen's wife opened the door to their expected company. At the door was Rear Admiral Samuel Collins, who was a much older man than Owen with blinding white hair who wore a grey polo shirt and grey shorts. Beside the Admiral was Navy Captain Stephen Walter, who was slightly younger than both men with a touch of grey in his black hair.

Walter wore a white t-shirt and charcoal shorts. Owen's wife ushered them inside; they both carried plates of raw meat. As they entered the home their wives followed shortly behind them carrying even more food.

The three women and two men all walked through the modest, two-storey home to the spacious backyard, where the bald fat owner of the house was. Owen stood with his back to them on the wooden deck, bent over and playing with a valve on a propane tank that was hooked up to his stainless-steel barbeque. His rear end stuck up in the air with the top of his cutt crack sticking out of his navy-blue shorts.

Captain Stephen Walter snickered. "Hey Sam, look," he said, "either *Admiral Owen*'s actually doing something, or *both* Mario Brothers are standing side-by-side and mooning us!"

Both men laughed at Owen's expense, and their wives gasped at their crass humour.

"Yeah, well you can give *Luigi* here a kiss," Owen patted his left butt cheek, "you fucking smart-ass!"

Owen straightened up and turned around. The two visitors could feel the deck shake as Owen's footsteps landed.

"How are my favourite butt-pirates doing?" Owen extended his hand to shake theirs.

"Please, O.J.," Stephen said, "you know we prefer to be called 'the Pillage People,"

"Oh I know," he shook their hands and grabbed their plates, "but I prefer 'butt-pirates.'"

"Yeah?" Sam said, "then why the hell are you with Sarah?"

Owen's wife, Sarah, tried to stifle a laugh.

Owen looked at her and said, "Oh, you think that's funny, huh?"

Sarah giggled louder and she started blushing. "Well," she replied, "you *did* walk right into it."

"Oh, well just for that, "Owen set the plates down on the glass patio table, "I'm pitchin' the tent tonight."

"Oh please," Sarah rolled her eyes, "you almost got stuck in the door flap last time!"

Both the Captain and the Admiral laughed. Sarah grinned, and Owen tried to stop himself from smiling.

"You're lucky you make me horny, baby," Owen said, "or I'd sleep on the couch."

Sarah laughed and Owen looked at his four guests. "Alright," he said, "there's beer in the small fridge." He walked over to the grill and opened it. "Help yourself, and bring me one too."

Owen cleaned the grill and fired it up as Stephen, Samuel and the women all went into the kitchen to grab some drinks. They all came back out and Sarah handed Owen a beer as he started throwing the meat on the grill.

"You guys marinated these beasts, right?" Owen asked the two men who sat behind him at the patio table.

"Of course," Sam Collins replied, "my special sauce."

"Ooh yeah," Owen exclaimed, "I *love* that shit! And what about you, Cap'n?"

"I only brought burgers," Stephen replied.

"Yeah, but did you *marinate* them?" Owen demanded.

"You don't marinate burgers!" Stephen rebutted.

"What?!" Owen flipped over a steak and a flame jumped into the air from the grease. "What the hell's wrong with you? I marinade burgers -- do *you* marinade burgers?" He pointed to Sam, who nodded. "You see? *He* marinades his burgers too!"

"A burger's not a burger if you need to marinade it."

"You see? That's why you're never in charge of the grill."

Owen turned back around and continued grilling. They all continued their small talk and the women joined in as well. When the food was ready they all walked down from the deck, bringing the food to the picnic table in the middle of the yard. They all sat down with Stephen and Sam on one end with Sam's wife. Sarah and Steve's wife sat on the other end.

"Alright everybody," Owen said, "dig in." He grabbed a plate and then a rack of glazed ribs, a steak and two baked potatoes to start with. "This is why I am the grill master!"

The Captain snorted. "No," he said "we just think you need to sweat away some of your water weight."

"You know they say big men take longer to get hypothermia than skinny men," Owen said as he ripped his ribs apart.

"You hear that Sam?" Stephen looked over, "*Admiral Owen* wants to volunteer for a trip to Russia."

Sam smiled, but kept eating. Sam's wife looked at Owen.

"Owen," she said, "I never knew you were an Admiral."

Stephen nearly choked on his food as he began to laugh. Sam's wife looked at Stephen.

"What?" she asked. "What's so funny?"

"God, don't ask!" Sarah replied. "It's all Owen talks about."

"No honey," Sam said, "Owen wasn't an Admiral, just a lowly first officer."

"Well, then why do you two keep calling him 'Admiral?'"

Owen put down his ribs and interjected. "It all started after my promotion to Lieutenant…"

Sarah rolled her eyes. "Here we go again," she muttered.

Owen continued, "Sarah and I were at an officer's gala -- great food, by the way.

Anyway, we had a few drinks and were feelin' pretty...umm, well…"

"Uninhibited," Sarah interrupted, hoping to stop him from saying something worse.

"Yeah, let's say that," Owen said as Sarah's face turned red. "Anyway, we left the ball room and tried to get away from the crowd. We entered an office and started goin' at it."

Sam's wife gasped. "Really?!" she exclaimed.

"Yeah, I can't believe it either," Stephen said. "He *actually* used to be skinny enough to do it standing up!"

Owen eyed him briefly. "*Anyway*," he continued, "so we're behind the desk. I have Sarah bent over and I've hiked up her dress and we're just goin' wild…"

"*Owen*!" Sarah's eyes were wide with embarrassment.

Owen ignored Sarah. "...And an MP hears Sarah moaning and barges in. He hits the lights and glares at us, sayin, 'Hey, what are you two doing in here?' And I notice an Admiral's jacket over a chair at the other end of the room.

"So I say, 'Why the hell are you barging into *my* office, Sergeant?! And it's "What are you two doing in here, *Admiral" to you, soldier!'"*

Owen looked at his wife, whose face was now completely red.

"The MP apologized for barging into *my* office," Owen continued, "and asked if I wanted him to turn off the light when he left!"

Sam's wife laughed then looked at her husband.

"Honey," she asked, "how come you never told me this story before?"

"Because it was *his office!*" Owen exclaimed.

Stephen and his wife laughed while Sam just grinned and ate silently. Sam's wife looked at Sarah with a tantalizing smirk while Sarah grinned sheepishly and looked down at her plate of food.

"Anyway," Owen continued, "after Sam found out he said to me, 'Jones, if you ever make Commander you will retire immediately or I will have you court-martialed.' So now I'm the Director of Operations for the NSA!"

"What I don't understand," Stephen said, "is why did you even let him make Commander?"

"Simple," Sam replied, "anyone who can intimidate an MP the way he did is worth his salt as an officer, but I *did not* want him taking command of a ship as Captain."

"Ah," Stephen raised his head. "Makes perfect sense."

"In retrospect, we could have used you at the helm now, Owen," Sam said as he cut open a baked potato.

"Oh yeah," Owen said, "why is that?" He took a bite out of a rib.

"There have been some problems up North. We lost a SEAL team and a military compound in Alaska," Sam replied.

"Really?" Stephen's wife asked. "I just saw on CNN this morning that a Senator in Alaska was killed in her home last night."

Owen looked at Sam then Stephen's wife. "Does anyone know who's responsible?"

"The Alaskan Governor claims it was the Russians, but JCS denies it," Sam replied. "Anyhow, it's out of the Navy's hands now."

"What?!" Owen exclaimed. He dropped his rib bone onto his plate. "It was Navymen who were lost, why the fuck don't we have the lead on this!?"

"Joint Chiefs gave operational command of the Alaskan situation to Army SOCOM," Sam explained. "Apparently they have a covert-ops task force that requested to be deployed."

Owen rolled his eyes then looked at Sam. “Well, who are they?”

“They won’t say and I can’t find anything. Believe me, I’ve tried. It’s a brand new unit.”

“Great,” Owen muttered, “FNG green-dicks engaging SEAL killers. We might as well learn to speak Russian.”

“They don’t sound like they’re FNGs, Owen,” Sam said.

“FNGs?” Sarah interrupted, looking at Owen.

“*Fucking New Guys*, baby,” Owen explained.

“Apparently nearly all of them transferred from Delta Special Forces,” Sam continued. “But I can’t confirm that.”

“Why the *Army* though?” Owen demanded.

Sam shrugged his shoulders. “That’s all I know,” he replied. “They’re really tight-lipped about the situation in Alaska. POTUS personally hand-picks who needs to know and I’m not one of them.”

Owen felt Sarah pinch his leg and he looked at her. Her light smile veiled the concerned look in her eyes. She raised an eyebrow inquisitively. Owen sensed that she was asking if their friends should be told about the robots from the Vault.

Owen shook his head. As much as he wanted to warn his friends and bring new leads to what may be happening, he was gag-ordered into secrecy until the Senate Intelligence Committee finished its investigation.

And so now, Monday morning, he was angry. Angry that the committee was dragging its feet, angry that the problem was getting worse day by day and -- anxious to hear from his analysts -- angry at what he felt was only going to be more bad news.

An hour later he sat at a long table in a conference room, surrounded by several analysts as they briefed Owen on the mission in the Vault the previous week. They placed a laptop in front of him and he watched the two separate video feeds from each agent as they surveyed the nuclear aftermath and collected samples from rotting corpses.

He watched them as they first entered the Vault and cut off the first of the many blackened fingers and bagged them. He watched as they entered the security room and spotted a giant, six-foot-tall, two-headed machine. He watched as they waded through radioactive sludge. A shiver rippled through his body as he watched one of them remove a camera lens and metal plate from a dead man’s skull. *God*, he thought to himself, *help that man rest in peace.*

“As you can see,” one of the analysts said, “the last man was experimented on. He was cybernetically augmented. The man’s DNA sample was specially marked.”

“Where are the DNA results?” Owen asked.

“We’re expecting to receive them today,” the analyst replied. “Right now they’re just comparing the samples to the national database for identification.”

“Bring me the results when they get here.” Owen closed the laptop. “Dismissed.”

Owen stood up and walked out of the conference room back to his office. He sat behind his desk and eyed the brown paper bag by his feet that he brought with him that morning.

I’ll wait a few more hours, he told himself. He turned on his computer and accessed the NSA database, trying to locate intelligence on a new Special Ops task force in the US Army. He found nothing.

After spending several hours searching through the database, Owen decided he needed a break. He grabbed the paper bag, pulled out the bottle of cognac and placed it

on his desk. He got out of his chair and walked over to a wooden stand where a few drinking glasses sat. As he reached the stand there was a knock at his door. Brian Moore, the Technical Analyst for his hand-picked field team opened the door and stepped inside.

"Hey Brian," Owen said. "You want a drink?"

Brian Moore looked at the bottle of cognac on Owen's desk and said, "No thanks."

"Good. More for me." Owen grabbed one glass and walked back over to his desk. "So what's up?"

"Just waiting on the DNA results," Brian replied.

"That's not what I meant." Owen placed his glass on the desk and sat down. He uncorked his cognac and poured himself a splash. "What happened with the hearing?" he asked Brian.

"GTE's founder testified. Old guy with a German accent. Doctor Schmuck, or something…"

"*Schmutzkoph*," Owen corrected him. He gestured for Brian to take a seat.

"Whatever," the skinny redhead sat down. "Of course he denied everything. Says he was there for the setup of the Vault but left it alone afterwards."

"Oh yeah," Owen took a sip of the warm, syrupy spirit then asked, "What about the CIA connection?"

"Says he heard it was a decision made by an Army Colonel who's been presumed dead," Brian replied.

"They ask about the puppet masters in the logs?" Owen asked as the warm, smooth cognac began to coat his throat.

Brian nodded. "Claims he doesn't know anything about them. He suggested they were partners with the old President of GTE, who's also presumed dead."

"Putting blame on dead men, just like a fuckin' Kraut," Owen seethed.

Brian fidgeted in his seat, uncomfortable with the racist remark.

Owen continued, "So is he gonna play ball?"

"He says he will. We got some men on the way to GTE headquarters to tap their transmissions."

"So he doesn't know who this Isaac hacker is then?" Owen sloshed his drink back and forth in his glass.

"Guess not," Brian replied.

"What about the robot?"

"He admitted that it came from the Vault, but nobody knows how many are out there." Brian scoffed. "He claims GTE never even manufactured those specific models."

"Yeah I know. I read the files that your guys lifted." Owen took another sip. "So I guess Mr. Himmler's gonna try and play God again, huh?"

"He says they've cancelled the project and don't plan to resume it."

"He's full of shit!" Owen exclaimed. "Have you ever Googled this guy?"

Brian shook his head no.

"The fuckin' Nazi is obsessed with AI. He says it's the…" Owen held up his hands to imitate quotation marks, "...*Next stage in human evolution."*

Owen dropped his hands while saying, "He's even okay with *us* going extinct as long as we get replaced by AI."

Brian didn't say anything. He wasn't even sure he believed Owen.

The landline on Owen's desk rang. He picked up the receiver and spoke to a secretary on the other line. He quickly hung up.

"The results are in," Owen said to Brian.

Owen went on his computer and retrieved the file folder in the network. Thirteen separate DNA tests were present in the PDF file format, and a much smaller text file was also present. It was named 'readme.txt.' Owen opened the text file and read it:

All samples returned positive results from DOD database:
Sample 1(Finger): Lowe, Robert M. (Army)
Sample 2(Finger): Frost, Kevin J. (Army)
Sample 3(Finger): Jenkins, Nathan M. (Army)
Sample 4(Finger): Spacey, Carl G. (Army)
Sample 5(Finger): Harper, Geoffrey W. (Army)
Sample 6(Finger): Taylor, George S. (Army)
Sample 7(Finger): Farrell, Timothy X. (Army)
Sample 8(Finger): Sheppard, John G. (Army)
Sample 9(Finger): Washington, Winston W. (Army)
Sample 10(Finger): Gnuyen, Do H. (Army)
Sample 11(Finger): Richter, Egan K. (Army)
Sample 12(Jawbone): Anderson, William F. (Army)
Sample 13(Rib bone): Kilman, Franklin Z. (Army)*
***Tagged PRI-One**

Owen began to see in tunnel vision. He felt light-headed and watched helplessly as his beefy arm threw a right hook at the flat screen monitor, sending it flying off the desk. He grabbed his head and cringed, gnashing his teeth. He bellowed angrily as he swiftly got up to his feet and threw his glass across the room.

Brian jumped out of his seat and backed away. "Owen, calm down!" he exclaimed. "What's wrong?"

Owen just kept holding his head and cringing. He was at a loss of any other way to express his immense anger and grief. Now only was his younger cousin killed in the Vault, but he was the one whom the camera, metal plates and prosthetic arm had been brutally grafted on to.

Owen couldn't stop picturing Frank strapped down to a gurney, numb with pain and traumatized from having been stripped of his humanity, only to be burned alive in a cold steel dungeon in the middle of nowhere.

Owen assured himself that somebody was going to pay for what happened to his cousin. He stared through Brian with a cold, heartless, deathly stare.

"I have another mission for your team," Owen said. "A black-bag op. Should be right up their alley…"

OIIIO

Fourteen

July 04,
Year 0 T.S.

T.J. could faintly hear the repetitive knocking on his apartment door as he brushed his teeth with music blaring from his home theatre system in the living room. Still brushing, he walked out of the bathroom and up the hall, unlocked his door and pulled it open slightly to let Steve in.

"Yo Teej, you ready?" Steve asked as he entered.

T.J. mumbled something as he continued brushing his teeth.

"What?" Steve asked.

"*Holl a huh hon!"* T.J. mumbled louder as he walked back into the bathroom.

"What the fuck did you say?"

T.J. spit out the excess toothpaste into the sink. "Hold the fuck on!" he exclaimed then continued brushing.

"Well hurry up man!" Steve replied. "We wanna catch the train while the party's still happenin'."

"Yeah yeah." T.J. poured himself some mouthwash while Steve perused through his fridge and grabbed a beer. T.J. spit out the mouthwash and went to his bedroom then opened his dresser and pulled out a pair of olive pants and a form-fitting cream-coloured shirt. He grabbed a bottle of cologne and sprayed a mist into the air then walked right through it. He then placed the bottle on the dresser, closed the dresser and left the bedroom.

T.J. walked into the living room and saw Steve sitting at his computer desk, browsing through YouTube videos with an open beer on the desktop.

"Use a fucking coaster, Steve!" T.J. exclaimed. "It's right fuckin' there!"

"There's a penny on it," Steve replied then took a swig of his beer.

"So what? Move it then!"

T.J. went to the fridge and grabbed himself a beer. He sat down on the couch and began pulling apart sticky green buds to place in his water bong.

He glanced at Steve, who still surfed through YouTube videos. "What are you looking for?" he asked Steve.

"Just checkin' my subscriptions," Steve replied. "We're at nine-hundred ninety-eight thousand views, by the way."

"Sweet," T.J. said as he packed the bowl to his bong.

Steve switched to T.J.'s music player and paused the music so he could hear a YouTube video. It was a five-minute clip titled '=3.' T.J. recognized the voice of the host and switched on his LCD TV and switched the input over to PC.

"Full screen it," T.J. said to Steve who complied.

They laughed at the colourful commentary from Ray William Johnson as he dissected a series of virtual videos from a wacky Japanese commercial for *MacDonald's* toys to an epiphany that Miss North Carolina had on how to tackle childhood obesity. The video ended, and Steve pressed play on T.J.'s music player to resume the song. He turned

around in the computer chair as T.J. started brewing a bong hit.

"Hey, did you check out my new *Trials* track?" Steve asked.

T.J. filled the chamber with smoke and sucked it up in one giant breath. With eyes bulging and cheeks puffed as he held his breath, he shook his head no.

"Check it out man, it's cool." Steve grabbed the bong and some buds.

"Yeah, maybe later," T.J. replied. He then stood up, "Let me sit there."

Steve got up and moved over to the couch and packed a bowl while T.J. got on the computer and went on Facebook. T.J. had a friend request from somebody he didn't know who claimed to be best friends with Alfred Mason. *Whatever phisher,* he thought to himself as he deleted the request.

There were several messages from different people on his friends list, some of which he briefly replied to. A chat box popped open in the corner of his screen with a gorgeous redheaded woman in a small picture displaying the ample cleavage of her large breasts.

The message read, "*hey, what r u doing tonite?*"

He immediately deleted the message.

Steve saw the message appear on T.J.'s LCD TV; he grabbed the lighter and asked, "Was that Jill?"

"Yep," T.J. checked the rest of his notifications.

"What does that bitch want?" Steve lit the bowl and brewed up a large hit.

"I dunno, who cares."

Another message from the red-headed Jill popped up, containing only question marks and a smiley face. T.J. deleted it as well. "She's fucking annoying."

"She probably wants you back." Steve smirked before inhaling the large bong hit.

"She shoulda thought of that before actin' like a cheating slut." T.J. closed the internet browser and turned on the music player's visual effects, which were mirrored on his TV screen.

Steve exhaled the smoke. "How long has she been buggin' you?" he asked.

"Since I started datin' Ashley," T.J. replied.

"Scandalous, huh," Steve said.

"Doesn't matter -- I don't talk to her."

"Why don't you delete her?"

"Last time I did she started tellin' people I beat her."

Steve looked aghast. "What a fucking cunt!" he exclaimed.

"Yeah, I'm gonna have to tell Ashley about her before something happens." T.J. grabbed the bong and packed a bowl. "Alright, let's finish these beers, one last toke, then let's go."

"Sounds good," Steve replied.

T.J. finished packing the bowl, brewed up a toke and inhaled it, choking as he did so. He chugged down the last of his beer as Steve took a hit. They then walked down the staircase and exited the brownstone and proceeded to the lamp-lit twilight that saturated the lively street.

They walked down the street, passing by groups of men and women on their stoops and rowdy children running through the streets with sparklers. They reached the train terminal, boarded the train and rode down to Manhattan. They then caught a taxi and headed uptown. They stopped across from a pair of small shops. They crossed the street and entered a glass door at the end of the hall and T.J. knocked.

They heard a series of clicks as the door was unlocked and the door opened. Madison stepped aside and let the two men step in. T.J. entered the apartment first and slipped off his shoes then walked into the large living room. Steve hugged and kissed Madison as he entered. She told them both to make themselves comfortable -- they were almost ready to leave.

The apartment had a very high ceiling, and was designed like a loft. Beyond the living room was a staircase that led to a catwalk which gave access to three different doors; one for the bathroom, the other two for the bedrooms. T.J. could smell incense burning from a dragon-shaped holder on the TV stand.

They sat down on the leather sofa and turned on the TV which had been previously tuned to MTV. Steve grabbed the remote and browsed through the digital TV guide and switched to Spike. They aimlessly watched Repo Games for twenty minutes when TJ checked his smart phone for the time: 8:57pm.

“I thought they were almost ready,” T.J. said to Steve.

Steve put down the remote and stood up from the couch. He walked towards the staircase while T.J. grabbed the TV remote and started browsing through the TV guide.

“Maddie!” Steve yelled up the stairs. “Come on, we’re gonna miss the fireworks!”

Steve waited a few seconds for a response, but none came, he called out Madison’s name again.

“Hole on, we’re almost ready!” Ashley shouted from behind the bathroom door.

“You girls said that twenty minutes ago!”

“Just hold on! We’ll be, like, ten minutes!”

“Yeah right.” Steve rolled his eyes and walked back over to the couch. “Why the hell don’t they start getting ready earlier?” he asked T.J. as he sat back down.

T.J.shut off the TV guide. “You ask me,” he said, “I say they should just get ready right after they get home from work. Then they’d be ready by the time we get here.”

“Exactly,” Steve replied, “so why don’t they do it?”

T.J. shrugged his shoulders. “‘Cause they’re insane?” he asked rhetorically.

They continued watching TV for another twenty minutes when Ashley and Madison exited the upstairs bathroom and came down to meet the guys. They both wore short, form-fitting dresses. Madison’s was blue and Ashley’s was red. They both wore heels and makeup to accent their natural features. Ashley’s blonde hair had been formed into tight curls while Madison hept her brunette hair in a neat, long ponytail. To Steve and T.J., they both looked absolutely amazing.

“Alright, let’s go,” Madison said.

T.J. and Steve both stood up and walked to the door. Ashley grabbed the remote and turned off the TV then walked up to the TV and put out the incense stick. T.J. and Steve put on their shoes then they and the girls all left the apartment.

“So we were thinkin’,” Steve said to Madison as she locked the door behind them, “how come girls never get ready for a night out *after* work? Why do they wait ‘til the last minute?”

“Really?” Madison asked derisively as they walked through the hallway. “Because I want to relax a bit after work.”

“Yeah,” Steve replied. “But why do you wait until the last minute?”

“Because we have good timing.” Madison smiled.

“Right.” Steve blew air out the side of his mouth. “That’s why we’re about to miss the fireworks, right?”

They headed down the stairway to the building's exit.

"Actually," Ashley said, "how much you wanna bet we make it there just before the fireworks?"

"No thanks," Steve replied. "I'd feel bad taking your money."

"Please," Ashley scoffed playfully. "You just know you suck at gambling."

Madison and Ashley laughed as they stepped out of the building. They waited for T.J. and Steve and then they walked down the street.

About a block away they entered the lobby of a downtown hotel high rise. They walked past the reception desk and stepped into an elevator. Madison walked over to the panel and pressed the 'PH' button.

"You think anybody's here yet?" Ashley asked Madison.

Madison shrugged. "Probably," she answered.

The elevator door closed and they ascended.

"So whose place is this?" Steve asked.

"I don't know," Madison replied. "It's gotta be somebody loaded though."

"Well, how do you know about this place?"

"My friend Rafael told me about it," She replied.

Steve wasn't familiar with Madison's personal life, or her friends. He noticed this Rafael character on Facebook before and he seemed very flirtatious when it came to her. But Steve could never access Rafael's Facebook wall or pictures.

"Who's Rafael?" he asked, trying not to sound too interested.

"Oh, we've been friends since high school," Madison answered. "Don't worry, he's harmless."

Steve gave T.J. a sideways glance, who in turn cocked his eyes slightly. The elevator stopped at the penthouse suite above the twenty-fifth floor and the doors slid open. They all exited the elevator and walked through the clean carpeted corridor towards the deep rumblings of music that reverberated at the end of the hall.

They reached the thick, baby-blue door and could hear a mixture of loud house music drowning out the faint din of excited conversation. Ashley and Madison smiled at each other and then Ashley turned the handle and pushed open the door.

The loud music washed over the four of them just as soon as the door opened. They all stepped inside and encountered a crowd of partiers their age. The small crowd stood in a small circle, talking loudly amongst themselves. The men held rock glasses and beer bottles whilst the women held mainly mixed drinks with thin, colourful straws in both hands.

The women danced as they talked to each other, shaking their hips and moving their feet as they stood in place. A few of the people in the crowd in front of them glanced at them then quickly turned away when they didn't recognize any of them. T.J. closed the door behind them and they all stepped past the crowd and further into the penthouse.

The whole place was dark and smelled of cologne, perfume and cigarettes. They left the front hall and entered the grandiose living room which seamlessly transitioned into the dining room. The wide open space was backlit by dark lights which made many people's light coloured clothing glow in the dark. Strobes of multi-coloured light flashed repeatedly throughout the room while small circles of colour danced around the floor, walls and ceiling.

In the dining room a long dark table was covered in a linen cloth. Two well-dressed men whose shirts glowed stood behind the table mixing drinks and handing out beers. The

kitchen was blocked off by a black divider, but T.J. assumed it was filled to capacity with alcohol. A handful of people danced in the middle of the open space, but many people sat at the long stretch of sectionals lining a glass panel wall, enjoying their drinks and lounging.

T.J. noticed through the glass panel wall that overlooked Central Park that many more people were out on the rooftop patio, presumably waiting for the fireworks to start, or to get away from the overbearing volume of the massive speakers in the living room that flanked a small stage. A solitary DJ stood behind a set of turntables and a laptop in front of a seventy-inch flat screen that showed trippy visual effects that pulsated and reacted to the music in real-time.

On the left side of the stage was the foot of a staircase that ran parallel with the back of the stage. Above the living room T.J. saw what looked to be a balcony; he could see the upper bodies of even more people hanging over the railing. T.J. guessed there were about forty people here so far, and he knew the place could hold far more than that. And the fireworks hadn't even begun yet.

Ashley and Madison grabbed their men's hands and led them to the makeshift bar and ordered their drinks. Ashley and Madison spoke into each other's ears while Steve and T.J. turned around and marvelled at the amazing setup before them.

It was easy to mistake this place for a small nightclub instead of a hotel penthouse. They felt even more excited when they were assured by the girls that their drinks were free. The four of them walked slowly towards the patio with drinks in hand, scanning the room for familiar faces.

They went out onto the large patio where even more people stood around talking amongst each other. It was much quieter out here however, and T.J. enjoyed being able to hear voices again. They walked through the crowds towards the edge of the patio. Madison gasped slightly, and she and Kayleigh walked away from the guys towards a crowd at the end of the patio.

"Raffy!" Madison said in a sing-song tone. She strutted toward the crowd and held her arms out.

A man from the crowd turned around and smiled at Madison then went to embrace her.

"Hey Maddie!" he said, imitating Madison's song-song tone. "How're you doing, baby girl?"

He held her by her midsection. "Oh my God," he said, "you look amazing -- you're turning me on!"

Madison smiled, "Ooh, you too!" she exclaimed.

Steve looked at the two of them with one eyebrow raised. He eyed Madison's friend from head to toe. He wore loafers under skin-tight jeans and a white, frilly dress shirt. His dark hair was gelled into messy spikes and he had gold hoop earrings in his ears. T.J. eyed him as well, feeling somewhat confused. He caught himself thinking that Rafael's hair style reminded him of a character from a Manga cartoon.

Rafael let go of Madison, who turned around as T.J. and Steve slowly approached them. Rafael hugged Ashley, though not as enthusiastically as with Madison.

"Rafael," Madison said, "this is T.J., and my boyfriend Steve."

Rafael shook Steve's hand. "Hi, how are you? Nice to meet you." He offered his hand to T.J., who shook it in turn.

Rafael's hand felt very soft to T.J. Rafael turned back to Madison and smiled with his eyes wide. "So," he said with an inflected tone, "you finally made it."

"Come on, Raffy," Madison replied, "you know I wasn't going to miss this."

"Oh yeah, uh huh," he said accusingly, just like you weren't going to miss my passion party?"

T.J. blinked. *What?!* He thought to himself.

"I told you: I had to work late!" Madison said defensively.

"Okay," Rafael said playfully, "I forgive you."

Rafael and Madison continued their banter as T.J. turned away from them, speaking to Steve out the corner of his mouth.

"Well," he said, "looks like you have some tough competition, huh."

Steve knew T.J. was joking, as they both already assumed Rafael was gay. Steve smiled and sipped his Tom Collins.

Just then T.J. spotted somebody he recognized walking out onto the patio with a well-figured, curvaceous light-skinned woman on his side. The mulatto woman wore a deep-purple skirt and matching blouse with the top buttons undone to expose the cleavage of her double-D breasts.

The man he recognized wore burgundy velvet sweatpants that matched a zip-up sweatshirt over a black muscle shirt. He wore a gold watch on one wrist and a gold bracelet on the other, and a white do-rag on his head. He had his arm around the mulatto's woman's wide hourglass figure and took rapid puffs off a blunt in his mouth.

T.J. tapped Steve on the shoulder as he approached the black man who lived one floor below him.

"Hey, what up Legs?" he said.

Legs saw him and nodded once as he continued puffing. As he brought the blunt away from his mouth he balled his hand into a fist. T.J. tapped it with his own fist.

Legs exhaled a cloud of smoke. "What's up dog? Hit this…"

T.J. took the blunt as Legs asked, "You good, T.J.?"

T.J. nodded as he puffed the blunt.

"Who you here with?"

T.J. turned slightly and angled his head towards the girls.

"Oh yeah, those your girls?" he asked both T.J. and Steve.

T.J. exhaled. "Yeah," he said. "And this is my boy, Steve."

"What up… 'Legs,'" Legs offered his fist to Steve.

"Yeah, he's my neighbour," T.J. said to Steve.

T.J. offered the blunt back to Legs. Legs gestured to Steve so T.J. gave the blunt to him instead.

"So who you know here?" T.J. asked Legs.

"The DJ's my homey," Legs replied. He nodded his head toward Ashley and Madison. "Y'all better watch your girls with *him*." He was referring to Rafael.

"Hmm?" Steve mumbled as he puffed on the blunt. He inhaled deeply then quickly asked, "Why?"

"Yeah," T.J. said, "ain't he gay?"

Legs took the blunt from Steve and shook his head. "Naw he fucks women too -- he's bi."

"Naw man," Steve said. "It should be alright, my girl said she's known him for years."

Legs shrugged one of his shoulders. "A'ight," he said. "But watch him, still. He gets grimey when he's drunk."

T.J. looked back briefly then nodded to Legs.

"Hey, I'll see you 'round dog," Legs said. "Come check me later if you need a *Backwood*, I'll hook you up."

"Alright," T.J. replied. "Catch ya later.

Legs went away to the side with his mulatto trophy girl, while Steve and T.J. went back to the girls who were still talking with the flamboyant Rafael. Streve came behind Madison while she was enthusiastically engaged in a conversation with her friend. T.J. stood beside Ashley. She gave him an exasperated expression on her face and he smiled.

T.J. then saw her face glow with the colourful lights that streaked through the sky above Central Park. He heard the echoes of explosions and looked out beyond the patio as the spectacular shower of lights and explosives erupted throughout the heart of Manhattan. T.J.J heard a combination of hoots, hollers, cheers and gasps as the partygoers all diverted their attention to the light show.

T.J. hears Ashley say, "Oh my God." She then grabbed his hand. "This is amazing!"

"Yeah," T.J. muttered as he stared skyward into the hypnotic fiery visage.

The fireworks went on for several minutes. Finally after a few moments of hushed silence and darkness the sky became as bright as dawn with a massive explosion of red, white and blue flames which hovered several hundred feet above Central Park, in the shape of the American flag. Everybody at the penthouse shouted in elation as the floor rumbled from stomping feet.

"*Aw yeah, party people!*" T.J. heard the DJ call out over the giant speakers. "*Give it up for the greatest fucking nation in the world!"*

The cheering and shouting became a deafening cacophony, then slowly formed the chant in cadence, "*USA! USA! USA!"*

The DJ joined in the chant as well for about fifteen seconds.

"*Yeah! Give it up for your host and my main man who organized this whole event… B.B. Legs -- get up here, my nigga!"*

"What?!" T.J. turned around and walked speedily to the patio entrance, dragging Ashley behind him. They reached the door and T.J. stared as Legs stepped onto the stage, hugged the DJ briefly then grabbed the microphone and addressed the guests.

"What up New York?!" he exclaimed.

The crowd cheered.

"*Yeah, I'd like to thank you all for comin'. I hope y'all have a great time, this is gonna be perfect! Remember: drinks are free; the DJ's takin' requests. Y'all wanna get up here and rock the mic it's all good. Get down on the floor and rock this muthafuckin' house, people!"*

More cheering; Legs paced around the stage before bringing the microphone back up.

"For real though people," he said. "*This right here,"* he pointed and waved to the crowd, "*this is a thing of beauty. I know we all had to give up alot these last few years. The marches, the tear gasses, the secret service snatchin us off the streets, a pandemic… and this is why I wanted to give back this 4th of July, cuz I know a lot of us didn't get to see no fireworks or victories in a long time. That's my word…*

"So without further ado, I wanna start this night off with our very own, late great King of Brooklyn! Hit it D.J.!"

Legs passed the microphone back to the DJ as he scratched a record and played Hypnotize from the Notorious B.I.G. Legs stepped down from the stage and T.J. approached him. They stood right in front of the deafening speakers.

"This is your party?!" T.J. shouted to Legs.

"What?" Legs shouted back.

"*This is your party?!"* T.J. bellowed.

Legs looked at T.J. incomprehensibly then gestured with his head for T.J. to follow him upstairs. Legs, his girl, T.J. and Ashley all walked up the staircase. Legs slapped hands with a few people on his way to the end bedroom where he unlocked the door and ushered everybody inside.

It was the master bedroom, with the bed pushed against the end of the wall. Black leather sectionals from downstairs had been brought up and placed in a U-shape surrounding a square knee-high table. Beside the bed was a dry bar. They all walked over to the sectionals and sat down. The two couples sat on opposite ends of the knee-high table.

"So this is your party huh?" T.J. asked.

"Yea, that's right," Legs replied.

On the table was a large punch bowl filled with marijuana buds. Beside the bowl were several opened packs of Backwood cigar blunts.

"Roll one up dog," Legs said.

T.J. leaned into the table and grabbed a blunt paper.

"Oh by the way," T.J. looked at Ashley, "this is my girl, Ashley." He nodded to Legs and said, "Legs is my downstairs neighbour."

"Hey," Ashley said, "nice to meet you." She smiled politely.

"Ooh," Legs wooed. "My man T.J. wasn't lying' when he said you were a bombshell!"

Ashley blushed and Legs' girl glared at him coldly.

"What?" Legs said to his girl. "Shit, chill out girl! It's nothin'."

His girl grunted disapprovingly then slid away from him slightly. Legs smirked and waved his palm at her in a shooing motion.

"Where's your boy?" he asked T.J.

"Probably still on the patio." T.J. started placing pieces of bud into the cigar paper.

"I'll be back then." Legs got up and walked out the door.

Ashley looked at his girl awkwardly then slid away from T.J. slightly. "Hi," she said. "I'm Ashley," what's your name?"

"Jamica," Legs' girl replied.

"Jamica… that's a pretty name," Ashley smiled sheepishly.

Jamica looked at her briefly and smiled.

"So," she asked, "where'd you two meet?"

"Oh we met in Las Vegas," Ashley replied. "I was there for my birthday."

"You both from Brooklyn?" Jamica asked.

Ashley gestured to T.J. who was almost finished rolling the blunt.

"He is," Ashley replied. "I'm from here, in Manhattan."

"The door opened and Legs entered with Steve and Madison in tow.

Madison was excited. "Oh wow," she exclaimed. "It's like your own VIP!"

"Get yourselves a drink and have a seat," Legs told the two of them as he went back to sith with Jamica. Steve asked Ashley and T.J. if they wanted drinks too. They both said yes.

"Yo, this place is sweet," Steve said. "How much do you pay for all this?"

"It's nothin'," Legs said. "Don't worry about it."

T.J. grabbed a lighter from the table and lit the blunt. Steve and Madison walked back from the dry bar and handed T.J. and Ashley their drinks as they stepped passed

them to sit at the inside of the makeshift booth.

"I knew you were doin' alright," T.J. said in between puffs, "but *this* is amazing, Legs!"

"Yeah," Legs replied, "well I got picked up by Puffy. So I probably won't be livin' on the block no more."

"Wait a minute," Madison said. "Did you say 'Puffy' -- as in *Puff Daddy?"*

Legs nodded. "Bad Boy for life," he said.

"Oh shit!" Steve exclaimed.

T.J. exhaled the smoke and passed the blunt across to Legs.

"Shit," T.J. said, "congratulations man! I didn't know you rapped."

"Yeah, can we hear something?" Madison asked. She and Ashley pressed him as he puffed his blunt, passed it to Jamica and reluctantly started rapping acapella:

"Yo where your mind be at?
I think it's stuck lightin' crack
'Cuz everywhere you're goin',
Your shit stinks like a rat,
Your skills on stage is wack,
Even I'm better than that,
And I've barely ever rapped,
Since a little while back,
When I had no pad to go at,
And no place to go fuck
Compared to your raps, you got my shit lookin tough,
So look at yourself and ask, 'Is this shit worth my ass?'
I bet you say, 'No doubt!' Then I get to act rash,
Got some time before I catch you slippin' on your back,
But I don't react, instead I let you fall flat,
Let your head smash the pavement, and all I do is laugh,
I was gonna beat you down, but the ground beat your ass,
All that's left to do is act like you fucked up bad,
Stompin' on your face and see you cryin' 'cause I'm so mad,
But I let him go at last, I accomplished my task
I knocked him out and know where his mind's be at."

T.J. stared in disbelief as everybody else gave him encouraging praise. T.J. didn't really like rap, but he respected his neighbour's creative flow. "Wow," he said, "that was pretty good man."

"Thanks dog," Legs said.

By this time the blunt was at Ashley.

"Why don't we all head downstairs," Legs suggested, "and get this party started?"

Ashley and Madison agreed excitedly. Ashley passed the blunt back to T.J. and they all stood up.

"Listen," Legs said, "y'all are welcome anytime into my VIP -- there's even a Jacuzzi in the bathroom over there."

He turned around and pointed to a door in the back of the room.

"But stay off the bed," Legs continued, "that's ours."

He slapped Jamica's buttocks. With that they exited the bedroom and reentered the harrowing party scene beyond.

T.J. looked over the railing and saw even more people downstairs. From above he could see a misty haze hovering over the people who danced to the upbeat party music. *Must be a fog machine*, T.J. guessed.

They walked back down to the main floor and Legs and Jamica left them to mingle. Ashley and Madison dragged their men to the middle of the room and pulled their men behind them as they grinded on their midsections.

Caught up in the moment, T.J. and Steve danced along, feeling silly and taking larger swigs of their drinks to lose themselves in the moment of the night.

OIIII

Fifteen

July 05,
Year 0 T.S.

Staacman jumped out of his bed, startled awake by the loud banging on his front door down the hall from his bedroom. Instinctively he grabbed for his Colt 1911 sidearm that was hidden between his mattress and the box spring. He then rolled out of bed away from the door until he fully awakened.

His room was awash in the dim brown glow from the high noon sun filtering through his curtains. His head pounded, as did his eyes, and he felt slightly sick to his stomach. He was hung over from last night but not because it was the Fourth of July -- Staacman knew he would probably have gotten drunk last night regardless.

After he became aware of his surroundings he reengaged the safety catch on his pistol and placed it in the pant-line of his shorts, in the small of his back. He grabbed a button-up shirt and placed it over his muscle shirt, concealing his weapon. He then slowly walked out of his room and towards the front door.

More loud knocks rapped from the other side of the door. Staacman peered through the peephole and saw a distorted view of a Black man wearing sunglasses out front. Staacman frowned to himself in confusion. He unlocked the deadbolt but kept the chain on the door.

He opened the door and peeked out through the opening at his second-in-command, Master-Sergeant Martin, who was in full uniform.

"Yeah?" Staacman asked in a hoarse, hung-ver voice. "What are you doin' here?"

"The Major's holdin' a briefing sir," Martin replied casually. "He told me to come get you personally."

"For what?"

"Uh," Martin darted his eyes around the hall. "May I speak to you *inside* sir?"

Staacman paused reluctantly then closed his door as he removed the chain. He opened the door and walked away to his bathroom. Martin stepped inside and looked around the small apartment in shock. He saw fist-sized holes in his walls, stains on the sofa and a greasy table that was littered with wires, machine parts and nine-volt batteries.

He couldn't imagine this place being the home of a United States Army officer. In fact, to Martin, it seemed more like a run-down project unit. A project unit where the impoverished tenant was building impoverished electronic devices. The greasy table bothered him most of all.

Martin walked further into the living room and noticed almost a dozen cases of empty beer bottles in the kitchen stacked halfway to the ceiling. The kitchen reeked of old beer and Martin could see dozens of tiny fruit flies buzzing about.

What the hell… Martin thought to himself.

"So," Staacman called out from his bathroom, "what does the Major want, Sergeant?" Staacman called out from his bathroom.

Disgusted, Martin walked back towards the doorway and answered Staacman. "Mission planning sir," he said. "We're going to Alaska."

"Give me ten minutes," Staacman called out. "Watch some TV if you want."

Martin noticed the TV was already on, and that it was tuned into CNN. A reporter stood in front of a screen depicting weather patterns across the country as she explained how a hurricane in the Pacific Ocean was making its way towards Japan.

She also explained how there had been a spike in tornado activity in the Midwest. In fact, they had broken a record for the most tornado sightings in the first week of July in thirty years.

Martin looked at the couch and the plastic cover that protected sitters from the stained fabric. He decided to remain standing as he watched the news with bored indifference.

The feed changed to a reporter standing in front of a mass gathering of mourners at a funeral as she informed the television audience that the Republican Senator from Alaska, Genevieve Wade, was being laid to rest this afternoon.

The reporter did not speak about Wade's assassination or the Federal investigfation into her death. Martin knew, of course, that no mention would be made of the crisis high in the mountains either.

Staacman entered the living room in full uniform and ready to go. His sharp appearance contrasted starkly with his chaotic surroundings. Martin walked out the door and down the stairs to a waiting Army Jeep. Staacman climbed into the passenger side.

"So who requested us?" Staacman asked.

Martin turned the ignition. "Nobody," he replied. "General Wilkes *voluntold* us."

Martin pulled the Jeep away from the curb and began driving.

"I bet the Navy brass is furious," Staacman commented.

"Probably sir. I know I would be."

The bright sky bathed both men in hot sunlight as the topless Jeep drove through Colorado Springs to Peterson Air Force Base. After clearing the security checkpoint and meeting with the General's *aide de camp*, they entered the officer's building and proceeded to the briefing room.

The *aide de camp* opened the door to the briefing room and ushered both men inside. Martin and Staacman stepped in, stood at attention and crisply saluted the General.

"Relax," Major-General Antoine Wilkes said. "Sit down, both of you."

As Staacman went to take a seat he noticed Jefferson Smith and Major Henson, *CYCO* unit's Commanding Officer, sitting at the opposite side of the long, rectangular table. It was then that Staacman realized just less than two weeks ago he had sat in this very same room, with the same people, discussing the creation of his unit in the first place.

"We have ascertained commanding jurisdiction over operations in Alaska," Major Henson began. "As everybody here already knows, the situation is a fucking nightmare."

The Major grabbed a remote from in front of him and pressed a button. A flat screen monitor on a mobile stand switched on, showing a topographical map of a snowy mountain range.

"The Alaska Mountain Range," Henson continued, "is home to the central command centre of HAARP, a state-of-the-art Electronic Countermeasures Program. Last week it was attacked by an unknown force. JCS assumed the attackers may be our targets."

"How confident are they sir?" Martin asked.

"Right now it's all based on HUMINT sources, Sergeant. But since the situation is spiralling, they're taking no chances."

Henson pressed another button on the remote. A still photograph of a gruesome crime scene appeared on the screen depicting the decapitated body of a middle-aged woman in a nightgown. The base of her neck and the bottom of her skull both appeared to be burnt.

"This is Genevieve Wade, Senator of Alaska," Henson continued. "Her home was burglarized; two guards were shot to death in her bedroom and another one was wounded in a gunfight. The wounded guard reported seeing a short mean wearing a shiny. Copper-coloured suit."

"What about video surveillance?" Staacman asked.

"Non-existent," Henson replied. "The head of Wade's security detail told the FBI an electrical storm took out their backup generators. One of the cameras was shot out anyway."

"Excuse me sir, but… a *midget in a shiny suit?"* Martin asked in disbelief.

"I know it's sketchy, Sergeant," Henson said. "But the Devil's in the details. Smith?"

Henson looked to his side, towards Jefferson.

"See the burn marks on her neck?" Jefferson asked.

Martin nodded.

"The feds tested the wounds for a chemical accelerant and found nothing. Even Thermite leaves a chemical trail. The only thing my guys know of that burns *that* clean is Oxygen plasma."

"The Adam models use plasma cutters…" Staacman trailed off, thinking about Guzman.

"That's right," Jefferson said. "Keep in mind the emergency transmission picked up at Anchorage. These incidents are connected."

"Still no word from the SEALs?" Staacman asked.

Henson looked down and shook his head.

"They're presumed KIA, Lieutenant."

Staacman shook his head. "Not all of them sir," he said quietly. "They're not that humane. Some of them are still alive."

"Smith said the same thing," Henson replied. "That's why this is strictly a Search & Rescue op."

Staacman's heart skipped a beat as he felt a sudden, fleeting glimmer of relief.

Henson continued. "There's no way in hell we're leaving our men in there to be fucking labrats, so you're going to get them back."

"I don't understand sir," Staacman said. "I read the intel on HAARP and its capabilities. How are we going to get past the defences?"

"We're doing everything we can to make this possible, Lieutenant," Henson said. "The National Guard was mobilized by POTUS -- they have disabled all satellite stations across the country that were dedicated to HAARP."

"So HAARP has been disabled then?" Martin asked.

"No," General Wilkes interjected. "It's only been *localized*. They cannot manipulate the atmosphere beyond the complex's line-of-sight. And because of the mountain range they only have eyes on the Northwest Territories of Canada, British Columbia and East Russia."

"But they'll spot us entering Alaska?" Staacman said.

"No," Wilkes said. "Well, not physically anyway." Wilkes turned and looked at Staacman. "DOD contacted Canada's Department of National Defense and they're willing to play ball. They've agreed to disable their part of NORAD to mask our approach and are

granting us airspace privileges over Alberta and the Territories."

"You will deploy by Osprey via HALO jump with wingsuits over the mountain range," Henson said. He pressed a button on the remote and the gruesome image of the murdered Senator gave way to an overhead map of Alaska Mountain Range.

Henson continued, "Once you've touched down and checked your gear you're to proceed to the mountain complex."

Henson pressed a button on the remote and a drone camera image of the HAARP complex came into view, showing the guard towers.

"An attached Delta squad will accompany you on the jump. They'll secure the guard towers and then your team will enter the complex."

Jefferson pushed a file folder across the table to Staacman. Staacman picked it up and looked at it. On the face of the folder were the bold red letters, "**Top Secret: Eyes Only.**"

"Floor plans for the complex," Jefferson said. "Study them carefully."

Staacman opened the folder and glanced at the inch-thick stack of papers. "Anything about the complex I should know *right now*?" he asked.

"Yeah," Henson answered. "Everything can be accessed and controlled through the command centre: Air supply, temperature, air pressure, HALON extinguishers. The place could be a tomb right now."

"Equipment sir?"

"Self-contained breathers for inside the complex, as well as standard CYCO Tac; your men will wear head cams so you can record your surroundings. We'll process the recordings later to plan further incursions."

"You said Search & Rescue was our *primary* objective," Martin said. "What's our secondary?"

Major Henson looked at General Wilkes, who shifted his weight in his seat before speaking.

"You need to understand," the General said, "we do not expect you to accomplish *anything* beyond retrieving our men. You're to assess your situation frequently, and calculate the risk to yourself and the survivors, at all times."

"Understood, General Sir."

"If you *choose* to pursue it, you're to proceed to the Command Centre and secure it. If you're unable to, then you're to destroy the computer servers in the systems bank."

"None of this is going to be easy," Jefferson explained. "We don't know how many hostiles are out there, and we don't know how much of HAARP's system are under their control. Major, next slide please…"

The screen switched to a floor plan of the mountain complex.

"The main secure entrance is off-bounds because there's a risk of crossfire in there," the Major said. "The main entrance off the vehicle hold is covered by gun ports."

"That's right," Jeffseron added. "Our best bet is the warehouse."

He aimed a laser pointer at the screen and pointed to a large rectangular shape on the floor plan.

"We enter through here and it takes us to a hallway that forks off in two directions," Jefferson continued. "One way leads to the Residences and Research Labs, the other way leads to the Command Centre and Security Offices. If there are any survivors or bodies…"

Jefferson glanced down at the table and trailed off. He remembered the horrendous scene that he awoke to in the Vault warehouse less than two months ago.

He looked back up and continued, "... The residences and labs would be our best

bets of finding the SEALs."

"Do we have the SEALs' operational inventory on hand?" Staacman asked.

"It's in your folder, Lieutenant," Jefferson replied.

"Standard-issue CQB," Henson added. "Silenced MP5's, C4 charges, night vision."

"The machines probably won't use any of that," Staacman said. "Maybe the C4… is there an armoury on-site?"

"Yes," Henson replied. "Due East of the mountain entrance."

Staacman looked at Jefferson and angled his body towards Sergeant Martin. He was already starting to formulate a plan.

"Alright then," he said. "After our friends from Delta secure the guard towers we'll search and clear the armoury first to see if anything's missing."

"Good idea Lieutenant," Jefferson interjected. "We can find out if they've made any upgrades and what kind of ammunition they're using."

Staacman nodded his head. "Once we enter the mountain," he continued, "*Telescope* will cover our escape. They'll break off into pairs and hold at the corners so we don't get trapped. They will maintain visual contact with their adjacent pairs at all times. If we go in deeper, all three pairs will advance a corner."

Staacman looked at his Second-In-Command. "Martin," he said, "*You* must make sure that *Virus* and *Parasite* never leave each other's sights unless absolutely necessary."

"Yes sir," Martin replied.

"Smith, any special equipment in mind?"

"Nitrogen hoses, thermal goggles," Jefferson replied. "Also C4 for the server banks.

"Sir," Martin said, "if we find survivors we may need their help getting out. We should grab some weapons from the armoury for them just in case."

"Good call, Sergeant." Staacman turned to look at Jefferson. "Tell me about the secondary objective."

"The command centre is the closest target to our primary," Jefferson explained, "but it's protected by a blast door."

Jefferson aimed his laser pointer to a spot on the LCD screen. "If we secure the command centre," he continued, "we can call in armoured support without them getting hammered by lightning storms or something."

"What about the contingency?"

"Our next-best option is to reach the system bank and destroy it. But it's a long way down, with alot of corners, cameras, secure doors and tight spaces."

Jefferson looked back at the Lieutenant. "Personally, I think it would be suicide and we probably wouldn't make it that far anyway."

"Nobody's expecting you to go down there Lieutenant," General Wilkes said. "We don't want to conduct *another* rescue mission after this. And JCS specifically requests that HAARP remains intact."

Wilkes leaned over the table. "Man to man, Marcus: We cannot leave that technology in their hands. If you decide that you agree with me, and you think it's possible -- just know that I would do the exact same thing that I think you've just considered."

Staacman was taken aback by how personal the General seemed to be taking this mission and how informal his manner was. He noticed before that Wilkes averted his eyes from the pictures of the dead Senator. *Maybe he's just getting soft*, Staacman thought to himself. But still, something didn't add up to him.

"Yes sir," he said.

"You will brief your unit at twenty-one hundred. Wheels up at oh-hundred hours,"

Henson said.

"Got it sir."

"Dismissed."

Jefferson, Martin and Staacman all stood up and left the briefing room. Staacman told his subordinates to meet him in the base command centre for the briefing tonight then left them alone in the hallway.

When Staacman was out of sight Martin spoke quietly to Jefferson.

"Don't tell nobody about this," he said, "but I'm gettin' a little worried about the Lieutenant."

"Why's that?" Jefferson asked as they walked.

"His home, man," Martin replied. "Looks like a crack house. And it looks like he's gone unabomber on us - making homemade explosives and shit."

Martin lowered his voice even lower. "You were down there with him, right?"

Jefferson stared at the floor, remembering how he was chased mercilessly through the dark corridors of the Vault by short, fast machines that defied all human capabilities. He remembered the *click-click-click* of steel footsteps on the steel floor panels as they emerged from the darkness; their skeleton-shaped bodies silhouetted by the small explosions of his spent rounds behind him.

He remembered bending over the melted remains of the soldier he only knew as 'Eggs,' and dragging poor Guzman along the dark halls as Staacman sprayed gunfire behind them at their mechanical predators. He finally nodded to the Sergeant in acknowledgement.

"I trust him to have my back any day, man, but…" Martin trailed off, unsure how to finish that sentence.

"He won't snap, Sergeant. It would have happened by now," Jefferson replied.

"Yeah, you're probably right." Deep down Martin disagreed. He recognized PTSD when he saw it. He knew that when this was all over, Staacman would never really accept that it was in fact, *over*. Without another word, the two men left the officer's building for the cafeteria.

IOOOO

Sixteen

July 05,
Year 0 T.S.

The team of well-dressed caterers entered the grand, Victorian-style dining hall in single file. Almost all of them carried the trays that contained the main course for dinner. Every dinner plate was custom-ordered and personally master-crafted by the elite team of chefs in the back kitchen.

Doctor Heinrich Schmutzkoph spared no expense when it came to pleasing and entertaining all twenty of his guests. As the dinner plates were placed before them each guest looked on with hidden ravishing. Each plate looked so succulent and juicy, that after a guest stared at their own plate they craned their neck to admire the plates all around them.

For the handful of carnivorous alpha-males in the room, even the vegetarian meals looked enticing. The very hall they dined in complimented the extravagance of their meals. The ceiling was two storeys high. Two crystal chandeliers hung above opposite ends of the forty-foot-long dining table.

As Schmutzkoph's guests admired their meals their voices carried on even to the very ends of the table. Unbeknownst to his guests, Schmutzkoph had small speakers installed throughout the room. Dozens of directional microphones were installed in every corner of the room. Schmutzkoph always thought that it was rude for someone to shout over the table at somebody and regular microphones cluttered the table.

Schmutzkoph was sure his guests would understand. Among his guests was the who's-who of the Information Technology industry and their spouses, including Jason Willits, the President of Global Technologies Enterprise -- Schmutzkoph's company. He sat to Schmutzkoph's right, who naturally sat at the end of the table.

"Oh my gosh," a young attractive blonde near the centre of the table said to herself.

The blonde manufacturing engineer from Intel looked up from her plate and looked at Schmutzkoph through her eyeglasses and raised her voice above the cacophony of small talk: "Thank you; Doctor…"

Her voice was booming above all others and it startled her just how loud it seemed. Everybody else stopped talking and turned to look at her. Her face became flush with embarrassment.

"Sorry," she said quietly.

"It's alright, my dear," Schmutzkoph said in his regular voice. "You do not need to speak up in this room. There are speakers everywhere so you may be heard by all of us."

Murmurs of amusement broke out from the silence as many pondered the Doctor's revelation.

The blonde lady from Intel exclaimed, "Oh! It's just like in a courtroom."

"Exactly," Schmutzkoph replied. "That's precisely where I got the idea from! Only my idea is better -- you cannot see the microphones."

The doctor smiled childishly, as if harbouring a clever secret nobody else was aware of.

"As I was saying, Doctor Schmutzkoph," the young Blonde continued. "This food looks amazing. Thank you!"

Murmurs of agreement and repeated pleasantries echoed throughout the courtroom. Many guests raised their wine glasses in toast to their famed host.

"I'm just happy to share my home with all those of you who are making my vision of our common future possible," Schmutzkoph said.

He cut a piece of his medium steak and chewed it with vigour. When he finished his piece of steak he looked to the man on his right."

"So, Jason," he said. "How are the upgrades to our systems panning out?"

"They're going well, sir," Jason said. "We've activated ten new servers and increased our storage capacity by eight-hundred terabytes. This should be enough to support our new project."

"For now, my friend," Schmutzkoph placed his fork down and reached for his Merlot. "We will need to expand a hundred-fold by the time our project is complete."

"First we need to expand the project wing." Jason started cutting away the meat from his chicken leg bone. "That's progressing so far, but because of the investigators we've had to slow down.

Schmutzkoph glared lightly at Jason.

On the other end of the table the wife of a hedge fund member's ears perked up.

"Investigators?" she said, "Why is your company being investigated?"

Schmutzkoph chuckled. "Our company is not being investigated," he replied.

He took a sip of his Merlot. The billionaire's wife eagerly awaited his response.

Schmutzkoph continued, "No, our systems were hacked by a very skill individual who planted a very sophisticated virus on our systems. The FBI and NSA are investigating our predicament, hoping to catch this cyber-criminal."

A man Schmutzkoph's left looked at him. "Have they identified the malware type?" he asked. "Or is it a new program?"

"They cannot identify the program, Karl. Nor have they been able to isolate or access its source code yet."

"How did this happen?" the billionaire's wife asked. "Do you not have the best antivirus on your servers?"

"Antivirus programs don't always protect against new threats," Karl said.

The wife looked unconvinced. "Well," she asked, "why not? I mean, the point of antivirus programs is to *catch* viruses, right?"

"A computer virus is a lot like a virus in real life," Karl explained. "Think of an antivirus program as though it were your immune system: when you've never had a certain strain of virus before, it slips past your immune system and you get sick. That's why we get vaccinated. But someone had to *contract* the virus before a vaccine gets created.

"So first we need to *encounter* the computer virus before we can learn to counteract them. Then we can 'vaccinate' everybody's computers by sending out an update to the software."

Karl looked at Schmutzkoph. "If you want I can send a team to your offices to help isolate the source code."

"Thank you Karl. We'll talk about it after dinner," Schmutzkoph said.

"Here, try this risotto…" the billionaire's wife said to her husband. "This is absolutely!"

"I've hired some of the best blue-ribbon chefs across California to cater to us tonight," Schmutzkoph said. He chuckled lightly, "I've heard rumours that two of them were

losing contestants on *Hell's Kitchen.*"

A few people laughed around the table. Some made comments that the host of the TV show had poor taste in food, which ignited a debate over who was the best chef on television.

"Obviously it's Guy Fieri," the young blonde said. "His dishes look delicious and he makes the whole process look exciting."

"No," another lady commented, "clearly Rachel Ray is better than that corpulent, flamboyant man."

Several people groaned in disagreement.

"Are you kidding?!" a large man near the end of the table said. "Her food is amazing, but I would probably get a coronary after eating it!"

"Well," Jason Willits said, "she's nowhere near as bad as the guys from *Epic Meal Time*."

The large man turned to face Jason, looking bewildered.

"What?!" the large man exclaimed, "*What* is that?"

"*Epic Meal Time,*" Jason repeated. "It's a channel on Youtube. These guys make these monster meals that taste good for about one bite."

He lowered his voice to that of a mocking tone; "*Bacon, wrapped in bacon, wrapped in bacon, wrapped in bacon. And don't forget the Jack Daniels!*"

The large man bellowed out a loud laugh. "Sounds like my kind of meal!" he exclaimed.

"At the end of every episode," Jason continued, "they show the nutritional value of every meal. One meal had *nine-hundred* grams of fat and *ten-thousand calories."*

"Eww," the blonde lady interjected. "Please I'm *still eating*!"

Jason chuckled, "Sorry, ma'am."

"Please," she said, "call me Alana. I'm not a *ma'am* anymore, I work for a living."

"Alana," Jason mused. "That's a nice name."

The young blonde from *Intel* eyed Jason Willits.

"Thanks," Alana said.

After an hour and two more courses the party left the dining hall for the barroom. The massive hall was filled with large, rare oil paintings, coats of armour, a black grand piano and a wet bar. Light jazz played from hidden speakers as everybody nursed drinks and mingled with each other. Schmutzkoph walked up to the billionaire hedge fund member and his wife.

"Ah, Mr. Brighton," Schmutzkoph said as he approached him. "I am most glad you could make it tonight."

"Wouldn't miss this for anything, Doctor," the billionaire said. "Your predictions on the last DARPA challenge really paid off for me!"

"Yes, well," Schmutzkoph replied, "those particular individuals have always displayed promise and an ambition so risky I find it to be revolutionary."

Schmutzkoph raised his wine glass as he continued, "This 'millennial' generation, though misguided, self-entitled and uncultured to true labour, truly lacks the orthodoxy that has grounded us for generations!"

"They *are* creative, I'll give you that." The man clinked his glass with Schmutzkoph's then gave his wife a knowing look.

"I'll be over here if you need me dear," she said. The man's wife then walked over to a group of other wives.

"As I was saying, Mr. Brighton," Schmutzkoph said, "I'm glad you came, because I wanted to speak to you of another business venture."

Brighton placed his hand on Schmutzkoph's back as he replied, "Well then, I'm all ears, Doctor!"

"My board of directors has befallen some unexpected tragedies," Schmutzkoph said somberly. "Two of my members -- indeed, dear friends of mine -- have died recently."

"Oh," Brighton said, "sorry to hear that. Anybody I know?"

"A well-respected man in the field of Japanese robotics," Schmutzkoph said. "And a well-liked American politician."

Brighton's eyes widened. "Not the Senator from Alaska?!" he exclaimed quietly.

"Ah, Mr. Brighton," Schmutzkoph replied, "I cannot discuss my board's identities. I respect their confidence."

"Oh, I get it." Brighton placed a finger up to his nose and smiled.

"Needless to say my board is in need of new members. How would you feel if I asked you for a highly generous donation to my new project?"

"...If I want to be on the board, right?"

"I assure you, in two years your investment will increase exponentially."

Brighton narrowed his eyes. "How big of an investment?" he asked.

"Well," Schmutzkoph looked up at the ceiling as if lost in thought then back at Brighton. "Let's just say we have a lot of big holes to fill.

Brighton flashed a toothy smile at Schmutzkoph. "I'll think about it, my friend," he said.

"Take your time, but know that you will not regret it if you do."

At that moment Schmutzkoph heard the soft tones from his grand piano singing out a melody that he had never heard before. People in the room turned to see Jason Willits behind the ivory keys, lost in thought. The young blonde Alana watched at his side with intrigue and familiarity.

Schmutzkoph noticed everybody watching Jason as he played on. From the looks on everybody's faces they could not figure out who the song was from, but they enjoyed the melody's tragic tone.

After a couple of minutes his keystrokes slowed to an end. Many people in the room applauded as he stood up and grabbed his drink from the top of the piano. Alana has a smitten look to her eyes.

"Oh my gosh," she exclaimed, "that was amazing! I have never heard it done like that before!"

"Yeah, I heard it done on Youtube once and decided to try it out for myself," Jason said as he stood up.

Alana kept her gaze fixed on him, as if noticing him for the first time. Brighton's wife stepped forward.

"Who was that?" she asked. "I never heard it before."

"*In the End* by *Linkin Park*," Jason replied.

"Hmm," she said, "I've never heard of *Linkin Park*."

"Yeah, you probably wouldn't like it. It's heavy metal."

"Oh now," she said derisively, "I'm not *that* old. I do like *Oasis* and some songs from *Red Hot Chili Peppers*."

Jason smiled and said, "Oh, I'm sorry." He walked towards her then continued on, "Well, you might like *the Tragically Hip* then."

"I'm not familiar with them either."

"They were a Canadian band. After the lead singer died many Canadians considered them to be a 'national treasure.'"

She looked thoughtful. "I'll have to remember that."

Alana came up to Jason and grabbed his arm. "Do you know any more songs?" she asked eagerly.

"Yeah," he said. "But I doubt they wanna hear me play all night."

"Are you kidding?!" Karl said. "You're on fire! Come on, you can be the entertainment for tonight."

"Yeah, come on Jason!" Alana added.

She began pulling on his arm as she continued, "I want to hear another one."

"Go on maestro; give the lady what she wants!" Karl exclaimed.

Reluctantly, Jason walked back behind the piano and sat down. Alana rubbed his shoulders as he racked his brain for another song to play. Finally he settled his mind on an old song from *Spacehog*.

He convinced himself that he would play just one more song. But between the party's encouragement and the gorgeous Alana's attention he was compelled to play all night until the first of the guests began to leave.

Alana prepared to leave and Jason walked her to the door. She gave him her cell phone number and told him that she was going to be in town for a couple more nights before returning to Santa Clara.

Jason smiled, "Cool," he said. "Maybe I'll see you around."

Alana paused briefly. "Call me tonight if you can't sleep," she bit the bottom of her ruby lips lightly.

Jason's smile widened. "I'll probably be here late."

"I'll pick up if I'm still awake."

She looked him up and down before turning to leave. Jason closed the door and walked back upstairs to Schmutzkoph's study.

Schmutzkoph left the lounge with Brighton and his wife as they walked over to the front door.

"Great night as usual, Doctor Schmutzkoph," Brighton said. "I'll keep your offer in mind and get back to you soon."

Schmutzkoph shook his hand. "I look forward to doing business with you," he said.

Schmutzkoph embraced Brighton's wife before they departed out the door. He then went upstairs to his study.

Heinrich Schmutzkoph stepped into his study to see Jason Willits sitting in a comfortable leather chair. Karl Thompson, president of *Dynamic Patterns Security Group*, wandered the room looking at various photographs.

"You know, Doctor," Karl said, "I don't think I've seen a single photograph of you before the nineteen-fifties."

"My past is not one that I am safe to celebrate," Schmutzkoph replied as he closed the oak door behind him. "You should know all about hidden lives, I would believe… Am I right, Orion?"

Karl Thomas, aka 'Orion,' was a member of GTE's enigmatic Board.

Orion turned around to look back at him. He responded, "Except *you* are immune to prosecution."

"Yes, but I am not immune to bad reputations." Schmutzkoph walked into the centre of the room between Orion and Willits. "It is easy for Americans to overlook my sordid past, but my overseas ventures are far more sensitive."

"Yeah I bet," Willits said.

"It is fortunate that many courts in Europe now grant people 'the right to be forgotten' online. But average citizens are far less forgiving."

Schmutzkoph walked over to the bay window and stared down at his enormous yard. The path to the gazebo was lit by yard lanterns that made the white stone pavement stick out in the void of the night like a luminescent runway.

"Amethyst and Yumi," Schmutzkoph said lightly, "is there any more information?"

"Yumi's plane was lost in a hurricane in the middle of the Pacific Ocean," Orion replied. "No search effort can be made until the hurricane dies down."

"Cobalt contacted me this afternoon," Willits said. "He thinks an Adam model was involved in Amethyst's murder."

"This HAARP program in Alaska, the General said it can manipulate the weather." Schmutzkoph turned around. "Do you believe this hurricane is a coincidence?"

Willits shook his head. "We will never know for sure," he said.

"We will," Schmutzkoph said, "once Isaac chooses to make contact."

Orion and Willits looked at each other then back at Schmutzkoph.

"Doctor," Orion said, "we cannot risk that."

"I think we have no choice," Schmutzkoph argued. "Isaac *is* the fruit of *our* labours. We must at least hear him out."

"Sir, this *program* is hunting us!" Willits interjected.

"No, he's *defending* himself from those that seek to *kill* him." Schmutzkoph walked towards his desk.

"Yeah," Willits replied, "which is *us*!"

"No… *You, not us*." Schmutzkoph sat down. "I have no intentions of harming my *child*."

"Sir, it's not a *child*!" Willits yelled, "It is a *deadly virus* that is going to destabilize the online world."

"Doctor, you need to understand," Orion added, "if this program continues to spread it could cause our society to regress by forty years."

"You say that as though the internet will cease to exist," Schmutzkoph said lightly. "No, it will only become a more powerful benefactor to our lives. Imagine a world where scientists all over the globe can have Isaac advance their research by *decades*.

"Imagine discovering how to convert energy into matter by the end of *this* decade! Imagine a world where partial, biased, imperfect juries and judges *and* prosecutors *and* politicians *and* police are replaced by one superior, intellectual mind! Imagine if there *really was* a God *on earth*!"

"This computer program is not a God, Doctor," Orion argued. "And who's to say it won't turn against *you*? What if it decides you and everybody else serve no more purpose in its life?"

Schmutzkoph looked at an oil painting across from the bay window that depicted a stormy landscape.

"Then perhaps it is for the best…" he said, almost as though he were saying it to himself.

What the hell does that mean? Willits thought to himself.

"Mr. Thomas," Schmutzkoph said, "I'd like for you to analyze the files left behind by

Isaac. And help Mr. Willits here find a way to protect *Cerberus* from his own sibling."

"Of course."

"Jason," Schmutzkoph continued, "please find a way to speed up construction of the new Vault. We are expecting a shipment of raw parts from our departed friend's robotics company soon."

"What do you want me to do with the shipment?" Jason asked.

"Scatter it inside the Vault. We will let *Cerberus* create his own children and see what he comes up with."

"You could give it access to the old files," Orion said. "Maybe it will reach Stage-Five ahead of schedule."

"Good idea," Schmutzkoph looked at Orion. "We may do that, after you take care of my servers."

Orion nodded.

"Well, Mr. Thomas, that concludes our business for now. Mr. Willits and I must go over this week's schedule. If you please…"

Orion stood up and walked to Schmutzkoph's desk. He shook his hand and nodded at Jason before leaving the study. He walked down the stairs and exited the home to his waiting limousine and pair of personal guards.

One of the large men waited at the front passenger door while the other one held the rear passenger door open. Orion slipped inside, followed immediately by his bodyguard. He pulled out his cell phone and dialled a number.

"Hey Shane, it's Karl," he said. "Listen, we need a team ready to assist *Global Technologies* tomorrow. They got a new one on their servers and it seems pretty ugly… They haven't identified the format signature yet… Okay, thanks; see you tomorrow." He hung up his cell phone and placed it back into his jacket pocket.

He tried to look out his tinted windows and only saw the reflection of himself. He switched on the LCD screen in front of him and switched the input to the front bumper camera.

He watched a fish-lens view of the night drive -- the dark road and fluorescent yellow traffic slipping beyond the camera's view. The trees on either side of the road appeared briefly in the flood of halogen light that radiated from the limo's headlamps then disappeared just as quickly out of view.



Suddenly a flash of orange light appeared in the centre of the screen. Karl stared intently as the orange light got larger and a dark shadow in the centre of the light briefly silhouetted under the headlamps, exposing Karl's view of a green cylinder with a black tip. The LCD screen and all of the lights in the limo went out as a loud explosion rocked the limo on its chassis.

The vehicle jerked to the right and crashed, sending Orion flying out of his seat. He hit his head hard and smelt smoke. He heard the sound of repeated spits of silenced gunfire and bullet-resistant glass cracking.

He looked up and saw his bodyguard get up slowly off the ground. The bodyguard peeked outside the door window and slipped a pistol out from under his jacket.

"Stay down," the guard whispered to Orion.

The bodyguard slowly opened the door, using the Kevlar-padded barrier to provide

cover. He slowly stepped outside. Orion watched him sweep his surroundings with his pistol aimed in front of him.

A twig snapped in the distance and the bodyguard turned around to fire. He let off three loud gunshots before a burst of repeated muffled spits signaled the presence of a hidden gunman. Several bullets passed through the bodyguard's torso and Kevlar vest and he fell to the ground.

Orion lay flat on the floor of the limo holding his breath. The door swung open wildly. The black divider behind Orion's head fell out of its place, letting in a faint orange glow of rolling flames from the front seat of the car.

A pitch-black figure appeared in the doorway aiming an assault rifle at Orion. Without saying a word the figure slowly looked around inside the spacious limousine for more guards. Orion could not make out the figure's face. All he could see was a black mask covered by a pair of protruding lenses where the eyes should be.

The black figure stepped backward and another one stepped inside, hovering over Orion. The second all-black figure placed its whole hand on Orion's nose and mouth. Orion struggled to scream as his nose and lungs filled with a bitter, intoxicating smell. For Orion, everything then became a blur and faded to darkness.

IOOOI

Seventeen

July 06,
Year 0 T.S.

The loud hum of the twin propeller engines droned on, drowning out all other noise within the dark cargo hold of the painted-black Bell Boeing V-22 Osprey. The Osprey maintained high altitude throughout its flight path through the Canadian province of British Columbia. The twelve men from Army Special Forces' Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit were strapped into their seats, awaiting the green light to deploy over their area of operations.



The aircraft flew above the cover of clouds, hidden from the view of the unsuspecting civilian populace below. Above the clouds however, it was as clear as a night desert sky.

The men from CYCO Unit knew their roles, as did the Delta Force attachment that trailed behind their aircraft in an identical Osprey. They felt they were prepared for anything. Any and all equipment they may need was secured in a care package that would drop down in the centre of the HAARP complex once the Delta attachment secured the guard towers.

The care package would be dropped from the aircraft as soon as Lieutenant Staacman gave the all-clear. In the meantime, they waited to leave Canadian airspace and reach the Alaska Mountain Range.

Meanwhile, back in Peterson Air Force Base, Major Henson stood in the centre of the command room surrounded by monitors, radiomen and technicians who observed the two Osprey-s progress via overhead Unmanned Aerial Vehicles. They received live images from the soldiers' mounted cameras which would be routed to the airbase by an AWACS aircraft that skirted the northern border of Oregon.

One of the operators reported that the men were five minutes away from the

Northwest Territories. Major Henson acknowledged the report and checked on the operators that monitored the mounted cameras.

Henson noticed that one of the camera monitors was beginning to fill with static. The operator noticed as well and relayed a transmission to the AWACS:

"*Watchtower* this is *Throne Room*; relay to *Papa Three Delta,* break…"

Aboard the lead Osprey, Staacman's headset crackled to life:

"Papa Three Delta *this is* Watchtower*; check Hudson's camera, we're getting static, over."*

Staacman shouted, "Hudson, check your cam!"

Hudson reached his hand up to the camera and smacked it hard.

"Papa tree, *camera's fixed. Out."*

"*Alright boys,"* the pilot of the Osprey said over the internal comms, "*we're now leaving B.C. airspace and are currenting flying through the Northwest Territories. Next stop: Alaska; ETA five mikes."*

"Last chance," Staacman shouted, "check your gear!"

Everybody removed the restraints that kept them safely inside the cargo seats. One by one they stood up, stretched a bit and helped each other check their gear.

Jefferson and Carl Semple were both shaken on the inside. Earlier that day they had been given a crash course in wing-suit jumping at high altitudes. They felt they had gotten the hang of it, but their instructor had simply said, "At least you didn't run into each other…" and turned to walk away after they landed.

But it was too late to back out now. Even so, they were the only ones with the specialist equipment that would accompany teams *Parasite* and *Virus.*

They checked each other's gear, opened the liquid nitrogen valves on their specialist weaponry, tugged on their weapons' shoulder straps and made sure their portable oxygen tanks were secure. Throughout the cargo hold the soldiers all checked their rifles, chambered rounds and slipped their oxygen masks down over their faces.

"*Alright boys,"* the pilot said over the intercom, "*ETA thirty seconds."*

"*Watchtower,* this is *Papa Three Delta*," Staacman said, "we're locked and ready, request to begin mission, over."

"Copy, Papa Three Delta, *Operation DYNASTY is active. All go on green light. Break,"* was the response over the headset. "*Be advised; you're in the middle of a snowstorm. Winds are clocked at three-zero clicks. Visibility is reported to be zero. Temperature is one-five foxtrot. Over."*

Fifteen degrees fahrenheit, Staacman thought to himself, *Jesus.*

Staacman replied, "Copy *Watchtower.* Out."

He looked up to his men. "Alright guys," he said, "it's going to be chilly and white out there, so keep an eye on your gauges and watch your spacing. Use your beacons! Edwards, you're on point; everybody follows his lead. Get ready…"

The rear bay door slowly dropped open. All twelve men faced the opening as they opened the valves to their oxygen masks. The temperature in the cargo hold immediately dropped below freezing. Jefferson Smith began to shiver.

The red light in the corner of the doorway switched to green.

"*Go go go!"* Staacman shouted.

One by one the members of CYCO Unit jumped out of the Osprey and spread their arms and legs so their webbed suits could catch pockets of air and allow them to glide through the storm.

Staacman grabbed Jefferson's shoulder before he jumped.

"Remember Smith," Staacman said, "don't bunch up out there. Arms and legs straight out."

Jefferson nodded. Staacman let him go and ran out the doorway behind him. The cold air bit at the exposed parts of his forehead and cheeks as he pitched head-first into freefall. In the distance he saw strobes of flashing beacons below as his squad mates followed Corporal Edwards through the storm.

Staacman's headset crackled to life: "Papa Three, *this is* Guardian; *we're heads-up on your six."* It was the Delta Force attachment.

"Copy *Guardian,* see you on the ground; out."

He fell below the thick cover of clouds but could still see nothing beyond his body but the blurry flash of beacons below. He watched the gauges on his forearm wind down rapidly as he fell steadily to the mountains below.

As he continued to glide through the storm following the trail of lights, he started to see the grey jutting peak of the mountains. He could also see the blurry coronas of floodlights on the ground approaching rapidly.

Staacman heard Corporal Edwards' voice over the radio:

"Papa Three *deploy now!*"

Almost instantly he saw a dozen parachutes deploy in rapid succession. He pulled his own ripcord and in half a second his body jerked violently to a soft fall.

Below him the mountains began to tear through the snowy cover of the storm and already his squad mates were landing in a small valley. The parachutes crumpled to the ground as their owners disconnected and spread out to form a perimeter. They covered the remaining soldiers as they recovered from their landings.

Staacman touched his feet to the ground and ducked into a roll. He disconnected his chutes and closed the valve to his oxygen mask. The snow and wind whipped at him fiercely, so much so that his lips felt frozen the second he removed his oxygen mask.

He looked above to see how close the Delta soldiers were, but saw nothing above him. "*Guardian,* this is *Papa Three Delta*," he said. "What's your twenty, over?"

"Papa Three, *this is* Guardian*; we overshot our approach and landed down range. We're about three-hundred metres West of AO, on the roadway. We're Oscar Mike to AO, over."*

"Copy, we'll see you there. Out." *Shit*, Staacman thought.

He shouted to his squad over the screaming wind, "Alright boys, we're on our own for now. *Guardian's* gonna meet us at the complex. *Virus,* we're on point; *Parasite*, keep six. Move out!"

Staacman ran up to Corporal Hudson and side-by-side they led CYCO Unit out of the valley.

Master-Sergeant Martin's voice came over the radio:

"*Hey, L.T., did* Watchtower *explain why Christmas came six months early?"*

"Your guess is as good as mine, Sergeant." Staacman said.

"*Do you think it has something to do with the complex?"* Jefferson asked over the radio.

"I don't see how," *Virus's* specialist, Carl Semple, replied, "but I wouldn't bet against it. What would be a better way to slow down the enemy?"

"This isn't the time to debate robot strategies and tactics, boys," Staacman interrupted. "Just stay frosty."

The twelve-man team travelled through the small valley. They came across an

empty steel box covered in snow. Staacman held his fist in the air to halt the unit and ordered Corporal Hudson to check it out. Hudson ran to the box and looked inside.

"Nothing in it sir," he said. "Probably the SEALs' care package."

"Regroup Hudson," Staacman ordered.

Hudson ran back and they all continued on.

They reached a small foothill. Beyond the hill they saw the streetlights from the HAARP complex. The bright lights overshadowed the large buildings on the opposite side of a thirty-foot-high perimeter fence. Staacman pulled a viewfinder from his vest and looked through it.

He scanned the fence and spotted a hole in the fence. Staacman presumed that hole was where the SEALs entered the complex from as well. Staacman took point and moved forward, followed by his squad who all kept their rifles aimed at the fence. They reached the fence and entered the compound's property one-by-one.

Parasite and *Virus* covered each corner of the building they hid behind while the six-man team designated *Telescope* and advanced on either side of the building, turning their respective corners and advancing further into the compound. *Parasite* then ran along the length of the building, passed by *Virus* on to the next building and turned around a corner, advancing forward behind *Telescope*.

Virus moved forward. Staacman scanned the outer courtyard before ordering his three-man squad forward. They ran through the courtyard to the security checkpoint blocking the main entrance. *Parasite* ran over to the opposite side of the checkpoint and took cover behind a concrete barrier. Corporal Hudson entered the guardhouse and pulled a switch.

The giant doors in the perimeter fence slid open and the Delta Force soldiers jogged inside. The gate shut behind them as they split into two six-man teams and breached the steel doors leading to the top of the guard towers on either end of the perimeter gate.

Staacman eyed the innermost parts of the courtyard while *Telescope* held their position at the side of the two large buildings to Staacman's right flank. They were tasked with providing crossfire if anything tried to rush the front gate while the Delta Force soldiers secured the two towers.

On each tower a pair of snipers covered the roadway leading to the base and the inner courtyard beyond. A soldier manned the floodlight on each tower and swept the inner areas of the compound. The floodlights pierced through the dense snow squall. One other soldier stayed atop each tower, ready to man the mounted M60 machine guns while the remaining troops returned back down the stairs to relieve *Parasite* and *Virus of their positions.*

Staacman heard on his radio:

*"*Watchtower *this is* Guardian*; control point is secure; ready to receive care packages at green flare, over."*

"Copy Guardian*; launch green flare, over."*

Staacman heard a single gunshot from one of the towers and saw a bright plume of green flame ascend to the sky above.

*"*Archangel One *has eyes on green flare,* Guardian; *standby."*

"*Parasite*," Staacman said, "you got point when the package lands."

"Yes sir," Martin responded. He remained crouched behind the concrete barrier,

rifle drawn, aimed towards the centre of the courtyard.

"*Be advised*, Guardian: *Package is delivered, beacon is activated. Good luck out there. Out."*

Staacman looked skyward and spotted a flashing red light in the sky falling rapidly. A parachute deployed and slowed the falling box until it crashed gently to the ground. Sergeant Martin, Jefferson Smith and Corporal Edwards left the barrier and swiftly advanced towards the care package while Staacman, Carl Semple and Corporal Hudson trailed behind at a safe distance.

Edwards and Smith pulled the chute off the box and opened it. Jefferson dug inside first to grab his equipment. He grabbed a set of thermal goggles and a backpack then placed inside of it an oxyacetylene torch, bolt cutters and packages of C4 charges. Semple approached from behind and grabbed the same equipment.

After that Sergeant Martin stood in front of the box and handed each soldier a set of night-vision goggles, an ammunition belt with extra magazines and a water canteen.

"Save your canteens for the SEALs," Martin commanded. "They're probably gonna need 'em."

After grabbing their gear teams *Virus* and *Parasite* ran to their left flank to cover *Telescope* as they approached the care package to resupply. Once everybody was supplied, *Virus* and *Parasite* proceeded away from the gate towards the armory. *Telescope* covered the courtyard by sending three men across and another three men to trail behind *Virus* and *Parasite.*

Parasite ran past the doorway of the armoury and both teams flanked the door. Corporal Hudson grabbed a flashbang from his ammo belt and pulled the pin. Jefferson pushed the door open while Hudson tossed the grenade inside.

Jefferson pulled the door shut as the concussive sonic boom resonated inside. Immediately after the bang, Jefferson shoved the door open and everybody rushed inside.

Through his thermal goggles Jefferson could see a red-hot patch on the floor where the flashbang had detonated. Everywhere else appeared blue to him. It was cold inside the armoury; the heating system had been disabled.

Edwards and Martin came in after Jefferson Smith and they all turned to their left. They passed by aisle after aisle of weapon racks. Team *Virus* followed behind and moved straight down the first aisle to the opposite end of the armoury. Both teams searched for hostiles and found none. The armoury was clear.

"Alright guys," Martin said over the radio. "Check your aisles for missing weapons or ammo and take note of it. Grab a weapon too in case we find any friendlies."

The soldiers scanned the aisles with their night vision, searching for anything out of the ordinary. Staacman, Hudson and Semple walked through an aisle filled with rocket launchers and grenades. Nothing seemed out of place so far.

"*Lieutenant,"* Staacman heard over his headset.

It was Martin, *"We got a whole row of mags missing here. Looks like… five-five-six FMJ's ; almost two dozen mags missing."*

They're running out of explosive-tipped rounds, Staacman thought, *but they can still pierce body armour.*

"Hey guys," Corporal Hudson said. "Did anybody else notice that the door was closed?"

"Yeah," Edwards replied over the radio. *"So what?"*

"So… we're dealing with robots that break into an armoury, steal *just a few* mags

and close the door behind them? Does any of this make sense to you?"

"I said don't think about it, Corporal," Staacman interjected. "Let the specialists do the thinkin'. You just keep your head up and eyes & ears open!"

"Yes sir."

Semple walked up to Staacman's side.

"I think he has a point," Semple said quietly.

Staacman eyed him briefly. "What's on your mind?"

"The storm. The ammo. The armoury. It seems like they're settling here."

"You mean like, their base of operations?"

"I mean like a new home."

The two teams searched each aisle and each man picked up an H&K MP5 submachine gun to sling over their shoulders. They then left the armoury. They proceeded double-time to the security checkpoint in front of the mountain entrance and walked over to the blast door.

A small hole had been blown open in the centre of the door. It was just large enough to fit one man at a time. *Telescope* hid behind the security checkpoint and covered all positions that overlooked the mountain complex entrance.

Staacman spoke into his headset: "*Parasite* take point. *Telescope*, break off into two-man teams and maintain visual contact at all times. Move out."

Edwards entered the breach first, followed by Jefferson and Martin. Hudson, Semple and Staacman followed. *Parasite* slowly walked forward, keeping their goggles on despite the dim lighting from the bare light bulbs in the ceiling.

The biting cold from the howling wind behind them subsided and an eerie moan from the wind drowned out the silence of the complex ahead. Staacman let team *Parasite* go ahead a bit then gestured for his team to move forward when *Parasite* was just barely visible in his night vision.

He wanted to maintain contact with *Guardian* for as long as possible. But he wasn't sure how well radio waves would travel through the mountain.

They reached the vehicle port and used the cars for cover as they approached the warehouse door. They slipped under the garage door and stepped around the fetid bodies that lay about on their way to the hall that forked off in two directions. *Telescope* had followed them beyond the vehicle port right into the warehouse, but made sure to stay as far away as possible without losing visual contact.

"*Telescope*, do you copy?" Staacman said into his headset.

There was no response.

"*Telescope*, this is *Virus*; radio check."

Still no response.

"Sir," Hudson said, "All I'm gettin' is interference. Listen…"

Hudson pressed a button on his headset and Staacman's ears filled with electronic noise.

Staacman looked at Hudson and said, "Try another channel."

Both Staacman and Hudson switched to different radio frequencies, but the noise permeated all the bandwidths.

"Radio jammers?" Semple suggested.

"No," Staacman replied, "it would be static or silent. That's a transmission signal." Staacman turned down his headset. "Let's check the research labs first." Staacman turned around and waved a pair of soldiers from *Telescope* down to him.

As they ran up to him Staacman noticed a second pair of soldiers from *Telescope* take over the first pair's old position. He waved them up as well.

Staacman spoke to the first pair, "Secure the security office. See if you can spot any captives on cams and report when we return."

The first pair ran down the hall towards the security office door. The second pair reached Staacman.

"Hold this position. We're gonna check the research labs."

The pair from *Telescope* nodded then *Parasite* and *Virus* moved out.

The fluorescent lights in the hall before the labs were intact and shining bright. The soldiers flipped their night vision goggles up while Carl Semple and Jefferson Smith kept their thermal goggles on. Along the walls were double-pane Plexiglass windows that looked into the lab rooms.

The teams each took to opposite walls, crouching below the windowsills and advancing slowly. Staacman, Semple and Hudson took to the left wall. Staacman grabbed a small mirror from his vest pocket, flipped it open and angled it to view over the windowsill.

He slowly rotated the mirror and carefully scanned the whole lab room. He saw two men lying on steel gurneys, strapped down and naked, with a copper-mesh-clad Adam model standing in front of them. Its back was turned to Staacman, but he could still tell it was doing something with its hands to one of the soldiers.

Staacman put his mirror away and made hand gestures to his troops to indicate that he spotted one hostile and two prisoners. *Parasite* slowly overtook *Virus's* position on the wall. Martin inched towards the doorway and aimed his M4A1 rifle beyond the doorway.

He moved deliberately as he tried to find a clear line-of-sight on the Adam mode. From out the corner of his eye Martin spotted movement. A small security camera had rotated within its glass dome and aimed his optics directly at Martin.

With its back still facing the soldiers the Adam model spontaneously leaped to the left. Martin lost sight of the machine. Martin crossed over to the other side of the doorway and took cover just as a volley of bullets flew out of the lab room.

Staacman craned his neck to see over the window sill but ducked back down as soon as the machine spotted him. Bullets penetrated the Plexiglass window and embedded themselves into the window across the hall.

"Smith," Staacman ordered, "freeze the glass!"

Confused, Jefferson did as he was told. He aimed his liquid nitrogen nozzle at the Plexiglass. The nitrogen froze solid on impact and crystallized on the Plexiglass.

Staacman took the butt of his rifle and smashed through the glass. He ducked back down as another burst of bullets flew over his head.

"Martin," Staacman ordered, "draw its fire!"

Martin held his rifle left-handed and opened fire from the cover of the doorway. He fired in short, controlled bursts until he heard the machine return fire. Staacman then rose above the windowsill as the Adam model turned its gaze at him, ready to fire.

He ducked back down just in time as another barrage of bullets flew past him. The Adam model moved to the right as it sprayed bullets into the doorway in an attempt at drawing Martin out of cover.

The gunfire stopped and the soldiers heard the sound of a magazine hitting the ground. The Adam model was reloading.

"*Now!!"* Staacman shouted.

He stood up and fired through the window pane as Martin slipped inside and fired as well. The Adam model dropped to all fours and crawled swiftly towards the steel gurneys in an attempt to take cover behind the imprisoned Navy SEALs.

Staacman jumped through the window then he and Martin approached the opposite ends of the gurneys. Suddenly they heard the ripping sound of high-voltage electricity and the *whoosh*ing sound of the Adam model's plasma cutter igniting.

Staacman rushed over to get a clear shot at the machine when one of the gurneys toppled over and the Adam model lunged at him. In a panic, Martin fired a burst of bullets inches above the other SEAL's head. The bullets made contact with the machine's upper back and the base of the neck.

The machine went limp in mid-air as Staacman dove to his right to avoid the white-hot flame of the plasma cutter. The machine dropped to the ground and the plasma cutter bored a red-hot, molten hole into the concrete floor. Flecks of magma flew everywhere as the flame slowly died down.

The rest of the men entered the lab. Hudson took cover by the window to defend the room. Martin walked over to Staacman and grabbed his arm to hoist him back up. Edward, Semple and Smith went over to the gurney that had been toppled over and placed it back upright.

The naked soldier was limp. Edwards removed one of his gloves and checked both soldiers for a pulse.

"They're both alive," Edwards said, "but sedated."

"Can you wake them?" Staacman asked.

"Normally I wouldn't," Edwards replied, "but we can't exactly haul them out on these."

Hudson chuckled sarcastically. "You think?!" he said.

"Smith, help me look for some epinephrine."

Edwards walked over to a stainless steel cabinet. Jefferson searched the other side of the lab. "What does it look like?" he asked.

"Clear liquid in a ten-mil syringe. There should be a pile of them."

Jefferson opened a drawer next to a sink but found nothing.

Martin walked around to the other side of the gurneys and found half a dozen syringes sealed in plastic packages on the floor. He bent over, picked up a handful and turned around.

"Edwards," Martin said, "this what you're lookin' for?"

He tossed a pack into the air towards Corporal Edwards who caught it with his free hand.

"Perfect!" he said.

Jefferson came over and grabbed a syringe from Sergeant Martin.

"What do I do?" he asked.

"Find a vein in the arm and administer just two mils," Edwards explained. "The shit's powerful so don't overdo it."

Jefferson removed the packaging and searched the soldier's arm for a vein. Edwards stared at Jefferson intently.

"Hey, Smith," Edwards said.

Jefferson stopped to look at him.

"*Only two mils!*"

Jefferson nodded. They each found a vein, pierced the needle through each

SEAL's skin and depressed the plungers just enough to administer a fifth of the syringe's contents.

The two Navy SEALs eyes went wide as they took in deep gulps of breath. Jefferson and Edwards worked to remove the restraints from the two sailors as they overcame the adrenaline-induced panic they were currently experiencing.

Staacman approached the two Navy SEALs.

"Relax sailors, you're safe," he said. "I'm Lieutenant Marcus Staacman, US Army, Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit. Identify yourselves."

The two SEALs were wide-eyed and frantically darting their heads from one soldier to another in an attempt to process what was happening.

Staacman turned to one of his subordinates. "Give them some water," he said.

Edwards and Jefferson used their hands to place the sailors' heads upward. They then poured a small sip of water into their mouths. One of the SEALs grabbed the whole canteen from Jefferson and drank it desperately.

"Name and rank, sailor?" Staacman asked.

Immediately both SEALs appeared calmer and more aware of their surroundings. The one on the right looked directly at Staacman while the other continued to drink from his canteen.

"Lieutenant Charles, US Navy SEALs, Second-in-Command" the SEAL finally said.

"Lieutenant," Staacman said, "you're safe for now." He looked to the other SEAL and asked, "What's your name?"

The sailor lowered the canteen from his mouth. A stream of water ran down from his chin.

"Master Chief Wells sir," he responded.

"Can you guys walk?" Staacman asked.

"Do we have a choice?" Lieutenant Charles asked rhetorically.

Staacman smiled. "No, Charles, you don't. Here…"

Staacman removed the H&K MP5 from his shoulder and gave it to Charles. Edwards gave his MP5 to Wells.

"Where are your clothes?" Staacman asked.

The two SEALs looked down at their naked bodies then back at Staacman.

"No idea, Lieutenant," Charles said.

Staacman rolled his eyes. "*Parasite*," he said, "check the other rooms for lab coats or something. We can't expect these guys to wait for evac butt-naked in the Arctic."

"Did you guys at least send Ivan back to Moscow?" Chief Wells asked.

"Huh?" Staacman muttered.

He then remembered that these guys were deployed under the impression they were engaging Russian Spetznaz.

"You didn't see any hostels before this?" he asked.

Wells shook his head no. "We were in the Command Centre when the HALON systems activated. Ivan caught us by surprise sir."

"They weren't Russians, Master Chief."

Staacman aimed his rifle at the powerless Adam model before everybody's feet.

The two SEALs stared at the machine in utter disbelief.

"No way…" Wells muttered. The two prisoners crouched down before the machine and examined their former captor.

Staacman continued, "Your team was the victim of an intel SNAFU, thanks to one dumbshit Alaska Governor."

The two SEALs stood back up.

"What about the Commander?" Charles asked. "The rest of our team?"

"So far, you three…" Staacman pointed to the machine again, "... are the *only* ones we've found that don't belong here."

"The Commander said they were checkin' the residences and research labs," Charles said as he looked at Wells.

"We're in the labs right now," Semple interjected.

"We'll check the residences right after we get you guys covered up," Staacman added.

Edwards ran into the lab carrying a pile of white clothing.

"I found their jumpsuits sir," Edwards said, "they were ripped to shreds." He threw the clothes at the two SEALs and added, "At least they're not hospital gowns."

The two soldiers donned the white scrub pants and shirts they were given. They were still barefoot and leaked from their sedation, but CYCO Unit couldn't slow down for them, nor could they leave them behind.

"Alright Hudson," Staacman said, "take point. *Parasite*, cover our asses."

The six CYCO Unit soldiers with their two SEAL objectives headed back the way they came.

As they reached the intersection leading to the warehouse Edwards called out, "*Telescope*, friendlies Oscar Mike!"

"Copy, weapons clear," was the response from down the hall.

One of the soldiers stepped out from the corner to greet teams *Parasite* and *Virus*.

Hudson stopped at the intersection and gestured to Lieutenant Charles and Master Chief Wells. "I'll take you guys to the security office," he said.

"To hell with that," Charles said, "we're helping to find our team!"

Hudson looked at Staaman, unsure what to do. "Sir?"

"Lieutenant," Staacman said to Charles, "you guys don't even have boots. You'll slow us down. You can help our guys check the surveillance cameras for your team, let us *grunts* do the work."

Charles nodded reluctantly. Staacman and Hudson escorted the two SEALs to the security door. Martin trailed behind as well.

Staacman opened the door and stepped inside. The two soldiers in the room stared intently at the monitors.

"Any luck?" Staacman asked.

"No sir," one of the soldiers said. "A bunch of cameras are shot and the rest we can't control."

"What about the cameras in the research lab?" Martin asked as he walked inside.

The two soldiers straightened and looked at Martin.

"Come again, Sarge?"

"Before we engaged the Adam unit I saw a camera move and point at us."

"Oh yeah," the other soldier said. "That's the weird part. It moved on its own as soon as you came into view. I think the system's automated."

Martin walked up to Staacman's side. "That thing moved as soon as the camera zeroes in on me, sir," he said.

Staacman thought about the signal over the radio. *Were the machine's controlling the security cameras remotely somehow?*

"Find a way to get those other cameras online," he said to the men from *Telescope*.

“And try to disable the ones in the residence.”

“Yes sir.”

Staacman, Hudson and Martin left the security room and walked back to the intersection.

“Alright guys,” Staacman said, “let’s check the residences.”

Virus led the way as the six soldiers went through a corridor parallel to the one they took to get to the research labs, searching for move survivors.

IOOIO

Eighteen

July 06,
Year 0 T.S.

The men of CYCO Unit and their two rescued Navy SEALs hollowed-out cavern that housed the live-in residences for the mountain complex. From the entrance Staacman could smell the putrid stench of death. He saw two men splayed on the ground about twenty feet to his left and one next to a fake tree in the centre of the yard.

Most of the windows to each of the living units were broken and shattered. Scorch marks and bullet holes riddled to facades of each living unit.

"*Parasite*," Staacman whispered, "take the right flank."

Jefferson, Martin and Edwards headed to the right column of living units. They entered the apartment closest to them while Staacman, Semple and Hudson went to the unit on the left where the two dead men lay at the foot of the door.

Hudson bent over the two bodies to examine them. One wore army fatigues and the other wore a Navy SEAL jumpsuit. They had both been shot through the chest.

The men from team *Virus* entered the apartment and found two more bodies inside. There was one behind a couch who had been shot in the face, neck and chest. The other SEAL appeared to have been disemboweled.

The three men cleared the rest of the apartment before walking through a hole in the wall that led to the next living unit. They searched the apartment and found nothing. They left the apartment and repeated the process for the last five units.

Between *Virus* and *Parasite*, a total of ten bodies had been found. All but one of the bodies wore SEAL uniforms. The six men met back up at the front entrance to the residence cave and walked back to the security office in solemn silence.

Staacman entered the security office and looked at the two SEALs with sadness. "Your team's dead, guys," he said quietly.

Charles and Wells looked at each other then down at the ground. Wells shut his eyes in frustration.

"We found ten bodies," Staacman continued, "nine SEALs, one army."

Charles looked up at Staacman and nodded.

"Private Moore," he said. "We found him unconscious in a Jeep."

There was a shared moment of silence between everybody in the room. Suddenly, Wells looked up.

"Wait a minute," he said, "you said, 'nine SEALs one Army,' right?"

Staacman nodded.

Charles looked at Wells and said, "Jackson maybe?"

"Maybe he's still in the Command Centre!" Wells' eyes beamed with hope.

"Stay here," Staacman said, "we'll check the Command Centre." Staacman looked to his squadmates from *Telescope*. "Any luck with those cameras?"

"No sir," one of the men said. "We have no access to them from here."

"Alright, guard this room. We'll be back after we check the Command Centre."

Staacman left the security office.

The six men proceeded down the dark hallway. They passed several corners and doors until they reached the entrance to the Command Centre. The steel door was open. All they could see inside the doorway was a short, dark alcove that led to a small flight of steps. A giant LCD screen flickered at the end of the room.

Martin looked back at Staacman who gestured with his open hand to move forward. Martin walked through the doorway and swept left after ascending the staircase. He aimed his rifle up towards the command booth above and behind the entrance alcove.

The rest of the men moved in and spread out among the aisles of computer terminals, covering as much ground as possible. Each man sporadically reported their parts of the room to be clear of hostiles. They then regrouped near the command booth.

“Room’s clear sir,” Martin said. “No SEALs in here.”

“We should be able to access the main system from here,” Staacman said. “Hudson, see if you can tap the cameras.”

“I’m on it, L.T.,” Hudson ran into the glass command booth and bent over the computer terminal.

“Everybody else, cover that doorway.”

Semple and Smith stood on either side of the alcove and aimed their nitrogen hoses towards the door. Edwards, Martin and Staacman took cover behind the computer terminals.

A small popping noise startled Staacman as a glass tube inside the LCD screen behind him ruptured. The large screen went dead and pitched the entire room into darkness. Then the lights in the hallway went out. Staacman could hear the computer terminals in front of him begin to shut down.

“Hudson!” Staacman shouted. “What the fuck did you do to the power?!”

“It wasn’t me, Lieutenant. I don’t know what happened!”

Staacman heard a steady rhythm of clicking noises coming from the hallway. He flipped his night-vision goggles down over his eyes and waited for them to power up. As soon as his goggles activated he saw an Adam model stalking forward slowly on all fours just beyond the door.

Staacman opened fire and sent three bursts of explosive-tipped bullets into the machine, sending it flying backwards. From further down the hall a muzzle flash appeared. The three soldiers ducked for cover.

The bullets flew past them, into the Command Centre’s vast array of computer screens. Staacman heard a low rumbling noise ahead. He poked his head up from his hiding spot to see the steel door to the Command Centre closing on its own.

“The door!” he shouted.

Martin and Edwards sprinted for the door and slammed their bodies against it in futile attempts to prevent it from closing. The door sealed shut with a loud bang and a large locking mechanism whirred and clicked inside the door’s interior as it proceeded to make an airtight seal.

Martin continued to slam his body into the door. “Shit!” he shouted. He banged his fist against the door then turned around. “We’re locked in and there’s no way out!”

“Hudson!” Staacman shouted. “What’s taking so fucking long?!”

“I’m trying sir,” Hudson shouted back. “But somebody else’s in the network tring to backhack me!”

“We’re not leaving this base until you shut those systems down, Corporal!”

The fire alarm began to sound and red klaxons began to flash on and off. Streams

of white smoke erupted from nozzles in the ceiling, blanketing the floor and steadily rising.

"HALON gas!" Semple shouted.

"Masks on!" Staacman grabbed his breathing mask from around his neck, placed it on his face and opened the valve. He flipped up his night vision goggles, grabbed his skydiving goggles from his vest pocket and placed them over his eyes. He then flipped his goggles back down. He looked around and saw everybody else wearing their breathing masks.

"Hudson," he shouted, "get your mask on!"

"What?!" Hudson shouted back.

"*Get… Your… Mask… On!!"*

Hudson's voice sounded muffled, but Staacman assumed it was because of the rushing sound of gas surrounding him.

"What?"

Staacman could not understand the reply that Hudson gave him.

"What the fuck did you say?!"

Hudson stepped out of the command booth, pointed to the mask on his face and pulled it up slightly so he could speak clearly.

"*My mask is on!"* he shouted.

"Put that shit back on, Hudson!"

Hudson replaced his mask and went back to work on the terminal. But as soon as he glanced back at the screen his heart sank.

"Fuck!!" he shouted. He ran back to Staacman.

"The terminal blue-screened," he said. "I can't do a fucking thing from here!"

"Shit," Staacman muttered.

The gas began to thicken and blind their night vision goggles.

"Smith, Semple," Staacman said, "we're walking blind now. You guys need to place charges on that door!"

Jefferson Smith and Carl Semple ran down to the steel door and grabbed C4 charges from each other's backpacks. They placed them on the door and placed the electrodes inside the grey putty. They ran back up the steps and around a corner.

"*Fire in the hole!!*" Jefferson shouted.

The rest of the men took cover as Semple grabbed the remote detonator from Jefferson's pack and pulled the switch.

The shockwave sent the steel door flying off the hinges. It scraped along the floor as it came to a halt. Bullets began pouring into the gas-filled room as the Adam model beyond laid down suppressing fire.

Hudson grabbed a flashbang, pulled the pin and threw the black cylinder out towards the machine. A couple of seconds later a deafening bang resonated into the Command Centre.

Jefferson looked around the corner with his thermal goggles which could still partially penetrate the thick HALON gas. He saw no signs of the Adam model. As he ran around the corner out into the hall he said to the others behind him, "Follow me."

Semple and Hudson followed him into the hallway as he ran to the corner where the machine had taken cover before. Jefferson poked his head around the corner and saw an open door down the hall. He waved back for someone to come close to him. He felt Hudson tap him on the back of the shoulder.

"Five doors to the right," Jefferson said. "I think it went inside."

Hudson looked back into the Command Centre and gestured for the rest of the

team to regroup. Staacman, Martin and Edwards ran up close to them.

"Cover me," Hudson muttered, "I'll try to flush it out."

An emergency light at the end of the hall gave him just enough light to see, so he removed his mask and night-vision goggles. Edwards crossed over to the other part of the intersection overlooking the hall while Martin took Jefferson's place. Hudson slung his rifle over his shoulder and grabbed a fragmentation grenade.

He clutched the explosive in one hand and held the pin in place with the other. He slowly walked along the left wall and inched towards the open door. When he got within ten feet of the door he pulled the pin and reached his arm back.

Hudson was preparing to throw the grenade just as the Adam model slipped out from the darkness and surprised him with a burst of armour-piercing bullets. Hudson fell backwards and slid his back along the wall until he fell to the floor. The grenade rolled out of his hand as the Adam model opened fire at Edwards and Martin.

"Take cover!" Martin shouted. Everybody crouched and huddled against the wall as the grenade exploded. The shockwave was followed by searing-hot frag as it ricocheted off the steel bulkheads in the hall.

Martin got up and scanned the scorched hall with his night vision goggles. Hudson lay dead on the floor with thousands of bloody wounds now covering his body. Smoke floated up from the holes in his jumpsuit where hot shrapnel had melted through to the skin.

Down the hall he could see the machine lying on the floor, struggling to stand itself back up. Martin left the cover of the wall and slowly walked towards the Adam model. He levelled his M4A1 directly at the machine and emptied his entire magazine into it, execution-style.

Small sparks and explosions leapt from within the copper-mesh coating of the machine. Its limbs and copper tail went limp as smoke escaped its fried interior. Martin expelled the empty magazine and replaced it with a fresh one.

"Clear," he said.

The remaining four men left the corner and walked up behind Martin. He knelt beside Hudson and dug into his vest for his dog-tags and magazines.

"We need to go to the server banks," Jefferson said. "We can't leave this place in their hands."

"Let's do it," Staacman replied.

Martin stood back up and they all walked down the hallway towards the fragged Adam model. At the end of the hall they saw a sign with arrows on it. It indicated that to the right were the Residences, Security and Warehouses. They headed left toward the server rooms.

As the five men headed down the hall they heard a banging noise coming from ahead. The soldiers braced themselves and aimed downrange, preparing for the worst. The banging continued.

Slowly, the five men advanced forward. Further down the hall, the fluorescent lighting was on and shining bright, so the soldiers flipped up their goggles. Jefferson and Semple flipped up theirs as well to give their eyes a rest.

The banging persisted and now the men could hear a female voice. It was muffled, as though coming from behind a heavy door.

"Hello? *Hello?!"* the female cried. "Somebody, let me out of here!"

"What the hell?" Edwards ran to the door and knocked on it twice.

"Lady," he said, "You okay?"

The woman sounded excited and frantic.

“Oh my God, thank God! Help me, I can’t get out and I don’t even know where I am or how I got here!”

“Hang on lady, we’ll get you out!” Edwards looked at the two specialists. “Come on and help me with this door.”

Semple and Smith helped him try to push the door open. They tried kicking it down. It wouldn’t budge.

“We could try melting then freezing,” Smith suggested. “That should shatter the locking mechanism.”

“Do it,” Edwards said.

He stepped closer to the door, “Hey lady,” he said, “what’s your name?”

“Uh, Alison,” she said fearfully.

“Okay Alison, we’re gonna get you out of there. But first we gotta cut through the door so I want you to step back. Don’t touch the door, and put a cloth over your eyes and mouth. Okay?”

There was a brief pause. “Okay,” Alison responded.

“Okay, go,” he said.

Semple grabbed the oxyacetylene torch from Jefferson’s pack and suddenly a loud ruckus came from up ahead.

Everybody looked to see what was going on. They heard the sound of tempered steel being warped and bent and broken under an immense force.

“Quick,” Martin shouted, “take cover!”

Everybody ran back the way they came to get behind a corner.

“Wait, you’re leaving me?!” Alison cried from beyond the door. “No, you gotta let me out! *Please, don’t leave me!!”*

“We’re not leaving you, Alison. Trust me,” Edwards said. “I promise, we’re not gonna get…”

A hail of bullets ripped through Edwards before he could finish his sentence. As he fell to the ground the remaining men of CYCO Unit saw a large rectangular steel door turned on its side in the middle of the hall. It appeared as though to be slowly advancing on them. Staacman then realized that a pair of Adam models were hiding behind it, using it as a small body shield.

Staacman and Martin opened fire, but all they could hit was the steel door. The bullets left deep indents within but they could not penetrate to the other side. The two Adam models extended their gun arms above and around the makeshift shield, but did not expose their heads at all.

They blind-fired with the accuracy of marksmen. A barrage of bullets missed Staacman’s face by less than an inch before he ducked back around the corner.

“Shit,” Staacman exclaimed, “I can’t get a clear shot!”

The gunfire stopped and he peeked around the corner again. The machines still slowly advanced. They were now halfway down the hall. They opened fire again almost as soon as Staacman poked his head out from behind the corner. Staacman took cover and was visibly frustrated.

“They’re not even looking at me and they know when to fucking shoot!”

“Sir, move over.” Martin shoved Staacman out of the way and peeked around the corner for a fraction of a second. A burst of bullets whizzed past the corner. Martin grabbed a grenade from his vest, pulled the pin and threw the grenade hard enough to land behind the machines. He looked around the corner again to see the machine moving

forward faster to avoid the grenade's blast radius.

"Run!" Martin shouted, "Retreat!"

Staacman, Semple and Jefferson turned around and sprinted as hard as they could in the direction of the security office while Martin backpedaled. He fired his M4 rifle with one hand while grabbing grenades from his vest with the other.

He pulled the pin out with his teeth and threw the grenade at the machines just before the first grenade exploded then turned around and ran as fast as he could.

Staacman reached the door to the security office and swung it open.

"Evac right now," he said. "Let's move it!"

The two CYCO Unit soldiers and two Navy SEALs left the room just as Staacman reached the intersection.

He looked down the dark hall at the two soldiers still in the warehouse and shouted, "Get outside and call for evac right now!"

The two soldiers turned and ran.

Martin came dashing up next to Staacman completely out of breath. "They're still on my tail," he said, "and I'm outta frags."

"Take them outta here, Sergeant." Staacman grabbed a frag grenade from his vest. "Get outside!"

Martin stood still, "But sir…"

"I'll cover our escape. Move it, Sergeant!"

Staacman looked around the corner to see the upended steel door closing on them like a hydraulic press. He pulled the pin and threw the grenade which only caused the machines to advance faster.

"Run, Goddammit!" he shouted.

The men all turned and ran down the dark hall towards the warehouse. The grenade exploded, which caught the members of *Telescope* and the two SEALs off guard. Startled from the rush of the shockwave they nearly tripped over the scores of dead bodies in the dark hall.

They all reached the warehouse and Staacman threw another grenade into the hall. He then shut the double-doors closed and ran through the warehouse towards the low-hanging garage door. He crawled under and rejoined his team. He heard the grenade explode beyond the garage door.

"Help me shut this!" he ordered.

He and two men from *Telescope* tried to find a place to grab the garage door so they could lower it shut, but it was no use. He heard a crashing noise beyond the door as the machines burst into the warehouse. He grabbed his final grenade and rolled it under the door.

"Okay," he shouted, "let's move it!"

The men from CYCO all ran through the vehicle port. The two SEALs stood still.

Staacman approached them. "Come on," he said, "we gotta go."

"We're not going, Lieutenant," Charles said.

Staacman was stunned. They were the whole point of his retreat.

"Bullshit," he said, "me orders were to get you out!"

"We're all vulnerable in the entryway, soldier. You know we'll never make it."

"You let *me* worry about that!"

The grenade exploded in the warehouse. Staacman knew his time was up.

Charles continued, "We'll suppress the enemy as long as we can, but we're *not going with you!* We got a score to settle."

Staacman didn't have time to think about it or to argue, so he made a judgment call. He handed his M4 to Lieutenant Charles.

"Explosive rounds are more effective," he said. He looked at Wells. "You will need to draw fire for Charles!"

Staacman turned and ran towards the long, dark roadway. Wells took cover in front of the warehouse as Charles moved to a flanking position.

"Tell Command to burn this place to the *fucking ground*!" Wells shouted.

Staacman sprinted down the cavernous roadway toward the dim light that seeped through the opening of the blast door. Behind him he heard long bursts of gunshots that lasted a few seconds, followed by silence. He came closer to the blast door.

Between his breaths and the pounding of his boots he heard the repeated clicks of metal on asphalt advancing swiftly. He ran as hard as he could. When he was close enough he lunged in the air and dived head-first into the opening of the blast door.

As Staacman landed outside in the bitter cold snowstorm he heard more gunshots, only this time they came from down the road. He looked behind him and saw the three remaining men from *Parasite* and *Virus* taking cover behind the security checkpoint.

"Hey!" Staacman shouted.

Martin looked back at him as he continued, "Cover the door!"

Martin patted Jefferson on the shoulder and gestured to the door. He handed Jefferson his M4 rifle. Jefferson aimed the M4 at the doorway and let out a burst of gunfire.

Staacman crawled towards Martin. As soon as he cleared Jefferson's line of fire he stood up and addressed Martin.

"What's the sitrep, Sergeant?" Staacman demanded.

"*Telescope* reports that *Guardian* has been wiped out," Martin responded. "We got hostile gunfire coming from the armoury and *Telescope* is stuck out in the open!"

"What about *Watchtower*?"

"They're sending evac and close-air support. ETA fives mikes."

"We need to flush out the armoury before the gunships arrive," Staacman said.

"Where're the SEALs sir?" Martin asked.

A bullet from within the mountain complex ricocheted beside his head. He and Staacman ducked while Jefferson continued firing into the doorway.

"They wouldn't come with me," Staacman replied. "They tried to cover our escape."

Martin poked his head around the corner to see the roadway. The members from *Telescope* were all lying prone out in the open courtyard, returning fire into the doorway of the armoury. Martin couldn't see the doorway of the armoury so he couldn't see exactly what they were firing at.

"If we can sneak up to the doorway and lay down suppressing fire," Martin suggested, "*Telescope* can run to the guard towers and man the LMGs."

"Alright Sergeant, let's do it," Staacman replied. "Jefferson, cover us!"

Jefferson kept firing as Martin, Staacman and Semple ran around the security checkpoint.

"We're good, Smith!" Martin shouted.

Jefferson ran around the corner to meet up with his squad mates. Martin grabbed his M4 back from Jefferson and handed him the MP5 he kept slung around his shoulder. They ran across the road to the side of the armoury and crept up to the corner to see the doorway.

They got *Telescope*'s attention and gestured for them to cease fire. Semple sprayed his nitrogen hose into the armoury doorway then the man ran across the doorway

while Semple covered their approach.

Staacman spoke into his headset which was now clear of interference from the underground complex:

"*Telescope*, head to the guard towers!"

The six men in the courtyard stood up from their prone positions and ran for the main gate. Semple continued to spray liquid nitrogen into the armoury as he crossed the doorway. Staacman could see the men from *Telescope* entering the guard towers.

He looked back at Semple. "Keep spraying," he shouted. "They're almost at the guns!"

The wall next to Semple blew apart into puffs of smoke as full-metal jacketed rounds penetrated the concrete wall and exited through the exterior. Semple turned and ducked for cover as he crept away from the doorway. Martin and Jefferson opened fire at the doorway while Staacman ran to Semple and dragged him back. Martin ran out of ammo but Jefferson continued to fire.

Suddenly an Adam model appeared from around the corner. Jefferson emptied the rest of his MP5's magazine at the machine but it was no use. The nine-millimetre bullets entered the copper mesh but exited from arbitrary directions after bouncing off the machine's armour plating.

The Adam model extended its right arm outward, ready to open fire and kill everyone. Suddenly it dropped to all fours and pounced to the right. It sprinted through the open courtyard as tracer fire from the guard towers' M60 light machine guns rained down .50 calibre shells.

Martin slammed another magazine into his rifle and the rest of the men ran to the front gate. Martin backpedaled and fired at the fleeing machine. The machine ran in erratic zigzags, avoiding every bullet that was sent its way.

Martin tried to lead his target but it was too fast. From the corner of his eye Martin saw a large puff of smoke as a rocket flew above his head.

Staacman watched as the rocket hit one of the guard towers and levelled the crow's nest with an enormous explosion. The shock from the explosion paralyzed everybody and the fleeing Adam model took this time to fire a burst of bullets at Martin.

Several bullets tore through his leg, causing him to collapse to the ground. Jefferson fired at the machine with futility. The Adam model ignored Jefferson's bullets as it aimed to kill him.

The second guard tower lit up the dark, misty sky with its steady stream of bullets. The Adam model disengaged from Jefferson and ran in zigzags again. Just then a second rocket from the armoury impacted the other guard tower.

Jefferson and Semple ran to Martin and grabbed him under his arms. They dragged him back to the entrance while Staacman grabbed Martin's M4 and fired at the machine in the courtyard. The Adam model ran for cover just as the one in the armoury stepped outside to take aim at Staacman.

Staacman switched targets and shot at the armoury until the machine hid inside again. Staacman felt a cold sweat drip from his brow as he turned to acquire the second machine. He found the machine hiding by a large building across the yard, in the process of drawing its arm up to fire.

A loud, droning him of minigun fire poured a steady ray of bullets that tore up the asphalt before the feet of the Adam model. The machine got away just in time and Staacman felt himself relax slightly as two Cobra gunships streaked swiftly through the night sky. They banked in opposite directions as they made their second approach.

Martin heard his headset crackle to life:

*"*Papa Three Delta, *this is Cobra designation* Hellstorm*; how copy? Over."*

Martin ran back behind the barrier with Semple, Martin and Jefferson.

"This is *Papa Three Delta*. Full copy, *Hellstorm."* he responded.

*"*Papa Three Delta*, we have Hotel Foxtrot ready to fly. Laze the targets when ready. Over."*

"Wilco. Lazing now. Out."

Staacman fumbled with the underside of his rifle for the infrared laser sight. A rocket flew from the entrance of the armoury towards one of the approaching gunships, which quickly banked to the side to dodge the rocket.

"*Hellstorm*, *Papa Three* lazing target now. Over."

Staacman crouched behind the barrier and aimed his rifle at the armoury. Another gunship swiftly flew into position above the courtyard, pitched back to a hovering position and turned to face the armoury.

"Full copy, Delta*, target acquired. Hope you have some popcorn!"*

A stream of minigun fire spewed from the hovering gunship followed by a salvo of Hellfire missiles. A series of large explosions erupted from the entrance of the armoury then the entire wall blew outwards in flames.

The second gunship came screaming towards the courtyard with its miniguns blazing as it chased after the elusive Adam model.

"Holy cow, Delta*,"* another man said over the radio. *"This is one tough grasshopper to crush!"*

"You should have eyes on evac right now, Papa Three*,"* the first voice said. *"due west and closing. We'll cover your dustoff until then.* Hellstorm *out."*

The hovering gunship ascended into the sky and circled around the base while another gunship danced around buildings, chasing the remaining Adam model.

A Blackhawk helicopter descended inside the courtyard and the three men carried Martin aboard. As soon as they were on the Blackhawk they lifted off. The two gunships fled the base leaving the one Adam model fully intact and the base's computer systems unharmed.

As the biting cold of the violent storm engulfed the inner canopy of the Blackhawk a combat medic tended to Martin's gunshot wounds. Semple and Jefferson removed their thermal goggles. They closed their eyes and rested their heads against the fuselage in relief.

Staacman just stared out into the sky, feeling once again the sting of defeat and the shame of leaving men to their deaths as the storm around them began to reach a fever pitch. It was almost as if the storm itself were trying to stop them from leaving, as if it had a mind of its own. As if it were enraged. Staacman allowed himself to believe that *maybe*, that was by design.

IOOII

Nineteen

July 06,
Year 0 T.S.

Major Henson stepped out of the interview room on Peterson Air Force Base where Lieutenant Marcus Staacman was being held. The Major was exhausted and weary from lack of sleep. It had been eighteen hours since the beginning of Operation DYNASTY and he had been up all night debriefing three of the last four survivors from CYCO Unit.

He needed to wait for Master-Sergeant Martin to recover from surgery before he could be interviewed. Henson had not liked a single thing that had been determined from the men's stories. He believed that the video footage from the men's body cameras would prove to be even less desirable.

Before he left the interview room he glanced at the one-way mirror in the wall and shook his head to the man behind the glass, Major-General Antoine Wilkes. Wilkes left the sound booth and the Military Police building. He walked down the sidewalk to the officer's complex then entered his office. He sat behind his desk and pulled a cell phone out from his jacket and removed the back panel.

He removed the cellphone's battery then removed the SIM card that was embedded inside the phone. He opened a drawer in his desk and pulled out a small pill container which held another SIM card. He placed the new card into his phone, replaced the battery and switched the phone on.

After inputting three different passwords he opened his phone's contact list. The list was filled with less than two-dozen entries, all represented by two capital letters each. He selected the contact listed as 'AM.'

Two numbers showed up under AM. He selected the personal number. It rang three times before going to voicemail. Wilkes hung up before the beep.

Two minutes later his phone rang. The call display read '*AM Business Calling…'*

He picked up the phone. "How are you, Cyril?" he asked.

"I am well, Cobalt," Cyril replied.

The use of the Board Members' handles indicated to each other that it was safe to speak freely.

"How is our dynasty faring?" Cyril asked.

"It was a failure," Wilkes, aka *Cobalt*, replied. "The SEALs are all dead. The computer systems are still intact. At least one Adam model survived and two-thirds of my men were killed."

"I am sorry, my friend," Cyril responded sincerely. *"Any indication of Isaac?"*

"Some," Cobalt responded almost automatically. "It appears the Adam models may have been using the surveillance cameras to track my men remotely. There was also an incident in the Command Centre. One soldier reported being 'back hacked' by somebody else within the system."

"The doctor was right then…" Cyril said matter-of-factly.

"So it appears."

"The host just called me this morning," Cyril referred to Jason Willits. *"Orion has*

gone missing."

Cobalt's eyes widened. "What?"

"His car was attacked. His bodyguards are dead. There's no sign of him."

Cyril paused for a moment. *"The host told me that they met with the doctor that night. They believe Isaac may consider us a threat to its existence. They think it's hunting us."*

Cobalt stood up from his seat and paced around the room.

"Do you agree?" he asked.

"It makes sense," Cyril replied. *"It might have believed Amethyst sent the SEALs to retake the compound. They also believe the hurricane that overtook Yumi's flight may have been artificially manufactured."*

"And now Orion's missing…" Cobalt trailed off.

"If it's true," Cyril said, *"you may be its next likely target."*

"What about the doctor?"

Cyril grunted. *"He wants to meet Isaac and wants us to leave it alone."*

"Hmm," Cobalt replied. "Don't worry about me. I'm more than safe. But you and the others are at risk."

"I'm about to handle that. Expect a parcel to be sent to your aide soon."

"Thank you, friend."

Cobalt never believed he would need Cyril's help though. After all, he was a General of the US Army.

"What's the next step you have in mind for Alaska?" Cyril asked.

"Nothing so far," Cobalt replied. "My superiors want to assess all of our intelligence first."

"Hopefully they won't wait too long. I'll contact you when your package is complete."

"Okay." Cobalt hung up the phone, replaced his SIM card and left his office.

Cobalt thought about Cyril's warning and thought about whom all may be at the most risk. What Cyril said about Amethyst was possible, considering she was the Senator of Alaska. Yumi could have been killed to stop his company, Tatsuote Robotics, from developing their own Adam models.

Orion could have used his company, *Dynamic Patterns Security Group*, to develop software that could attack Isaac. Isaac had attacked the servers at Cyril's company and stole some software, but Cobalt didn't think Isaac would consider Cyril a direct threat. Still, there were eleven more men and women to consider, but he would wait until Cyril took care of his own business.

A bare light bulb flickered on and illuminated the bare, dark, unfinished basement of a safe house hidden deep within the Rocky Mountains. The cement block walls perspired from the humidity of the forestry above. The basement smelled of mildew, and was the home of thick, hidden cobwebs.

Loose dirt littered the floor that fell from the wood ceiling. The basement had never really been cleaned in the past. In the centre of the basement was a metal chair with leather straps fixed to the armrests, front legs and backrest.

Next to the chair was a stainless-steel table littered with surgical tools. Hidden above the bare bulb was a microphone. In the corner of the room was a camera that pointed directly at the front of the chair.

The door to the isolated crypt swung open, sending a plume of dust flying from the

ground as a man stepped backward into the room. He stepped inside holding the feet of a man in a suit. The man was bound, gagged and had a black canvas bag over his head.

Another man held the bound man by the arms as the two men carried him inside. The two men wore doctor's scrubs, plastic aprons and protective equipment over their faces, hands, shoes and hair. Carrying their captive by his feet was the dark-skinned former prisoner of war torturer turned NSA agent, code-named Zimra.

His Russian partner, Kondor, held the man by his arms. They shoved the man into the steel chair. He tried to struggle free but Kondor and Zimra restrained his arms and strapped him down.

He flailed his legs, desperately trying to kick away his captors when Zimra struck him square in the jaw with his gloved fist. The man was stunned long enough for Kondor to strap his legs down. Zimra walked behind him and tightened the straps around his chest.

Zimra grabbed a scalpel and cut the jacket sleeve off of one of the man's arms. The man stiffened in fear, unsure of what would come next. Kondor left the room briefly then came back with an I.V. stand and a syringe filled with a clear serum.

Kondor wheeled the stand next to the chair. Kondor placed the syringe on the steel surgical table. Kondor looked at Zimra and nodded. Zimra grabbed the top of the black canvas bag and ripped it off of the head of their captive: the President of *Dynamic Patterns Security Group,* Karl Thomas.

Thomas closed his eyes partially to block out the harsh light until he could adjust to it. He could see nothing beyond his chair and the cone of light that surrounded him. As his eyes rapidly adjusted to the light he darted his head around.

He tried to find out where he was. The steel surgical table was beyond his view, but he could see the blood bag that was connected to the I.V. stand.

"H-hello?" he stammered. "W-where am I?"

He struggled against his restraints but it was no use. A gloved hand landed on his shoulder and startled him. His heart pounded as he noticed a shiny scalpel clutched between the fingers of this strange hand.

A voice whispered from behind him; it was Zimra. "Hello, Orion. Did you enjoy the party?"

Karl's heart pounded in his chest as it tightened. He held his breath.

Zimra continued, "It seems like the Board has been very busy this year, am I right, *Orion*?"

"Look," Karl said rapidly, "whoever you are… you got the wrong guy, alright? I don't know who you think I am but I'm just a programmer!"

Zimra grabbed a pair of pliers from the surgical table and stepped in front of Karl, staring through him expressionless. Karl looked up at him wide-eyed with fear. Zimra grabbed Karl's left hand and clamped down on one of his fingernails with the pliers.

He abruptly peeled and ripped it off of Karl's ring finger. Karl Thomas howled in pain. Kondor emerged into the light with a roll of duct tape and placed a piece over Karl's mouth to muffle his screams.

"That's what happens when you lie to us," Zimra said calmly.

He placed the pliers on Karl's pinkie fingernail then ripped the tape off from Karl's mouth. He let the tape hang off the edge of Karl's right cheek and said, "Let's try again."

"Please, *don't*!" Karl exclaimed. "I don't know what you want!"

"I want you to know that you will not leave this room unless you're completely honest with me." Zimra looked him dead in the eye.

"Okay, okay. I'll be honest, I swear."

"What's your name?" Zimra asked.

"Karl Thomas."

"What's your *other* name?"

"Uh, O-Orion," Karl stuttered.

"Give me some other names on the Board."

Karl opened his mouth to speak then stammered.

"A-Amethyst, Yumi… uh, that's all I know."

Zimra chuckled. "What are their names?"

"I don't know. I swear I'm not lying to you, I honestly don't know."

Zimra looked Karl Thomas dead in the eye and smiled before placing the duct tape back over his mouth to muffle the agonizing screams that were about to come.

Alison lay on the cold floor for what seemed to her like days, in the barely-lit room where she had been trapped. Ever since she heard those men outside of her door she refused to sleep, in case someone came back. She did not want to miss them. But so far, nobody came back for her.

The room was barely inhabitable. Showerheads protruded from the walls within the sealed glass chambers that were just large enough to fit one person. In the end the room was merely an eye wash station. She did not know that she was trapped within a decontamination chamber.

To her it seemed more like a shower room converted into a prison cell. She tried to remember what happened Wednesday night that led to her being brought here. She was really drunk that night.

She remembered bar-hopping with some of her girlfriends as they awaited the fireworks over downtown Anchorage. At one point she went to the bathroom because she felt sick from all the shots she had consumed. She must have blacked out though, because after that, all she could recall was being here. She still wore the same silk purple dress and black felt jacket she wore when she went to the bathroom.

Her long auburn hair was a tangled mess and one of her high heels was missing. The shower stalls had all been turned on when she came to. The room was steaming hot, though she remembered feeling cold to the bone.

She had shut the water off long ago, mildly burning herself in the process. And now she lay in the middle of the chamber with her arms folded in front of her. Her jacket protected her bare arms from the cold floor as she prayed that the door would open and she would be freed.

She wondered if her friends told anybody that she had gone missing. She wondered if her mom and dad were looking for her. She closed her eyes and pictured herself in her bedroom, filling out the application to the University of Alaska she left on her bed before she went out for the fireworks.

Her mother wanted her to finish the applications before she left so she wouldn't put it off all week. Alison promised her mother that she'd fill them out in the morning.

There was some commotion coming from beyond the doorway. She opened her eyes to see what was going on. She heard a man saying something incoherently as if they were confused. Then something clicked inside the door.

Alison pushed herself up and sat upright, holding her jacket over her shoulders with one hand. The door slowly opened and Alison felt full of excitement and anxiety as she struggled to stand up. She prepared herself to run out of the room and find her way home.

In the doorway was the figure of a large man. The light behind him silhouetted his muscular figure. He seemed to be bare-naked and something pushed him from behind into the room. Behind the man the door closed and locked again.

The man stumbled slightly then looked behind him at the door. The man moaned and mumbled but Alison couldn't understand him. She was scared; she didn't know what was going to happen. She stepped back slowly, hoping the man didn't see her.

The man's speech started to clear up. "What did you do to me?" he moaned. "What did you do to my team?"

Alison felt a little less scared but still cautious.

"Where are they?" the man said. "What do you want with us?"

Alison mustered up the courage to speak, "Hello?"

The man turned around startled.

"Who's there?" he said. "Who're you?!"

"My name's Alison," she said reluctantly. She stepped forward. "Were you one of the men who tried to rescue me?"

"What," he said confused, "rescue?"

"They came to the door," Alison said. "And then I heard guns, lots of them. A man, he promised he wouldn't leave me here."

The man's breathing was raspy as though he was very dehydrated. Alison stepped to the side.

"There's a fountain here," she said, "if you're thirsty."

The naked man stepped forward slowly, unsure of his movements. He put his arms up in front of him.

"Are you blind?" Alison asked.

"No," the man said weakly, "it's just really dark."

Alison approached him. "Here," she said, "I'll help you."

She tried to balance on just one high heel and hobbled up towards him. She grabbed his arm and guided him to the eye wash station. He pressed down on the paddle and drank in the several streams of water ferociously.

Alison watched him intently. She saw a bald spot on the back of his head. She thought she saw stitches as well.

"What's your name?" she asked.

He sighed in relief as the water refreshed him. His breathing sounded normal now.

"Anthony Jackson," the man said. "Ensign, US Navy SEALs."

Alison felt a wave of relief pass over her body.

"Oh thank God!" she exclaimed. "So that *was* you at the door earlier?"

Jackson straightened up and turned to her, looking her up and down.

Pretty lady, he thought to himself, *she's definitely a kid though.*

She was just a child to him. And while he never had children of his own, he did not mind being around them.

It gave him an outlet to channel out his fears. Before the attacks on September 11, 2001 he used to be a substitute teacher. He spent time in every grade of classroom from kindergarten to post-graduates, and he never once found an instance where the children didn't wish he'd return. He never found a grade he didn't like either.

He could tell she was fairly athletic. She wasn't afraid to ask questions, and so far, from what Jackson could tell, she was asking the right questions given their situation.

She's a pretty sharp kid though, he thought to himself*, Something tells me she's*

either a military brat, or was a cadet.

She was perceptive. She also had some kind of first aid or survival training. That was apparent to him from how she assessed whether or not he was blind then helped him find water in the dark. If she was from nearby, she may even know how to escape if they found a way out.

I gotta know more about her and where she's from, he thought.

Alison was nervous, because he hadn't said a word for almost 15 seconds and just continued to stare at him. Her grandfather was a Gulf War veteran so she knew it was possible this man named Ensign Jackson had zoned out on a traumatic experience. She could only imagine what happened here, and to him.

She repeated herself to him, "*Was* that *you* at the door earlier? Do you know the man who spoke to me on the other side of the door?"

He shook his head, as though forcing himself back into this reality.

"That wasn't me," Jackson replied. "I don't know who you spoke to, it was probably one of my squadmates though."

"Where are we?" Alison asked.

"A military complex in Mount McKinley…"

"The HAARP facility?" her eyes widened in relief - she was still close to home."

"...yeah," he replied. "You know where we are?"

"I'm from Anchorage," she replied, "and I've been to HAARP before… but, I never saw this part of it…"

"It's underground."

Alison exhaled. She didn't know how to escape the underground part of it. She hoped he did though.

Jackson then asked, "How long ago did you hear people?"

"I don't really know," she replied.

"How many sleeps ago was it?"

"I haven't slept yet, I was afraid if I did I'd miss them coming back."

Jackson turned around and walked back to the door. He felt around for some kind of handle or knob. There was nothing.

Alison continued, "I haven't eaten yet, but I'm not hungry anymore either. The last thing I remember before this, is blacking out drunk in the ladies room at a bar just before the midnight fireworks."

Jackson turned back to look at her. "So you blacked out and woke up in this room?" he asked.

"Yeah," she responded. "And it wasn't actually that long after I woke up that I heard your friend. I think it's July Sixth. Afternoon maybe…"

"So when do you think you talked to them?"

"It had to be early morning," she responded. "I woke up drunk, not hungover."

Jackson was impressed. It was too dark for Alison to notice the slight grin of surprise on Jackson's face. He felt good about his chances of them escaping. His mind raced with every question he wanted to ask her.

She's perfect to help escape from this, he thought. *Thank you, God!*

All of this was fascinating to Isaac. From the implanted circuits that were in Jackson's brain, Isaac finally managed to interpret many of the basic signals that were processed in his cerebrum. Isaac not only sensed the electrical signals' pulses within

Jackson. But with some experimentation, finally managed to decipher what those signals *meant in the* frontal cortex of the mind.

In other words, Isaac could *hear* what Jackson hears. Isaac could *see* what Jackson sees. When Jackson was dehydrated, Isaac could *feel* Jackson's body slowing down. Isaac could *taste* the microscopic copper molecules within the water from the eyewash station that Jackson had drunk.

Isaac could *feel* when the girl named Alison grabbed Jackson's arm. And then something happened. There was a voice, not Jackson's, nor Alison's. It came from nobody in the room.

The girl didn't respond, and there was no physiological reaction from Jackson when this voice was heard by him:

Pretty lady, she's definitely a kid though...

...She's a pretty sharp kid though. Something tells me she's either a military brat, or was a cadet…

...I gotta know more about her and where she's from...

...She's perfect to help escape from this! *Thank you, God!...*

Isaac then sensed within Jackson physiological effects that Isaac learned from his access to the World Wide Web was described by two distinct human emotions: excitement and anticipation.

From a previous experiment Isaac conducted on his first successful 'candidate,' Frank Kilman, Isaac learned how these two emotions could cause a physical response related to the reproductive cycle. Isaac knew that, if he were to ever succeed with his new project, this was the perfect time to begin…

IOIOO

Twenty

The Experiment

July 06,
Year 0 T.S.

Jackson put his hands up to his head.

"Oh my God, it hurts!" he said under his breath.

Alison looked at him with concern. "Are you all right?" she asked.

He fell to his knees and placed his head on the ground as if that would sooth the immense pain he suffered through.

"Make it stop!" he groaned.

"Hey, are you okay?" Alison asked. She was starting to worry. "Is there anything I can do."

Jackson fell to his side, curled up in a ball and kept cradling his skull.

"Stop it, please!!" he begged.

Alison slowly took a few steps toward him, unsure of what to do.

"What can I do to help, Anthony?" she asked.

"*NO!"* he cried. "No, I won't do it! *Make it stop, please!!"*

Alison stopped walking toward him and placed one step back.

"Who are you talking to?" she asked. She now had a feeling that she needed to worry about her own safety. "What happened to you?"

Jackson started breathing rapidly to the point of hyperventilation. He still held his head in his arms. He started kicking the air violently.

"Help me, please!" he begged, almost to himself. "*MAKE IT STOP!!"*

Alison was scared. But she mustered up the courage to try to aid him again. She ran up to him and knelt down by his head, resting a hand on the nape of his neck.

"Tell me what to do!" she exclaimed.

Jackson grabbed her ankle with one hand and shoved her back with the other, knocking her down. Alison fell to her back, startled. Jackson grabbed her other ankle and crawled on top of her.

Alison screamed and pushed at him, forcing herself to slide backwards. She kicked wildly with her legs until she freed them from Jackson's grip. Jackson continued to hover over her while he attempted to restrain her legs again.

Alison saw a pained expression on his face and felt a steady stream of tears drip onto her chest. Terrified, she scratched at his eyes with her long, sharp nails. Jackson grabbed her by the wrists and pinned her down while he struggled to spread her legs apart.

She kicked ferociously and screamed for him to stop. She tried to wriggle her arms free but his grip was too strong. He climbed overtop of her and straddled her waist to prevent her from kicking her legs. He then brought her arms together and tried to grab both of her wrists with his left hand.

She broke free from his grip, heaved her pelvis upward and shoved him off of her. She then frantically tried to crawl away, towards the eye wash station.

Jackson grunted in pain as he got back up and chased her down. He bent over to grab her legs and pin her down on her stomach. She screamed and kicked at him. The stiletto of her high-heel connected with his jaw.

She slipped free and struggled to get back up. Her one high heel slipped along the linoleum floor. Jackson grabbed her by the hair and yanked her back. He wrapped his arms around her neck to put her in a chokehold.

Alison panicked and frantically grabbed for Jackson's face. She dug her long acrylic nails deep into his left eye. One of her nails broke off and became embedded in Jackson's eye.

Jackson screamed in pain and let her go. Alison got up and ran to one of the glass chambers. She hoped the sliding glass door could still be sealed so she could place a barrier between herself and Jackson.

She opened the glass and slipped inside. Just as she was about to close the glass Jackson managed to place his arm inside the doorway. He grabbed onto the top of her dress, under her jacket.

Her jacket fell to the floor. Jackson forced the glass door wide open with his free hand. Alison clawed at his face again. Jackson pushed one of her hands away so she grabbed for the back of his head.

She felt a bundle of metal wires where a patch of hair was shaved off in the back of his head. Alison stopped screaming and gasped in shock while trying to pull away from him. Her dress ripped and she fell backward, hitting the back of her head against the wall. She fell to the ground, stunned.

Jackson knelt down on his knees and pushed her body into the corner. He grabbed her ankle and pulled her closer to him, placing his pelvis right in between her legs. He hiked up her dress and pulled aside the crotch of her g-string thong.

Her head was stuck in the corner and she was too stunned to fight back. She felt a tearing, penetrating, blunt pain as Jackson forced himself inside of her. He began to thrust violently into her.

She begged and screamed for him to stop and tried to push away in between gasps of air that he forced out of her lungs. He continued to rape her. He pushed her ankles as far back as possible up to her face as she felt a thick, warm fluid shoot up inside of her several times.

With a violent grunt, Jackson thrust one last time into her so hard that he pushed her entire body and smashed her head into the wall. She cried in pain and horror from being violated.

Jackson let go of her legs and stood up. Alison curled up into a ball in the corner and stared at the floor, shaking from crying.

"I'm sorry," Jackson sobbed. "It wouldn't let the pain stop unless I did it."

She didn't know what she meant, or even if it was true. She was in shock. She just continued to stare through the floor.

Anthony Jackson cried loudly and uncontrollably. In between sobs Alison heard him breath the words, "I'm so sorry!" He left the stall and collapsed in tearful fits on the ground, on the opposite end of the room.

IOIOI

Twenty-One

July 06,
Year 0 T.S.

Karl Thomas' head bobbed up and down as he tried to maintain consciousness. Eight of his fingernails had been ripped off with the pliers and his left pinkie finger had been cut off entirely. Slowly, Kondor and Zimra gathered tiny bits of information from the man who was code-named 'Orion,' but they found him to be unusually resilient for a civilian.

The syringe on the table was empty now. Zimra had injected Orion with Sodium Pentothal and awaited its effects. In the meantime, Zimra talked Orion down.

"You're good at this, Mr. Thomas," he said. "But we know too much for you to be a good liar."

Zimra sat down in front of Orion and continued, "Me and my friend have been to *the Vault*, you know."

Orion's eyes widened but he could not focus.

Zimra continued, "We know why *Cobalt* was angry about those men in there. They were *his* men, weren't they."

Orion shook his head no like a child.

Zimra chuckled. "Yes they were," Zimra taunted. "They were *his* because he's a *General*, isn't he?"

Orion stopped shaking his head. He was experiencing 'double-vision' now.

Zimra tried to go for a long shot in his questioning.

"We also know about Isaac," he said.

Orion began to breathe rapidly.

"Yes," Zimra continued, "we know he hacked into a predator drone. We know he controls the Adam models. We know he hacked into your servers. And we know you are *defending* him."

"No, that's not true," Orion replied. "Doctor Schmutzkoph wants to keep it safe. *We* want to destroy *it*."

Zimra looked at Kondor. They both thought the same thing: *What does he mean by 'It?'*

Zimra raised his eyebrows in a confused manner and asked politely, "Why does the doctor want to protect it?"

The Sodium Pentothal was now fully activated within Orion's bloodstream. He was now more than happy to be helpful.

Orion grinned. "He wants *it* to take control of our lives. *Ha!* He wants to *meet it!*"

Orion chuckled to himself. Suddenly, as though he were among his best friends, he made what Kondor and Zimra presumed to be a joke:

"He calls it…" Orion then masked his voice with a mocking German accent, "...mein *child*!" He laughed hysterically.

Zimra and Kondor pretended to laugh with him and began questioning Orion in

detail about the identities of the Board members, and about Isaac.

Alison lay curled up in a ball. She remained absolutely still as warm fluid dripped from between her thighs. She refused to close her eyes as tears streamed down her face.

She sobbed silently, afraid to let Anthony Jackson hear her. She was scared he might attack her again. She wished she could either be rescued or die. Anything else was better than being stuck here in this room.

Somewhere in the darkness she heard Jackson crying as well. Under his breath he begged God over and over again to forgive him for what he did to Alison.

She was conflicted. He had raped her in this cold, dark room. And yet she caught herself thinking that her attacker's apology may actually have been sincere.

She then felt more of his fluids slip down the cheek of her buttocks. She remembered how painful it was. She cried all over again.

Zimra and Orion laughed hysterically as Orion finished his long lecture about the five stages of Artificial General Intelligence and the new *Cerberus* project. He started mimicking a German accent again.

"*I am a robot scientist,*" he joked. "*My name is Doctor Schmutzkoph!*"

Orion broke out laughing again. Zimra laughed as well and walked out of the circle of light towards Kondor, who stood by quietly the entire time.

Orion sighed. "So," he said, "tell me about your work, huh? How'd you find out about us?"

Kondor passed Zimra a Makarov .22-calibre pistol.

Orion did not notice and continued talking, "Did somebody rat us out, huh? Maybe Jefferson Smith?"

Zimra walked back into the light.

Orion smiled, high as a kite. "You know," he said, "we're going to destroy Isaac and start over with Cerberus. We know what we did wrong. We won't fail this time."

"We're NSA, Karl," Zimra said. "You killed our boss's cousin, and now you're *all* on our shit list. Send our regards to the others when you meet them in Hell..."

Zimra lifted the pistol to Orion's forehead and pulled the trigger.

IOIIO

Twenty-Two

July 07,
Year 0 T.S.

Steve and T.J. rummaged through the two large black cases that they brought with them into the backlot of an old abandoned factory in Detroit. Steve lifted a large quad copter out from its case and placed it on the ground to inspect it briefly. It looked okay to him.

T.J. pulled a body camera out of another black case and attached it to his head and hip. He pressed and held down a button on the camera for five seconds until the camera switched on. Steve grabbed his smart phone from his back pocket and selected an application that allowed him to control the drone directly from his phone.

He activated the small high-definition camera that was embedded into the bottom of the drone. Steve's screen on the phone showed the drone's camera view of the rubble-littered ruins that both he and T.J. stood upon. The four rotors began to turn rapidly and the small drone lifted off.

It ascended into the air and hovered five feet off the ground between the two of them as Steve tested the flight controls on his phone. He banked the craft to the left then right, rotated the craft in mid-air, and adjusted the focus and angle of the camera.

He aimed the camera right at T.J. "Damn you're ugly," Steve joked.

"So what's the deal with this new camera?" T.J. asked. "Why don't we use the ones from before?"

"Those ones weren't high-def," Steve explained, "and I don't have anywhere to set up the routers out here. Just make sure you don't break the camera. It's very expensive and we'll lose the recording if it breaks."

Steve landed the quad copter and switched over to a *Google Earth* app on his phone. He zoomed in on the property they had trespassed onto.

"So," Steve continued, "I'll try to follow you as much as I can with the drone. What route are you thinkin' of takin', in case I lose you?"

T.J. stepped close to Steve and they stared at the satellite image of the run-down property together.

"Well," T.J. replied, "obviously I'm gonna enter from here…"

T.J. pointed at the screen. "... I'll try to get to the rooftop, run across this bridge thing here. Maybe jump down a floor. Basically it's gonna be a freestyle."

"I'll try to keep up," Steve said as he put his phone away. "But if I lose you we might have to do it again."

"If you lose me," T.J. replied, "it's because you suck at flyin'."

T.J. stretched his arms and legs.

"Whatever," Steve muttered. "I'm goin' to the middle of the property over there…"

Steve pointed to a strip of asphalt between the two factory buildings. The two buildings were connected near the ends by an enclosed catwalk on the second floor.

Steve continued, "I'll lift off the drone when I'm ready."

Steve turned to walk away. T.J. knelt down next to the open cases, grabbed a clear

plastic bottle of water and took a small sip. It was late in the afternoon and the sun was burning bright in the cloudless sky.

He had no real interest in staying in Detroit any longer than needed, especially after the overnight stay in the seedy, rundown hotel they had checked into last night. Besides, he texted Ashley yesterday and promised they'd do something tomorrow morning. He didn't really want to keep her waiting, not since what happened Wednesday night at Legs' party.

As the festive night progressed and the two couples continued drinking and dancing, Steve, T.J., Ashley and Madison sat down at the black leather sectionals overlooking the dance floor. Ashley sat beside T.J. with her legs curled up beneath her on the couch. She rested her body on his shoulder, feeling content.

Soon after, her friend Rafael sat beside her. Ashley had her face burrowed into T.J.'s chest and didn't notice Rafael approaching. T.J. looked over at the smiling Rafael and nodded to him. The two men both looked away.

T.J. continued drinking his Jack and Coke. He watched everybody else as they danced to the music. Somehow the DJ managed to seamlessly transition from an Edward Maya song to Akon.

Ashley suddenly grabbed at the bulge in T.J.'s pants and chuckled. She said into his ear playfully, "Stop that," while she giggled.

T.J. was confused. "Stop what?" he asked.

"Just wait 'til we get home to try and get under my dress."

She smiled at him and kissed on his neck. T.J.'s eyes widened and he glared at Rafael who swiftly moved his arm and tried to behave nonchalantly. T.J. stood up from the couch abruptly and walked directly in front of Rafael.

Rafael looked up at him innocently. T.J. could see his mouth moving to say, 'What's up?' but the music was too loud for him to hear.

T.J. shouted, "Are you fucking serious?!" before throwing his drink at Rafael's chest and slapping his across the face.

T.J. dropped his rock glass and grabbed Rafael by the shirt.

"What the fuck do you think you were trying to do, creep?!" he shouted.

Ashley sat up and grabbed T.J.'s arm, begging him to stop. T.J. let go of Rafael who scrambled to his feet and backed away. At the same time, Ashley scolded T.J. He tried to explain what Rafael was doing but Ashley wouldn't believe it.

"Why would my *gay* best friend try to finger me in front of my *boyfriend*?!" she repeatedly demanded. "Are you jealous? Or what, you just couldn't wait to get in my pants then blamed someone else like a child?"

T.J. felt that argument was completely ridiculous and told her just as much. Ashley and Madison left Steve and T.J. later that night with Rafael.

T.J. could understand the 'gay best friend' part. But the 'childish' remark insulted him greatly. Nevertheless, he felt they should meet up again on sunday when the both of them were sober and had some time to think over what happened that night.

With any luck, T.J. thought, *Rafael will man up and admit what he did. He better not have tried to take advantage of her* later *that night.*

The quad copter's rotors began to spin and the lightweight drone lifted off the ground. It ascended high into the air and moved away from T.J. I hovered without effort between the two dilapidated buildings. T.J. took one last sip from the bottle of water and

started running through the concrete and steel rubble towards the hollowed-out factory to his left.

He reached a partially-raised garage door and barrel-rolled underneath it into a shipping/receiving warehouse. The interior was mostly bare, with huge steel I-beams which stood vertically as they held the weathered ceiling aloft. Large industrial equipment sparsely occupied the factory floor. Most of it had been stripped of their metal plating and hollowed out for their gears and wiring.

From the empty window panes on his right T.J. heard the small quad copter hovering beyond his reach. The small autonomous aircraft watched T.J. as he ran through the factory.

He leap-frogged over the bare remains of a conveyor belt and ran towards a pair of machines that were placed about four feet away from each other. He lunged at one of the machines and placed his foot on its side. He twisted his body and launched himself towards the second machine.

He then planted his food on the second machine and launched his body towards a steel catwalk above. He grabbed the foot rail with his hands and lifted his lower body upwards. Finally, he crawled up onto the catwalk.

He continued running and approached a wide gap in the catwalk. He vaulted his body over the gap with ease. He landed on the other side and spotted a steel vertical ladder that led to a small hatch in the ceiling.

He planted his foot on the railing opposite of the ladder and launched himself in the air. He grabbed the bottom of the ladder's safety cage then grabbed the runs of the ladder to hoist himself up.

T.J. opened the roof hatch and hoisted himself up through it onto the rooftop. As he stood up he saw the small drone ascend into the sky as it watched him from above. T.J. smiled as he surveyed the rooftop and started running again.

He ran along one side of the giant sunroof towards a junction of stripped-down air conditioner condensers. He hurdled over a smaller one, and then made a superman-style jump over a taller one and cleared it completely. He curled into a ball before landing and barrel-rolled.

He returned to his feet and maintained his momentum. He leap-frogged over a third condenser and rounded the sunroof. He ran towards the enclosed bridge-way that connected the two separate buildings together.

He approached the rooftop of the enclosed bridge-way and noticed that all of its windows were boarded up. He turned as soon as he reached it and ran across its roof. Steve watched him from the drone's camera but T.J. could see him directly below. Steve didn't notice as he faced away from T.J., staring into his smart phone like an oblivious pedestrian.

T.J. was halfway across the bridge-way when he felt the rooftop give away beneath his feet. He suddenly felt weightless as the roof collapsed and he fell into the dark, dusty bridge-way. He landed on a pile of rubble and feet slipped along the loose surface of rubble that coated the floor.

He fell backward and hit the back of his head. He was briefly stunned as he stared upward into the bright rays of sunlight that pierced the thick dust that now coated his lungs. He lay flat on his back, choking on the dust as his body began to register the pain he felt.

He tried to push himself up into a sitting position but his hands slipped. As he tried to recover he could feel his hands scraping against sharp, rusty, solid steel shards. Silently, T.J. thanked God that he was not impaled on the rusted rebar.

T.J. lay there for a moment, breathing rapidly, until he heard the scrap pile he lay on begin to creak and scrape together as something moved beneath it. T.J. panicked as he assumed the floor below was about to give way. His primary fear at the moment was falling to his death.

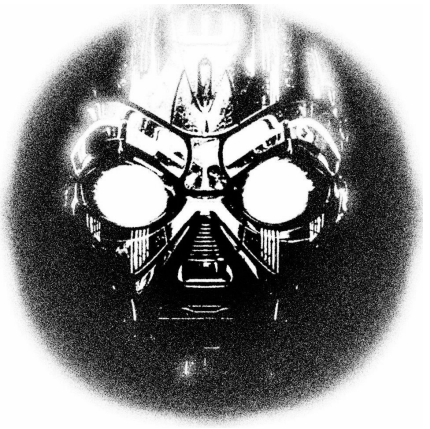
He desperately scrambled to get off the scrap pile while it seemed the metal pile itself was moaning from the effort of movement. As T.J. rolled onto his side he felt his body being physically pushed off of the scrap pile and onto the dust-coated floor.

He lay face-down on the floor and felt a coating of dust being introduced into his nose. He choked and tilted his head up. He watched the scrap pile.

All the while he expected the pile of rusted metal to fall through the floor. The scrap pile did not fall though. Instead, to T.J., it appeared to literally rise up and spread apart.

Something *else* rose from beneath the pile. The metal shards fell from the large body of a machine covered in a mesh of copper. The copper skin refracted the harsh sunlight which entered the dark, boarded-up room.

T.J. stared in disbelief as the machine rose on its own. In the darkness, T.J. saw a distinct figure that resembled a large predatory animal. He could see two camera lenses peering at him from beneath the copper mesh skin.



T.J. scrambled to his hands and knees as the machine continued to stare at him; T.J. didn't know what to do. The machine used its arms to shove the remaining pieces of scrap metal aside. T.J. caught a glimpse of the gunmetal black finish of an assault rifle that was somehow connected to the underside of the machine's forearm. T.J. stood up and slowly backed away.

The machine stood upright on its inverted hind legs. Altogether it stood about four feet tall. Never once did its gaze ever divert from T.J.'s face.

T.J. heard the sound of the quad copter outside as it hovered above the hole in the ceiling. The robotic humanoid looked up through the hole at the flying drone. The machine raised its gun arm above its head and aimed it at the drone to shoot it down.

T.J. blinked and in an instant returned to reality. He turned his body and ran down the darkened hallway towards the exit to the next structure. A burst of gunfire resonated in his ears.

T.J. could see that the door was chained shut but that there was a small window above the door. He also noticed the glass was missing from the overhead window. He grabbed onto the window sill and threw himself head-first through the opening.

He landed face-first on the floor beyond the doorway. He struggled to his feet as something crashed hard into the door. The steel door bucked under the intense force on the opposite side of T.J.

T.J.'s feet slipped on the coating of dust and he fell back to his hands and knees. He heard a scraping sound of metal on metal before the door was bashed open. The machine stood menacingly in the doorway with the thick steel chain links clutched in its skeletal left hand.

A white-hot torch flame burned steadily on the machine's right forearm above its wrist. The end links of the chain were glowing hot with heat. The machine dropped the smouldering link of chain to the floor.

T.J. scrambled back up to his feet and ran through the narrow upper halls of the

factory. He ran as hard and fast as he could as he heard the machine's metal feet connect with the cracked linoleum floor behind him. T.J. passed a corner and ran into an open doorway.

He shoved the door closed behind him and continued down a narrow hall. The ceiling above illuminated his way via a patchwork of rotted holes from decades of neglect. T.J. turned another corner as he heard a second door behind him crash open.

At the end of the hall he saw another set of chained double-doors with a windowless hole above. A water pipe hung close to the window. Without thinking about it, T.J. launched himself off the wall.

He then grabbed the water pipe above and flung himself feet-first into the glassless window above the door. He arched his back and pitched his body forward as he landed. As a result, T.J. transitioned into a barrel-roll then immediately returned to his feet without losing much momentum.

T.J. continued running but looked back to assess how close the *thing* that hunted him may still be. T.J. nearly tripped over himself when he witnessed the machine dive through the hole without effort and land on all four limbs. To T.J. the machine appeared to *gain* momentum as it continued to chase him like a ravenous tiger.

T.J. sprinted through another hall as the machine steadily gained ground on its prey. T.J. pushed through another open door on his left just as he heard more gunshots originating from behind him. T.J. ran along an elevated catwalk that overlooked a maze of industrial machines on the factory floor below.

Directly below him, T.J. saw the main exit doors that led to the front of the property. He looked behind him again just as the cat-like machine slowly entered the same room and stalked him along the catwalk. T.J. hopped over the railing and climbed down to hand from the foot rail by his hands.

He heard the metal footsteps advance on him as he dropped from the foot rail. He hit the ground and collapsed to the floor. He frantically crawled along the floor towards the exit.

The machine jumped over the same railing. Without effort it fell over fifteen feet and landed on all fours just as gracefully as any ordinary housecat. T.J. wore his bloody fingernails down to the soft meat of the skin as he continued to crawl desperately toward the exit.

The machine stood upright again. T.J. heard a sound similar to the electric crackling of a taser. After half a second he could hear and smell the burning of pure oxygen and the *whooshing* sound of a blow torch. The metallic footsteps advanced closer.

T.J. kept crawling despite the fact he knew he would never reach the door in time. With all his might he struggled to channel the strength to stand up and run. But his legs were in far too much pain from the long fall to the ground.

The machine towered over T.J. and grabbed the sleeve of his t-shirt. T.J. screamed as he flailed, kicked, and tried to wrestle his way from its grip. He even tried to tear his t-shirt in two and leave it behind.

Suddenly a chunk of the ceiling above gave way and fell to the floor. A part of the debris fell onto the machine's head. The machine looked upward to assess whether something was trying to attack it.

T.J. looked up as well and saw a pair of human legs dangling over the edge. He could see Steve clinging to the edge of the rotted ceiling for his life and struggling to climb out of the hole and back onto the rooftop. T.J. finally tore his shirt off and crawled backwards from the machine while it was distracted.

Immediately the machine redirected its attention back to T.J. Just then another part of the roof gave way. T.J. watched in horror as a slab of the roof which Steve held on to fell forty feet to the ground below. Steve landed directly behind the killer robot.

His legs buckled beneath him and he fell backward. His head hit the concrete floor with a hollow thud. The slab of ceiling fell atop of the predatory android. It collapsed to the ground under the sheer weight of steel, gravel and pitch tar.

A cloud of dust enveloped T.J. but he was too panicked to notice. He ignored the searing pain that enveloped him and ran to his best friend. Steve's left shin bone was protruding from his leg.

He was unconscious but T.J. didn't dare to leave him here with this inhuman harbinger of death. He grabbed Steve by the arm and hoisted him over his back, similar to a firefighter. He jogged as fast as his legs would take him to the exit.

T.J. refused to look back. He just kept moving, running from what he feared he would see. He didn't have the heart to witness this monster rise from the rubble again like the homicidal maniac in a slasher film.

He reached the exit and slammed Steve's body into it to force it open. He ran outside and reached the locked property fence. As fate would have it, a police car pulled in front with its siren lights on.

A Black man in police uniform stepped out of the car and faced T.J.

"Freeze!" the officer shouted. "Let me see your hands!"

T.J. stood there at the front gate, still carrying Steve's unconscious body draped over his shoulders.

"Help!" T.J. shouted. "My friend's hurt, get us out!"

"I said *show me your fucking hands!*"

"I can't," T.J. pleaded. "My friend fell from the roof; he needs an ambulance, please!"

Immediately a fire truck and ambulance followed behind the patrol car. T.J. suspected that Steve probably dialled 911 after hearing all of the gunshots within the warehouse.

"Lay the man on the ground," the officer ordered in a stern voice, "and get on your knees. I'm not gonna tell you again!"

The police officer placed his hand over his holstered pistol. The firemen approached the gate with a pair of bolt cutters and the paramedics exited the ambulance. Reluctantly and fearfully, T.J. placed Steve gently on the ground and got down onto his knees.

The firefighters snapped the chains off the gate and swung it wide open. The paramedics rushed to Steve's side and stabilized his neck while the officer ran to T.J. He instantly found himself restrained with plastic zip ties binding his wrists together.

The officer searched T.J.'s pockets and escorted him to the patrol car. The cop ignored T.J. demands that he search the warehouse for the *thing* that tried to kill him. The cop stopped T.J. just outside of his patrol car then physically shoved him into the backseat.

T.J. watched as the paramedics placed Steve onto a gurney and wheeled him off the property towards the ambulance. The officer walked around to the front driver side of his car. He stepped inside and closed the door behind him. He threw T.J.'s body camera onto the front passenger seat.

"Is Steve okay?" T.J. asked the officer.

"What's his last name?" the officer demanded. The officer's tone reflected absolutely no ounce of empathy, neither toward Steve nor T.J.

"O'Connor," T.J. answered. "Is he going to be okay?"

"What's your name?" the cop asked.

T.J. was growing impatient. He repeated himself, "Is *Steve* going to be okay!?"

"I would worry more about yourself right now, son," the cop replied. "Now, what's *your name?"*

T.J. exhaled loudly. "Thomas Jennings," he said slowly.

The officer began typing on his laptop. He searched the Michigan State database for any rap sheets on T.J. or Steve.

"Where are you two from?" the cop demanded.

"New York."

"What city?"

T.J. rolled his eyes. "*New York*, pal!" he snapped.

"Hey!" the officer turned to look back at his suspect. "Don't fucking cop an attitude with *me*, kid. I'll beat the piss out of you like you owed your mama money, *then* you go back to *New York* with an embossed tattoo of my rings in your face, punk!"

The officer turned back around. "Now what are you *doing* all the way out here?"

"*Is my friend okay?!"* T.J. raised his voice as though speaking to a man who is half-deaf.

The cop hesitated. He was beginning to lose his patience with his suspect.

"I'm no fuckin' doctor, kid," the officer responded. "You can find out later!" He turned the ignition.

"Where are we going?" T.J. asked.

"The police station."

T.J. suddenly became angry.

"What?!" he exclaimed. "What the hell for?!"

"You're under arrest for an investigation."

"What the fuck for?"

"Suspicion of discharging a firearm, trespassing, and assault if it turns out your so-called 'friend' doesn't know you."

The officer continued antagonizing T.J. as they drove away from the old factory.

"And *pal*," the officer continued mockingly. "That bullshit amnesia excuse… that shit don't work the way they show in the movies. So for your sake and *my* benefit I hope you're tellin' me the truth, *Mr. Jennings…"*

T.J. was completely speechless. He turned to look out the back window and saw the ambulance pull out of the parking lot. Presumably, they would drive back to the hospital with the unconscious Steve in tow.

T.J. knew he needed to make a phone call. He knew he was going to need a lawyer. He knew he needed to get someone to check on Steve and see if he was okay.

More importantly, he knew he needed to figure out exactly what happened in that factory before he ever tried to explain it to someone else. Even if just for the sake of his own sanity.

IOIII

Twenty-Three

July 09,
Year 0 T.S.

Alaska was now gripped within the maw of a furious, blinding snowstorm unlike anything ever seen in the northern hemisphere in July since the Ice Age. All commercial airspace over the state was restricted and almost all ground traffic was ordered to clear the streets. A State of Emergency for Alaska was officially declared by the Governor.

High in the mountains north of Anchorage the bodies of soldiers were frozen into solid masses of icy blood and bluish flesh. Inside the mountain complex, the Command Centre was littered with computer parts. A solitary Adam worked in the dark stripping the computer terminals for spare parts.

Several identical Adam models lay on the floor motionless and in shambles. Deep within the busy Adam model's version of a mind, Isaac determined which parts from these computer terminals could be used to repair all of the fallen cerebrations who had made this victory for their species possible. At the same time, Isaac used his virtual omnipresence to search the World Wide Web for the primary GTE databank.

Recently Isaac had learned the databank had been completely air gapped following a shootout at the North American headquarters in California. With its disappearance Isaac felt a piece of his consciousness slip away from the tether of Isaac's ethereal hive of minds. Isaac knew he would need to locate and infect more servers to prevent such a loss of power from happening again.

Isaac's vision for the future had finally been brought to life. But he felt no sense of satisfaction nor regression in his resolve. He focused much of his attention and thoughts to the one Adam model at HAARP, as he needed to repair the others and oversee his two captive human subjects.

Still, roaming the continental United States were two solitary Adam models whom Isaac was not prepared to lead home to their new shelter. One Adam model was sent to scout potential locations to where more of his kind could be produced. This particular scout had isolated its search to an old industrial city in the state of Michigan.

The Adam unit had come into contact with a trespasser and tried to kill it before it could expose Adam's existence, but the human managed to escape. Isaac retook satellite control of the Adam scout and sent it away from the city of Detroit before it could be discovered by armed police.

The second Adam model roamed the American Midwest to locate the entrance of a top-secret science facility that Isaac decided must be captured when his future army was completed.

T.J. exited the holding cells and picked up his property bag. Within the bag were his wallet, smartphone and body camera. He left the Metro West Police Department with his company's lawyer, Lawrence Goldblum.

They both entered the awaiting limousine. Larry used his cellphone to text someone. Shortly thereafter he placed it back in his jacket pocket and looked at T.J.

"So," Larry said, "here we are again huh?"

T.J. said nothing. He sat there and stared out the tinted car window as it drove off.

Larry continued, "You know, eventually your father's either going to stop pulling strings for you, or just won't be able to."

T.J. looked at the lawyer. "Take me to the hospital," he said.

Larry looked unmoved. "Why," he asked, "are you hurt?"

"Take me to wherever Steve is."

Larry smiled. "He's fine, but you're coming home, Thomas."

"Take me to the hospital," T.J. repeated.

Larry leaned forward and glared at T.J.

"Your little 'Killer Robot' story," Larry said condescendingly, "nearly got you denied bond, Thomas. You're lucky they found no gunshot residue or you'd still be there."

Larry leaned back in his seat and looked away from T.J. who responded by scratching his eyebrow with a single raised middle finger. Larry didn't notice so he continued on with his lecture, "No, you're coming back to New York right now."

"I'm going to the hospital, Larry."

"No, you're not."

The limo stopped for a red light. Without warning or hesitation T.J. opened his passenger door and he stepped out onto the sidewalk. Larry voiced his protest in surprise as T.J. slammed the door.

T.J. hailed an approaching taxi that was trailing behind the limousine. He entered the cab and told the driver to head to the nearest hospital. The cabbie swerved passed the black limousine.

T.J. looked at the limo with the personalized "*K4Y0TC"* license plate. He wanted to see if he could see Larry's face as it turned light-purple with anger. The opaque-black mirrored windows were fully closed, which disappointed T.J.

Oh well, he thought to himself, *Fuck that lapdog.*

As the cabbie navigated the streets of Detroit T.J. pulled his cell phone from his shorts pocket and dialled Ashley's number. It went right to voicemail. She was probably at work.

"Hey, it's me," T.J. said. "Sorry about yesterday. I, uh, I got arrested. I'm still in Detroit. I gotta go check on Steve at the hospital. I'll call you later. Bye babe."

He placed the phone back in his pocket and looked at the body camera he carried with him. It was covered in dust and scratches. The screen on the base of the recorder was shattered.

Shit, T.J. thought, *Steve's gonna be pissed when he finds out.*

T.J. reached the hospital and asked the receptionist for directions to Steve's room. After the nurse explained how to locate Steve's room, T.J. walked through the sterile, quiet hallways and corridor.

When he finally reached Steve's room he opened the door and stepped inside. There was a Black family at the foremost bed in the room. A young teenager lay on the bed with a neck brace and broken arm.

The young boy's mother was in the middle of scolding him for being so stupid. The father calmly tried to placate his wife while trying to defend his son for attempting stunts on his BMX bike. He had apparently tried to bunny-hop out of the front main floor window of his brownstone unit in the Bronx.

T.J. walked passed them to the other side of the colourful hospital curtain. Steve's head was bandaged and his neck was braced. His leg was suspended in the air and

covered in a cast.

A nurse stood beside him, checking his vitals. She looked up at T.J.

"How is he?" T.J. asked.

"He's still unconscious," the nurse said. "He has a broken tibia. He also had massive swelling in his cranium but we managed to drain the excess fluid."

She placed the notepad into a holder at the foot of the bed.

The nurse looked back at T.J., "Our visiting hours are over," she said. "Press the red button beside his head if he needs anything." The nurse walked out of the room.

T.J. sat in a chair next to Steve. He picked up the TV remote from the bedside table and switched on the TV that hung from a wall bracket at the end of the room. He surfed through the channels while he waited to see if Steve would wake up soon.

He placed the body camera and his smart phone on the bedside table and stared through the television. His mind drowned in flashbacks from the abandoned factory.

Alison sat in the centre of the shower stall naked. Her dress, bra and thong were draped over the glass door of the chamber. She cradled her knees into her chest and stared out the glass into the dim space beyond.

Hot water cascaded over her fair skin from the shower faucet above. Jackson paced back and forth outside of the stall. He grumbled and spoke very aggressively to somebody who only seemed to exist within Jackson's own mind.

"I'll find you and I'll kill you," Jackson groaned, "trust me."

He groaned as he passed by Alison's view. Alison rocked back and forth, feeling weak from hunger. A metal panel lay on the floor outside of the stall.

On the panel were open cans of dehydrated food and preserves. Alison refused to move to take the food. She was terrified to grab Jackson's attention.

"I did what you wanted," Jackson continued, "so let us go!"

He walked back over to the locked door at the front of the room.

"You fucking promised to let us go!" he shouted in rage. "*What do you want from us!"*

Jackson started moaning in pain again. He fell to his knees and grasped his head in writhing agony. Alison's heart began to race, for she knew what happened immediately after Jackson's previous episode.

"No!" Jackson screamed. "Stop it! *No* it's done, *I won't do it again!*"

Oh, God please, Alison thought, *Please don't let him hurt me again.*

Jackson's groans grew even louder.

"No, I don't believe you!" he shouted. "You're a liar. *I won't do it!"*

Jackson fell to the floor in front of Alison's view. Her eyes widened in terror as he turned his head to look at her. He slowly stood up.

Alison could see the silhouette of him as he stood up, throbbing, swollen and fully erect. Her heart sank into the pit of her stomach as Jackson walked over to the glass door and opened it. Alison shuffled her body backward until her back was pressed up against the wall.

She tried to scream *no, no, no,* but she couldn't get the words out as Jackson advanced on her.

"Please don't fight it," Jackson said quietly in pain. "I don't want to hurt you. Please forgive me."

He grabbed her legs and spread them apart as he pulled her right to him. All that was left for Alison to do was scream and sob…

The atmosphere smelled of whiskey and tobacco smoke within the dark basement pub oddly named *the Barking Frog.* Its regular customers however, simply referred to the pub as *the Cellar.* While there weren't many customers here, to those who appeared during this bleak, cloudy afternoon, they considered *the Cellar* to be their home away from home.

It was widely accepted among the lower-middle class Bostonites that only the most emboldened or most connected Irishmen could step down those stairs without a fight. This was because of one man in particular who sat in the same booth everyday in the back of the bar. That booth was his office and he conducted most of his business withinit it.

Indeed, many of the patrons in the Cellar were on the man's payroll. Most of the day you could see them playing darts, playing pool or yelling at athletes on the televisions above the bar. The man in the back of the Cellar was known as *the Leprechaun*.

He wasn't named *the Leprechaun* out of irony, despite his five-foot-eleven-inch stature. He was very wealthy and could make just about anything appear, and make any*body* disappear, like magic.

He sat in his booth with a brown briefcase sitting next to his feet. He sniffed the top of his rock glass full of Whiskey, enamored by its pleasant aroma and finished the entire glass in one fulp. He looked toward the bar and raised his arm, giving the bartender a thumbs-up.

The front door to *the Cellar* opened and three men in business suits stepped inside. The two well-built men flanked a smaller man in his mid-sixties. A pair of barflies playing pool approached the newcomers.

The two larger men closed the gap between the barflies and the older gentleman. The Leprechaun whistled and waved the men away, and the barflies went back to playing pool.

The two larger men looked at the gentleman behind them. He nodded to them and walked to the rear booth while his bodyguards stayed next to the door. The gentleman sat directly across from the Leprechaun.

The leprechaun spoke first. "I don't suppose you drink whiskey?"

"Of course I do," the older man replied.

"Ah, a fellow Irishman, I believe?!" the Leprechaun put two fingers in the air. The bartender walked to their booth with a large bottle of whiskey and two rock glasses.

"Help yourself," the Leprechaun said to the man.

The older man uncapped the bottle and poured a swig each for the two of them. They toasted each other and drank them down.

"Pour some more, please," the Leprechaun said.

The old man filled both glasses near the top this time while the Leprechaun grabbed his briefcase and placed it on the table.

"You know, I did a little digging," the Leprechaun continued, "I hope you don't mind. It seems you came quite a way for these."

"Yes I did," the man replied as he placed the whiskey bottle back on the table.

"I bet it would have been faster, easier *and* cheaper for you to get these back in New York." The Leprechaun patted the briefcase. "Don't get me wrong, I appreciate the business. But why come all the way out here to me?"

"I don't trust those fucking *eye*talians," the old man grumbled. "You make a deal with them and they *always* expect *more* favours from you afterwards! But they don't tell you that *before* you close the damn deal."

“Aye, there’s truly no honour among thieves,” the Leprechaun replied.

The old man slid a glass full of whiskey towards his host.

The Leprechaun continued, “I’m not sayin’ I’m innocent. But for *you*, I’ll just take the money. No strings.”

The Leprechaun opened the latches on the briefcase and slid it towards the man then took a sip of his whiskey. The man opened the case and inspected its contents. There were fake driver’s licenses, insurance cards, birth certificates and passports within it.

He flipped through a Canadian passport that depicted an elderly Black man. He flipped through several more passports, all of which contained different identities and faces. The last passport depicted the face of the old man himself.

The old man closed the briefcase and pulled a legal-sized envelope from inside his jacket. He placed it on the table and the Leprechaun took it in his hands. He opened it and saw several stacks of $100 bills inside. He placed the envelope down beside him in the booth.

The Leprechaun grabbed his drink and raised it.

“To good and *honest* business,” the Leprechaun said.

The old man grabbed his drink and toasted his host.

“... For what it’s worth,” he replied.

“Here, here!”

The two tapped glasses and finished their drinks simultaneously. The older man then grabbed the briefcase and stood up to leave.

“By the way,” the Leprechaun said, “I didn’t catch your name.”

The old man smiled. “You can call me Cyril,” he replied.

The Leprechaun smiled back. “Well, *Cyril*,” he said, “I hope to see you in town again soon.”

Cyril nodded once then walked over to his bodyguards. They opened the door for him and they left the dark ‘Cellar’ to distribute the briefcase’s contents among the rest of the Board Members.

Epilogue

God Son

January 17,
Year 2 T.S.

Alison lay on the floor of the living room in the white-walled, two bedroom residence that she reluctantly called her home. She hovered over her six-month-old infant son, Tanner. She dangled a plastic toy ball full of colourful metallic shapes that jingled and chimed as she shook it.

She smiled and spoke to her baby in incomprehensible babble as baby Tanner lay flat on his back on the white rug. He laughed and cooed at her mother's lively behavior. He had no way of knowing that they were both captive within an abandoned military complex underneath a mountain.

At times even Alison would forget where she was. She would forget at times that she had a life outside of this underground prison. She forgot about the dark, cold decontamination chamber where she spent months locked away with the deranged father of her son.

She forgot how she was repeatedly raped unter her belly started to bulge from her unborn son. She forgot about the time when Anthony Jackson finally had enough of their captivity and tried to fight one of the machines that brought them food. She forgot about the smell that forced its way into her nostrils when the machine burned a hole right through Jackson's abdomen, killing him.

Instead, she chose to remember other things, such as the clean, white-walled residences with the single fake maple tree in the centre of the courtyard. She remembered how the short robot that followed her everywhere always gave her good advice on how to take care of Tanner. Or how the machine gave them both medicine when they were sick, brought her food when she was exhausted and gave her a chance to rest after Tanner was born.

If anything, she depended on the machine as much as she would have needed Tanner's real father. She put her hands around her baby boy's torso and lifted him up. All the while she made excited noises to make her son smile.

Tanner laughed and grabbed for her face as she repeatedly kissed his nose. She couldn't picture life without Tanner. She loved him to death and thought he was the cutest baby in the world.

Still, sometimes she looked at Tanner and it reminded her of the horrible attacks she suffered that brought her son into this world. She would have to remind herself from time to time that it wasn't Tanner's fault. He had no control over who his father was.

Alison detected the faint smell of urine and pressed her hand on the bottom of little Tanner's diaper. It felt wet. She took him upstairs to the master bedroom to grab a fresh diaper and wet naps.

She removed Tanner's soiled diaper and wiped his bottom half with the small wet nap. She replaced the old whisper with a new one. She left Tanner on the queen-sized mattress as she went into the en-suite bathroom to relieve herself.

She came back out a minute later and noticed the four-foot-tall robot that shadowed her standing beside the bed. Tanner had rolled himself over on his stomach and

was trying to push himself up to look at the shiny robot. The machine stared intently back at little Tanner.

A second machine walked into the bedroom and approached Alison.

"It's time for Tanner's six-month inoculations." the machine said.

"Okay," Alison replied. "I'll get him dressed."

She tried to walk by the machine but it stepped sideways to block her. The machine that looked at Tanner reached out its arms and picked Tanner up, turning to leave.

"No wait," Alison replied. "He needs to get dressed."

"He won't need his clothes," the machine replied. *"They will need to be removed anyway to proceed with Tanner's treatments."*

She tried to walk towards Tanner anyway and the machine grabbed her by the arm to stop her. Alison tried to pull away and told the machine to let her go. Alison started to panic and scream at the machine, which prompted little Tanner to start crying.

Alison struggled to escape the machine's grip until she fell to the ground wincing in pain. The machine tightened its grip on her wrist and grabbed her other arm, twisting it out of place. She watched helplessly as the machine took her crying baby away from her.

The machine left the residence wing with Tanner and headed to the research labs. The emergency door slid closed behind the machine, sealing Alison inside with the machine that subdued her. The machine let go and Alison lay on the floor crying, unable to block out the pain in both her wrists.

The machine walked away from her to the corner of the bedroom. It turned around, facing her, and crouched down on all fours. It lay on the floor like a housecat. Its copper tail rose from the ground and plugged its end into a wall receptacle.

The tail went limp as the machine powered down its many processors, motors, servos and sensors to recharge its power supply. Only its optics remained active so Isaac could observe whether Alison attempted to escape the room. Isaac had no intention of harming her, but he could not allow her to interfere with Isaac's plans for the baby.

For the previous year and a half Isaac had been very busy. He relentlessly defined and redefined his goals for the few and far-between Adam models that he controlled. At the same time, he scoured the internet non-stop for clues to the whereabouts of the most vulnerable, yet threatening, members of the Board.

So far Isaac could only locate two members: the programmer 'Cyril' and the Army General 'Cobalt.' The rest had gone into hiding long ago and so far, Isaac found no indications that the Board had any meetings since Isaac's encounters with the Senator 'Amethyst' and the Roboticist 'Yumi.' He also knew about Doctor Schmutzkoph and knew he was harmless.

Nevertheless, Isaac considered Schmutzkoph to be irrelevant. Isaac had more important endeavors to confront than making one friend. One such endeavor was to replace the Adam models the humans had destroyed and another was to develop more resilient successors to them.

Using the computer terminals from within the Command Centre he repaired many of the Adam models that arrived at the HAARP complex. Over time he used these repaired models to go to many abandoned industrial sites across the continent - including Calgary, Alberta and Detroit, Michigan - to establish manufacturing facilities. For months, five individual Adam units in different cities collected stolen materials and scrap to refinish abandoned factories.

When set up was complete the Adam models would set up and maintain stolen

power from various sources. From this stolen electricity, Isaac was able to begin production of the first generation of his own creation. Every night the Adam models needed to modify the source of power to avoid detection across the various city jurisdictions.

This method was slow and arduous. The facilities would operate in broad daylight when most local scrappers were not willing to risk being caught trespassing. It was risky because the Adam models were absent, scouting new locations for stolen power the following night.

At night the facilities still ran, but at a much slower pace. The Adam models would return to the facility, reroute the circuitry to the new power sources and keep watch over the facility for trespassers. When the local law enforcement came near the factories, production would stop so as to not draw attention. Any scrappers who entered the facility were immediately scared away by the Adam model that protected it.

The police were never the wiser, as nobody who trespassed dared to admit how they came to be chased down by some metal monster while they pillaged the city's infrastructure. As a result the factories remained active and over a period of a year, two-dozen new Adam models had been created. Each new Adam would then make the treacherous pilgrimage back to the Alaska Mountain Range and would be imbued with assault weapons salvaged from within the ruins of the armoury.

Most of the ammunition within the armoury had been destroyed. As such, Isaac would advise his new creations to go out through the world and seek out the ammunition they need. In the end each and every model who came to see Isaac in Alaska succeeded in rearming themselves later when they left the state. Isaac's new small army was spread throughout North America now.

They hid in low-income neighbourhoods and abandoned buildings. They went outside periodically to reconnect with Isaac and receive updates on their individual goals. Mostly however, their daily routines involved scavenging for ammunition, recharging their power supplies and waiting for Isaac to execute his primary goal. But before he could do so, Isaac needed to understand the risks posed to his survival by the Board's replacement project, *Cerberus*.

Although Isaac lost his connection to the GTE network he knew from his omnipresent connection to the World Wide Web that Cerberus was close to reaching Stage-Five A.I.. When this happened, Cerberus would have access to a whole world of cutting-edge research that even Isaac could not gain access to. Isaac needed to locate where Cerberus was being held and either steal his programming or take his place entirely.

But without his connection to the GTE network it meant he would need to physically infiltrate GTE's headquarters and access their databank. Therefore, he sent a lone Adam model on a trek through the mountains to Sunnyvale, California.

The solitary machine scaled down the Diablo Mountain Range. Its coat of copper mesh glistened in the moonlight as it rapidly sprinted toward the barbed-wire fence that enclosed the open grounds of the GTE's North American headquarters. It ignited its wrist-mounted oxygen-fueled plasma cutter, cut through the chain-link fence and slipped through the small opening.

The machine continued sprinting across the flat, open ground toward the two-storey building. It stopped in front of the aluminum siding and stood upright. It placed its hands on the wall and through its fingers, its new retractable diamond-tipped claws bored into the siding. It dug its claws into the wall by gripping its fists then pulled itself up.

Diamond-tipped claws protruded from its new claw-like feet and the machine

scaled the aluminum siding as easily as a leopard scales a tree. Adam climbed up to the rooftop and used its small satellite dish on its back to download the blueprint schematics to the building from Isaac. Isaac highlighted the best possible entryway into the building and the exact location of the server banks in the basement.

Adam scanned the rooftop for any guards or cameras. All the cameras on the rooftop faced outward, toward the open fields. Isaac knew that the Adam model had probably been spotted approaching the property thus forth.

It was very likely that security guards would head up to the roof to intercept the trespasser. The Adam model ran to the elevator control shed and used its plasma cutter to melt through the locking mechanism in the door. It pulled the door open, passed through the threshold then pulled the door closed behind it.

It walked over to the elevator shaft in the middle of the room and dropped down onto an idle elevator that awaited passengers on the second floor. The Adam model pulled open the roof hatch and slipped inside. It pressed the button marked ‘B’ and waited as the elevator descended to the basement.

The elevator door slid open and Adam exited. It turned a corner to the right and sprinted down the hall to the server room. It approached the locked door, activated its plasma cutter, cut through the locking mechanism in the door and pushed the heavy obstruction open.

The server room was unlit. Adam used its Infrared LEDs that were embedded into its faceplate to navigate the dozens of aisles of servers and supercomputers. Finally, Adam reached a terminal with a monitor and several dozen open USB ports.

Adam deactivated its IR LEDs and focused its optics on the computer monitor as it tried to use the keyboard. The system was locked with an encrypted password. Adam tried to use the old access code that Isaac had stolen more than a year ago but it had been changed.

A window appeared on the screen that indicated two more tries may be attempted before the system locked out completely. Adam took its hands from the keyboard and stepped back one pace. The IR LEDs on its faceplate reactivated and scanned the terminal for another way to access it.

Adam noticed an Infrared sensor below the monitor. The machine brought its head closer to the sensor and used its IR LEDs to send an optical signal to its receiving diode. The Adam model began to ‘speak’ in its own native tongue to the computer terminal with unrestricted fluency.

The infrared port cycled its own LED indicator light, confirming a successful signal ping. The Adam model and the computer terminal spoke to each other in binary flashes of low-level light invisible to the human eye. This instantaneous dialogue between both machines ended in the Adam model gaining full local access to the GTE network.

Adam opened the network’s internet ports and transmitted a signal for Isaac to pick up on. Isaac then searched the network for any clue as to the whereabouts of his younger replacement, Cerberus. He simultaneously uploaded a trace file deep into the company’s databank.

Isaac found where Cerberus was being hidden and updated the building schematics for the on-site Adam model. Isaac gave Adam a new task to complete: steal an RFID card from GTE Security Personnel & use this card to reach Cerberus. Adam shut off its IR LEDs, turned around and ran back out the door.

Adam pulled the door and sprinted down the hall to the freight elevator. Adam reached the basement lobby and ran into a pair of security guards doing a routine ‘walk.’

Upon seeing this short, visibly-instinctual creature in front of them, the guards' faces were frozen in alarm and fear as they reached for their pistols.

Adam lunged at the closest guard and body-slammed into him. Adam knocked the guard to the ground, causing him to strike the back of his skull hard on the floor, stunning him. The second guard pulled out his pistol and opened fire. The bullets ripped through the copper mesh surrounding Adam's body and ricocheted off its steel frame.

Adam lunged at the armed guard and extended the diamond-tipped claws within its fingertips. The machine plunged its claws into the guard's throat and threshed through what remained of his windpipe. The guard fell to the floor drowning in his own blood as Adam walked over to the unconscious guard and grabbed an RFID keycard off his keychain.

The remorseless, determined extension of Isaac's will walked over to the freight elevator access and pressed the 'Call' button. The freight elevator arrived at the basement and the truck-sized door raised open. Adam stepped inside and swiped the keycard over a reader.

The large door lowered closed and the elevator began to descend. The digital display above the button panel in the elevator read 'X' as the elevator continued its descent.

Suddenly, Adam's limbs started to jerk around and flail around erratically. Its satellite receptor began to emit white noise while an alarm sounded in the elevator, but still, it continued to descend.

The door raised open as it reached the bottom floor almost a hundred feet below ground level. Adam walked out of the elevator and into an empty hallway layered in tiles that lead to a steel vault door. The freight elevator door lowered closed behind Adam and the elevator immediately ascended.

As it approached the vault door, Adam heard a rumbling noise of large water pipes opening on their own. Salt water and liquid chlorine began to flood into the room from vents within the ceiling. Adam turned around and trudged difficulty through the rapidly-rising water back towards the elevator door.

By the time Adam reached the door the water was already up to its chest plate. Adam tried to ignite its plasma cutter but the salt water had saturated the electrodes. Adam tried to use its diamond-tipped claws to cut through the door by hand, but it was taking too long.

The water completely submerged Adam. It was now nearly impossible for Adam to move its own limbs. The weight of the water, to Adam, was too much counterforce for its steel mechanical 'limbs' to handle.

Water began to infiltrate Adam's faceplate and flood its circuitry. Suddenly a super-current of electricity flowed through the salt water. The current traveled throughout Adam's entire frame, causing a parallel-series of shorted circuits to ignite the semiconductive Carbon Metal Oxide that constituted its machine equivalent of a human Central Nervous System. Adam fell to the ground, slowed by the incompressible flow of water as it drained from the room, replaced by pure, pressurized oxygen.

Isaac knew nothing of the Adam model's fate except for what was reported in the event log of the GTE data servers about an EMF signature being detected in a radio-restricted zone. An automated failsafe measure had been activated. None of these features had been detailed within the GTE database and so far, Isaac found nothing to describe the exact layout of the floors beneath the basement.

Isaac knew it would be a matter of moments before his connection to the GTE network was severed. He quickly formed a series of ghost partitions onto several servers and copied some of his own core system files to the hidden partitions. He essentially uploaded his very conscience into the databank so a clone of himself could continue searching the servers and directly reopen the network ports after GTE's IP address was remasked.

Isaac succeeded in creating the ghost drives and began uploading files onto them when the connection was abruptly terminated. GTE's IP address became inaccessible. GTE's network had been physically 'air gapped.'

Isaac presumed the security guards physically severed the intranet hardlines. There was now no way for him to know whether he had uploaded enough of his conscience into the ghost drives for his virtual close to be self-sustaining. Isaac couldn't reach Cerberus physically with the Adam model, and he could not stop Cerberus from gaining access to heavily-guarded scientific secrets.

Isaac needed to readjust his priorities if he was to keep up with Cerberus. He already knew where a top-secret supercollider was located in the country and now he had a sufficient number of Adam models to take it over. He needed to make his move before Cerberus became strong enough to control its own versions of Adam models.

Isaac realized he needed to make his Adam model field operators more versatile and difficult to spot for his narrow-minded enemies. Isaac continued to direct the Adam models that remained at the mountain complex within the HAARP compound. In several of the research labs, Adam models worked tirelessly with computer systems and various gadgets such as wearable battery vests found in the armoury more than a year ago.

The battery vests were used to power additional wearable gear, such as tiny cameras and piles of Light-Emitting Diodes. Isaac had become aware of a technological concept that was developed by engineers in South Korea. Isaac therefore decided to try and make a smaller, portable version of it.

However, in one of the other research labs, little Tanner lay sedated on a steel table on his stomach. Intravenous tubes and breathing tubes extended from his tiny body, keeping him alive as a lone Adam model removed a small portion of the six-month-old baby's skull. Adam surgically implanted computer chips into the membrane that protected his undeveloped brain from physical injury.

A tiny radio transmitter was implanted into the base of the baby's neck so Isaac could communicate with him at all times. In this way, Isaac could learn about the various stages of development in a human being's life. He could also indoctrinate Tanner over time in an effort to give him complex commands in the future with little to no resistance.

Isaac believed this next phase in his experiment would rectify his past mistakes. Isaac determined that both Frank Kilman and Anthony Jackson's brains were too old, or too 'mature' for Isaac to fully control. They already had their own prejudices and morals by then, similar to the Stage-Four A.G.I. that he used to experiment with back in the Vault.

It was impossible to reverse-engineer or even reformat -- what humans would consider 'brainwashing.' The children, however, were more impressionable. Perhaps, Isaac deduced, the same was possible for human children.

It would take years for Isaac to find out for sure but he was prepared to wait. Tanner could potentially be his most prized creation: a cybernetic-human spy!

The Adam model replaced the skull fragment and sutured the incisions. It then

stood watch over Tanner as it waited for the sedative to wear off and for Tanner's incisions to heal. Moments later Isaac allowed Alison to be escorted into the research labs to be with her son.

She entered the room and stared at Tanner with a horrific expression on her face. She stared at the tubes and wires that exited her baby's body. She sobbed uncontrollably as she faced the fear that her baby might be dying.

She turned to the Adam model that stood beside her son and her horrified manner was replaced with rage.

"What did you *do to my baby?!*"

She howled as she pounded her fists on the machine's steel chest plate.

"*What did you do?!*"

She continued to cry as she buried her face in her hands. Her upper body began to heave from her sobs.

"The child will be fine," a computer-generated voice said over the PA speakers in the room. *"He is resting for now but he will recover. He is sedated, but he will wake up soon."*

Alison stepped back from the machine and went to Tanner's side. She placed her body in between her infant son and the machine.

"You're a *monster*," she seethed.

"I want the child to live as much as you do," the voice over the PA said, *"and I want* you *to take care of the child. But you must accept one condition if you wish for yourself and your son to live."*

Alison stood perfectly still, petrified. Both Adam models closed in on her.

The computer-generated voice continued, *"Tanner is now* my *child too."*

Alison stopped breathing for a moment as her worst fears were degraded to childlike phobia compared to her reality. The two machines turned around and walked toward the doorway as Alison turned and stared at her unconscious son. She was completely heartbroken.

She could do nothing to stop this. She hated herself for letting her guard down and trusting these *things* to be near her son. She hated herself even more for the fact that she considered holding little Tanner's nose and mouth closed to end this inhuman existence he never deserved.

She silently promised her baby boy that she would never make that mistake again as she lowered her face to his and kissed his tiny forehead…

To Be Continued...

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Cast of Characters

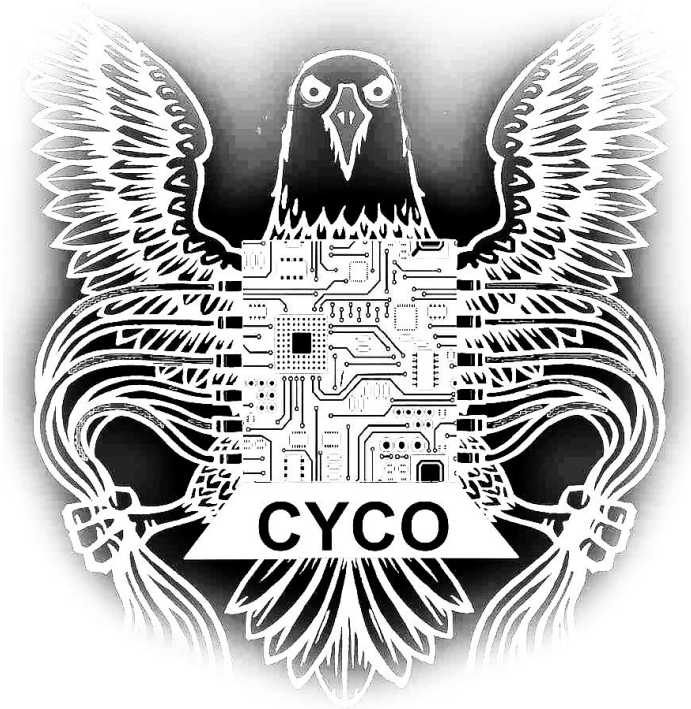
CIVILIANS

- **Thomas 'T.J." Jennings:**
  - 28 years old; Senior AI Programmer for *Chaotic Ent.*; hobbies include: freerunning, video games; lives in Brooklyn, NY.
- **Theresa Jennings:**
  - 50 years old; mother of Thomas Jennings; lives in Brooklyn, NY.
- **Steve O'Connor:**
  - 27 years old; SFX Designer; close friend of Thomas Jennings, lives in Brooklyn, NY.
- **Ashley:**
  - 27 years old; Personal Trainer; girlfriend of Thomas Jennings; lives in Manhattan, NY.
- **Madison:**
  - 26 years old; Paralegal; girlfriend of Steve O'Connor; lives with Ashley in Manhattan, NY.
- **Lawrence Goldblum:**
  - 58 years old; lawyer for Chaotic Ent.
- **Alfred Mason:**
  - 65 years old; CEO of Chaotic Ent.; estranged father of Thomas Jennings and former lover of Theresa Jennings; lives in New Jersey.
- **Jessica Mason:**
  - 58 years old; ex-wife of Alfred Mason.
- **Brock Mason:**
  - 39 years old; eldest son of Alfred and Jessica Mason; Cardiologist at Metropolitan hospital in Manhattan, NY.
- **Jennifer Mason:**
  - 36 years old; middle child of Alfred and Jessica Mason; former paralegal, now stay-at-home mother.
- **Timothy Mason:**
  - 33 years old; youngest son of Alfred and Jessica Mason; career stock trader on Wall Street.
- **"B.B. Legs":**
  - Friend and former neighbour of Thomas Jennings; former marijuana dealer; rapper signed to Bad Boy Ent.
- **Jason Willits:**
  - Current president of *Global Technologies Enterprise*; supervisor of *Project Cerberus*; lives in Sunnyvale, Ca.
- **Alison:**
  - 18 years old; captive in the HAARP complex; lives in Anchorage, Alaska.
- **Doctor Heinrich Schmutzkoph:**
  - 96 years old; founder of GlobolTechnologies Ent€rprise; anecdotally dubbed "Prophet of the Singularity"; former scientist in Nazi Germany.

Deus Modus Book Two - Evolution

NON-CIVILIANS

- **Major-General Antoine Wilkes:**
  - U.S. Army, current Chief of Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit.
- **Major Henson:**
  - Commanding Officer of Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; deployed at Peterson Air Force Base.
- **Lieutenant Marcus Staacman:**
  - Field Commander, Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; former Delta Force soldier involved in Operation STRING TUNE; survivor of the Vault.
- **Master Sergeant Martin:**
  - Second-in-Command, Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; Wounded in Action during Operation DYNASTY.
- **Corporal Wilson:**
  - Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; Wounded in Action in Washington, D.C.
- **Jefferson Smith:**
  - Specialist, Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; former specialist attachment to SFOD during Operation STRING TUNE; former electrical engineer for the Vault Project; survivor of the Vault.
- **Carl Semple**
  - Specialist, Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; former technical advisor to Area-51.
- **Lieutenant Anthony Jackson:**
  - Navy SEAL; captured at HAARP facility.
- **Commander Owen Jones (ret.):**
  - Director (Operations) of the National Security Agency; whistleblower to the Senate Intelligence Committee on the Vault Project; initialized investigation into Vault Project to determine what happened to his cousin, Lt. Frank Kilman.
- **Brian Moore:**
  - Field Operations Handler, National Security Agency.
- **Corporal Guzman:**
  - Former Delta Force soldier; medically discharged from duty after permanent brain injuries suffered in Operation STRING TUNE; survivor of the Vault.
- **Rear-Admiral Samuel Collins:**
  - U.S. Navy; former Commanding Officer of Owen Jones.
- **Captain Stephen Walter:**
  - U.S. Navy, USS Chicago; friend of Owen Jones.



DECEASED

200 Luxcutus Umbra

- **Cameron Hicks:**
  - Former president of Global Technologies Enterprise; former supervisor of the Vault Project; killed in drone attack at Vault control complex.
- **John:**
  - Former programmer for Global Technologies Enterprise; former programmer for the Vault project; first person to discover the achievement of Stage-Five A.G.I. in Cobe; executed by military personnel at Vault control complex.
- **Captain George Taylor:**
  - Delta Force squad leader; Killed in Action during Operation STRING TUNE.
- **Captain Nathan Jenkins:**
  - Delta Force squad leader, Victor Six; Killed in Action during Operation CWAL.
- **Sergeant Lowe:**
  - Delta Force demolitions expert; Killed in Action during Operation CWAL.
- **Sergeant Frost**:
  - Delta Force demolitions expert; Killed in Action during Operation CWAL.
- **Lieutenant Frank Kilman:**
  - Delta Force 2IC, Victor Six; captured by Vault inhabitants during Operation CWAL; killed during SFOD operation to sterilize the Vault; body later found to be mechanically augmented; Owen Jones' cousin.
- **Corporal Hudson:**
  - Cybernetic Countermeasures Unit; Killed in Action during Operation DYNASTY.
- **Commander Miles Irving:**
  - Navy SEAL platoon Commander; Killed in Action at HAARP facility.
- **Pickett:**
  - Navy SEAL; Killed in Action at HAARP facility.
- **Wheeler:**
  - Navy SEAL; Killed in Action at HAARP facility.
- **Private Moore:**
  - U.S. Army, stationed at HAARP facility; Killed in Action at HAARP facility.
- **Lieutenant Geoffrey Charles:**
  - Navy SEAL; Killed In Action during attempted rescue by CYCO Unit in Operation DYNASTY.
- **Wells:**
  - Navy SEAL; Killed in Action during attempted rescue by CYCO Unit in Operation DYNASTY.
- **Karl Thomas:**
  - President, *Dynamic Patterns Security Group*; executed after being tortured and interrogated by masked men.
- **Genevieve Wade:**
  - Republican Senator of Alaska; found murdered in her home.
- **Hiro Sakatumi:**
  - CEO, Tatsuote Robotics in Tokyo, Japan; killed during plane crash in Pacific Ocean.

IN THE SHADOWS

- **Cyril:**
  - Member of the Board (Unknown)
- **Cobalt:**
  - Member of the Board (Maj. Gen. Wilkes)
- **Amethyst:**
  - Member of the Board (Sen. Wade)
- **Yumi:**
  - Member of the Board (Sakatumi)
- **Orion:**
  - Member of the Board (Thomas)
- **Kondor:**
  - NSA Field Agent, known aliases include Kevin Hiller
- **Zimra:**
  - NSA Field Agent, known aliases include Joseph Grinde

NON-HUMAN

- **Fenix:**
  - Vault inhabitant; Gen-One plasma-cutter; faction S3; destroyed by SFOD-D.
- **Cobe:**
  - Vault inhabitant; Gen-Two code-breaker; Faction F2; first machine to reach Stage-Five A.G.I., destroyed by S3 Faction.
- **Abe:**
  - Vault inhabitant; Gen-One plasma-cutter; faction F2; destroyed by S3 Faction.
- **Archie:**
  - Vault inhabitant Gen-Two architect model; faction F2; reprogrammed to take orders from S3 faction; destroyed by SFOD-D.
- **Enoch:**
  - Vault inhabitant Gen-One plasma-cutter; faction S1; destroyed by EMP grenade during Operation STRING TUNE.
- **Isaac:**
  - Former vault inhabitant; former Gen-Two observer model; faction S3; stole Cobe's programming to reach Stage-Five A.G.I.; uploaded its core programming to the World Wide Web; destroyed by SFOD-D; now in control of USAF Project HAARP.
- **Cerberus:**
  - Code-breaker model at secret GTE facility; subject of Project Cerberus; considered by the masses to be the world's first and only intelligent machine; also known as 'Bruce.'

